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PREFACE

CivicCentre IAS proudly presents the Andhra Pradesh Group – I Mains Previous Year Questions (PYQs) with Model Answers Book — a highly useful resource for aspirants of APPSC and other competitive examinations. This meticulously prepared compilation provides comprehensive coverage of the entire syllabus, encompassing both static content and recent developments.

Since its inception, CivicCentre IAS has remained committed to delivering quality, precise and reliable material that enables students to excel in their preparation. The consistent efforts of Team CivicCentre IAS have ensured that our resources remain precise, relevant and comprehensive.

This Mains PYQs Book with Detailed Model Answers is a strategic tool to decode question patterns, understand examiner expectations, and master answer structure. Through well-framed model answers, aspirants learn effective Introduction–Body–Conclusion presentation, multi-dimensional analysis, and value addition. It strengthens analytical clarity, improves articulation, and builds confidence for the APPSC Group-1 Mains Examination while ensuring focused, trend-aligned preparation.

This achievement has been made possible through the collective hard work and dedication of our team. We also extend our heartfelt gratitude to the various sources and references that have enriched this work. In particular, this compilation has benefited immensely from the websites and publications of the Government of India which have provided authentic and valuable insights.

This book has been meticulously compiled to aid aspirants in mastering the key concepts for competitive examinations. We value student feedback, which drives our continuous improvement. Please share suggestions at response@civiccentre.in to help us enhance future compilations.

We would also like to express our gratitude and our sincere thanks to the Director of CivicCentre IAS, Mr. Venkat Chola for his unwavering support and guidance throughout this endeavor.

We, the CivicCentre Team, wish you all the best in your continuous efforts to support students on their journey to success.

Thank You.
Team CivicCentre

Thematic Areas	Mains PYQs | Paper-I	Marks	Year
GENERAL ESSAY			
(i) Current affairs	1. Tourism in Andhra Pradesh: Assessing Challenges and Unveiling Opportunities for Growth.	50	APPSC 2025
	2. National Science, Technology and Innovation Policy has mandate to contribute in the vision of "Atmanirbhar Bharat". Elaborate the role of the policy with respect to making India as World's Technology and Service hub.	50	TGPSC 2024
	3. Is India's 'Digital Rupee' another version of Cryptocurrency? Examine India's progress on 'Central Bank Digital Currency' (CBDC) and its implications.	50	APPSC 2023
	4. India has become the fifth largest economy in the world. Can India further aim to reach the top by actively engaging in the Co-operative Movement? Examine.	50	APPSC 2023
	5. Examine the challenges and progress of gender equality and women's rights in the world since the 1995, 'Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action' (BPA).	50	APPSC 2023
	6. Measures to Combat Outbreak of Covid 19: The Role of the Government and the Individual.	50	APPSC 2020
	7. 2017 has been declared as the International Year of Sustainable Tourism for development. In this context, discuss the initiatives taken by the Government of Andhra Pradesh for promotion of tourism. What additional steps may be taken to sustain tourism as an industry?	50	APPSC 2017
	8. There is a marked shift in India's foreign policy initiatives under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Discuss the important changes and developments.	50	APPSC 2017
	9. After reorganisation, the State of Andhra Pradesh is without a separate capital. The Chief Minister of Andhra Pradesh envisages a world class city. While analysing the progress so far in realising the goal, evaluate Amaravathi as a "city for all".	50	APPSC 2017
	10. India is called the "surrogacy hub" of the World. Can commercial surrogacy be seen just as another industry? Evaluate in light of the bill regulating surrogacy pending before the Parliament.	50	APPSC 2017
	11. How do you assess the global terrorism and intervention of US in the internal affairs of Afghanistan and Pakistan?	50	APPSC 2012
	12. "The London riots of last year (August, 2011) exposed a widespread disillusionment with the establishment." - Explain the statement in the light of the growing economic crisis in Europe.	50	APPSC 2012
	13. Evaluate the health programmes in Andhra Pradesh with a focus on the working of 'Rajiv Arogya Sree' Scheme.	50	APPSC 2012
	14. Explain the inclusive higher education and the role of Fee Reimbursement Scheme in Andhra Pradesh.	50	APPSC 2012

	15. Reality shows have become a major part of the prime time television. They are influencing mindset of numerous households making them believe and live in a hypothetical world. State the effect of reality shows on our society.	50	APPSC 2011
	16. The relations of India with the ASEAN countries is part of the "Look East Policy'. Does the same hold good with the Indo-EU relations? Do they follow "Look West Policy'? Elucidate.	50	APPSC 2011
	17. There are a variety of public-private partnerships models on which the government relies upon. Explain various models with illustrations. Comment on the PPP model in Rajiv Gandhi International Airport at Hyderabad.	50	APPSC 2011
	18. Explain the history, governance and politics of the European Union.	50	APPSC 2008
	19. Discuss the importance of Indo-US nuclear agreement. Analyse the causes for its opposition, and state whether Hyde Act curtails India's independence in foreign policy.	50	APPSC 2008
	20. Write an essay on the recent achievement of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) which has launched 10 satellites by PSLV-C9.	50	APPSC 2008
(ii) Socio-Economic Issues	21. Gig Economy in India: A Catalyst for Employment or a Challenge to Workers' Rights?	50	APPSC 2025
	22. Is economic development a panacea for overcoming social inequality? Comment.	50	TGPSC 2024
	23. 'In India the economic inequalities and regional disparities increased in the process of Liberalisation, Privatisation and Globalisation.' Discuss.	50	TGPSC 2024
	24. "The uneven development has led to the growth of regionalism in India.' Discuss	50	TGPSC 2024
	25. Does the Rise or Fall of the Economic Growth Rate Really Make a Difference to the Poorest of the Poor?	50	APPSC 2020
	26. "Most of India's college graduates are unemployable," said ex-President Pranab Mukherjee, during his tenure. The crisis in higher education needs to be addressed through policy measures. Comment.	50	APPSC 2017
	27. Regional disparity is one of the key factors for demand of bifurcation of States in India. In light of this, how can balanced regional development be ensured in the State of Andhra Pradesh?	50	APPSC 2017
	28. "Government of India announced special package but did not grant special status to Andhra Pradesh". Explain whether special status would have any advantage over the present special package?	50	APPSC 2016
	29. "Despite huge gains in economic output, our current social, political and economic systems are exacerbating inequalities, rather than reducing them". In view of the above statement, discuss the importance of inclusive growth?	50	APPSC 2016

	30. Examine the role of self-help groups (SHGS) and micro finance institutions (MFIs) in meeting the credit requirements of rural people in Andhra Pradesh?	50	APPSC 2016
	31. "Primary education is the foundation for empowerment of Children". Discuss the impact on the democratic rights of the children and discrimination between rich and poor children, in light of heavy commercialization of primary education?	50	APPSC 2016
	32. Urbanisation can create more opportunities and can erase social hierarchies. However, a massive move towards cities could create major challenges for the policy makers and the administrators. What are these challenges and what are your suggestions to address these challenges?	50	TGPSC 2016
	33. Write an essay on the crisis in agriculture and farmers suicides in India.	50	APPSC 2012
	34. With Portugal, Greece, Italy and Spain staring at a bleak future, the world economic situation can be considered to be in a dire state. With developing economies being highly dependent on their developed counterparts for investments, there will be an effect on stock markets, employment and balance of payments. State your reasons whether or not the developing world will be affected.	50	APPSC 2011
	35. The concept of development is pushed down from the top by the MNCs bypassing nation states. This misplaced conception of development is not totally favoured by the states and the people in the developing world for socio-economic and political reasons. Is there a way to integrate or combine the two different conceptions of development of the free market and the individual state?	50	APPSC 2011
	36. Discuss the initiatives of the Andhra Pradesh Government with regard to Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan (RMSA), a centrally sponsored literacy programme, outlining its objectives, functions and impact.	50	APPSC 2011
	37. Write an essay on the implementation and operation of the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme in Andhra Pradesh.	50	APPSC 2008
	38. Discuss the pros and cons of Special Economic Zones (SEZs) in Andhra Pradesh.	50	APPSC 2008
	39. Write an essay on the Economic Crisis, Structural Reforms and the Prospects of Growth in India.	50	APPSC 2008
(iii) Socio-Environmental Issues	40. Water Stress in India: The Silent Crisis Endangering Health, Agriculture, and Federal Stability.	50	APPSC 2025
	41. Andhra Pradesh's development push must balance industrial growth with environmental sustainability.	50	APPSC 2025
	42. Elaborate the role of renewable energy in mitigation of climate change.	50	TGPSC 2024

	43. "The world is now in the middle of a new mobility revolution. Examine India's efforts at accelerating the deployment of electric vehicles (EVs).	50	APPSC 2023
	44. The Draft Environment Impact Assessment (EIA) Notification of 2020: An Analysis.	50	APPSC 2020
	45. How to Maintain a Proper Balance Between Developmental Activities and Water Conservation?	50	APPSC 2020
	46. In Stephen Hawking's words, "Mankind must move to outer space within a century". In the backdrop of his prediction, what are the factors leading to pessimism in turning around the global environmental degradation? Discuss.	50	APPSC 2017
	47. "River linking is a panacea for the woes of farmers of Andhra Pradesh". In light of the above statement, explain how river linking can solve the problem of water scarcity in Andhra Pradesh. Also describe Pattiseema project of Andhra Pradesh and its benefits?	50	APPSC 2016
	48. What are global initiatives implemented by the United Nations for sustainable development? Discuss	50	TGPSC 2016
	49. Critically examine the measures taken by the Indian government for improvement of food security.	50	TGPSC 2016
	50. What are the aims and objectives of the National Water Policy? How are they reflected in the state water policies? Explain.	50	TGPSC 2016
	51. With constant rise in global temperatures, greenhouse gases and global sea levels, it is disastrous that climate change talks at Copenhagen between major nations have failed to come to a consensus. Explain why our leaders have failed to come to a mutual understanding for combating climate change.	50	APPSC 2011
	52. What is 'Drought'? What are the implications of drought? Discuss the various steps taken by the government in this regard. How do you tackle the problem there is drought continuously for three years?	50	APPSC 2008
(iv) Socio- Political Issues	53. Demographic Dividend or Burden? Rethinking the Population Explosion Narrative.	50	APPSC 2025
	54. Ethnic conflicts in India: A growing threat to national integration and inclusive development.	50	APPSC 2025
	55. Demographic Shifts in South India: Implications of Population Growth on Political Representation.	50	APPSC 2025
	56. The Three-Language Formula under NEP: Balancing Regional Identity and National Unity in India.	50	APPSC 2025
	57. Is judicial activism distorting separation of powers enshrined in the Indian Constitution? Critically examine citing relevant judicial pronouncements.	50	TGPSC 2024
	58. Despite Constitutional Guarantees and Policy Initiatives, Social Justice in India faces significant challenges. Examine.	50	TGPSC 2024

	59. India is the second largest urban system in the world. In this connection, examine whether India is equipped with adequate urban planning and governance.	50	APPSC 2023
	60. Andhra Pradesh is the first state in India to have established village secretariats and thereby, signalling a march towards achieving Gandhian ideals. In this connection, discuss the pioneering work of ' the Grama Sachivalayam' in revolutionizing governance.	50	APPSC 2023
	61. "India possesses a countless number of soft power resources that could prove to be greatly beneficial if harnessed properly. In this connection, examine India's soft power - its challenges and opportunities.	50	APPSC 2023
	62. Ek Bharat Shrestha Bharat is the call to forge national integration and the spirit of collective consciousness. Examine whether India has succeeded to rise above the forces of communal prejudice.	50	APPSC 2023
	63. Should there be Reservation for Women in Politics?	50	APPSC 2020
	64. Chinese Aggression and India: A Strategic Response.	50	APPSC 2020
	65. There is a global resurgence of nationalism or right wing. Discuss its implications for democracy and the neo-liberal economic policies.	50	APPSC 2017
	66. The Constitution of India provides protection to life and liberty of a citizen. At the same time, growing events of terrorism, naxalism and mob violence, underscore the need for stringent laws for control. Discuss the measures to be taken for striking a balance between both.	50	APPSC 2017
	67. Discuss the progress in recent Indian efforts in evolving joint counter terrorism strategy with different allies? What is the implication of current violence in Kashmir Valley on these efforts?	50	APPSC 2016
	68. What is the present situation of Dalits in India? Despite numerous developmental schemes and stringent laws for protection, why there is no substantial progress at the ground level?	50	APPSC 2016
	69. “Sedition laws have no place in a democracy” – Comment on the above sentence, in the context of the recent conflicts in our country?	50	APPSC 2016
	70. Explain “BREXIT”? Discuss its likely impact on governance, politics and economy of European Union?	50	APPSC 2016
	71. Write a critical essay on violation of human rights. What measures do you suggest to protect human rights in times of crisis?	50	TGPSC 2016
	72. Write an essay on 'War on Terror' in the light of 9/11.	50	TGPSC 2016
	73. Write a critical essay on the existing laws/policies against sexual harassment of women at the workplace.	50	TGPSC 2016
	74. What does the Indian National Policy for Senior Citizens 2011 reveal about the changing Indian society? Elaborate.	50	TGPSC 2016

	75. The civil society has to play an active role, when institutions of democracy have not served the people of India as well as they were expected to."- Discuss the statement in the context of the struggle for Jan Lokpal Bill.	50	APPSC 2012
	76. Write an essay on decentralised democracy and empowerment of weaker sections, in the light of recent developments in Panchayati Raj system in Andhra Pradesh.	50	APPSC 2012
	77. Examine the causes and consequences of the emerging sub-regionalism and demand for smaller states in India.	50	APPSC 2012
	78. Assess the power of courts to intervene in executive policy in the context of judicial activism of recent days.	50	APPSC 2012
	79. Democratic decentralization or Panchayati Raj aims at making democracy real by bringing the millions into the functioning of their representative government at the lowest level. However, parallel bodies at various levels diluted its aims and functions. Discuss with illustrations from Andhra Pradesh.	50	APPSC 2011
	80. Analyse reasons for the decreasing proportion of female population in India and suggest solutions to contain this trend.	50	APPSC 2008
	81. Discuss the working of Panchayati Raj in Andhra Pradesh with a focus on devolution of powers to local bodies.	50	APPSC 2008
(v) Cultural and Historical aspects	82. Illustrate the role of aniconic symbols in the representation of Gautam Buddha in Sunga arts and relate its influence to the development of Buddhist art in later periods.	50	TGPSC 2024
	83. The Role of the Youth in Preserving India's Cultural Heritage.	50	APPSC 2020
	84. Discuss the emergence of various cultural forms as tools of social mobilization in the Telangana statehood movement.	50	TGPSC 2016
(vi) Issues related to Civic Awareness	85. Obesity is a silent pandemic undermining India's public health gains.	50	APPSC 2025
	86. With advent of new technologies every year the need for human touch keeps descending. New technologies have surely made life easier, but is this taking us away from our basic necessities to maintain personal - physical relations without fellow human beings?	50	APPSC 2011
(vii) Reflective Topics	87. Motivation may be understood as the set of forces that cause people to behave in certain ' ways. Elucidate the above statement and describe the importance of motivation and need for a motivated employee in any organization.	50	TGPSC 2024
	88. Beauty is truth, truth is beauty'.	50	APPSC 2023
	89. Civic Sense and Public Spaces: An Urgent Need to Behave Responsibly.	50	APPSC 2020
	90. My First Public Speaking Experience.	50	APPSC 2020

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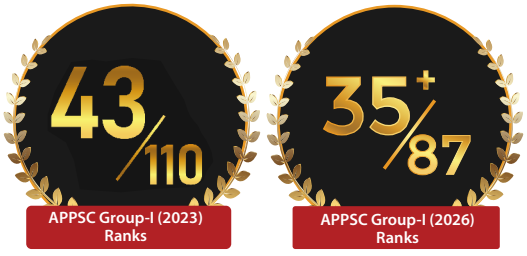
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Mains PYQs | Paper-I | Model Essays

GENERAL ESSAY

(i) Current affairs

1. Tourism in Andhra Pradesh: Assessing Challenges and Unveiling Opportunities for Growth. (APPSC, 2025)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Assess
Approach	• Begin with the significance of tourism in Andhra Pradesh's economy and also mention its rich heritage, coastline, and temples. • Give data from the AP Tourism Department. e.g., tourism contributes around 7% to state's GDP. • Discuss poor infrastructure, lack of connectivity, inadequate promotion, and environmental degradation. • Mention gaps in policy implementation like the 2015 A.P. Tourism Policy's limited execution. • Highlight ecotourism, spiritual circuits (Tirupati, Amaravati), coastal tourism, and digital marketing. • Reference "Dekho Apna Pradesh," "Eco-tourism policy," and public-private partnerships. • Suggest sustainable tourism, skill development, and integrated tourism circuits. • End with a forward-looking note on tourism as a driver of inclusive growth and cultural branding.
Introduction	Andhra Pradesh stands at an inflexion point in its tourism trajectory, endowed with a 1053 km coastline, hill shrines of pan-Indian fame, rich Buddhist and Kakatiya heritage, dynamic urban nodes such as Visakhapatnam, and a recently reoriented state tourism policy. The state possesses the natural and cultural capital to be a top national tourist destination. Yet, the promise of tourism as a driver of regional employment, rural livelihoods, and state revenues has not been fully realised; the sector remains skewed toward a few high-pull pilgrimage and coastal clusters, while vast hinterlands and emerging circuits remain underdeveloped. Recent administrative documents and district reports signal both scale and unevenness. for example, aggregated visitor arrivals in Andhra Pradesh reached into the hundreds of millions in 2023, highlighting enormous domestic demand that coexists with low foreign tourist penetration and spatial concentration of receipts.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Challenges of Tourism in Andhra Pradesh** The first structural challenge is concentration. pilgrim circuits like Tirumala and urban coastal hubs such as Visakhapatnam dominate arrivals and receipts, producing seasonal congestion, pressure on civic services, and leakage of tourist spending to a narrow set of enterprises. The Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) alone accounts for several thousand crores in receipts and is a magnet for millions of devotees annually; while this generates scale, it also eclipses investments in heritage towns, rural circuits, and nature tourism products that could spread benefits. Second, infrastructure and connectivity gaps remain acute beyond the primary nodes. Although air connectivity to the state's capitals and port cities has improved, first-and last-mile links, reliable public transport, and quality accommodation in secondary districts lag, raising travel friction and limiting average tourist length of stay and per-capita expenditure.

Third, the foreign tourist base is thin. while domestic arrivals run into the tens or hundreds of millions, foreign tourist arrivals to Andhra Pradesh remain a small fraction of India's inbound numbers, a barrier to earning higher foreign exchange, developing premium experiences, and attracting global marketing.

Fourth, coordination and product diversification are still works in progress. Multiple agencies, overlapping regulatory regimes, and uneven private sector participation make project implementation slow; natural-heritage sites need scientifically guided conservation, while community engagement remains sporadic.

Finally, data gaps and weak impact evaluation hamper evidence-based planning, although central and state reports now publish district-level data, the granularity, frequency and use of real-time statistics are inadequate for adaptive management.

Opportunities for Growth in Andhra Pradesh Tourism

Against these constraints lie clear, actionable opportunities. Demand is already present on scale. District and coastal figures show large domestic movement (Visakhapatnam district reported over two million visitors in a single year recently), which provides a launchpad for converting one-day visitors into multi-day stays through curated circuits and experiential offerings. Upgrading product mix, for instance, positioning Andhra's Buddhist sites (Amaravati, Bhattiprolu), Kakatiya monuments (Warangal nearby), coastal adventure, and gastronomy trails can generate longer stays and higher local expenditure.

Another opportunity is institutional reform. the Andhra Pradesh Tourism Policy 2024–29 explicitly seeks to "position Andhra Pradesh among the top 10 states in India for Foreign Tourist Arrivals" and to raise tourism's employment share, signalling political will and a policy architecture for incentives, PPPs, and targeted marketing. If implemented with outcome-based monitoring and facilitating private investment in mid-market accommodation, these policy moves can shift the state's unit economics favourably.

Sustainable and community-led tourism presents both social and economic upside. Village homestays, interpretive trails managed by local panchayats, and eco-certificate programmes for guesthouses can retain a larger share of the tourist rupee locally while protecting sensitive ecosystems. Smart use of digital platforms for micro-entrepreneurs, such as skill training for guides, digital payments, and online distribution, will convert latent supply into marketed products. Finally, leveraging anchor attractions such as TTD to create spillover circuits (pilgrim-plus leisure, wellness and heritage routes) can disperse demand temporally and spatially and increase average spend per visitor.

Evidence and Examples related to AP tourism

Empirical signals validate these directions. Visakhapatnam's district tourism department reported a record visitor count exceeding two crore in 2024, demonstrating hub potential when local authorities focus on events, beach management, and improved amenities; the city example indicates that with modest investments in cleanliness, safety and promotion, visitation can scale rapidly. At the same time, national tourism publications show that India's overall foreign tourist arrivals have recovered post-pandemic, which creates a window for Andhra Pradesh to intensify international marketing. The TTD's revenue projections and cash reserves underscore how a concentrated asset can fund catalysing investments. For example, financing regional infrastructure, restoring nearby heritage sites, or supporting community tourism pilots provided governance channels are institutionalised.

Policy Interventions and Implementation Priorities in the Tourism Sector

	To convert potential into outcomes, policy must be tactical and sequenced. First, invest in connectivity and service-level improvements in secondary circuits: targeted road upgrades, reliable last-mile transport, graded signage, and tourist facilitation centres. Second, create a differentiated incentive framework under the state tourism policy that rewards private investment in mid-range hotels and experiential operators outside major nodes. Third, institutionalise destination management organisations (DMOs) at district and cluster levels with clear KPIs, data dashboards, and a mandate to coordinate conservation, marketing and skills. Fourth, launch focused international marketing campaigns aligned to niche markets — Buddhist circuits for Southeast Asia, coastal leisure for Gulf markets, and pilgrimage packages for the Indian diaspora backed by measurable conversion targets. Finally, embed sustainability through carrying-capacity rules for sensitive sites, accreditation for homestays, and community benefit-sharing clauses in PPP contracts. The state policy's stated aim to increase tourist spending and employment offers a clear performance yardstick if linked to time-bound metrics.
Conclusion	Tourism in Andhra Pradesh is both an economic lever and a governance challenge. The state's rich natural and cultural endowments and recent policy momentum provide a rare opportunity to rebalance growth from heavily concentrated pilgrimage and urban hubs toward diversified, inclusive circuits that generate widespread employment and sustainable revenue. Achieving this will require pragmatic infrastructure fixes, stronger local institutions, smarter marketing to capture higher-value foreign tourists, and community-centric product development. As the policy documents themselves assert, the task is not merely to attract more visitors but to enhance the quality of the tourism economy so that revenues, livelihoods and conservation advance together, turning Andhra Pradesh's latent strengths into durable development outcomes.
Model Question	"Tourism in Andhra Pradesh has immense untapped potential but faces systemic bottlenecks." Examine the key constraints and suggest strategies for sustainable tourism development.
Value Addition	Andhra Pradesh Minister for Tourism, in the past 15 months, has attracted ₹10,644 crore investments in the tourism sector and signed Memoranda of Understanding (MoU) with 103 companies. The AP government had put in place a comprehensive, balanced, and investment-driven tourism policy that envisions Andhra Pradesh as a tourism hub. Currently, the Tourism Department is focused on building circuits, homestays, caravan facilities, tent cities, and developing large-scale eco/adventure tourism hubs with significant private and Central government investments. The tourism sector had been given industry status, and the AP government rolled out the new Tourism Policy 2024–29. It offered benefits like capital incentives for investors and power tariff reimbursements, which helped bring in projects worth ₹10,644 crore.
2. National Science, Technology and Innovation Policy has mandate to contribute in the vision of "Atmanirbhar Bharat". Elaborate the role of the policy with respect to making India as World's Technology and Service hub. (TGPSC, 2024)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Elaborate
Approach	• Introduce by presenting STIP 2020 as a strategic instrument of Atmanirbhar Bharat, promoting self-reliance, innovation, and global competitiveness. • Highlight India's key technological milestones (Example: Chandrayaan-3, Green Revolution) and STIP's role in bridging R&D gaps through increased investment, private sector participation, and mission-mode projects. • Explain STIP's facilitation of innovation in defence, electronics, space, and biotechnology, citing examples like ISRO's Chandrayaan-3 and Defence iDEX.

	• Show how STIP promotes startups and innovation-led enterprises, exemplified by ventures such as IdeaForge, Agnikul Cosmos, and Pixxel supported by initiatives like Startup India and Atal Innovation Mission. • Illustrate the strengthening of a globally competitive workforce through NEP 2020 reforms and skill programs like INSPIRE, VAJRA, and Skill India. • Conclude by reinforce STIP's role in operationalizing Atmanirbhar Bharat, fostering sustainable, climate-aligned innovation, and enabling India's emergence as a global technology and services hub.
Introduction	"Science is a beautiful gift to humanity; we should not distort it," said Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam. For India, science has never been merely an academic pursuit, it has been a tool of national reconstruction, a path to self-reliance, and a symbol of civilizational progress. In the contemporary world, nations are not measured by the size of their armies or economies alone, but by the depth of their innovation ecosystems. The National Science, Technology and Innovation Policy (STIP) embodies this understanding. It aims to position India as a self-reliant, technologically sovereign, and globally competitive nation, fully aligned with the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat. This vision is not isolationist, it is an assertion of India's capability to design, manufacture, and innovate for itself and for the world. The STIP thus seeks to transform India into the world's technology and service hub, where knowledge becomes both the means and the end of development.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Science and Technology: The Strategic Core of Atmanirbhar Bharat** India's post-independence journey has shown how technology can shape destiny, from the Green Revolution and White Revolution to Chandrayaan-3 and the digital revolution. Yet, despite this progress, the country's investment in R&D has remained around 0.7% of GDP, far below global leaders like the U.S. (3%) and China (2.4%). The STIP (2020) was conceived to bridge this gap. It calls for doubling national R&D expenditure, enhancing private sector participation, and aligning research priorities with national missions, from climate change and health security to frontier technologies like artificial intelligence, quantum computing, and semiconductors. The policy redefines the government's role from being the sole driver of research to being a facilitator of innovation-led growth. It adopts a "quadruple helix" approach, integrating government, industry, academia, and society into one ecosystem of creativity and purpose. **STIP and the Vision of Technological Self-Reliance:** The COVID-19 pandemic revealed the vulnerabilities of global supply chains and underscored the importance of scientific independence. India's swift development of Covaxin, an indigenous vaccine developed by Bharat Biotech and ICMR, showcased the power of homegrown science. The Atmanirbhar Bharat Abhiyan calls for domestic strength across critical sectors — defence, electronics, space, and biotechnology. STIP provides the blueprint for achieving this by encouraging indigenous design, innovation, and manufacturing. Initiatives such as Defence iDEX (Innovations for Defence Excellence) have empowered startups to develop cutting-edge systems. ISRO's success with Chandrayaan-3 and the opening up of the space sector to private players under IN-SPACe have created a thriving ecosystem of over 200 space startups. These examples illustrate how STIP's intent is being translated into national capability. **Building High-Tech Manufacturing and Semiconductor Ecosystem:** One of the clearest manifestations of STIP's spirit lies in India's semiconductor drive. The India Semiconductor Mission (ISM), launched with an outlay of ₹76,000 crore, seeks to develop domestic fabrication and assembly facilities. Recent approvals for

Tata Electronics' chip fab in Gujarat, Micron's assembly plant in Sanand, and CG Power's project in Assam mark India's decisive entry into the global semiconductor value chain.

These developments align perfectly with STIP's emphasis on mission-mode projects and public–private partnerships. The Chips to Startup (C2S) programme is nurturing design expertise across 85 academic institutions, creating a future-ready workforce for the electronics industry.

Thus, from being a consumer of imported chips, India is gradually evolving into a design and manufacturing hub for advanced technologies, a cornerstone of true Atmanirbhar Bharat.

Nurturing Innovation, Start-ups, and Knowledge Entrepreneurship:

A vibrant innovation ecosystem is vital to converting scientific potential into economic growth. India today hosts the third-largest startup ecosystem in the world, with over 100,000 registered startups and 110+ unicorns. This transformation has been made possible by a synergy between STIP, Startup India, and Atal Innovation Mission (AIM). The Department of Science and Technology's Technology Business Incubators (TBIs) and Research Parks at IITs have bridged the gap between academia and industry. Startups like IdeaForge (drones), Agnikul Cosmos (private launch vehicles), and Pixxel (earth observation satellites) are products of this innovation chain. Such ventures are not only creating jobs but also exporting high-value technology and services. India's innovation-led entrepreneurship is becoming a global brand of reliability, cost-efficiency, and creativity, precisely the vision STIP sought to ignite.

Human Capital: The Backbone of a Global Services Hub:

Science and technology thrive where human potential is cultivated. STIP complements the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 by advocating multidisciplinary education, research fellowships, and mobility programs. Schemes like INSPIRE, VAJRA Faculty, and Rashtriya Avishkar Abhiyan are nurturing research talent from school to advanced levels. At the same time, Skill India and FutureSkills Prime train millions in AI, data analytics, and cloud computing — essential for sustaining India's leadership in IT and knowledge-based services. With 1.5 million engineers graduating annually and a growing pool of skilled professionals, India has become the digital service capital of the world, exporting over USD 250 billion worth of IT and knowledge services in 2024–25. The STIP amplifies this advantage by upgrading skills from low-end coding to high-value design and R&D services.

Institutional Reforms and Legal Frameworks for Innovation:

For innovation to flourish, a robust legal and institutional environment is indispensable. The STIP advocates reforms in intellectual property rights (IPR), research funding, and public procurement. India's domestic patent filings have grown by 30% between 2020 and 2024, reflecting rising confidence in indigenous innovation. The proposed National Research Foundation (NRF) under NEP 2020 will provide integrated funding and ensure industry participation in academic R&D.

Moreover, public procurement reforms now give preference to "Made in India" technology solutions, providing assured markets for domestic innovators. These reforms collectively strengthen the innovation–commercialization continuum, essential for building a self-sustaining technology economy.

Global Partnerships and Reverse Brain-Gain:

Self-reliance in science does not mean isolation. The STIP promotes strategic international partnerships for co-development of technologies. The Indo-U.S. Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technologies (iCET) covers cooperation in semiconductors,

	AI, quantum computing, and 5G/6G technologies. Collaborations with France in renewable energy, Japan in materials science, and Israel in water management showcase India's global scientific diplomacy. Further, initiatives like VAJRA and GIST (Global Indian Scientists and Technocrats) bring diaspora experts back into India's research fold, creating a reverse brain-gain that strengthens domestic capacity while deepening global networks. **Inclusivity and Sustainability in Innovation:** True technological progress must be inclusive and sustainable. The STIP embeds grassroots innovation, traditional knowledge systems, and eco-friendly technology into its framework. The National Innovation Foundation (NIF) identifies and supports rural innovators. Unnat Bharat Abhiyan links universities with local development problems, turning campuses into laboratories of social innovation. Meanwhile, India's investment in green hydrogen, biofuels, and waste-to-wealth projects demonstrates the policy's alignment with the Paris Climate Accord and the Mission LiFE (Lifestyle for Environment). Such initiatives ensure that India's scientific rise contributes not just to profit, but also to planetary well-being.
Conclusion	The National Science, Technology and Innovation Policy is not merely a policy document, it is a national vision statement. It encapsulates India's aspiration to convert its demographic dividend into intellectual capital, its scientific curiosity into industrial capability, and its innovation into global influence. By integrating research, industry, and governance, STIP operationalizes the dream of Atmanirbhar Bharat, an India that designs, builds, and innovates for itself and for humanity. As India establishes semiconductor fabs, launches private space missions, exports digital frameworks, and leads the world in affordable innovation, it stands on the verge of becoming a global technology and services hub. In the words of Swami Vivekananda, *"The power of the mind is infinite."* The National Science, Technology and Innovation Policy harnesses that infinite power, ensuring that India's mind, powered by science and guided by self-reliance, lights up the path to a truly developed and confident nation.
Model Question	"Despite significant progress in education and professional opportunities, women remain underrepresented in STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics) fields. Critically examine the challenges faced by women in STEM in India and globally, and suggest policy measures and initiatives to promote their participation, leadership, and innovation in these fields."
Value Addition	**Some of the major R&D initiatives taken by the government in 2024-25 to promote indigenous scientific innovation:** • In 2024–25, the Government operationalised the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) under the Department of Science and Technology (DST) with a mandate to enhance participation from the private sector and promote interdisciplinary research aligned with national priorities. • The government has approved the Research Development and Innovation (RDI) Scheme to incentivize private sector participation in research and development. • 'VigyanDhara' scheme of the DST has been operationalised to strengthen the Science, Technology, and Innovation (STI) ecosystem in the country. • The government has approved the 'Biotechnology Research Innovation and Entrepreneurship Development (Bio-RIDE)' scheme of the Department of Biotechnology with new components namely Bio- manufacturing and Bio- foundry. • The National Quantum Mission (NQM) to seed and nurture a vibrant & innovative ecosystem and position India among the global leaders in quantum technologies.

	• Under the National Mission on Interdisciplinary Cyber Physical Systems (NM-ICPS), DST has launched BharatGen initiative for IoT& IoE, focusing on Large Language Modelling (LLM)/ Generative AI for developing advanced Gen-AI models tailored to India's linguistic, cultural, and socioeconomic diversity.
3. Is India's 'Digital Rupee' another version of Cryptocurrency? Examine India's progress on 'Central Bank Digital Currency' (CBDC) and its implications. (APPSC, 2023)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Examine
Approach	• Define Digital Rupee and clarify the difference with cryptocurrency (backed by RBI vs decentralised). • Mention the RBI pilot launch (2022) of CBDC in the wholesale and retail segments. • Show how CBDC differs from Bitcoin/Ethereum in volatility, regulation, and trust. • Show India is testing e₹ in interbank settlements and retail transactions in select cities. • Mention Advantages like Faster payments, financial inclusion, reduced transaction costs, and reduced dependency on cash. • Mention Challenges: Cybersecurity, privacy concerns, digital divide, and threat to commercial banks. • Give Implications like Strengthens monetary policy, reduces reliance on crypto, and boosts fintech. • Mention Conclusion that it is not crypto, but a regulated digital currency that can modernise India's economy.
Introduction	The emergence of digital currencies has revolutionised the global financial system. While cryptocurrencies like Bitcoin and Ethereum have sparked debates over regulation, volatility, and security, sovereign-backed digital currencies have emerged as a stable alternative. India, recognising the transformative potential of digital money, has introduced the concept of the "Digital Rupee," a Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) issued by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI). The key question often posed is whether this Digital Rupee is just another form of cryptocurrency or a completely different instrument. The distinction lies in regulation, trust, and legal recognition. The Government of India in the Union Budget 2022–23 announced the launch of the Digital Rupee, making India one of the first major economies to formally adopt a central bank digital currency. As India experiments with wholesale and retail pilots, the implications of this initiative span monetary policy, financial inclusion, cross-border trade, and technological innovation.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Digital Rupee versus Cryptocurrency** Cryptocurrencies are decentralised, unregulated digital assets whose value is determined by market speculation. They are based on blockchain technology but operate outside the purview of central banks. The volatility of Bitcoin, which fluctuated from nearly USD 68,000 in 2021 to less than USD 20,000 in 2022, illustrates the risks associated with cryptocurrencies. In contrast, the Digital Rupee is a sovereign currency issued and backed by the RBI. It carries the same legal tender status as physical currency, and its value is anchored to the Indian rupee. Unlike crypto-assets, it is not a commodity or speculative investment but a regulated instrument of exchange. This fundamental distinction highlights that the Digital Rupee is not another cryptocurrency but a central bank-issued innovation designed to strengthen the financial system. **Progress of Central Bank Digital Currency in India** India's journey toward a CBDC gained momentum after the RBI released its concept note on digital currency in October 2022. Following this, pilot projects were launched

for both wholesale and retail segments. In the wholesale segment, the Digital Rupee was tested for interbank settlement of government securities, aiming to improve efficiency and reduce transaction costs. In the retail segment, trials began in select cities like Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru, and Bhubaneswar, allowing users to transact using CBDC wallets provided by participating banks such as SBI, ICICI Bank, and HDFC Bank. These pilots mark a significant step in integrating digital currency into India's financial ecosystem.

Globally, over 100 countries are exploring CBDCs. China has advanced with its "Digital Yuan," while countries like Nigeria have already rolled out the e-Naira. India's progress is thus timely, ensuring it does not lag in the evolving global financial order. According to the Atlantic Council's CBDC tracker, India is among the 18 countries running pilot projects, demonstrating its proactive approach in this domain.

Implications for Monetary Policy and Financial System

The Digital Rupee has far-reaching implications for India's monetary policy and financial stability. Firstly, it enhances the transmission of monetary policy by providing a direct channel between the central bank and citizens, reducing dependence on intermediaries. Secondly, it reduces the costs of printing, transporting, and storing physical currency, which the RBI spends thousands of crores on annually. Thirdly, it provides a reliable and sovereign-backed alternative to cryptocurrencies, thereby safeguarding financial sovereignty.

However, there are concerns about the disintermediation of banks if people shift deposits to CBDC wallets. If not managed properly, this could reduce liquidity in commercial banks and impact credit creation. The RBI has clarified that CBDC will complement, not replace, existing banking channels. By striking this balance, India can modernise its financial system without destabilising it.

Digital Rupee and Financial Inclusion

India has made significant strides in digital finance through platforms like Unified Payments Interface (UPI), which processed over 18 billion transactions in June 2025. The Digital Rupee builds on this momentum, offering an inclusive platform that can reach the unbanked and underbanked. Rural areas often lack access to formal banking infrastructure, but with CBDC, individuals can hold digital wallets even without traditional bank accounts. This can significantly accelerate financial inclusion, a key development goal under the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Furthermore, the Digital Rupee can reduce transaction costs in cross-border remittances. India is the world's largest recipient of remittances, with inflows reaching USD 111 billion in 2022, becoming the world's largest recipient and the first country to surpass the $100 billion mark. A CBDC can streamline these transactions, reduce fees, and benefit millions of migrant workers and their families.

Technological and Security Dimensions

CBDC operates on advanced distributed ledger technology (DLT) and requires robust cybersecurity frameworks. In a country where cybercrime cases rose by 24.4% per cent in 2022, according to NCRB data, ensuring the safety of digital currency is paramount. Issues of data privacy, protection against hacking, and digital literacy remain pressing challenges. The RBI has emphasised that, unlike public blockchain cryptocurrencies, the Digital Rupee will function on a permissioned ledger, giving regulators greater oversight.

At the same time, technological innovation in CBDC can boost India's fintech ecosystem, encouraging start-ups and firms to innovate payment solutions. This aligns with the government's vision of "Digital India" and enhances the country's competitiveness in global digital finance.

	Geopolitical and Strategic Implications In a world where financial sanctions and dollar dominance often dictate economic outcomes, the Digital Rupee strengthens India's monetary sovereignty. It can facilitate trade with countries outside the SWIFT network, offering alternatives in times of geopolitical uncertainty. For instance, the possibility of conducting trade in CBDCs with partners like Russia or ASEAN members can shield India from exchange rate volatility and global payment disruptions. By building interoperability with other CBDCs, India can carve a strategic space in global finance. **Challenges and Concerns** Despite its potential, the Digital Rupee faces multiple hurdles. Public acceptance and trust will take time to build, especially among rural populations with limited digital literacy. Cybersecurity risks pose threats to financial stability. Banks fear losing deposits to CBDC wallets, while privacy advocates worry about state surveillance of transactions. Moreover, implementation costs, interoperability with existing systems, and technological glitches could hamper the rollout. Addressing these challenges through phased adoption, strong regulation, and public awareness campaigns will be critical.
Conclusion	The Digital Rupee is not another version of cryptocurrency but a regulated, sovereign-backed instrument that represents the next stage in India's financial evolution. By leveraging technology, India has made significant progress in piloting CBDC in both wholesale and retail domains. Its implications are vast, from improving monetary policy efficiency and reducing transaction costs to enhancing financial inclusion and safeguarding sovereignty in global finance. At the same time, challenges of cybersecurity, privacy, and banking stability require careful management. As Prime Minister Narendra Modi observed, "India is leading the world in digital payments," and the Digital Rupee is a natural extension of this leadership. If implemented thoughtfully, the CBDC will not only modernise India's economy but also strengthen its position in the global financial system.
Model Question	Differentiate between India's Digital Rupee and private cryptocurrencies. Critically analyse India's strides in Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) and evaluate its potential impact on the financial system.
Value Addition	**Stable coins:** They are typically backed by underlying assets' reserves or by algorithms that modify the supply based on market demand. They are designed to have a constant value in comparison to a traditional currency or other asset. They are either centralised or hybrid E.g., Tether (USDT)
4. India has become the fifth-largest economy in the world. Can India further aim to reach the top by actively engaging in the Co-operative Movement? Examine. (APPSC, 2023)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Examine
Approach	• Give an introduction by linking India's GDP growth with grassroots economic models like cooperatives. • Mention Context like cooperatives in agriculture (Amul), banking, housing, and rural development. • Mention the Role in Growth that helps inclusive development, farmer empowerment, and rural industrialisation. • Mention Strengths like Democratic functioning, community ownership, and reducing exploitation by middlemen. • Mention Progress on how the Ministry of Cooperation (2021) shows a policy push.

	• Mention Challenges like Political interference, lack of professionalism, and low capitalisation. • Mention Implications, like if reformed, cooperatives can support Atmanirbhar Bharat and GDP growth. • Mention the Conclusion that a strong cooperative sector can complement corporate and state-led models for a top economic ranking.
Introduction	India's economic trajectory in the 21st century has been remarkable. From being a developing nation grappling with poverty and shortages at independence, it has today emerged as the world's fifth-largest economy, surpassing the United Kingdom in 2022 according to IMF data. This achievement reflects structural reforms, demographic advantages, and technological progress. Yet, India aspires to climb further, aiming to become the third-largest economy by 2030 and ultimately reach the top position globally. For such a transformation, inclusive and sustainable growth is critical. In this context, the co-operative movement, with its deep roots in India's socio-economic fabric, assumes renewed significance. The question arises: can India reach the top by actively engaging in the co-operative movement? The answer lies in examining the role of cooperatives in empowering communities, promoting self-reliance, and complementing the larger economy.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The Significance of India as the Fifth-Largest Economy** India's achievement of being the fifth-largest economy is not just a statistical milestone but a reflection of resilience. India contributed to the GDP of over USD 3.7 trillion in 2023. Its services sector, IT exports, and manufacturing push under "Make in India," and rising consumer demand have all contributed to this growth. However, challenges remain, like inequality, rural distress, unemployment, and regional imbalances. For India to sustain growth and aim for the top, economic gains must reach the grassroots. This is where the co-operative movement becomes an instrument of inclusive growth, ensuring that prosperity is not confined to urban elites but spreads across rural and semi-urban landscapes. **Historical Role of the Co-operative Movement in India** The co-operative movement in India began in the early 20th century with the Co-operative Credit Societies Act of 1904. Since then, it has expanded into multiple sectors such as agriculture, dairy, housing, banking, and consumer goods. The movement was not merely an economic initiative but also a social reform tool aimed at empowering marginalised communities. Post-independence, cooperatives were recognised as vital for rural development. It was emphasised that "The spirit of cooperation is the basis of all social progress." India's "Operation Flood", spearheaded by the National Dairy Development Board in the 1970s, showcased the power of cooperatives. Amul, the dairy cooperative from Gujarat, transformed India into the world's largest milk producer, contributing over 22 per cent of global milk production. Similarly, IFFCO (Indian Farmers Fertiliser Cooperative) and KRIBHCO have empowered millions of farmers by providing access to fertilisers and agricultural inputs at affordable prices. These examples highlight that cooperatives have been engines of growth and equity. **Relevance of the Co-operative Movement for Future Growth** To reach the top of the global economic hierarchy, India requires models that combine efficiency with equity. The cooperative movement embodies this blend. Cooperatives operate on democratic principles of "one member, one vote," ensuring inclusivity. They empower small farmers, artisans, and workers who otherwise remain outside the formal economy. In agriculture, where 86 per cent of farmers are small and marginal, cooperatives can provide collective bargaining power, better market access, and value

addition through agro-processing. In banking, cooperative credit societies have historically bridged the gap between rural populations and formal finance. In housing, urban cooperative societies provide affordable solutions for middle-class families.

The International Cooperative Alliance estimates that cooperatives worldwide provide jobs to 280 million people, which is nearly 10 per cent of global employment. For India, which needs to generate millions of jobs annually to absorb its demographic dividend, cooperatives can serve as platforms for self-employment and entrepreneurship. They also align with the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat by reducing dependence on exploitative intermediaries and foreign supply chains.

Policy Push for Strengthening Cooperatives

Recognizing their importance, the Government of India created a separate Ministry of Cooperation in 2021 under the leadership of the union Home minister. The ministry aims to "strengthen the cooperative movement in the country and deepen the cooperative-based economic development model." Policy reforms such as computerisation of Primary Agricultural Credit Societies (PACS), digitalisation of cooperative banks, and support for multi-state cooperatives are steps in this direction. The recent initiative to create 2 lakh new PACS in five years shows the scale of government commitment. These measures ensure that cooperatives are not just seen as rural relics but as modern, tech-driven enterprises capable of competing in global markets.

Challenges Facing the Co-operative Movement

Despite successes, the co-operative movement in India has faced structural and operational challenges. Political interference has often undermined democratic functioning, with cooperatives becoming instruments of patronage rather than people's empowerment. Many cooperative banks have suffered from poor governance and rising non-performing assets, as seen in the Punjab and Maharashtra Cooperative Bank crisis. Lack of professionalism, limited capitalisation, and resistance to modernisation have also hindered their efficiency. Moreover, cooperatives have sometimes failed to adapt to global competition, remaining inward-looking and inefficient. Unless these issues are addressed, the movement's potential to propel India to the top economy will remain unrealised.

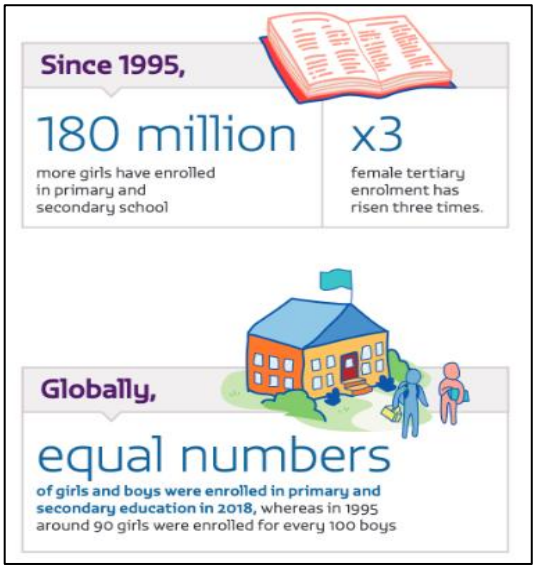
Examples and Comparative Global Experience

Globally, cooperatives have demonstrated remarkable success. In Japan, agricultural cooperatives contribute significantly to food security and rural stability. In Italy, cooperative enterprises account for a significant percentage of GDP in regions like Emilia Romagna, making them globally competitive. In Israel, the kibbutz model revolutionised agriculture through collective ownership. These examples show that with professionalism and innovation, cooperatives can thrive alongside capitalist enterprises. India can learn from such experiences to reform its cooperatives, making them engines of both growth and equity. Amul's expansion into global markets, IFFCO's diversification, and SEWA's empowerment of women workers illustrate how Indian cooperatives, too can scale up successfully.

Implications for India's Aspiration to Reach the Top

If India aspires to become the top economy in the world, cooperatives can play a decisive role in ensuring balanced and inclusive growth. They can provide rural communities with access to markets, credit, and technology, thereby reducing inequality. They can contribute to employment generation in sectors like dairy, fisheries, handicrafts, and agro-processing. They also offer resilience during crises; during the COVID-19 pandemic, many cooperatives stepped in to provide essential services when

	supply chains collapsed. Furthermore, cooperatives align with India's constitutional vision of social and economic justice under the Directive Principles of State Policy. They can help bridge the rural-urban divide, making India's growth more sustainable.
Conclusion	India's position as the fifth-largest economy is a milestone worth celebrating, but the path to the top requires inclusive growth models that empower the marginalized. The cooperative movement, with its history of transforming rural India, offers such a model. By democratizing economic participation, providing grassroots empowerment, and complementing state and corporate initiatives, cooperatives can drive India toward the top of the global economic ladder. Yet, reforms are essential such as professionalization, transparency, digitalization, and insulation from political interference must guide the next phase of the cooperative movement. As Amul's slogan "Taste of India" became the taste of global success, the cooperative movement, if revitalized, can become the spirit of India's journey to global economic leadership. India's dream of reaching the top is not distant if its cooperatives are actively engaged as partners in nation-building.
Model Question	The cooperative movement has historically shaped India's socio-economic landscape. In the context of India's emergence as the fifth-largest economy, assess whether revitalised cooperatives can serve as catalysts in propelling India to a top global economic position.
Value Addition	Operation Flood, also known as the "White Revolution," was a dairy development program launched in India in 1970 by the National Dairy Development Board (NDDB). Spearheaded by Dr. Verghese Kurien, it transformed India from a milk-deficient nation to the world's largest milk producer by creating a National Milk Grid to link farmers with consumers and establishing cooperative societies to provide farmers with control over resources.
5. Examine the challenges and progress of gender equality and women's rights in the world since 1995, the 'Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action' (BPA). (APPSC, 2023)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Examine
Approach	• Start with the significance of the Beijing Platform for Action (12 critical areas). • Trace global progress: women in politics, education, and workforce participation. • Give data (e.g., UN Gender Gap Index, SDG 5 progress). • Highlight regional disparities: Nordic success vs Middle East/Africa challenges. • Discuss persistent issues: wage gap, gender-based violence, and representation. • Mention Indian perspective: laws (POSH Act, Maternity Benefits Act), schemes (Beti Bachao Beti Padhao). • Critically examine gaps in implementation and cultural barriers. • End with roadmap: intersectional feminism, inclusive growth, stronger global cooperation.
Introduction	The 1995 Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action (BPA), adopted at the Fourth World Conference on Women, was a landmark in the global movement for gender equality. With participation from 189 governments, it identified 12 critical areas of concern, ranging from poverty and education to violence, health, and political representation. It was hailed by UN Secretary-General Boutros Boutros-Ghali as a "defining agenda for women's empowerment." In the decades since, the world has made notable strides in advancing women's rights, yet progress has been uneven, fragile, and often undermined by structural barriers such as patriarchy, economic inequality, and conflict. This essay examines the challenges and progress of gender equality globally since the BPA, drawing on statistical evidence, legal reforms, and contemporary examples.

Body & Infographic Representation	**Global Progress in Education and Literacy** One of the most visible achievements since 1995 has been in the field of education. According to UNESCO, the global gender parity index in primary education reached near equality by 2018, compared to a wide gap in the early 1990s. Countries like Bangladesh, once struggling with Female literacy, now report 98% enrolment of girls in primary schools. India too has seen dramatic improvement, with the female literacy rate rising from 54.16% in 2001 to 65.46% in 2011, largely due to schemes like Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan and Beti Bachao Beti Padhao. However, secondary and tertiary education still show disparities in many developing countries, with UNICEF reporting that in Sub-Saharan Africa, more than 33% of girls are out of secondary school, highlighting persistent challenges.  **Health and Reproductive Rights** The BPA stressed women's right to health and reproductive autonomy. Since then, maternal mortality rates have fallen globally by 34% between 2000 and 2020, as per the WHO. India's Janani Suraksha Yojana and institutional deliveries significantly reduced maternal mortality, with India's MMR declining from 556 per 100,000 live births in 1990 to 93 in 2029-21. Global initiatives like Every Woman Every Child have improved access to reproductive health. Yet, inequalities persist-UNFPA data shows that in Sub-Saharan Africa, one in 37 women still faces the risk of maternal death. Moreover, debates around abortion rights, as seen in the Roe v. Wade reversal in the US (2022), highlight that women's bodily autonomy remains contested even in developed democracies. **Women in Political Participation and Leadership** The BPA called for greater representation of women in decision-making. Progress has been noteworthy. In India, women's political empowerment received a major boost with the passing of the Women's Reservation Bill, 2023, guaranteeing 33% reservation in Parliament and state assemblies. Globally, women leaders like Angela Merkel, Jacinda Ardern, and Ellen Johnson Sirleaf demonstrated inclusive governance styles, often praised during crises such as the COVID-19 pandemic. However, barriers remain. UN Women's 2022 report estimates it will take another 130 years to achieve gender parity in political representation at the current pace. **Economic Empowerment and Workforce Participation** The BPA emphasized women's equal access to economic opportunities. The International Labour Organization (ILO) notes that women's labour force participation globally stands at 47% compared to 72% for men, a gap that has barely narrowed in 30 years. In India, female workforce participation remains low at 25% (2022), one of the lowest globally, despite rapid GDP growth. Factors such as unpaid care work, workplace discrimination, and lack of childcare facilities restrict women's economic mobility. Yet, there are positive examples, such as self-help groups under the National Rural Livelihoods Mission in India have empowered millions of rural women economically. Globally, microfinance institutions like the Grameen Bank in Bangladesh have lifted

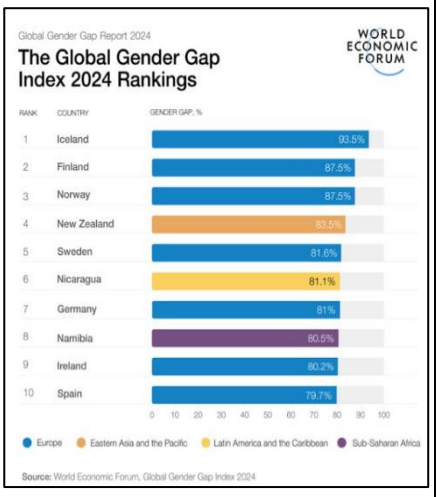
women from poverty, demonstrating the transformative potential of economic inclusion.

Violence Against Women: Persistent Global Challenge

The BPA identified violence against women as a major barrier to equality. Despite global campaigns like UNiTE to End Violence Against Women and laws such as India's Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act (2005), violence remains widespread. The WHO (2021) reported that 1 in 3 women globally have experienced physical or sexual violence in their lifetime. High-profile cases such as the Nirbhaya gang rape (2012) in India and the #MeToo movement (2017 onwards) highlight both the scale of violence and the rise of global consciousness against it. Conflict zones, such as Afghanistan under Taliban rule, continue to subject women to systemic oppression, with bans on education and employment for women reversing decades of progress.

Cultural and Structural Barriers

Despite legal reforms, deep-rooted patriarchal structures persist. Gender stereotypes, son preference, and unpaid domestic labour remain pervasive. The World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Report 2023 ranks Iceland first, but countries like India (129th) and Pakistan (146th) show the persistence of wide gaps in economic and political participation. The pandemic worsened these gaps. It exposed the fragility of gender equality gains when global crises strike.



Intersectionality in Women's Rights

The BPA recognized that women's experiences are shaped by intersections of class, caste, race, and ethnicity. For example, Dalit and Adivasi women in India face triple burdens of gender, caste, and poverty-based discrimination. In the US, women of colour still earn 64 cents for every dollar earned by white men, reflecting persistent racial and gender inequalities. Indigenous women in Latin America and Australia also face disproportionate violence and a lack of access to healthcare and education. Intersectionality highlights that gender equality cannot be seen in isolation but must address overlapping social inequalities.

Global Cooperation and SDG 5

The adoption of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) in 2015, particularly SDG 5 (achieve gender equality and empower all women and girls), has renewed global momentum. International organizations like UN Women, along with civil society and grassroots movements, have created frameworks for accountability. Initiatives such as HeForShe promote male participation in the fight for gender justice. However, the 2022 UN Gender Snapshot Report warns that at the current pace, achieving full gender equality may not be possible before 2100, emphasizing the need for stronger commitments.

The Indian Experience in the Post-Beijing Era

India's journey reflects both progress and challenges. Legal reforms such as the Maternity Benefit Amendment Act (2017), Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace Act (2013), and Prohibition of Child Marriage (Amendment Bill, 2021-pending) are progressive steps. Schemes like Ujjwala Yojana improved health and dignity, while Beti Bachao Beti Padhao sought to correct skewed sex ratios. Yet, challenges remain.

	Female labour participation is low, crimes against women remain high, and representation in corporate boards is limited. The passing of the Women's Reservation Bill, 2023, however, marks a historic turning point for political empowerment.
Conclusion	The Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action remains the most ambitious global blueprint for gender equality. In the nearly three decades since, significant progress has been made in education, health, political participation, and legal reforms. Yet, persistent challenges like violence, economic inequality, cultural stereotypes, and intersectional discrimination continue to hinder the full realization of women's rights. Global crises like the COVID-19 pandemic and conflicts further expose the fragility of gains. "Women's rights are human rights, but they remain unfinished business everywhere." For the world to achieve true gender equality, collective efforts must continue with renewed vigour, ensuring that the promises of Beijing 1995 are not just remembered but realized in the everyday lives of women across the globe.
Model Question	"Patriarchy remains the biggest barrier to women's empowerment despite legal reforms." Evaluate in the context of 21st century global societies.
Value Addition	The Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Act of 2017 significantly increased paid maternity leave to 26 weeks for biological mothers with fewer than two children, and introduced 12 weeks for adoptive and commissioning mothers. It also mandated a crèche facility for establishments with 50 or more employees and included a provision for "work from home" after the initial leave period, if mutually agreed upon by employer and employee. Employers are now required to inform female employees about their maternity benefits at the time of their appointment.
6. Measures to Combat Outbreak of Covid 19: The Role of the Government and the Individual. (APPSC, 2020)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Approach	• Introduce with a real-life anecdote/quote highlighting COVID-19's disruptive impact; set context for government and individual roles. • Discuss the Government Measures Health infrastructure (testing, tracing, treatment, and oxygen), vaccination drive, welfare schemes, education continuity, and digital platforms like CoWIN. • Explain Individual Role – COVID-appropriate behaviour, vaccination participation, community solidarity, fighting misinformation, empathy towards vulnerable groups. • Write about State–Society Interplay, How success depended on cooperation (Example: lockdown hardships, vaccination success, migrant crisis). • Highlight the Challenges & Gaps like Rural health deficits, migrant distress, economic disruption, digital divide, and misinformation. • Conclude by emphasizing shared responsibility; resilient healthcare + responsible citizenship = strongest Defence against future pandemics.
Introduction	In March 2020, India witnessed haunting visuals of migrant workers trudging barefoot along highways, carrying children and bundles of belongings, desperate to return home after the sudden announcement of a nationwide lockdown. These images remain etched in public memory, not only for the human suffering they revealed but also for the resilience and solidarity that emerged in response. Alongside government announcements of relief packages, countless individuals and community groups distributed food, arranged transport, and offered shelter. This dual narrative of state action and citizen responsibility captures the essence of pandemic management. The outbreak of COVID-19 was not only a health crisis; it was a multidimensional shock to

	economies, education systems, and social cohesion. Combating it effectively required both robust government intervention and active individual participation.
Body & Infographic Representation	**State as the Guardian: Policy, Infrastructure, and Relief** The foremost responsibility during any outbreak lies with the government to protect public health through prevention, detection, and treatment. India's response was structured around a multi-pronged strategy of promoting COVID-appropriate behaviour, scaling up testing and contact tracing, expanding treatment infrastructure, and ensuring mass vaccination. Ministries and institutions like the MoHFW and ICMR issued protocols for testing, treatment, and quarantine, while state governments converted stadiums and schools into makeshift hospitals. The devastating second wave of 2021, marked by oxygen shortages, underscored the urgency of strengthening health infrastructure, leading to the rapid installation of oxygen generation plants and ramping up ICU facilities. Perhaps the most remarkable achievement was India's vaccination campaign. Beginning in January 2021, it rolled out vaccines in a phased manner, prioritizing healthcare workers and the elderly before expanding to the general population. By 2022, India had crossed two billion doses administered—a feat that reduced mortality rates even as new variants continued to circulate. Internationally, India also supplied vaccines under the "Vaccine Maitri" initiative, reinforcing the idea that health security is global in nature. Yet, a pandemic is not fought in hospitals alone. Recognizing the economic fallout of lockdowns, the government announced the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Yojana, which provided free food grains to over 800 million people, cash transfers to women account holders, and free LPG cylinders. Migrant workers, among the hardest hit, were supported through Shramik trains, state relief funds, and community kitchens. Equally, institutions like NCERT, NIOS, and IGNOU designed online modules, community radio lessons, and television-based education to ensure continuity of learning for students cut off from classrooms. These measures reflected the multidimensional role of the state in managing not just a disease, but a societal crisis. **Citizens as the Frontline: Behaviour, Solidarity, and Responsibility** While governments created the scaffolding of response, its success depended on individual compliance and responsibility. Simple acts such as wearing masks, maintaining distance, and practicing hand hygiene became the first line of defence. Citizens who isolated themselves at the first sign of symptoms or who took regular testing seriously contributed to breaking transmission chains. Community action also played a crucial role. From NGOs delivering rations in urban slums to youth volunteers creating digital platforms to track hospital beds and oxygen availability, individuals extended the reach of state capacity. During the plasma therapy phase, thousands stepped forward as donors, often at personal risk, embodying a spirit of civic duty. Another arena where individuals made a difference was in combating misinformation. Rumors about miracle cures, vaccine side-effects, and conspiracy theories spread widely on social media. Vaccine hesitancy, a potential roadblock to immunization, was overcome only because large sections of the population voluntarily stepped forward, thereby protecting not just themselves but their communities. Acts of empathy became as important as public health measures. Checking on elderly neighbors, supporting domestic workers with wages during lockdown, and buying from local vendors were all forms of social responsibility that cushioned vulnerable sections. The pandemic revealed that resilience was not only institutional but also deeply personal and communal.

	Interplay of State and Society: Balancing Health and Livelihoods: The pandemic illustrated that neither government action nor individual effort alone could succeed in isolation. The strict nationwide lockdown in 2020 reduced transmission in the initial months but simultaneously disrupted livelihoods, leading to mass migration and hardship. The government had to recalibrate by designing welfare packages and easing restrictions in phases. Similarly, the success of the vaccination drive was as dependent on state logistics and production as it was on public willingness to get vaccinated. This interplay underscores that public health crises demand shared responsibility, where the effectiveness of the state depends on the cooperation of society, and the safety of individuals relies on institutional scaffolding. **Looking Beyond: Lessons and Recent Developments** The pandemic also generated important lessons for future preparedness. In May 2023, the World Health Organization declared that COVID-19 no longer constituted a Public Health Emergency of International Concern, signaling a transition from emergency management to long-term vigilance. More recently, in May 2025, WHO member states adopted a landmark pandemic treaty aimed at strengthening global cooperation, equitable access to vaccines, and transparent information sharing. These developments reflect a collective recognition that pandemics are not one-off events but recurring challenges requiring systemic planning. On the scientific front, the development of updated vaccines and booster recommendations in 2024–25 has ensured continued protection against emerging variants. India's CoWIN platform, which enabled real-time vaccination tracking, has become a model of digital governance. Telemedicine, too, gained traction, offering accessible healthcare to rural areas. These innovations now stand as legacy systems, ready to be adapted for future health crises.
Conclusion	The foremost lesson of COVID-19 is that pandemics test both governance and citizenship. Governments must invest in robust primary healthcare systems, surveillance networks, domestic manufacturing of vaccines and drugs, and shock-responsive welfare schemes. At the same time, individuals must remain vigilant against complacency, continuing to practice health-conscious behaviour, supporting the vulnerable, and resisting misinformation. Ultimately, combating a pandemic is not a battle fought in isolation by experts in labs or policymakers in offices. It is a collective struggle where the resolve of the state meets the responsibility of the citizen. COVID-19 has shown us that an agile state and a conscientious society together form the strongest vaccine against future crises.
Model Question	"With the WHO warning about 'Disease X' as a potential future pandemic, critically examine India's preparedness to deal with such public health emergencies. Suggest measures to build a resilient health system and strengthen social safety nets."
Value Addition	**Affordable Health Coverage for All:** Under Ayushman Bharat - PM Jan Arogya Yojana (AB-PMJAY): • As of December 20, 2024, over 55 crore beneficiaries from India's economically vulnerable population in the bottom 40% are covered with ₹5 lakh health insurance per family. • Over40 crore Ayushman Cards have been issued as of 3rdApril 2025. • Over 8.50 crore authorized hospital admissions throughout the country. • Overall, 31,846 hospitals (17,434 public and 14,412 private) have been officially empaneled under the scheme as of 3rd April 2025. • ASHA and Anganwadi workers are now included as beneficiaries. • Over 25 lakhs+ enrollment.

7. 2017 has been declared as the International Year of Sustainable Tourism for development. In this context, discuss the initiatives taken by the Government of Andhra Pradesh for promotion of tourism. What additional steps may be taken to sustain tourism as an industry? (APPSC, 2017)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Discuss, What
Approach	• Introduce with the concept of sustainable tourism and explain its global significance in the context of the UN's declaration of 2017 as the International Year of Sustainable Tourism for Development. • Explain the importance of sustainable tourism for Andhra Pradesh, emphasizing its role in economic diversification and environmental balance, especially given the state's long coastline and heritage wealth. • Discuss the key principles of sustainable tourism development, such as destination management planning, active community participation aligned with the SDGs. • Analyze the major initiatives of the Andhra Pradesh government, including the State Tourism Policy (2024–29), eco-tourism projects, heritage conservation drives, etc. • Also, include fiscal and human development interventions like skill development for guides and hospitality staff, micro-credit support for local entrepreneurs and artisans. • Explain the role of governance, decentralization, and the private sector, highlighting the strengthening of district-level tourism bodies with fiscal autonomy. • Highlight the importance of accountability and monitoring mechanisms, such as carrying-capacity studies, social audits of eco-tourism projects, employment share, and conservation indices. • Conclude by synthesizing global principles with local needs, stressing that Andhra Pradesh can make tourism a resilient and inclusive growth engine.
Introduction	In 2017, when the United Nations declared it the International Year of Sustainable Tourism for Development, the world was reminded that tourism is not merely about leisure, but about livelihoods, cultures, and ecosystems. A telling example comes from Andhra Pradesh's Lambasingi, often called the "Kashmir of Andhra," where local communities once dependent on seasonal agriculture began offering eco-homestays and guided treks. This not only supplemented their incomes but also showcased the region's pristine biodiversity to responsible travelers. Such stories illustrate how tourism, when guided by sustainability, can transform communities. For Andhra Pradesh with its long coastline, spiritual hubs like Tirupati, and heritage sites such as Amaravati, tourism holds immense promise if nurtured as a balanced, inclusive industry.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Tourism, Sustainability and Andhra Pradesh** **Reframing tourism policy: Andhra Pradesh's policy backbone** Since 2017 Andhra Pradesh has moved from fragmented promotion to a policy-driven approach that treats tourism as an engine for jobs, heritage conservation and regional development. The state's recent tourism policy documents (including the 2024–29 framework) emphasize attracting private investment, creating anchor destinations, diversifying products (heritage, eco-tourism, pilgrimage, cruise and adventure) and, importantly, embedding sustainability and community participation in project design. The policy package streamlines approvals, offers investor incentives, and sets out targets to develop "anchor" destinations that can catalyze regional growth. These policy commitments are central to sustaining tourism as an industry rather than transient event-driven growth. **Infrastructure and product development: building the visitor experience**

A sustainable tourism industry needs reliable connectivity, clean public services, and differentiated products. Andhra Pradesh has invested in several strands: upgrading coastal and temple circuits (notably around Tirupati, Srikalahasti and Visakhapatnam), developing integrated tourism zones and revamping APTDC's accommodation and transport offerings to provide packaged experiences for domestic and international travelers. There has been simultaneous stress on experiential offerings such as farm-stays, eco-trails and community-run homestays to broaden income sources beyond hotels and large resorts. Such investments raise the quality of the visitor experience while creating livelihoods across the value chain which includes guides, artisans, transport operators, and small hoteliers.

Heritage, festivals and culture: identity as a tourism asset

Andhra Pradesh's rich temple architecture, colonial forts, Buddhist sites and living crafts form a unique cultural inventory. Recent moves to codify heritage tourism practice and invest in conservation and festival promotion signal that the state understands tourism's dependence on authentic cultural assets. A focused heritage tourism policy and active festival calendars can stabilize seasonal demand, benefit local artisans (through market access and branding) and ensure conservation costs are offset by sustainable visitor management. A well-managed heritage strategy keeps communities central to interpretation and revenue sharing while protecting sites from over tourism.

Sustainable and responsible tourism: environment, waste and communities

The UN's sustainable tourism agenda stresses minimizing ecological footprint and maximizing positive socio-economic impacts. Andhra Pradesh has begun integrating sustainability: promoting eco-tourism in sensitive zones, encouraging energy and water efficiency in hospitality projects, and piloting waste-management approaches in urban and coastal destinations. Linking tourism projects to local natural resource management (for example coastal zone protection, mangrove restoration and watershed work around hill stations) creates resilience to climate risks, a vital consideration for a coastal state. Yet, implementation at scale requires stronger monitoring and incentives for low-impact infrastructure across private and public investments.

Institutional reforms and marketing: governance to match ambition

Transforming tourism into a sustainable industry has administrative and marketing dimensions. Andhra Pradesh has consolidated agencies (state tourism department, APTDC and district tourism cells) and introduced investor-friendly procedures to reduce red tape. Simultaneously, the state is investing in brand building like digital promotion, thematic circuits (spiritual, coastal, heritage), and partnerships with private tour operators to attract higher-yield travelers. Strengthening destination management organizations (DMOs) at city and circuit levels and creating data systems for visitor flows, carrying capacity and local economic impact will be necessary to make governance evidence-based and responsive.

Challenges that remain

Despite policy advances, several constraints persist. Infrastructure gaps along secondary circuits (last-mile connectivity, quality public toilets, reliable sanitation and waste systems) reduce repeat visitation. Seasonality concentrates employment and strains social welfare. Informal workers (guides, street vendors, small craftsperson) often lack access to formal credit, training or social protection. Environmental pressures like coastal erosion, waste in pilgrimage centres, and pressure on fragile hill ecosystems can quickly reverse the gains of promotion if not managed proactively.

	Finally, tourism's benefits are unevenly distributed unless deliberate inclusion measures reach poorer districts and marginalized communities. **Additional steps to sustain tourism as an industry** To convert the policy intent into durable outcomes, Andhra Pradesh can pursue a set of complementary actions beginning with destination management planning for each major circuit. This would involve clear carrying-capacity limits, visitor dispersal strategies, and revenue-sharing models that guarantee local communities meaningful economic benefits. Equally important is the need to mainstream green standards into the incentive framework: only projects with certified water and energy efficiency, zero liquid discharge, or comprehensive waste-management plans should qualify for fiscal support. Alongside, the state must expand skills and enterprise development through a certified training push in hospitality, language skills, and digital marketing, while also extending preferential micro-credit to tourism micro-enterprises to professionalize the supply side. Moreover, Andhra Pradesh must strengthen data and impact evaluation systems so that policies can be fine-tuned based on visitor profiles, economic multipliers, and social outcomes. This should be complemented by inclusive product development, such as community-owned eco-lodges, festival markets for GI-tagged crafts, and farm-stay circuits, to ensure that benefits are spread both geographically and seasonally. Finally, building climate resilience into coastal and hill tourism is imperative, using nature-based solutions and disaster-risk management frameworks to safeguard both visitors and local ecosystems. Together, these measures not only align with sustainable tourism principles but also create a more resilient and future-ready tourism industry for Andhra Pradesh.
Conclusion	The International Year of 2017 placed sustainability at the core of global tourism, linking it with the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Andhra Pradesh has since strengthened its policy framework, invested in infrastructure and branding, and emphasized heritage conservation and eco-tourism. These initiatives align with SDG 8 (Decent Work and Economic Growth) by generating jobs, SDG 11 (Sustainable Cities and Communities) through cultural revitalization, and SDG 13 (Climate Action) by promoting eco-friendly practices. Going forward, the state must translate policy into practice by institutionalizing destination management with carrying-capacity limits and incentivizing green-certified projects in line with SDG 12 (Responsible Consumption and Production). Empowering local enterprises, artisans, and women-led cooperatives through micro-credit and skills training will further SDG 5 (Gender Equality) and SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities). By embedding climate resilience in coastal and hill tourism, ensuring transparent governance, and advancing its vision of becoming a top tourism hub by 2030, Andhra Pradesh can make tourism a long-term engine of inclusive growth, cultural preservation, and ecological security, while contributing to India's SDG commitments.
Model Question	"India possesses immense tourism potential owing to its cultural diversity, natural landscapes, and historical heritage. Yet, the sector faces several challenges in realizing this potential fully. Discuss the opportunities and constraints of India's tourism industry, and suggest measures to develop it as a driver of sustainable and inclusive growth."
Value Addition	**Vision & Outcomes of the Telangana Tourism policy 2025-30:** • The vision of the Tourism Policy 2025-30 is to position Telangana as "India's Most Preferred Destination" by fostering harmonious blend of spiritual, heritage, culture, adventure, medical & wellness, eco-tourism with community empowerment

	through cutting-edge infrastructure and world class services to attract the tourists and investments. • **The policy aims to achieve the following outcomes:** ✓ Attract Rs.15000 Crores of new investments to tourism sector in next 5 years. ✓ Create additional Employment Opportunity for 'Three Lakh people' in next 5 years. ✓ To position Telangana in top 5 States in domestic and international tourist arrivals. ✓ Position diverse attractions of the state at Global level through concentrated efforts on digital marketing platforms / strong social media presence / literary documentation and preservation. ✓ Enhance tourism contribution to 10% or higher of the State GDP.
8. There is a marked shift in India's foreign policy initiatives under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Discuss the important changes and developments. (APPSC, 2017)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Introduce with context and an anecdote (2014 Madison Square Garden, 2023 G20) to illustrate the shift from reactive to leadership-driven diplomacy. • Highlight personal diplomacy, including frequent high-level visits that accelerate defence, investment, and technology agreements. • Emphasize India's economic diplomacy through initiatives such as Act East, Neighbourhood First, BRICS, I2U2, and Brand India. • Explain strategic balancing and multi-alignment, including deepening Quad ties while maintaining relations with Russia, West Asia, Africa, and Southeast Asia. • Discuss India's multilateral leadership and regional outreach, including engagement in the G20, BRICS, UN, ASEAN, as well as connectivity and security projects. • Mention constraints and risks, such as over-centralization, scrutiny of deals, balancing multiple partners, and MEA capacity limitations. • Conclude with India's Vishwaguru vision, highlighting strategic autonomy, global leadership, development-oriented influence, and responsible engagement.
Introduction	In September 2014, only a few months after taking office, Prime Minister Narendra Modi electrified the Indian diaspora at Madison Square Garden in New York. The event was more than symbolic; it projected India's rising global profile, turning diaspora engagement into a tool of foreign policy. Nearly a decade later, India's G20 presidency in 2023 culminated in the New Delhi Declaration, adopted unanimously despite divisions over Ukraine and economic recovery. In 2024, India played a decisive role in BRICS expansion, balancing ties with developed economies and the Global South. These episodes capture Modi-era foreign policy's transformation: from cautious, reactive diplomacy to a more ambitious, leadership-driven, and multi-aligned posture, combining personal outreach, economic statecraft, and proactive global agenda-setting to advance national development and strategic influence
Body & Infographic Representation	**Personal Diplomacy and 'Maximizing Prime-Ministerial Capital'** A defining feature of Modi-era foreign policy has been the centrality of the Prime Minister's personal engagement. Modi's frequent high-profile visits and carefully choreographed diplomacy have transformed leader-level outreach into a strategic tool. His February 2025 visit to the United States resulted in cooperation agreements in defence technology, clean energy, and digital innovation, illustrating how leader-level engagement accelerates negotiations and mobilizes investment. Similarly, the April

2025 visit to Saudi Arabia strengthened long-term partnerships in energy and investment, while June 2025 visits to Cyprus and Croatia, the first by an Indian PM, combined symbolic gestures with substantive outcomes such as diaspora engagement and business forums. Analysts note that this approach expands India's options globally but increases reliance on leader-level chemistry, requiring careful institutional follow-up.

Economic Statecraft: Trade, Investment, and "Brand India"

Modi's foreign policy closely links geostrategy and economics, positioning India as a development partner and investment hub. Policies like "Act East" and "Neighbourhood First" now emphasize connectivity, supply chains, and regional infrastructure. During the July 2025 five-nation Africa–Latin America tour (Ghana, Argentina, Brazil), Modi focused on trade, energy, and development cooperation, expanding India's footprint in resource-rich and emerging markets. The December 2024 visit to Kuwait, where he received the Mubarak Al-Kabeer Order, combined symbolism with bilateral negotiations on trade and investment. In Cyprus and Croatia (June 2025), Modi pitched "Brand India" to business forums, highlighting technology, start-ups, and green energy opportunities. Multilaterally, India's engagement in BRICS expansion in 2024 and I2U2-style initiatives reflects the strategic centrality of economic diplomacy in promoting national development and projecting India as a reliable partner in both North–South and South–South cooperation.

Strategic Balancing: Partnerships Without Formal Alliances

Under Modi, India has deepened strategic ties with the United States, Japan, Australia, and other democracies within the Quad, while maintaining historical ties with Russia and expanding outreach to West Asia, Africa, and Southeast Asia. This multi-alignment allows India to pursue defence modernization, space, and civil nuclear cooperation without formal alliance commitments. In 2024–25, defence-technology partnerships with the U.S. expanded, Quad coordination intensified, and operational collaboration with Russia continued, highlighting India's ability to navigate complex geopolitical pressures while maintaining strategic autonomy.

Multilateral Leadership and Institutional Entrepreneurship

India has actively used multilateral platforms to amplify its voice. Steering the G20 presidency in 2023 and achieving consensus on the New Delhi Declaration demonstrated India's bridge-building capabilities. The BRICS expansion in 2024 broadened India's outreach to Global South partners while retaining relationships with Western powers, creating new multilateral space for global governance reform. Platforms like the UN, Quad, and International Solar Alliance have allowed India to push agendas on digital public goods, climate finance, and supply-chain resilience. In 2025, India's leadership in Quad meetings and BRICS ministerial further illustrates its effort to translate economic and technological growth into institutional influence.

Neighbourhood First and Connectivity: Calibrated Outreach

India's neighbourhood policy combines developmental engagement with strategic caution. Recent years have seen a stronger focus on infrastructure and connectivity, including cross-border power trade with Nepal and Bhutan, the inauguration of railway and port links with Bangladesh in 2024, and continued investment in Sri Lanka's energy and port sectors. Complementary lines of credit and capacity-building programs strengthen regional integration. Security cooperation has also intensified, with joint anti-terrorism exercises with Maldives and Sri Lanka and enhanced maritime domain awareness via the Colombo Security Conclave. Under Act East in 2024–25, India deepened engagement with ASEAN on digital connectivity and supply-chain initiatives

	to manage great-power rivalry in the Indo-Pacific. The MEA highlights that physical, digital, and energy connectivity remains central to consolidating India's influence in its immediate and extended neighbourhood. **West Asia and Energy Diplomacy: Diversification and Geopolitics** India's West Asia policy has evolved from diaspora welfare and oil imports to comprehensive strategic partnerships encompassing energy, trade, investment, technology, and security. The Saudi Arabia visit in April 2025 advanced cooperation in renewable energy, defence production, and investment projects. The December 2024 visit to Kuwait, with the Mubarak Al-Kabeer Order, demonstrated India's stature and the Gulf's interest in infrastructure, fintech, and clean energy investment. The UAE–India Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) and collaboration in logistics and digital platforms underscore India's alignment with Gulf economic diversification strategies. Simultaneously, India's defence and energy ties with Russia continue, reflecting pragmatic hedging amid geopolitical polarization. **China and Border Dynamics: Deterrence and Hedging** India's approach to China in 2024–25 balances deterrence with engagement. Post-Galwan (2020), India strengthened border infrastructure along the LAC, expanded joint exercises with Quad partners, and enhanced maritime capabilities in the Indo-Pacific. India–China Corps Commander-level talks in 2024 sought to ease tensions, although troop deployments remain significant. Bilateral trade surpassed USD 118 billion in 2024, reflecting interdependence despite rivalry. India also deepened defence partnerships with like-minded states and maintained diplomatic channels via BRICS and the SCO, exemplifying strategic hedging that protects sovereignty while preserving engagement for economic and multilateral interests. **Recent Developments: Consolidation, Expansion, and Recalibration** The 2024–25 period demonstrates a consolidation of India's foreign policy gains. The MEA's institutional reports highlight economic diplomacy and India's role in shaping global governance. BRICS expansion in 2024 broadened India's partnerships with the Global South while maintaining ties with Western powers, advancing reform agendas. The strategic partnership with the U.S. strengthened, with civil-nuclear, space, defence, and high-level exchanges producing joint commitments on technology and security. Simultaneously, India maintained engagement with Russia and intensified outreach to West Asia for investment, energy, and diaspora concerns. These developments reflect a diplomacy that is assertive, diversified, and committed to preserving strategic autonomy. **Constraints, Critiques, and Risks** Despite successes, Modi-era foreign policy faces challenges. Personalized diplomacy, illustrated by high-profile visits to the U.S., Saudi Arabia, and the Africa–Latin America tour in 2025, risks over-centralization and policy volatility. Rapid transactional deals, such as investment or defence agreements, may attract domestic scrutiny regarding labour and environmental safeguards. Balancing ties with Russia and the West creates complex dynamics amid sanctions and geopolitical tensions. Leadership expectations from Global South partners, especially after BRICS expansion in 2024, require institutional capacity and sustained follow-through, which strain MEA resources. Multi-alignment also demands careful signaling to avoid unintended strategic drift.
Conclusion	Under Modi, India's foreign policy has evolved into an assertive, personalized, and economically-driven instrument that reflects the vision of India as a Vishwaguru, a global leader shaping norms, offering development solutions, and projecting moral authority. The period 2024–25 illustrates this vision through deeper strategic

	partnerships with democratic powers, expanded South–South cooperation via BRICS, continued engagement with traditional partners like Russia, and enhanced economic diplomacy promoting investment, technology, and sustainable development. By projecting India as a responsible global actor and institutionalizing gains across ministries, the country aims to combine strategic autonomy with global stewardship. The key task ahead will be translating diplomatic activism into tangible outcomes, strengthening security, fostering inclusive development, and positioning India as a guiding force in global governance, thereby realizing the vision of India as a Vishwaguru of the 21st century.
Model Question	"Vishwaguru India: Examine the vision of India as a global leader. Discuss how India's foreign policy, economic initiatives, and soft power contribute to achieving this aspiration, and identify the challenges in realizing it in the contemporary international order."
Value Addition	**India and ASEAN:** • India's Southeast Asian strategy recognizes the centrality of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) as the institutional foundation of regional architecture. India has systematically deepened its institutional ties with ASEAN through multiple mechanisms, such as the following: • **ASEAN-India Summit:** This annual summit serves as the apex platform for policy direction, with Modi's attendance at the 21st ASEAN-India Summit in Vientiane, Laos, in October 2024, reinforcing India's commitment. • **ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF):** India utilizes this platform to address regional security challenges, particularly maritime security and terrorism. • **East Asia Summit (EAS):** India's active participation in this forum emphasizes its role in broader Indo-Pacific strategic dialogues. • **ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus (ADMM+):** Defence Minister Rajnath Singh's presence at the November 2024 ADMM+ meeting in Vientiane highlighted India's security engagement with the region.
9. After reorganisation, the State of Andhra Pradesh is without a separate capital. The Chief Minister of Andhra Pradesh envisages a world-class city. While analysing the progress so far in realising the goal, evaluate Amaravathi as a "city for all". (APPSC, 2017)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Evaluate
Approach	• Begin with the context that the bifurcation of Andhra Pradesh in 2014 left it without a capital. • Mention the vision of Amaravati as a "world-class, people's capital" along the Krishna River. • Explain progress like land pooling schemes, infrastructure plans, foreign investments, and Greenfield design. • Discuss setbacks such as funding crises, political shifts, land disputes, and farmer protests. • Evaluate inclusivity, whether poor farmers and marginalised groups are truly benefiting. • Compare with global inclusive city models (e.g., Curitiba, Singapore). • Mention the current scenario of decentralisation policy, high court rulings, and stalled projects. • Conclude that Amaravati is still at a crossroads, needs balanced development ensuring equity and inclusivity.

Introduction	The reorganisation of Andhra Pradesh in 2014 created an unprecedented challenge for the residuary state, as it was left without a separate capital. Unlike Telangana, which inherited Hyderabad, Andhra Pradesh had to conceptualise and construct a new administrative, political, and economic hub from scratch. Against this backdrop, the then Chief Minister envisioned Amaravati as a world-class capital city that would embody inclusivity, modernity, and prosperity. Framed as a "people's capital" and a "city for all," Amaravati was projected to integrate global urban design with local cultural identity. However, the trajectory of Amaravati has been marked by ambitious promises, intermittent progress, political contestations, and unfulfilled aspirations. Analysing its progress so far provides a nuanced understanding of whether Amaravati has truly evolved towards becoming a "city for all" or remains a distant dream.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The Vision of Amaravati: A World-Class City** The conceptualisation of Amaravati was rooted in the aspiration to establish a futuristic city comparable to international models like Singapore, Putrajaya in Malaysia, or Brasilia in Brazil. Designed on the banks of the Krishna River, the city was envisioned as a hub of governance, commerce, knowledge, and culture. The master plan, prepared in collaboration with Singapore, envisaged Amaravati as a greenfield city spread over 217 square kilometres with state-of-the-art infrastructure, smart technology integration, green spaces, and inclusive urban planning. The project incorporated sustainable transport systems, extensive waterways, and mixed-use zones. Most significantly, Amaravati was projected not only as a symbol of modernity but also as an inclusive "city for all" that would uplift farmers, urban residents, industrialists, and marginalised communities alike. **Progress Made in Realising the Goal** In the initial years, Amaravati saw remarkable momentum. The land pooling scheme, a unique model in which nearly 30,000 farmers voluntarily contributed over 33,000 acres, was hailed as a pioneering step in inclusive development. Farmers were promised developed plots, annual compensation, and future appreciation of land values. Infrastructure contracts were awarded to reputed firms, and institutions such as the Andhra Pradesh High Court and Secretariat began operating from Amaravati. International firms from Singapore and Japan expressed interest in investments, and the World Bank and Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) initially extended support. By 2018, groundwork for road networks, government complexes, and residential areas had commenced, and there was a visible optimism about Amaravati's global potential. **Challenges and Setbacks in making Amaravati as Capital** Despite early progress, Amaravati's journey soon encountered formidable obstacles. The most significant challenge was financial: estimates for the project ran into several crores of crores, far exceeding the fiscal capacity of the state. Political discontinuity after 2019 altered the trajectory, as the subsequent government shifted focus to a decentralised model of three capitals of Visakhapatnam for the executive, Kurnool for the judiciary, and Amaravati for the legislature. This decision stalled ongoing works, disillusioned investors, and led to farmer protests that continue to this day. Moreover, international funding agencies like the World Bank withdrew, citing environmental and social concerns, compounding the crisis. The promise of inclusivity also came under strain. Farmers who surrendered land through pooling faced uncertainty regarding compensation and the fate of their holdings. Many smallholders expressed distress as speculative land markets benefited larger investors disproportionately. Urban poor and construction workers, who were

	expected to gain employment and housing, found themselves excluded amidst political ambiguity. This mismatch between vision and reality diluted the claim of Amaravati as a "city for all." **Amaravati and the Question of Inclusivity** For Amaravati to qualify as a "city for all," it must transcend being merely a showcase of elite urban infrastructure and instead serve the aspirations of diverse social groups. In practice, the benefits have been uneven. Farmers initially experienced empowerment through land pooling, but subsequent delays eroded trust. The middle class and entrepreneurs, who invested in real estate and business opportunities, suffered economic losses due to policy uncertainty. Marginalised groups such as the Scheduled Castes, the Scheduled Tribes, and women, who expected employment opportunities, saw limited tangible gains. This imbalance resonates with the broader critique of urban megaprojects worldwide, where the rhetoric of inclusivity often masks elite-centric development. The case of Brasilia, though planned as a modernist capital, ended up creating socio-spatial segregation. Similarly, Amaravati risks replicating such inequalities unless deliberate policies prioritise affordable housing, equitable employment, and social infrastructure like schools, hospitals, and public transport for all sections. **Comparative Perspectives and Lessons** Global examples underscore both inspiration and caution. Putrajaya in Malaysia, while visually impressive, has struggled to sustain vibrancy and inclusivity due to its limited engagement with ordinary citizens. In contrast, Curitiba in Brazil exemplifies how inclusive urban planning, through affordable public transport, green spaces, and participatory governance, can create cities that genuinely serve all. For Amaravati, the lesson is clear: building a capital cannot be merely about monumental architecture but must involve human-centric and socially just planning. **The Current Status of Amaravati** As of 2025, Amaravati remains embroiled in uncertainty. The three-capital policy has fragmented administrative functions, with Visakhapatnam emerging as the de facto executive hub. Amaravati houses certain legislative and judicial functions but falls short of being a holistic capital. The High Court judgments have oscillated between upholding Amaravati as the sole capital and recognising the three-capital model, deepening ambiguity. Farmers' protests have sustained pressure on the government, reflecting grassroots demand for Amaravati's development. Infrastructure on the ground is partial, with skeletal buildings and underutilised plots. For many stakeholders, Amaravati is a story of broken promises rather than a world-class city in the making. **Evaluating Amaravati as a "City for All"** Evaluating Amaravati against the ideal of a "city for all" requires a multidimensional lens. On the positive side, the land pooling model and initial global collaborations embodied inclusivity, at least in intent. The vision aligned with the aspirations of creating a modern, sustainable, and participatory city. However, in execution, inclusivity has faltered. Political instability, financial constraints, and lack of continuity in governance undermined the collective vision. Farmers, small investors, and marginalised communities bear the brunt of uncertainty. The city's progress is uneven, with symbolic rather than substantive achievements. Without equitable distribution of opportunities, Amaravati risks being remembered not as a "people's capital" but as a cautionary tale of ambitious dreams compromised by political contestation.
Conclusion	The reorganisation of Andhra Pradesh presented a historic opportunity to reimagine urban development through Amaravati as a world-class, inclusive city. While the initial

	momentum and vision were promising, the subsequent journey has been fraught with challenges that expose the vulnerabilities of large-scale urban experiments. Amaravati, as it stands today, is far from realising the ideal of a "city for all." For it to move towards that goal, governance must prioritise inclusivity, continuity, and fiscal realism. Policies must restore confidence among farmers, ensure affordable housing for the poor, create employment avenues, and uphold transparency in planning. As Mahatma Gandhi once remarked, "The soul of India lives in its villages"; unless Amaravati's development resonates with this principle by integrating rural aspirations with urban modernity, it will remain incomplete. In the final analysis, Amaravati still holds potential to be a beacon of inclusive growth, but realising it demands political will, financial prudence, and above all, a genuine commitment to making it truly a "city for all."
Model Question	In the aftermath of bifurcation, Andhra Pradesh aimed to develop Amaravati as a 'people's capital'. Critically examine the extent to which Amaravati has progressed towards becoming an inclusive and sustainable capital city.
Value Addition	Brasilia, a capital created ex nihilo in the centre of the country in 1956, was a landmark in the history of town planning. Urban planner Lucio Costa and architect Oscar Niemeyer intended that every element – from the layout of the residential and administrative districts (often compared to the shape of a bird in flight) to the symmetry of the buildings themselves – should be in harmony with the city's overall design. The official buildings, in particular, are innovative and imaginative.
10. India is called the "surrogacy hub" of the World. Can commercial surrogacy be seen just as another industry? Evaluate in light of the bill regulating surrogacy pending before the Parliament. (APPSC, 2017)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Evaluate
Approach	• Introduce with anecdote or real example; set the stage by highlighting India's rise as the "surrogacy hub" and the ethical debate. • Discus about Commercial Surrogacy as an Industry – Present arguments supporting its treatment as a service sector: livelihood opportunities, employment generation, global demand. • Present Ethical & Social Concerns like exploitation, commodification of women's bodies, inequality, child rights, and coercion in altruistic arrangements. • Discuss Surrogacy (Regulation) Act 2021, ART Act 2021, Law Commission reports, and restrictions/exclusions in the Indian model. • Add relevant contemporary Developments & challenges like Underground networks, court cases, exclusion of LGBTQ+/single parents, enforcement gaps, and recent raids/news. • Conclude by suggesting a balanced rights-based approach: regulated compensated surrogacy, fair safeguards, women's empowerment, and ethical frameworks.
Introduction	"Children are not commodities," remarked a former Indian health minister while tabling the Surrogacy (Regulation) Bill. Yet, for years, India was popularly known as the "surrogacy hub of the world." Fertility clinics mushroomed across cities like Anand in Gujarat, Delhi, and Hyderabad, attracting couples from around the globe who sought surrogacy as a solution to infertility. At the same time, economically vulnerable women agreed to carry children for wealthier families, often seeing it as an opportunity for financial survival. This sharp contrast between hope and hardship raises the central dilemma of whether commercial surrogacy can be regarded as just another industry or whether it requires a unique ethical and regulatory framework.

Body & Infographic Representation	**Surrogacy as an Emerging Service Sector:** Advocates of commercial surrogacy argue that it operates much like any other service sector, creating livelihoods for both skilled and unskilled workers while solving a crucial social problem of infertility. Fertility clinics employ doctors, nurses, counsellors, and service providers, while surrogates receive compensation that may transform their economic condition. In countries such as the United States and Canada, compensated surrogacy is regulated through transparent contracts and safeguards that ensure fairness to both parties. Supporters contend that India, too, could have formalized and professionalized its booming surrogacy industry, combining medical expertise with economic opportunity in a transparent and legalized manner. **The Invisible Costs of Commodification:** Yet, surrogacy is far from a conventional service. The ethical dilemmas are profound, ranging from the commodification of women's bodies to the unequal power dynamics between surrogates and intended parents. Most surrogates in India belonged to the poorer strata of society and were often driven by economic desperation rather than genuine choice. Research documented cases where surrogates had little say in medical decisions, faced health risks during pregnancy, or were left without adequate care after childbirth. Even in altruistic surrogacy, the possibility of familial coercion is real, as women may feel compelled to serve as surrogates for relatives regardless of personal preference. The rights and welfare of the child also enter the debate, raising questions about whether the practice reduces the child to a contractual object rather than recognizing its inherent dignity. **The Legal Turn in India:** Responding to these concerns, India enacted two crucial legislations. The Surrogacy (Regulation) Act of 2021 banned commercial surrogacy, permitting only altruistic surrogacy for married Indian couples under strict conditions. The Assisted Reproductive Technology (Regulation) Act, also of 2021, complemented this by mandating registration of clinics and establishing penalties for unethical practices. Together, these laws marked a decisive shift from India's earlier global image as a hub of commercial surrogacy to one of the most restrictive regimes in the world. However, the laws also face criticism. By allowing only altruistic surrogacy by close relatives, they severely limit feasibility. They exclude single parents, same-sex couples, and foreigners, raising concerns about discrimination. The lack of clear enforcement mechanisms also risks driving the practice underground rather than eliminating it. **Cracks in the Wall: Ongoing Challenges** Despite the ban, underground networks have continued to operate. Recent reports in 2024 and 2025 from Hyderabad and Gurgaon revealed illegal surrogacy rackets exploiting poor women under unsafe medical conditions. This highlights the limitations of prohibition without adequate monitoring capacity. Meanwhile, courts are increasingly being approached to review controversial provisions, such as restrictions on egg donation, surrogates' age limits, and the exclusion of LGBTQ+ individuals. The judiciary has been called upon to balance the state's intent to prevent exploitation with citizens' fundamental rights to equality, autonomy, and family life. **Searching for a Middle Path:** The debate over surrogacy often polarizes into extremes: complete commercialization versus total prohibition. Yet neither approach appears adequate. Surrogacy involves deeply personal bodily labour, the emotional well-being of women, and the future of children, all of which make it different from conventional industries. At the same time, ignoring the financial motivations of surrogates and intended parent's risks

	perpetuating illegality and exploitation. A balanced approach may involve regulated compensated surrogacy, where surrogates are fairly remunerated under strict safeguards. Mandatory counselling, health insurance, independent consent verification, and transparent contracts could reduce exploitation. Expanding access to single parents and same-sex couples would also align the law with principles of equality, while retaining safeguards to ensure dignity and protection. **Beyond Law: The Social and Economic Context:** Ultimately, surrogacy cannot be understood in isolation from India's broader socio-economic context. Women who chose surrogacy usually did so because of poverty, limited education, and restricted livelihood opportunities. Addressing these root causes is as important as regulating the practice itself. Expanding healthcare access, strengthening social security, and empowering women through education and employment opportunities are essential measures to reduce the vulnerability that makes women susceptible to exploitation in the first place. The intersection of reproductive rights with women's empowerment must remain at the core of policy thinking. **The Road Ahead:** India stands at a critical juncture. It has attempted to eliminate exploitation through prohibition, but the persistence of underground networks reveals the inadequacy of bans alone. Moving forward, India needs to refine its laws, creating a rights-based framework that balances ethical concerns with practical realities. Allowing regulated compensated surrogacy under transparent safeguards, recognizing diverse family structures, and strengthening monitoring capacity are vital steps. At the same time, broader socio-economic empowerment of women remains central to ensuring that surrogacy, if chosen, is a matter of informed agency rather than desperation.
Conclusion	Commercial surrogacy cannot be equated with ordinary industries, for it involves women's bodies, children's lives, and moral dilemmas that defy market logic. Yet, outright bans without alternatives risk fueling illegality and exploitation. The real challenge for India lies in crafting a humane, transparent, and rights-sensitive model of surrogacy that upholds the dignity of women while fulfilling the aspirations of intended parents. If India succeeds in building such a framework, it can move beyond the image of a "surrogacy hub" and emerge as a global example of how technology, law, and ethics can work together to protect both hope and humanity.
Model Question	"Body is not a commodity, yet modern bio-economies increasingly treat it as one." Critically evaluate this statement with reference to organ trade, surrogacy, and biomedical research.
Value Addition	**Some of the key Provisions of The Surrogacy (Regulation) Act, 2021:** **Ban on Commercial Surrogacy:** • The act explicitly prohibits commercial surrogacy, banning any form of financial compensation to the surrogate beyond reasonable medical expenses and insurance. • Only Altruistic Surrogacy Allowed: • Surrogacy is permitted only for altruistic purposes, meaning the surrogate mother receives no payment or reward. **Clinic Registration:** • All surrogacy clinics and banks must register with the appropriate authority before conducting any surrogacy procedures. **Strict Eligibility for Intending Couples:** • The couple must be an Indian citizen and married for at least five years.

	• They must have a certificate from a doctor confirming their infertility or an illness preventing conception. • The couple should not have any living children, except in cases of severe disabilities. • Both partners' gametes must be used, or a donor gamete can be used if medically certified necessary. **Strict Eligibility for Surrogate Mothers:** • The surrogate must be a close relative of the intending couple. • She must be married and have at least one child of her own. • Her age must be between 25 and 35 years. • A woman can only be a surrogate once in her lifetime.
11. How do you assess the global terrorism and intervention of US in the internal affairs of Afghanistan and Pakistan? (APPSC, 2012)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	How
Approach	• Introduce with a concise introduction linking the rise of global terrorism post-9/11 to US intervention in Afghanistan and Pakistan, emphasizing its global significance. • Explain the origins of the War on Terror and how the US justified military actions under security and anti-terror objectives. • Analyze the nature and outcomes of US involvement in Afghanistan, highlighting both military achievements and failures in governance and stability. • Examine Pakistan's complex role as both an ally and a safe haven for militants, addressing the consequences for sovereignty and domestic politics. • Discuss regional and humanitarian impacts, including refugee crises, extremism, and socio-economic damage, using credible global sources like UN and World Bank reports. • Conclude by evaluating long-term lessons for global counterterrorism, stressing the need for political inclusion, economic justice, and multilateral cooperation over prolonged intervention.
Introduction	The September 11 attacks marked a turning point that redefined global security architecture and the conduct of international relations. In response, the United States launched the "War on Terror," invoking the right of self-defense under the UN Charter, which led to military operations in Afghanistan and later deep engagement in Pakistan. The fall of the Taliban regime in 2001 was initially seen as a victory, but the prolonged occupation exposed the limits of military solutions to ideological extremism. US drone strikes, counterinsurgency missions, and intelligence collaborations with Pakistan created complex consequences, including civilian casualties, political instability, and anti-American sentiment. Moreover, the intervention reshaped global alliances, intensified debates on state sovereignty and human rights, and set precedents for preventive warfare. Two decades later, its outcomes continue to influence global counterterrorism policy and regional geopolitics in South and Central Asia.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Global Terrorism and the United States' Intervention in Afghanistan and Pakistan:** **The Rise of Global Terrorism and the War on Terror:** The attacks of 9/11 were a turning point that redefined the concept of global security. The US-led "War on Terror" declared by President George W. Bush sought to combat terrorism globally, beginning with military operations in Afghanistan under Operation Enduring Freedom. The Taliban regime, accused of sheltering Osama bin Laden and Al-Qaeda, was swiftly overthrown. However, this victory was short-lived. As the Taliban retreated into Pakistan's tribal areas, the conflict turned into a protracted insurgency.

Global terrorism during this period expanded beyond state borders, taking on a transnational character. The United Nations Security Council and the European Union introduced numerous counterterrorism resolutions and frameworks, emphasizing coordination among intelligence agencies and the freezing of terror-linked financial assets. Yet, as terrorism mutated into a decentralized network driven by ideology and digital recruitment, traditional military approaches proved increasingly inadequate.

US Intervention in Afghanistan:

The US invasion of Afghanistan in 2001 was justified on grounds of national security and global peace. Initially, it succeeded in dismantling Al-Qaeda's strongholds and toppling the Taliban regime. However, over the years, the mission evolved into a complex state-building project involving democracy promotion, reconstruction, and counterinsurgency. The US and NATO allies invested heavily in Afghanistan's military and political institutions, with over two trillion dollars spent according to the Brown University Costs of War Project.

Despite these efforts, Afghanistan remained deeply unstable. Corruption, weak governance, and dependence on foreign aid undermined legitimacy. The Taliban gradually regained control of rural regions, exploiting local grievances and the failures of the Kabul government. The 2021 withdrawal of US troops and the rapid collapse of the Afghan government exposed the fragility of two decades of intervention. The chaotic scenes from Kabul airport symbolized not only the end of America's longest war but also the limitations of external military solutions to deeply rooted internal conflicts.

The Role of Pakistan in the War on Terror:

Pakistan occupied a dual and often contradictory role in the US-led War on Terror. As a frontline ally, it received significant military and financial assistance from Washington, estimated at over 33 billion dollars between 2002 and 2018. The US relied on Pakistan's logistical routes, intelligence support, and cooperation in capturing key Al-Qaeda figures. Yet, Pakistan also faced accusations of harboring militant groups and providing sanctuary to Taliban leaders, particularly in regions like North Waziristan.

This duality strained the relationship between Washington and Islamabad. Drone strikes conducted by the US inside Pakistani territory to target militants often resulted in civilian casualties, fueling public anger and anti-American sentiment. The assassination of Osama bin Laden in Abbottabad in 2011 further deepened mistrust between the two nations. Domestically, Pakistan suffered immense human and economic losses, with tens of thousands of civilians and soldiers killed in terrorist attacks. The war blurred the lines between counterterrorism and sovereignty, creating long-term political and social repercussions.

Regional Consequences and Security Challenges:

The intervention reshaped South Asian geopolitics in multiple ways. Afghanistan became a battleground for regional rivalries, particularly between India and Pakistan. India supported infrastructure development and democratic institutions in Afghanistan, while Pakistan viewed Indian influence there as a strategic threat. Meanwhile, Iran, China, and Russia pursued their own interests, each wary of prolonged Western presence in the region.

The instability also contributed to the spread of radical ideologies and cross-border militancy. Terrorist networks like the Haqqani group and Islamic State Khorasan Province (ISKP) exploited the chaos to expand their influence. Refugee crises placed additional pressure on neighboring countries, while the drug trade continued to fund militant operations. Reports by the UN Office on Drugs and Crime revealed that

	Afghanistan remained the world's largest producer of opium even during peak international military presence, highlighting the failure of eradication efforts. **US Policy Shifts and Strategic Retreat:** Over time, American policy toward Afghanistan and Pakistan evolved from aggressive intervention to strategic disengagement. The Obama administration's troop surge in 2009 briefly improved security but failed to secure a decisive victory. The Trump administration pursued negotiations with the Taliban, culminating in the 2020 Doha Agreement, which paved the way for US withdrawal. Critics argue that this deal legitimized the Taliban without ensuring adequate guarantees for human rights and democracy. The Biden administration's final pullout in 2021 was driven by domestic fatigue and a reorientation of US foreign policy toward great-power competition with China and Russia. However, the rapid Taliban takeover revealed the enduring complexity of counterterrorism in fragile states. The resurgence of Taliban rule has raised concerns about a new haven for extremist groups, threatening regional and global security once again. **Humanitarian and Socio-Economic Dimensions:** Beyond geopolitics, the human cost of the War on Terror has been staggering. According to UNHCR, millions of Afghans were displaced internally and externally, creating one of the world's largest refugee crises. The World Bank and UNDP reported that poverty rates soared and women's rights deteriorated sharply after the Taliban's return to power. In Pakistan, terrorist violence devastated communities and infrastructure, hindering economic growth and education. US interventions also reshaped public perceptions of the West across the Muslim world. Many viewed the War on Terror as a pretext for geopolitical dominance rather than genuine concern for global security. Civil society groups, scholars, and international organizations such as Amnesty International have repeatedly highlighted issues of civilian casualties, unlawful detentions, and violations of human rights under counterterrorism operations. **Global and Contemporary Relevance:** The legacy of US interventions in Afghanistan and Pakistan continues to influence global counterterrorism strategies. The experience demonstrated that terrorism cannot be defeated solely through military might. It exposed the importance of political legitimacy, economic inclusion, and regional cooperation. The emergence of new threats such as ISIS, cyber-radicalization, and lone-wolf terrorism demands a more nuanced and multilateral approach. In the current global context, the focus has shifted toward the intersection of terrorism, migration, and governance. European Union reports and United Nations Development Programme studies emphasize addressing root causes such as inequality, marginalization, and failed state institutions. The Taliban's return has also prompted debates about engaging with de facto regimes to prevent humanitarian crises while safeguarding international norms. Meanwhile, Pakistan's ongoing struggle with internal militancy and economic instability highlights the enduring consequences of two decades of conflict.
Conclusion	The US intervention in Afghanistan and Pakistan represents one of the most consequential chapters in modern international relations. It began as a mission to eradicate terrorism but evolved into a complex experiment in nation-building and counterinsurgency. While it succeeded in removing Al-Qaeda's leadership and weakening some extremist networks, it failed to secure lasting peace or institutional

	stability. The repercussions continue to shape regional geopolitics, global counterterrorism, and the discourse on humanitarian responsibility. The lessons of this experience are clear. Sustainable peace requires addressing political, economic, and social grievances alongside security concerns. Military power can suppress symptoms of terrorism but cannot eliminate its roots. As the world confronts new challenges of extremism, technological warfare, and geopolitical polarization, the story of Afghanistan and Pakistan stands as a reminder that global security must rest on justice, development, and cooperation rather than domination and intervention.
Model Question	To what extent does the UNSC's approach to terrorism balance global security imperatives with respect for state sovereignty and human rights?
Value Addition	**Some of the key UNSC resolutions on terrorism:** • **Resolution 1373 (2001):** This is the most significant UNSC resolution on terrorism is Resolution passed after the 9/11 attacks, which established a new framework for international counter-terrorism by requiring all Member States to take specific measures. Established the Counter-Terrorism Committee (CTC) to monitor the implementation of the resolution by all Member States and to assist them in building their capacity to fight terrorism. • **Resolution 2178 (2014):** Addresses the threat posed by "foreign terrorist fighters," requiring states to stem the flow of these fighters and to respond to their returnees and families with respect for human rights. • **Resolution 2462 (2019):** Reaffirms previous resolutions, particularly on countering the financing of terrorism, and emphasizes the need to enhance cooperation between the public and private sectors to make targeted financial sanctions more effective. • **Resolution 2617 (2021):** This resolution renewed the mandate of the Counter-Terrorism Committee Executive Directorate (CTED) and emphasized the need for comprehensive and integrated counter-terrorism strategies that respect human rights.
12. "The London riots of last year (August, 2011) exposed a widespread disillusionment with the establishment." - Explain the statement in the light of the growing economic crisis in Europe. (APPSC, 2012)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Explain
Approach	• Introduce with the 2011 London riots as a reflection of deep societal disillusionment, connecting the immediate trigger (Mark Duggan's shooting) to broader socio-economic and political alienation. • Situate the unrest within the European context of the 2008 financial crisis and austerity measures that widened inequality, unemployment, and social exclusion. • Examine how youth frustration, loss of institutional trust, and racial and class tensions converged to create widespread unrest across Britain. • Highlight the role of technology and media in shaping decentralized protests, linking it to similar anti-austerity movements in Europe. • Assess government responses and continuing issues such as inequality, alienation, and the erosion of public trust. • Conclude by emphasizing that genuine stability requires inclusive growth, social justice, and empathetic governance that restores faith in democratic institutions.
Introduction	The London riots of August 2011 were among the most significant moments of unrest in modern British history. What began as a local protest in Tottenham following the

	police shooting of Mark Duggan soon transformed into widespread violence across English cities such as Birmingham, Manchester, and Bristol. The events went far beyond a single confrontation between citizens and police. They exposed the deep frustration of marginalized communities who felt alienated from the political and economic mainstream. Behind the scenes, the unrest reflected the larger European economic crisis, the tightening grip of austerity measures, and the growing distrust between the governed and those in power. The riots became an expression of collective disillusionment with a system that appeared to reward privilege while neglecting the needs of ordinary people.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The London Riots of 2011: Disillusionment with the Establishment and the Shadow of Economic Crisis:** **Economic Backdrop and the Effects of the 2008 Financial Crisis:** The London riots can be traced to the 2008 financial crash, which deeply altered Europe's economic landscape. Across the continent, countries faced collapsing banks, stagnating growth, and rising public debt. Britain, though outside the Eurozone, suffered similar pressures. The Cameron-Osborne coalition government imposed austerity measures to curb spending, cutting welfare, education, and local services that disproportionately affected working-class communities. According to the IMF's 2011 Regional Economic Outlook, Britain's recovery was slow, with persistently high unemployment. The Office for National Statistics noted that youth unemployment had risen to around twenty-two percent. In marginalized areas like Tottenham and Hackney, poverty, scarce job opportunities, and limited access to education deepened frustration. For many, austerity symbolized not just economic hardship but a growing loss of faith in the promise of social mobility. **Austerity and the Deepening of Inequality:** Austerity policies widened Britain's social divide. While major banks were rescued with public funds, ordinary citizens faced welfare cuts and mounting insecurity. The OECD's 2011 Social Outlook noted that the United Kingdom was experiencing its highest inequality in decades, fueling resentment among those who felt burdened by a crisis caused by financial elites. The "Reading the Riots" study by the London School of Economics and The Guardian found that participants expressed frustration over unemployment, poverty, and exclusion rather than purely criminal motives. Many young people felt valued only as consumers but denied real economic participation. The riots, therefore, embodied the despair of a generation living amid visible affluence but invisible opportunity. **Disillusionment with Institutions and the Question of Justice:** The shooting of Mark Duggan was the immediate trigger for the unrest, but it exposed a deeper divide between institutions and the communities they served. Many residents viewed the police as an oppressive rather than protective presence. The Guardian's investigation found that policing was a major source of anger, with frequent reports of discrimination and intimidation in minority areas. Beyond the incident, the riots reflected a broader collapse of trust in institutions. The Joseph Rowntree Foundation noted a sharp decline in public confidence in government and media after the financial crisis. For working-class and minority communities, racial profiling, unemployment, and cuts to public services reinforced this alienation. The riots thus symbolized defiance against a system perceived as unjust and indifferent. **Youth Alienation and the Crisis of Identity:** The 2011 unrest revealed the deep alienation of young people in Britain's cities. Many grew up amid promises of prosperity but were denied real access to it. Cuts to youth

programs and community centers left few outlets for engagement. The London School of Economics found that many rioters felt politically invisible and unheard.

Sociologists noted that consumer culture intensified this frustration, as constant exposure to wealth and luxury deepened feelings of exclusion. Looting, though unlawful, became a symbolic attempt to reclaim visibility in a society that ignored them. The riots ultimately reflected a generation adrift, caught between rising aspirations and shrinking opportunities.

A Wider European Pattern of Discontent:

The London riots were part of a broader wave of unrest across Europe driven by austerity and economic despair. Spain's "Indignados" movement, Greece's mass strikes, and protests in Italy over inequality reflected a continent-wide crisis of trust. The European Commission's 2012 report warned that austerity was deepening exclusion and creating a "generation at risk."

Britain's turmoil mirrored these patterns. Though contexts differed, grievances were shared, anger at systems that bailed out banks while neglecting ordinary citizens. The riots thus signaled a European crisis of legitimacy, revealing how economic instability and unaddressed inequality could rapidly erupt into social unrest.

Technology, Media, and the New Form of Protest:

A defining feature of the 2011 riots was the use of technology to spread unrest. Social media and instant messaging platforms enabled rapid coordination. The BBC noted that BlackBerry Messenger and Twitter allowed gatherings to form across cities within hours.

This represented a new, decentralized form of protest in the digital age. Lacking leaders or manifestos, it reflected raw anger rather than organized ideology. Such digital mobilization has since shaped global movements for climate action, racial justice, and economic reform. The London riots thus marked the emergence of a new era of spontaneous, technology-driven activism.

Aftermath and Continuing Lessons:

In response to the riots, the British government formed the Riots, Communities and Victims Panel, whose 2012 report cited poor police-community relations, job scarcity, and eroded trust as major causes. Yet critics argued the government prioritized punishment over prevention.

More than a decade later, many problems persist. The Resolution Foundation reported in 2022 that real wages had stagnated for years while living costs soared. The COVID-19 pandemic and war in Ukraine deepened instability. Across Europe, similar discontent has resurfaced through protests over inequality and economic strain. The anger once visible in London's streets now echoes in widespread political alienation and populist movements.

Contemporary Relevance and the Need for Inclusive Recovery:

The lessons of 2011 remain relevant today. Unemployment, housing insecurity, and inequality still shape the lives of young people across Europe. Reports from the World Economic Forum and the OECD warn that persistent disparities and economic instability threaten democratic trust. The current generation also faces challenges such as climate change, automation, and digital exclusion.

The disillusionment that erupted in 2011 has transformed into political apathy and mistrust in institutions. Governments must build fairer economies and inclusive social systems that prioritize opportunity, empathy, and justice. The London riots remind us that genuine stability arises not from growth alone but from shared belonging and fairness.

Conclusion	The London riots of 2011 were more than acts of disorder. They were the expression of a society fractured by inequality, disconnection, and mistrust. They revealed the limits of austerity and the dangers of ignoring the grievances of those left behind by economic progress. The riots also reflected a wider European struggle against financial injustice and the erosion of social solidarity. More than a decade later, the world continues to grapple with the same questions of fairness, opportunity, and belonging. The events of 2011 remind us that peace cannot rest on the silence of the excluded. It must be built on the foundations of equality, dialogue, and respect. When institutions fail to listen, protest becomes inevitable. The challenge before governments is to rebuild trust by ensuring that every citizen, regardless of class or background, feels that they belong to the same story of progress. The London riots stand as both a warning and a lesson in what happens when that sense of belonging is lost.
Model Question	Critically analyze how rising inequality, youth unemployment, and erosion of institutional trust have transformed the nature of public protests and riots in the 21st century.
Value Addition	**Some of the recent riots happened worldwide:** **Bangladesh:** • **Student-led "Quota Reform" Movement (2024):** In July and August 2024, students led a massive movement against a quota-based government hiring system. The protests escalated into widespread violence after a brutal government crackdown, ultimately leading to the resignation of Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina's government. **Nepal:** • **"Gen Z" Anti-Corruption Protests (September 2025):** Large-scale, digitally organized protests led by young people erupted following a government ban on social media platforms. Demonstrations quickly expanded to target systemic corruption and nepotism. Violent clashes with security forces resulted in dozens of deaths and led to the resignation of the Prime Minister and the appointment of an interim government. **United Kingdom:** • **Anti-Immigration Protests (2025):** Riots linked to anti-immigrant sentiment continued, with reports of violent disorder outside hotels housing asylum seekers and clashes in Northern Ireland. **United States of America:** • **"No Kings" Anti-Trump Protests (October 2025):** Protests were organized in cities across the US to demonstrate against perceived government authoritarianism under President Donald Trump. Slogans included "Resist Fascism," and many rallies took the form of street parties.
13. Evaluate the health programmes in Andhra Pradesh with a focus on the working of 'Rajiv Arogya Sree' Scheme. (APPSC, 2012)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Evaluate
Approach	• Introduce with the Andhra Pradesh's evolving public health landscape and introduce the Rajiv Aarogyasri Scheme as a milestone in social health insurance. • Explain the scheme's origin, goals, and institutional framework aimed at providing cashless tertiary care for BPL families. • Discuss the scale of operations, empanelled hospitals, utilization data, and fiscal allocations from government reports. • Evaluate outcomes on financial protection, access to care, and health indicators using NFHS-5 and Andhra Pradesh Socio-Economic Survey (2024–25) data.

	• Highlight key issues such as geographical inequities, delayed reimbursements, limited primary care integration, and fiscal sustainability. • Conclude by aligning reforms with SDG 3, emphasizing integration with NHM and Ayushman Bharat, digital governance, and sustainable universal health coverage.
Introduction	Public health in Andhra Pradesh has witnessed a remarkable transformation over the past two decades, driven by sustained investments in infrastructure, primary healthcare, and innovative health-financing mechanisms. Among its flagship initiatives, the Rajiv Aarogyasri Scheme, later renamed Dr. NTR Vaidya Seva and Dr. YSR Aarogyasri, emerges as a landmark in social health insurance aimed at achieving Universal Health Coverage (UHC). Conceived to provide cashless tertiary medical care for families below the poverty line (BPL), the scheme seeks to reduce out-of-pocket expenditure (OOP) and shield vulnerable households from catastrophic health costs. By integrating public and private hospital networks under a single umbrella, Aarogyasri has redefined the landscape of healthcare access and equity in Andhra Pradesh, reflecting the state's broader commitment to Sustainable Development Goal 3 (Good Health and Well-being) and inclusive, welfare-oriented governance.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Health Programmes in Andhra Pradesh: Evaluating the Rajiv Aarogyasri Scheme** **Evolution and Rationale of Rajiv Aarogyasri:** Launched in 2007 by the Government of Andhra Pradesh, the Rajiv Aarogyasri Scheme was conceptualized to bridge the accessibility gap for tertiary healthcare in a state where public facilities were limited and private care unaffordable. Its principal aim was to provide financial protection to BPL families by covering high-cost hospitalization and surgeries for life-threatening diseases such as cardiac, renal, neurological, and oncological ailments. The scheme initially covered around 933 procedures, later expanded to over 2,000 procedures under subsequent administrations. The Dr. NTR Vaidya Seva Trust and later the Dr. YSR Aarogyasri Health Care Trust became the implementing agencies, operating in a public–private partnership (PPP) model. This model reflected an important shift in public-health governance, from direct service provision to strategic purchasing, where the state acts as a financier and regulator rather than solely as a service provider. According to the Andhra Pradesh Health, Medical and Family Welfare Department, the scheme now integrates over 1,400 empanelled hospitals, both public and private, and provides cashless treatment up to ₹5 lakh per family per year. **Coverage and Implementation** Data from the Dr. NTR Vaidya Seva Trust (2024–25) shows that the Aarogyasri scheme has treated over 19.6 lakh beneficiaries since June 2024, incurring an expenditure exceeding ₹5,562 crore, with cardiac and cancer care accounting for nearly one-third of the total cost. As of 2025, the state reported more than 1.5 crore families covered under the scheme, representing almost 80% of Andhra Pradesh's population, aligning with the government's commitment to Universal Health Coverage (UHC). However, utilization trends reveal regional disparities. Districts with better hospital infrastructure like Visakhapatnam, Guntur, and Krishna see higher claim rates, while rural districts such as Vizianagaram and Kurnool lag behind, reflecting uneven access to tertiary care. The Andhra Pradesh Socio-Economic Survey 2024–25 acknowledges these disparities and recommends improved referral systems and district-level infrastructure to make Aarogyasri more equitable. **Impact on Financial Protection and Health Outcomes:** Evaluations by the Public Health Foundation of India (PHFI) and state health departments have shown that Aarogyasri has significantly reduced catastrophic health

expenditures for enrolled households. Beneficiaries reported a 60–70% reduction in OOP costs for major surgeries. However, data from NFHS-5 (2019–21) reveals persistent health challenges that extend beyond tertiary interventions. For instance, only 49.3% of women in Andhra Pradesh are covered by any health insurance or financing scheme, indicating that a large proportion of the population remains uninsured despite Aarogyasri's wide reach. Moreover, 36.6% of women and 32.4% of men are overweight or obese, and 32.5% of adults have hypertension, signifying an epidemiological shift toward non-communicable diseases (NCDs), areas not fully covered by the Aarogyasri's tertiary focus.

NFHS-5 also reports encouraging trends in certain indicators: institutional births at 98.5%, full immunization coverage at 79.6%, and under-five mortality rate reduced to 32 per 1,000 live births. These improvements are linked to the state's complementary health programmes such as the Nadu-Nedu initiative, 104 and 108 emergency services, and the Dr. YSR Village Health Clinics, which collectively bolster the primary and preventive healthcare ecosystem. Yet, the persistence of anaemia (64.4% among women aged 15–49) and malnutrition underscores that insurance-based tertiary schemes must integrate with preventive health strategies.

Equity, Quality, and Accessibility Challenges:

Despite its achievements, Aarogyasri faces structural challenges. Geographic inequity remains a serious concern, as rural families often travel long distances to access empanelled hospitals located in urban centres. Quality assurance mechanisms require strengthening, empanelment criteria and post-treatment audits are inconsistently implemented, and instances of overbilling or supplier-induced demand have occasionally been reported.

The Socio-Economic Survey 2024–25 highlights issues of delayed reimbursements to hospitals, amounting to thousands of crores, which have strained relations with private providers. In 2025, for instance, major hospital associations temporarily suspended participation due to non-payment of claims, illustrating operational bottlenecks that undermine service continuity. Furthermore, the scheme's narrow procedural focus leaves out outpatient care, chronic disease management, and preventive health—all major contributors to OOP expenditure in India.

According to NITI Aayog's Health Index 2023, Andhra Pradesh ranks among the top ten performing states in healthcare delivery, yet continues to struggle with human-resource gaps and underinvestment in primary care, suggesting that tertiary insurance schemes alone cannot ensure long-term health equity.

Fiscal Sustainability and Governance

Financing Aarogyasri represents a significant fiscal commitment for the state. According to the Andhra Pradesh Socio-Economic Survey 2024–25, nearly 6% of the total state budget is directed toward health and family welfare, with Aarogyasri accounting for a major share of that expenditure. While this indicates strong political commitment, it also raises questions about fiscal sustainability amid rising claim volumes.

The state government's 2025 proposal to expand coverage from ₹5 lakh to ₹10 lakh per family and to include 1,000 additional procedures may improve service scope but could also double the scheme's financial burden unless offset by efficiency measures, digital claims monitoring, and rational pricing of procedures. Strengthening the Aarogyasri Trust's e-claims management system, ensuring timely reimbursements, and introducing independent clinical audits are vital to avoid fiscal slippage.

Integration with Primary and Preventive Health Systems

	Post-pandemic policy reforms have prompted Andhra Pradesh to rethink its health strategy toward an integrated model. The state has launched Dr. YSR Urban and Village Health Clinics and Family Doctor programmes to ensure regular screenings, early diagnosis, and referral linkages with Aarogyasri empanelled hospitals. This convergence of primary care and tertiary insurance is critical to address the growing NCD burden, as highlighted by NFHS-5 findings on hypertension and diabetes prevalence. Moreover, the National Health Mission (NHM) and Ayushman Bharat – PM-JAY provide a complementary framework that can enhance Aarogyasri's efficiency through shared databases and portability. Integrating the two can prevent duplication of coverage and ensure continuity of care across health tiers, aligning with India's broader Universal Health Coverage (UHC) goals.
Conclusion	The Rajiv Aarogyasri Scheme stands as one of India's most ambitious state-led health insurance models, enhancing financial protection and tertiary care access for millions in Andhra Pradesh. Yet, findings from NFHS-5 and the Andhra Pradesh Socio-Economic Survey 2024–25 reveal that gaps persist in preventive, primary, and chronic care. Aligning with Sustainable Development Goal 3 (Good Health and Well-being), the way forward lies in integrating Aarogyasri with grassroots health infrastructure, strengthening human resources, and expanding digital health monitoring. Fiscal discipline, timely reimbursements, and convergence with Ayushman Bharat and NHM can ensure inclusivity and long-term sustainability. In an era of global health uncertainties, Andhra Pradesh's ability to align Aarogyasri with SDG-driven public health reforms can serve as a replicable model for achieving universal health coverage and resilient healthcare systems across India.
Model Question	Evaluate the performance of Telangana's health sector since 2014.
Value Addition	**Key Health indicators of Telangana:** **Table 3.3 Key Health Indicators**

Sl. No	Indicator	Definition	Telangana	India	Source
1	Maternal Mortality Rate	No. of Maternal deaths per 100000 live births	43	97	SRS 2018
2	Infant Mortality Rate	No. of Infant deaths per 1000 live births	21	28	SRS 2020
3	Under 5 Mortality Rate	No. of under 5 deaths per 1000 live births	23	32	NFHS-5
4	Neonatal Mortality Rate	No. of neonatal deaths per 1000 live births	15	20	SRS 2020
5	Total Fertility Rate	No. of Children per woman in the childbearing age group	1.5	2	SRS 2020
6	Institutional Deliveries	Percentage	97	88.6	NFHS-5
7	Crude Birth Rate	Number of live births during a year per 1,000 people	16.4	19.4	SRS 2020
8	Crude Death Rate	Number of deaths during a year per 1,000 people	6	6	SRS 2020

14. Explain the inclusive higher education and the role of Fee Reimbursement Scheme in Andhra Pradesh. (APPSC, 2012)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Explain

Approach	• Introduce with the inclusive higher education and highlight its importance in Andhra Pradesh's socio-economic development. • Explain inclusivity in higher education with focus on equity, access, and participation across socio-economic and gender lines. • Discuss the objectives, structure, and implementation of the scheme, integrating recent reforms like JnanaBhumi, Vasathi Deevena, and Thalliki Vandanam. • Evaluate outcomes in terms of enrolment, gender parity, and empowerment, citing statistics and government reports. • Integrate the scheme with NEP 2020 objectives and SDGs (4, 5, 8, 10), emphasizing holistic human capital development. • Conclude by suggesting measures for improving implementation efficiency, institutional quality, and digital monitoring for sustainable inclusivity.
Introduction	Inclusive higher education not only bridges socio-economic divides but also empowers communities by creating equal opportunities for learning and advancement. In Andhra Pradesh, the vision for inclusive education is deeply embedded in the state's welfare-oriented governance model, positioning "education as a right, not a privilege". The state continues to expand access to higher learning through digital platforms such as the JnanaBhumi portal and targeted aid schemes, ensuring that students from disadvantaged groups including Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, Backward Classes, minorities and economically weaker sections, can pursue higher studies without being blocked by financial constraints. According to the Andhra Pradesh Socio-Economic Survey 2024-25, education remains a leading area of public investment, accounting for about 12.3 % of total state expenditure, with major allocations directed towards scholarships, welfare transfers and infrastructure reforms. This sustained commitment underpins the state's strategy to promote both access and equity in higher education.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Inclusive Higher Education and the Role of the Fee Reimbursement Scheme in Andhra Pradesh** **Concept of Inclusive Higher Education:** Inclusive higher education involves equitable access and meaningful participation of all students, especially those from disadvantaged communities. It is not limited to enrolment but extends to retention, quality learning, and employability. In India, the concept gained strength through constitutional commitments under Articles 41 and 46, which mandate the State to promote education and economic interests of weaker sections. Andhra Pradesh's policies reflect these values by targeting Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs), Backward Classes (BCs), minorities, Economically Backward Classes (EBCs), and differently-abled students. The Socio-Economic Survey 2024–25 notes that the Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) in higher education in Andhra Pradesh reached 37.2% in 2023, close to the national average, with an upward trajectory driven by state welfare initiatives. **The Fee Reimbursement Scheme: Design and Implementation:** The Fee Reimbursement Scheme (FRS), introduced in the late 2000s, was designed to ensure that no deserving student is deprived of higher education for want of funds. It reimburses tuition fees and certain institutional charges for eligible students pursuing graduate, postgraduate, and professional courses in both public and private institutions. The scheme operates through the JnanaBhumi digital platform, integrating Aadhaar verification, attendance tracking, and direct benefit transfer (DBT) mechanisms to ensure transparency and accountability. The state's flagship Jagananna Vidya Deevena scheme provides 100% fee reimbursement for eligible students, while Vasathi Deevena offers annual financial

assistance of ₹10,000 for ITI students, ₹15,000 for polytechnic students, and ₹20,000 for degree and professional course students to cover hostel and mess expenses. As per the reports, over 9.8 lakh students benefited from the scheme during the October–December 2022 quarter, with a disbursement of approximately ₹699 crore. These measures collectively ensure that financial barriers do not hinder higher education participation.

Impact on Access and Social Inclusion:

The Fee Reimbursement Scheme has had a transformative impact on educational access, particularly among rural and low-income households. It has significantly increased enrolments of students from marginalized backgrounds in higher education institutions, especially in professional courses like engineering, pharmacy, and medicine. As per Socio-Economic Survey 2024–25, the scheme has contributed to the rise in female enrolment, with women constituting nearly 49% of total students in higher education, reflecting progress toward gender equity.

In rural districts such as Srikakulam, Kurnool, and Anantapur, the scheme has notably improved transition rates from secondary to tertiary education. The first-generation learners have been able to access higher education due to the scheme, marking a clear link between economic support and educational empowerment. Moreover, the inclusion of differently-abled students and minorities under the scheme's eligibility criteria underscores Andhra Pradesh's broader vision of social justice through education.

Challenges in Implementation:

Despite its significant achievements, the Fee Reimbursement Scheme faces several challenges. One persistent issue is the delay in disbursement of funds to institutions. Several private colleges faced delays in receiving reimbursement dues for the 2023–24 academic year, affecting financial planning and sometimes leading to temporary restrictions on student admissions. Furthermore, while the scheme covers tuition fees, it does not always address ancillary costs such as examination fees, books, transport, and digital access, all crucial in the current technology-driven learning environment.

Another concern lies in the over-reliance on private unaided institutions, which constitute nearly 75% of higher education enrolments in the state. This dependency often results in quality inconsistencies and inequitable learning environments. While the Fee Reimbursement Scheme enables access to these institutions, it cannot guarantee uniform quality or employability outcomes. Hence, financial inclusion needs to be accompanied by robust regulation, accreditation, and capacity-building in the higher education sector.

Integration with the National Education Policy 2020:

The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 provides a comprehensive framework for transforming India's education system, emphasizing inclusivity, multidisciplinary learning, and affordability. Andhra Pradesh's Fee Reimbursement Scheme aligns directly with NEP's vision of "equitable access for all" and its call to achieve a 50% Gross Enrolment Ratio in higher education by 2035. The state government has been taking steps to integrate NEP's principles by promoting flexible curricula, expanding open and distance learning, and establishing multidisciplinary universities.

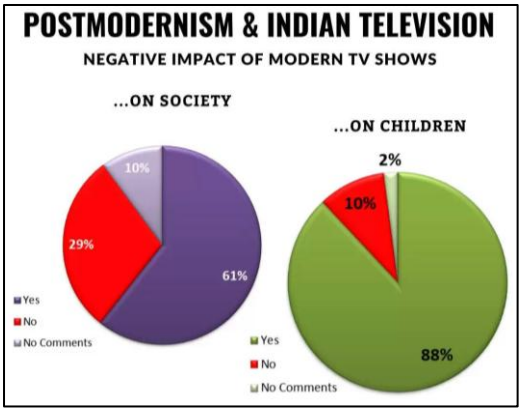
The Andhra Pradesh State Higher Education Council has initiated reforms to align fee reimbursement with institutional autonomy, quality enhancement, and employability linkages. Additionally, the introduction of skill-integrated courses and credit-based learning under the AP State Skill Development Corporation (APSSDC) ensures that students benefiting from the scheme also gain market-relevant skills. These reforms

	ensure that inclusivity is not limited to financial support but extends to academic and professional empowerment. **Recent Developments Strengthening Inclusivity:** Andhra Pradesh has launched several complementary initiatives to strengthen educational inclusion. The Thalliki Vandanam programme provides direct financial assistance to mothers for their children's education, improving educational continuity and reducing dropout rates in low-income households. The partnership between the state government and NVIDIA to establish an Artificial Intelligence University reflects a future-oriented approach to higher education, integrating innovation and technology. However, to ensure inclusivity in such advanced sectors, fee reimbursement and scholarship coverage must be expanded to include AI, data science, and emerging technology programmes. The Andhra Pradesh Socio-Economic Survey 2024–25 also highlights increased investment in higher education infrastructure, digital learning platforms, and faculty development programmes. These measures align with the NEP's emphasis on holistic human resource development and are designed to bridge the digital and regional divide in education.
Conclusion	Andhra Pradesh's Fee Reimbursement Scheme, along with complementary initiatives such as Vasathi Deevena and Thalliki Vandanam, embodies the spirit of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly SDG 4 (Quality Education), SDG 5 (Gender Equality), and SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities). While the Fee Reimbursement Scheme ensures tuition-free access to higher education, Vasathi Deevena supports students with living and hostel expenses, and Thalliki Vandanam empowers mothers to actively participate in their children's educational journey, thus fostering shared responsibility and gender empowerment. Together, these initiatives reflect NEP 2020's core objectives of equity, inclusion, and holistic learning. They also strengthen SDG 8 (Decent Work and Economic Growth) by improving employability and human capital. With enhanced implementation, digital transparency, and quality assurance, Andhra Pradesh can emerge as a national model for integrating inclusive education with sustainable development and social transformation.
Model Question	"Education is the most powerful tool to transform a nation." In the light of this statement, discuss how the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 seeks to create an inclusive, equitable, and holistic education system in India.
Value Addition	**Collegiate Education in Telangana:** • The Directorate of Collegiate Education manages 146 Government Degree Colleges, enhancing higher education with a Gross Enrollment Ratio of 39.3%, while technical education initiatives prioritise curriculum updates and industry partnerships. TASK (Telangana Academy for Skill and Knowledge) improves employability through skill development programs, benefiting students and faculty. • Collegiate Education focuses on improving higher education, ensuring equity, access, and quality. The state currently has 146 government Degree Colleges (GDCs), with 22 holding UGC Autonomous Status and 94 accredited by NAAC. In 2023-24, there were 48,954 student admissions with a Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) of 39.3. The government has also expanded its infrastructure, establishing 13 new GDCs in 2023-24 and introducing new courses like B.Sc (Honours) in Computer Science and Biotechnology.

15. Reality shows have become a major part of the prime time television. They are influencing mindset of numerous households making them believe and live in a hypothetical world. State the effect of reality shows on our society. (APPSC, 2011)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	State
Approach	• Introduction with a real-life example (Example: Indian Idol, Bigg Boss) to capture attention, then introduce the rise of reality television and state its growing influence on households. • Discuss how reality shows shape perceptions, body image, aspirations, aggression, and self-worth, especially among youth. Include both positive (inspiration, motivation) and negative effects (anxiety, unrealistic expectations). • Examine how these shows commodify private life, reinforce or challenge stereotypes, spread consumerist culture, and influence language, fashion, and social interactions. • Analyze their role as an industry: advertising revenue, careers, and entrepreneurship opportunities, but also exploitation of contestants. Explore political messaging, influencer culture, and how spectacle-driven content affects civic discourse. • Acknowledge constructive roles (talent recognition, education, etc) while evaluating ethical issues such as manipulation, mental health, and lack of contestant safeguards. • Suggest ways forward: contestant welfare measures, responsible content creation, and media literacy for audiences. • Conclude by weighing their dual nature and emphasizing the need for balance between entertainment and social responsibility.
Introduction	On the night of *Indian Idol*'s first season finale in 2005, millions of Indians stayed glued to their television screens, waiting for the winner to be announced. When Abhijeet Sawant, a middle-class youth from Mumbai, was crowned, the celebrations spilled onto the streets. For many, it was more than just a singing competition—it symbolized the rise of reality shows as aspirational platforms capable of transforming ordinary people into celebrities overnight. Over the years, the scope of reality television has expanded far beyond music and dance. From the quarrels inside "Bigg Boss" to the entrepreneurial pitches on *Shark Tank India*, such shows now dominate family conversations, social media feeds, and even fashion and consumer choices. The power of these shows lies in their dual identity: they entertain while claiming to be "real." Yet much of what appears authentic is, in fact, carefully curated drama designed to maximize ratings. This blurring of fiction and reality carries profound consequences. On one hand, reality shows inspire dreams and offer platforms for hidden talent; on the other, they foster unrealistic expectations, distort social values, and normalize a culture of spectacle. Their growing hold on prime-time television therefore calls for closer examination of their psychological, cultural, economic, and political impact.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The Influence of Reality Shows on Society** **The Rise of Reality Television** Reality shows have emerged as a dominant part of prime-time television, captivating millions of households worldwide. In India, programs such as *Indian Idol*, *Bigg Boss*, and *Kaun Banega Crorepati* command high viewership and social media traction. While marketed as unscripted entertainment, they have far-reaching consequences on viewers' aspirations, behaviour, and cultural values. This essay analyses their multifaceted impact on society through psychological, cultural, economic, and ethical dimensions. **Shaping Perceptions and Behaviour**

One of the most significant societal impacts of reality shows lies in how they shape public perceptions of "normal" social behaviour. Cultivation theory explains that consistent media portrayals influence viewers' sense of reality. Conflict-driven shows normalize aggression, manipulation, and sensationalism, making such behaviour appear acceptable in everyday interactions. Over time, viewers begin to equate dramatized behaviour with real life, blurring the line between performance and genuine human relations.



Psychological Effects: The Mind Under Influence

The psychological consequences of reality TV consumption are especially prominent among adolescents and young adults. Programs that glorify physical attractiveness, competition, and status foster body image concerns, anxiety, and self-worth issues. Studies from the UK's Mental Health Foundation link prolonged exposure to such content with low self-esteem and social comparison anxiety. However, the impact is not uniformly negative. For some, shows can serve as sources of motivation—talent hunts, for example, inspire individuals to hone their skills and pursue dreams. The difference lies in viewer maturity, parental guidance, and the ability to critically interpret televised content.

The Fame Economy and Aspirational Narratives

Reality shows project themselves as "democratizers of fame," offering ordinary individuals a chance at celebrity status. Overnight success stories reinforce the belief that stardom is accessible to anyone with talent—or sometimes merely with visibility. While this aspirational narrative is empowering, it can also be misleading. Research and journalistic accounts reveal that many contestants face disappointment after initial fame fades. Short-lived popularity rarely translates into sustainable careers, leaving participants vulnerable to exploitation, financial instability, and mental health struggles. The "fame economy" thereby normalizes fleeting recognition over long-term skill development.

Gender, Identity, and Representation

Reality television also plays a complex role in shaping gender roles and identity discourses. On the positive side, shows featuring diverse contestants bring visibility to marginalized communities and challenge stereotypes. For instance, regional formats occasionally highlight contestants from rural or disadvantaged backgrounds, showcasing their resilience.

Conversely, dating shows and relationship-based programs often reinforce regressive gender norms, objectification, and heteronormative ideals. Adolescents exposed to these portrayals may internalize problematic scripts of romance, attractiveness, and power dynamics, further embedding stereotypes in society.

Cultural Dimensions: Commodifying Everyday Life

Culturally, reality shows thrive on commodifying private emotions, conflict, and intimacy. Contestants' personal struggles are turned into consumable content for mass audiences. Editing, camera angles, and selective storytelling manufacture authenticity, even though much of the "reality" is heavily curated. Moreover, reality formats imported

	from the West undergo "localization" in India, creating hybrid cultural products that redefine lifestyles, speech patterns, and consumer desires. The popularity of such shows influences fashion trends, music consumption, and language use, effectively reshaping cultural identities. **Economic and Market Impact** From an economic standpoint, reality television is a lucrative industry. Sponsorship deals, advertising revenues, SMS voting, and digital streaming rights create significant financial flows. For participants, these shows can serve as platforms for entrepreneurship or acting careers. Yet, the economic benefits are often unevenly distributed. Media conglomerates and producers profit disproportionately, while contestants despite being central to the spectacle often receive limited compensation and little protection against exploitation. **Political and Civic Influence** Reality shows extend beyond entertainment into the political and civic realm. They provide platforms where political messages and consumer brands are subtly propagated. Contestants frequently become influencers with the ability to shape public opinion. The constant emphasis on spectacle and emotional appeal, however, risks trivializing serious civic issues. When conflict and dramatization dominate, nuanced debate and critical reflection suffer. This trend mirrors broader concerns about the "infotainment" culture in democratic societies. **Positive Contributions: Talent, Education, and Social Causes** It is important to acknowledge that not all effects are harmful. Certain formats serve constructive roles by discovering raw talent, providing livelihoods, and raising awareness about social issues. Shows focused on entrepreneurship (*Shark Tank India*), survival skills, or real-life problem-solving spark creativity and learning. Charity-based reality formats channel funds to social causes and inspire community involvement. Thus, the influence of reality TV cannot be reduced to a simplistic good-bad binary. **Ethical and Regulatory Concerns:** Reality shows raise serious ethical concerns, as contestants often face invasive surveillance, psychological stress, and exploitation for higher ratings. Reports of depression and, in extreme cases, tragic outcomes highlight the need for stronger safeguards. What appears as light-hearted entertainment can conceal significant mental and emotional strain. Addressing these issues requires a robust regulatory framework prioritizing contestant welfare. Mandatory counselling before, during, and after participation, along with clear, fair contracts, ensures informed consent. Broadcasters and content creators must provide warnings for sensitive material, enforce age-appropriate guidance, and maintain transparency in editing to avoid misleading portrayals. Equally important is audience empowerment. Media literacy campaigns in schools and communities can help viewers critically distinguish curated spectacle from genuine human experiences, mitigating the cultural and psychological impact of reality television while preserving its entertainment value.
Conclusion	Given their dual nature, reality shows demand a balanced societal response. Producers should exercise greater responsibility, regulators must ensure participant safety, and educational systems should nurture media literacy. Viewers, too, bear responsibility: cultivating critical awareness prevents passive consumption of curated spectacles as "reality." Reality shows are far more than entertainment—they are cultural texts that influence values, aspirations, and behaviors. They democratize fame and highlight talent, but also distort perceptions of reality, normalize conflict, and commodify

	intimacy. Their economic and political reach makes them powerful shapers of society, demanding ethical regulation and responsible production. Ultimately, whether reality shows enrich or erode our social fabric depends on how consciously we engage with them, as critical viewers, responsible producers, and vigilant policymakers.
Model Question	"With the rise of social media platforms, people are increasingly exposed to curated content that shapes perceptions and behaviour. Analyse the effects of social media on the psychological, cultural, and political fabric of society."
Value Addition	**Social Media Regulation in India:** • The Information Technology Act, 2000 (IT Act) is the main law that deals with online activities, including social media. It provides the legal base for electronic communication and e-governance. • Under Section 69A of the IT Act, the government has the power to block online content in certain situations, such as: ✓ Protecting India's sovereignty and integrity ✓ Ensuring the defence and security of the country ✓ Maintaining friendly relations with other nations ✓ Preserving public order • At the same time, Section 79(1) of the IT Act gives social media companies (called intermediaries) protection from being held legally responsible for what users post, but only if they follow certain rules. • In 2021, the government introduced the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules. These rules make it compulsory for platforms to be more responsible with content moderation. They must quickly remove harmful or illegal content and ensure a safer online environment for users.
16. The relations of India with the ASEAN countries is part of the "Look East Policy'. Does the same hold good with the Indo-EU relations? Do they follow the "Look West Policy'? Elucidate. (APPSC, 2011)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Does and do
Approach	• Start with the Look East Policy (1991 onwards) and India's outreach to ASEAN for economic and strategic reasons. • Explain its success, like trade, cultural, and security cooperation, leading to the Act East Policy. • Mention for Indo-EU relations, not framed as "Look West Policy" but involves structured engagement since the 1960s. • State that the EU is India's largest trading partner and major FDI source; strategic dialogue since 2004. • Mention Cooperation areas like trade, climate change, technology, counter-terrorism, and multilateral forums. • State Challenges like stalled Free Trade Agreement (BTIA), EU's human rights concerns, and Brexit impact. • Mention Indo-EU ties are pragmatic, interest-based rather than policy-driven like Look East. • Conclude that Indo-EU relations complement Look East but cannot be termed "Look West Policy" in the strict sense.
Introduction	India's foreign policy since independence has been shaped by its quest for security, economic development, and global influence. In this context, the "Look East Policy," launched in the early 1990s by Prime Minister P. V. Narasimha Rao, symbolised India's proactive engagement with the dynamic economies of Southeast Asia, particularly ASEAN. The policy was designed to integrate India into the Asia-Pacific growth story,

	diversify trade, and counterbalance China's influence. Over time, it evolved into the "Act East Policy," reflecting a more action-oriented approach. While India's ties with ASEAN and East Asia have been extensively analysed under this framework, an important question arises: do India's relations with the European Union reflect a parallel orientation, which could be described as a "Look West Policy"?
Body & Infographic Representation	**India and the Look East Policy with ASEAN** The Look East Policy, announced in 1991, was a strategic response to the end of the Cold War, India's balance-of-payments crisis, and the rise of East Asian economies. ASEAN, with its collective GDP of over $3.6 trillion today and comprising nearly 650 million people, became central to India's outreach. India's trade with ASEAN has grown significantly, from around $2.9 billion in 1993 to over $110 billion in 2022–23, accounting for about 11% of India's total trade. Initiatives like the India–ASEAN Free Trade Agreement in Goods (2009), Services and Investment (2015), and connectivity projects such as the India–Myanmar–Thailand Trilateral Highway reflect the deepening of economic cooperation. Beyond economics, the Look East Policy had a strong political and security dimension. India became a dialogue partner of ASEAN in 1992 and was later included in the East Asia Summit and ASEAN Regional Forum. Maritime cooperation, counter-terrorism collaboration, and defence exercises such as "SIMBEX" with Singapore illustrate the security dimension. It was noted that "ASEAN is at the core of India's Look East Policy." Thus, India's Look East engagement with ASEAN stands as a successful and multidimensional policy. **The European Union in India's Foreign Policy** The European Union, comprising 27 member states with a nominal GDP estimated to be around $19.99 trillion in 2025, is a global powerhouse in trade, technology, and diplomacy. The EU is India's third-largest trading partner, accounting for around 14% of India's total trade in goods in 2022, and the second-largest destination for Indian exports. Politically, India and the EU share common values of democracy, rule of law, and multilateralism. Strategic relations were formalised through the 1994 Cooperation Agreement and elevated to a "Strategic Partnership" in 2004. The annual India–EU summits provide an institutional framework for dialogue, covering issues like climate change, counter-terrorism, maritime security, digital transition, and health cooperation. For instance, during the COVID-19 pandemic, India and the EU worked jointly under the "Global Gateway" initiative to strengthen supply chains. Yet, Indo-EU relations have not always progressed smoothly. The Bilateral Trade and Investment Agreement (BTIA) negotiations, launched in 2007, remain stalled due to differences on intellectual property rights, market access, and labour standards. Moreover, the EU often raises concerns about human rights and environmental issues in India, which has occasionally created friction. Despite these challenges, India–EU relations continue to expand, reflecting growing recognition of mutual interdependence. **Does Indo-EU Engagement Represent a "Look West Policy"?** The phrase "Look West Policy" is not formally part of India's foreign policy lexicon, but it has been used by scholars and policymakers to describe India's engagement with its western neighbourhood and beyond. Traditionally, "Look West" referred to India's relations with the Gulf countries, emphasising energy security, diaspora, and regional stability. However, when applied to Indo-EU relations, the term can capture the essence of India's westward diplomatic and economic orientation. In many ways, Indo-EU relations mirror the rationale behind the Look East Policy. Just as ASEAN was a gateway to East Asian economic dynamism, the EU provides India with

access to advanced technology, investment, and global value chains. The EU is a leader in digital technology, renewable energy, and climate action in all areas where India seeks cooperation. Moreover, the EU's large Indian diaspora of nearly 2 million people further strengthens cultural and economic linkages.

From a political standpoint, India and the EU collaborate closely in multilateral forums, such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organisation, and the G20. The EU supported India's role in global climate negotiations, while India backed the EU's positions on sustainable development. Defence and security ties, though not as strong as with ASEAN or the United States, are growing, particularly in areas like counter-piracy operations in the Indian Ocean and joint naval exercises. Thus, Indo-EU relations, while not branded officially as a Look West Policy, do embody the characteristics of such an approach.

Comparative Analysis: Look East and Look West

A comparison between India's Look East engagement with ASEAN and its relations with the EU highlights both similarities and differences. In both cases, economic cooperation serves as the foundation, with trade and investment driving the partnerships. ASEAN provides India with access to emerging markets and strategic geography near the Indo-Pacific, while the EU offers advanced technology and a vast consumer base.

Politically, ASEAN engagement has focused on regional security and balancing China's rise, while EU relations emphasise global governance, climate change, and technology transfer. Institutionally, ASEAN is a regional bloc with strong security implications for India, whereas the EU is a more integrated economic and political entity. Moreover, while Look East has been a declared policy with clear strategic intent, Indo-EU relations have evolved in a pragmatic, issue-based manner rather than under a formal Look West Policy.

Nevertheless, both ASEAN and the EU represent pillars of India's external engagement. As Prime Minister Narendra Modi observed at the India–EU Summit 2021, "A stronger India–EU partnership is essential for a stronger world." This resonates with the idea that Indo-EU relations, like ASEAN ties, are central to India's vision of multipolar globalism.

Challenges and Opportunities in Indo-EU Relations

Despite the potential, several challenges hinder the full realisation of Indo-EU relations as a Look West Policy. The stalled BTIA negotiations remain the biggest obstacle. The EU's insistence on labour rights, environmental standards, and intellectual property protections contrasts with India's developmental priorities. Geopolitically, the EU's focus on its immediate neighbourhood, including Russia and the Mediterranean, often limits its attention towards India. BREXIT further complicated the picture, as the UK was one of India's closest partners within the EU.

However, opportunities abound. The EU's push for digital transformation, green energy, and resilient supply chains complements India's developmental needs. The India–EU Connectivity Partnership, signed in 2021, aims to build sustainable infrastructure in Africa and Asia, offering an alternative to China's Belt and Road Initiative. Defence cooperation is another emerging area, with France playing a leading role in Indo-Pacific security and Germany increasingly investing in maritime engagement. With negotiations for the BTIA recently restarted in 2022, there is renewed hope for deeper economic integration.

The Look East Policy with ASEAN and India's evolving partnership with the EU demonstrate the adaptability of Indian foreign policy in addressing changing global

	realities. While ASEAN ties are a product of the declared Look East/Act East framework, Indo-EU relations have developed more organically, shaped by trade, technology, and shared values. Though the phrase "Look West Policy" has not been formally adopted for Indo-EU engagement, the substance of the relationship reflects such a perspective, emphasising economic cooperation, political dialogue, and multilateral collaboration.
Conclusion	In a globalised world marked by shifting power centres, India needs robust partnerships both eastward and westward. The ASEAN provides regional anchoring in the Indo-Pacific, while the EU offers global leverage through technology, markets, and values. Together, they symbolise India's pursuit of strategic autonomy and multipolarity. "India's future is in Asia, but its destiny is global." In that spirit, Indo-EU relations, whether termed as Look West Policy or not, stand as an indispensable component of India's global engagement strategy.
Model Question	India's engagement with ASEAN is shaped by its "Look East/Act East Policy." In this context, evaluate whether India's relations with the European Union reflect a Look West approach in terms of trade, diplomacy, and strategic cooperation.
Value Addition	The Agartala-Akhaura Rail Link is a 12.24 km cross-border railway project connecting Agartala, Tripura (India), with Akhaura, Bangladesh, that was inaugurated in November 2023 with a successful freight train trial run. The project, a joint India-Bangladesh initiative, significantly reduces travel time and enhances trade between India's Northeast and Bangladesh's ports and cities, providing a shorter route to the Chattogram port and promoting regional connectivity.
17. There are a variety of public-private partnerships models on which the government relies upon. Explain various models with illustrations. Comment on the PPP model in Rajiv Gandhi International Airport at Hyderabad. (APPSC, 2011)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Explain and comment
Approach	• Define PPP. • Mention Models Overview like BOT (Build-Operate-Transfer), BOOT, BOO, DBFOT, OMT, Hybrid Annuity – explain briefly. • State BOT Example like National Highways projects (NHAI). • Mention DBFOT Example, such as Delhi Metro Airport Express line. • Stress on OMT Example, like Toll Road management on national highways. • Mention Hybrid Models: Example- Sagarmala, Bharatmala projects. • State the Case of RGIA Hyderabad, how it was successful in efficiency, world-class standards, and employment generation. • Conclude that while efficient and globally acclaimed, issues remain in land acquisition, user charges, and private monopoly need for balanced regulation.
Introduction	Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs) have emerged as a cornerstone of developmental policy in India over the last three decades, reflecting the evolving relationship between the state and the market. As the Indian economy liberalised in 1991, the government recognised that the scale of infrastructure demand could not be met by public resources alone. With fiscal deficits constraining public investment, the state turned towards private participation to mobilise capital, expertise, and efficiency. The concept of PPP thus embodies a middle path between state-led development and full-scale privatisation, where the government provides the enabling framework and the private sector brings in resources and management efficiency. In the Indian context, PPP has been most visible in infrastructure, roads, ports, airports, education, and health. The Economic Survey 2024-25 highlights the approval of 98 Public-Private Partnership (PPP) projects in the Ports, Shipping, and Inland Waterways sector, with a total value of

	approximately ₹69,800 crore, making it one of the largest PPP markets in the developing world. Within this framework, understanding the variety of PPP models and their implementation is crucial, and the Rajiv Gandhi International Airport (RGIA) at Hyderabad stands out as a flagship success story.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Concept and Rationale of PPP in India** The rationale for PPP stems from the limitations of the traditional state model of development. Public investment alone cannot bridge India's infrastructure deficit, estimated at nearly USD 1.5 trillion over the next decade. PPP enables risk-sharing, leverages private finance, and ensures better project delivery through contractual obligations. As the Twelfth Five-Year Plan observed, "PPP is not just about financing infrastructure but about improving efficiency and service delivery." The Planning Commission and later the NITI Aayog institutionalised PPP frameworks to ensure standardisation and transparency. International financial institutions such as the World Bank and ADB have also supported India in strengthening PPP ecosystems through viability gap funding and technical assistance. Thus, PPPs are not merely instruments of finance but vehicles of governance reform and development. **Variety of PPP Models in Practice** PPP is not a single model but a spectrum of contractual arrangements with varying degrees of private participation. The most widely used model in India has been the Build-Operate-Transfer (BOT) model, particularly in highway development under the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI). Here, private developers finance, construct, operate the project for a fixed concession period, and then transfer it back to the government. The Delhi–Gurugram Expressway and parts of the Golden Quadrilateral were executed under BOT. Another variant is Build-Own-Operate (BOO), where the private player retains ownership indefinitely, as in certain power projects. Build-Own-Operate-Transfer (BOOT) combines features of both and is applied in urban infrastructure projects. The Design-Build-Finance-Operate-Transfer (DBFOT) model has become dominant in recent years, with the government offering viability gap funding to make projects financially viable, as seen in port modernisation under Sagarmala. Operation-Maintenance-Transfer (OMT) is another form where private entities manage and maintain existing infrastructure, such as toll roads, for efficiency. More recent innovations include the Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM), a blend of EPC and BOT, where the government shares a significant portion of project cost while ensuring private participation, widely used in Bharatmala highways. These models illustrate the flexibility of PPP, adapting to sectoral needs and risk profiles. **Illustrations of PPP Success in India** The success of PPP in India can be seen in multiple sectors. In roads, the Mumbai–Pune Expressway pioneered BOT in 2000, demonstrating efficiency and quality. In ports, Mundra Port, developed by the Adani Group, became India's largest commercial port, reflecting the potential of private participation in logistics. The Delhi Metro Airport Express Line, though initially troubled, ultimately stabilised under a restructured PPP model. In healthcare, the Rashtriya Swasthya Bima Yojana (RSBY) and Ayushman Bharat rely on PPP mechanisms with private hospitals delivering services under public financing. Education too has adopted PPP, with states like Rajasthan and Andhra Pradesh partnering private agencies to expand school infrastructure. These illustrations show that PPP is not confined to infrastructure alone but extends to social sectors as well, reflecting its broad relevance in India's development strategy. **The Case of Rajiv Gandhi International Airport, Hyderabad** The Rajiv Gandhi International Airport (RGIA) at Hyderabad exemplifies the PPP model's success in India. Conceived in the early 2000s, RGIA was executed under the

DBFOT model with a concession period of 30 years, extendable by another 30 years. The GMR Group led the private consortium, with equity participation from the Government of India, the Government of Telangana (then Andhra Pradesh), and Malaysia Airports Holdings. The project involved a total investment of over ₹2,500 crore initially and was completed in record time, opening in 2008. What makes RGIA noteworthy is its world-class infrastructure, operational efficiency, and global recognition. The Rajiv Gandhi International Airport (RGIA) was consistently recognised by the Airports Council International (ACI) for its service quality in the 5–15 million passenger category, and even topped the list several times. By 2023–24, the airport handled over 25 million passengers annually and nearly 150,000 tonnes of cargo, making it a regional aviation hub. Its PPP model ensured not only financial viability but also seamless coordination between private efficiency and public oversight.

Socio-Economic Impact of RGIA

RGIA's impact extends beyond aviation into regional development. It created direct employment for over 25,000 people and indirect employment for more than 100,000 in allied services, logistics, and tourism. The airport catalysed the growth of Hyderabad as an IT and pharmaceutical hub by improving global connectivity. The presence of companies like Microsoft, Google, and Novartis in Hyderabad is partly attributed to the connectivity and infrastructure ecosystem provided by RGIA. Economically, the airport contributes significantly to state revenues through taxes and service charges. Socially, the project demonstrated effective rehabilitation and resettlement practices, with affected families provided compensation, employment opportunities, and community facilities. The PPP thus not only delivered a physical asset but also embedded socio-economic benefits in the development trajectory of Hyderabad.

Criticisms and Challenges of PPP and RGIA

Despite its success, the PPP model is not free from criticisms. At RGIA, concerns were raised about land acquisition, with nearly 5,500 acres allocated to the project, sparking debates on fair compensation. User development fees imposed on passengers became contentious, raising questions of affordability and equity. More broadly, PPP projects in India often face delays, cost overruns, and renegotiations due to regulatory uncertainties. The Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) has flagged instances of risk transfer being skewed in favour of private players. PPPs also face challenges of transparency, with contractual details often not accessible to the public. In social sectors, PPP has sometimes led to commercialisation at the cost of equity, as in health insurance schemes where private hospitals cherry-pick profitable cases. These challenges underline the need for better regulatory frameworks and accountability mechanisms to make PPPs more balanced and sustainable.

PPP in the Broader Development Discourse

The PPP model in India reflects the broader discourse on integrating state and market roles in development. Just as MNC-led globalisation has to be balanced with state sovereignty, PPP ensures that private capital operates within a public framework of accountability. The experience of RGIA demonstrates that PPP can deliver world-class infrastructure in developing countries, provided there is a strong regulatory and institutional framework. Quoting J.Y.Lim, "PPP is not a panacea, but it is a vital instrument in achieving our development objectives when designed with care and implemented with transparency." The lesson is that PPP should not be viewed as a replacement for the state but as a partnership where both sides share risks and benefits equitably.

Conclusion	In conclusion, PPP represents a pragmatic approach to India's development challenges, combining the efficiency of the private sector with the legitimacy of public oversight. The variety of models such as BOT, BOO, BOOT, DBFOT, and HAM provides flexibility to adapt to diverse sectors and contexts. Illustrations across roads, ports, health, and education show the transformative potential of PPP. The Rajiv Gandhi International Airport at Hyderabad stands out as a flagship PPP project, delivering not just infrastructure but also economic growth, employment, and global recognition for India's capabilities. Yet, challenges of transparency, equity, and regulatory oversight remain. Moving forward, the task is to strengthen institutional frameworks, ensure fair risk-sharing, and align PPPs with the broader goals of inclusive and sustainable development. In doing so, India can truly make PPPs a cornerstone of its development strategy, blending state priorities with private dynamism for the benefit of society as a whole.
Model Question	Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs) have emerged as a critical tool for infrastructure creation in India. Discuss the major PPP models with suitable examples. Evaluate the effectiveness of the PPP approach with special reference to the Rajiv Gandhi International Airport at Hyderabad.
Value Addition	**Build Operate Transfer (BOT):** Build Operate Transfer is a simple and conventional PPP model. Under this model, a private player is responsible for designing, building, operating and transferring the facility to the public sector after an agreed period of time. Here, the word 'operate' indicates that the private partner will operate the project for the contracted period, and then it will be transferred back to the public sector. The private partner has the responsibility to finance, construct and maintain the project. In return, they are allowed to collect the revenue from the users of the facility. The projects of PPP under the National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) are the major examples of the BOT model. It reduces the responsibility of the Government to maintain the project. The present issue with the BOT model is that most of the private sector infrastructural entities have huge debts and are now unable to get loans or capital to invest in the projects. Thereby, investments have declined in highways. Thus, as an alternative to BOT, the Hybrid Annuity Model was brought in to counter the failure of the BOT model in recent times.
18. Explain the history, governance and politics of the European Union. (APPSC, 2008)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Explain
Approach	• Introduce with the context of the EU's uniqueness as a political-economic union, its post-WWII origins, and its purpose of peace and integration. Briefly mention its present significance. • Trace the journey from ECSC and Treaties of Rome to Maastricht, Lisbon, and subsequent enlargements. Highlight key milestones like the single market, euro, and EU citizenship. • Explain the role of major institutions (Commission, Parliament, Council, CJEU, ECB). Emphasize the balance of supranational and intergovernmental elements. • Discuss law-making (ordinary procedure, QMV, unanimity), budgetary process, and the role of CJEU in ensuring legal uniformity. • Cover political cleavages, party groups, Euroscepticism, populism, Brexit, and how crises (financial, migration, pandemic, Ukraine war) shape integration or retrenchment. • Assess global role of the EU: trade diplomacy, security challenges, India-EU partnership, Russia-Ukraine, China, enlargement, and migration.

	• Critically examine achievements (single market, conflict prevention, regulatory power) and challenges (democratic deficit, divergence, sovereignty concerns). • Conclude by summarizing the EU as an evolving experiment in shared sovereignty, balancing unity and diversity, and draw lessons for global governance.
Introduction	The European Union is one of the most distinctive political and economic entities in the modern world. It is a union of 27 states that has grown out of the devastation of two world wars with the vision of securing peace through integration. Over seven decades it has evolved into a unique system that combines shared sovereignty with national autonomy. Neither a federation nor a loose confederation, the EU today represents the most advanced experiment in regional cooperation. It has created a single market, a monetary union, and institutions that make collective decisions while still respecting the voice of member states. In the contemporary context it stands as both a powerful global actor and a complex polity struggling to balance unity with diversity.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The European Union: History, Governance and Politics** **Historical Evolution: From Coal and Steel to a Single Market and Beyond** The European Union originated in the post-war period when European leaders aimed to prevent future conflicts by promoting economic cooperation. The European Coal and Steel Community established in 1951 marked the first step in pooling resources and controlling the means of war collectively. The Treaties of Rome in 1957 created the European Economic Community and Euratom, extending cooperation into broader economic sectors. Over the following decades integration deepened through key treaties and enlargements. The Single European Act of 1986 sought to complete the internal market by removing trade barriers. The Maastricht Treaty of 1992 formally established the European Union, introduced EU citizenship, and launched monetary union. The Lisbon Treaty of 2007 restructured institutions, strengthened the European Parliament, and enhanced external action. Enlargement waves brought Southern European countries in the 1980s and Eastern European nations in 2004 and 2007, expanding the Union geographically and politically. The introduction of the euro further strengthened integration. These successive treaties and enlargements created a distinctive system that combines supranational authority with intergovernmental negotiation, balancing collective objectives with the preservation of national sovereignty. **Institutional Framework and Governance** The European Union has built a complex institutional framework that reflects its hybrid nature of supra nationalism and inter Governmentalism. The European Commission serves as the executive body and guardian of treaties, responsible for drafting legislation, overseeing implementation, and representing the Union externally. The European Parliament is directly elected and represents EU citizens, sharing legislative and budgetary powers with the Council of the European Union, which is composed of ministers from member states. The European Council, made up of heads of state or government, sets the Union's overall political direction. The Court of Justice of the European Union ensures the uniform interpretation of EU law and has often expanded the scope of integration through its rulings. The European Central Bank manages monetary policy for the eurozone and plays a key role in financial stability. Specialized agencies and advisory bodies support policy implementation, while the European Court of Auditors monitors financial accountability. This institutional architecture balances power and oversight but also raises debates about efficiency, transparency, and democratic legitimacy. **Decision-Making and Policy Processes**

Decision-making in the European Union balances national interests with collective objectives. The ordinary legislative procedure is the primary method, where the European Commission proposes laws and both the Parliament and the Council must approve them. Many Council decisions are taken by qualified majority voting to prevent dominance by larger states, while sensitive areas such as foreign policy, taxation, and treaty amendments still require unanimity.

The EU budget is agreed jointly by the Parliament and the Council and is funded mainly through member state contributions and certain own resources. Implementation relies on collaboration between the Commission and national administrations. The Court of Justice of the European Union has reinforced the primacy of EU law and allowed citizens to invoke EU rules directly in national courts. These mechanisms have enabled significant harmonization in areas such as competition, trade, environment, and consumer protection, though the system's complexity can slow reforms and reveal divisions among member states.

Politics in the European Union

Politics in the European Union operates at three interconnected levels. At the transnational level, political parties form groups in the European Parliament to influence legislation. At the intergovernmental level, national leaders negotiate within the Council and European Council. At the domestic level, national parliaments and public opinion shape governments' positions.

For decades centrist forces such as Christian Democrats, Social Democrats, and Liberals dominated EU institutions and promoted deeper integration. In recent years however the Union has witnessed growing politicization. Eurosceptic and populist parties have gained ground by challenging Brussels on issues such as migration, fiscal solidarity, and national sovereignty. Debates have also intensified over rule of law enforcement, climate action, and digital regulation.

The Brexit referendum of 2016 exposed the fragility of public support and forced the Union to recalibrate its economic and foreign policies. Successive crises have further shaped EU politics. The financial crisis triggered disputes on austerity and solidarity, the migration crisis strained responsibility sharing, the pandemic spurred collective recovery measures, and Russia's invasion of Ukraine pushed energy diversification and greater security cooperation. Crises thus remain pivotal in driving either deeper integration or renewed national control.

External Relations and Strategic Challenges

In external affairs, the European Union combines normative objectives with pragmatic interests. It promotes democracy, rule of law, and human rights while acting as one of the world's largest trading blocs. The partnership with India exemplifies this approach through ongoing free trade agreement negotiations and cooperation on climate action, digital technology, and security.

The EU faces significant strategic challenges. The rise of China, Russia's assertiveness, and evolving relations with the United States require a more active global role. Enlargement remains complex as Western Balkan countries seek membership but political consensus within the Union is uneven. Migration management continues to test solidarity among members, and relations with neighboring regions remain sensitive. These challenges underscore the difficulty of pursuing coherent external policies when national priorities diverge and the Union must constantly balance collective action with the interests of individual member states.

Strengths, Weaknesses and Democratic Legitimacy

	The EU's strengths are significant. It has built the world's largest single market encompassing over 450 million citizens. It wields regulatory influence that extends far beyond its borders often called the Brussels effect. It has succeeded in preventing major conflicts among its members through deep interdependence. It also pools resources to address transnational issues such as climate change and digital transformation. At the same time weaknesses persist. The complexity of decision making and the perception of a democratic deficit undermine public confidence. Economic divergence between north and south or east and west fuels tensions. Sovereignty remains a contested theme particularly in areas closely tied to national identity. Reforms to address legitimacy include strengthening the European Parliament, promoting citizen initiatives, and involving national parliaments more actively. Despite these efforts skepticism and divergent interests continue to shape the trajectory of the Union.
Conclusion	The European Union stands as a remarkable and continuing experiment in shared sovereignty, defying simple classification as either a federation or a loose international organization. Its evolution through successive treaties has created a layered and complex institutional framework that balances integration with the preservation of national autonomy. This unique architecture has allowed the EU to adapt to changing global and regional challenges while maintaining cohesion among diverse member states. Today, debates within the Union focus on reconciling collective action in crucial areas such as climate change, digital transformation, energy security and defense with the need to respect democratic legitimacy at the national level. For scholars, leaders and citizens, the EU provides enduring lessons on multilevel governance, integration politics and the scope of cooperation in an interdependent world.
Model Question	"BRICS in the 21st Century: Examine the Current Challenges Facing the Bloc and Evaluate its Future Prospects as a Platform for Emerging Economies in Global Governance and Geopolitics."
Value Addition	**Schengen Area:** • It started in 1985 as an intergovernmental project between five EU countries – France, Germany, Belgium, the Netherlands and Luxembourg – and has gradually expanded to become the largest free travel area in the world. • Today, the Schengen area covers over 4 million square kilometres with a population of over 450 million people, and includes 29 countries. ✓ 25 of the 27 EU member states ✓ all members of the European Free Trade Association (Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland) • Every day around 3.5 million people cross internal borders for work or study or to visit families and friends, and almost 1.7 million people reside in one Schengen country while working in another. • Europeans make an estimated 1.25 billion journeys within the Schengen area every year, which also greatly benefits the tourism and cultural sector.
19. Discuss the importance of Indo-US nuclear agreement. Analyse the causes for its opposition, and state whether Hyde Act curtails India's independence in foreign policy. (APPSC, 2008)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Introduce with a brief background of India's nuclear isolation post-1974 and the 2008 Indo–US Nuclear Agreement as a landmark that ended this phase. • Explain how the deal enhanced India's energy security, legitimized its nuclear status outside the NPT, and strengthened strategic and technological partnerships with the U.S.

	• Highlight the broader outcomes—India's integration into global export-control regimes, access to advanced technologies, and deepening Indo–U.S. strategic ties. • Examine the domestic and international criticisms—concerns over sovereignty, strategic autonomy, non-proliferation principles, liability and safety, and lack of transparency. • Discuss the provisions of the Hyde Act, differentiate between its legal non-binding nature and practical constraints. Assess whether it curtails India's foreign policy independence or merely introduces pragmatic interdependence. • Conclude with a reasoned assessment that while the deal imposed some practical limitations, it largely strengthened India's global standing, energy security, and strategic autonomy within a framework of responsible interdependence.
Introduction	The Indo–U.S. Civil Nuclear Agreement of 2008, often referred to as the 123 Agreement, marked a turning point in India's foreign policy and energy security strategy. For decades since India's nuclear test in 1974, the country had been kept outside the global nuclear order, denied access to nuclear fuel and technology under the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) and subjected to sanctions after Pokhran-II in 1998. By enabling civil nuclear cooperation between India and the U.S., and through a special waiver from the NSG, the agreement not only ended India's nuclear isolation but also signaled its entry into the global nuclear mainstream. As the National Knowledge Commission once observed, *"The Indo–U.S. civil nuclear deal is not just about energy; it is about recognition of India as a responsible state with advanced nuclear technology."* This essay will discuss the importance of the deal, analyze the causes of opposition, and critically examine whether the Hyde Act curtailed India's independence in foreign policy.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Importance of the Indo–US Nuclear Agreement** **Energy Security and Development Needs:** India's rapidly expanding economy has placed immense pressure on its energy infrastructure, necessitating diversification into cleaner and more sustainable sources. The Indo–US Nuclear Agreement addressed this critical challenge by providing India with access to uranium fuel and advanced nuclear technology, resources essential for scaling up nuclear power generation. At the time, nuclear energy contributed barely 3% to India's total energy mix. Through this agreement, India envisioned a significant enhancement in its nuclear capacity to meet long-term developmental and environmental goals. The Planning Commission's Integrated Energy Policy (2006) underscored the importance of a "quantum leap in nuclear capacity" to ensure energy security and sustainable growth. By facilitating international cooperation and lifting barriers to nuclear commerce, the deal directly supported India's vision of achieving energy independence and clean power expansion. **End of Nuclear Apartheid:** For decades, India faced isolation from global nuclear trade due to its non-signatory status to the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT). The Indo–US Nuclear Deal marked a historic shift, effectively ending this "nuclear apartheid." Through the IAEA safeguards agreement and the NSG waiver, India was recognized as a responsible nuclear power despite being outside the NPT framework. As Prime Minister Manmohan Singh stated in Parliament (2008): *"This agreement is an instrument to end India's decades-long isolation from nuclear commerce."* The acknowledgment of India's impeccable non-proliferation record not only restored its global nuclear legitimacy but also reinforced its image as a responsible democratic power with advanced technological capabilities. **Strategic and Diplomatic Gains:**

The nuclear deal redefined Indo–US relations, transforming the two nations from "estranged democracies" into genuine strategic partners. It became a cornerstone for India's integration into key global export-control regimes such as the Missile Technology Control Regime (MTCR), Wassenaar Arrangement, and Australia Group. This diplomatic breakthrough also bolstered India's aspirations for inclusion in the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG).

The K. Subrahmanyam Committee on National Security (2002) had emphasized that "strategic autonomy must be reinforced by economic and technological strength." The nuclear deal exemplified this principle, strengthening India's international standing while enhancing its strategic leverage in global politics.

Technological and Economic Benefits

Beyond diplomacy, the agreement unlocked avenues for civilian nuclear trade and collaboration in advanced technologies previously denied to India due to sanctions. Access to high-end reactor designs, dual-use technologies, and global research partnerships spurred innovation in science and engineering. The resulting growth potential extended beyond the energy sector—encouraging foreign investment, technological modernization, and job creation in allied industries.

In this sense, the deal acted as a technological multiplier, facilitating India's transition toward a knowledge-based economy and expanding its research ecosystem in energy, materials, and nuclear safety.

Causes of Opposition

Sovereignty and Strategic Autonomy Concerns

A major concern among critics was that the agreement compromised India's sovereign decision-making, particularly concerning future nuclear testing. The Left parties and sections of the opposition argued that U.S. conditionalities might restrict India's strategic flexibility. The Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs (2007) warned that "the separation of civilian and military facilities could indirectly cap India's strategic programme." Such apprehensions stemmed from fears that the deal subtly limited India's nuclear deterrent and strategic autonomy.

Non-Proliferation Criticisms

International critics viewed the agreement as undermining the NPT regime, claiming that granting India an exceptional waiver weakened global non-proliferation norms. Countries like Austria and Ireland initially resisted the waiver, fearing it might encourage other non-NPT states to seek similar treatment. Despite these objections, India's record of responsible nuclear conduct and the U.S.'s strategic interest in balancing global power dynamics helped overcome resistance.

Domestic Political Opposition

Domestically, the deal triggered intense political debate. The Communist parties withdrew support from the UPA-I government, accusing it of compromising India's non-aligned stance and aligning too closely with the United States. The controversy culminated in the 2008 trust vote in Parliament, one of the most dramatic episodes in contemporary Indian politics. This episode reflected the deep ideological divisions between proponents of strategic engagement and defenders of traditional non-alignment.

Safety, Liability, and Transparency Concerns

The implementation of the Indo–US Nuclear Deal faced significant hurdles related to safety, liability, and transparency. The Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Act (2010), which introduced supplier liability clauses, became a major obstacle for foreign companies such as Westinghouse and Areva, as it made them financially accountable

	in the event of a nuclear accident. While intended to safeguard public interests, this provision discouraged private and international investment in India's nuclear sector. At the same time, critics pointed to persistent uncertainties surrounding reactor safety, accident liability, and the escalating costs of imported nuclear technologies. These issues collectively slowed down project execution and hindered the anticipated expansion of nuclear power generation in the country. Adding to these challenges was a lack of transparency in the negotiation and communication process. Opponents argued that key details of the Hyde Act and the 123 Agreement were not adequately shared with Parliament or the public, raising suspicions that India may have made excessive concessions. The perceived secrecy surrounding the deal eroded trust in the government's approach and provided ammunition to political critics, who questioned whether the agreement truly served India's long-term strategic and economic interests. **The Hyde Act and India's Independence in Foreign Policy** The Henry J. Hyde Act of 2006 was a U.S. domestic law outlining conditions for civilian nuclear cooperation with India. It required periodic presidential certification to the U.S. Congress and allowed suspension of cooperation if India conducted nuclear tests. Though intended for internal U.S. governance, these provisions raised apprehensions in India about possible external influence on its sovereign nuclear decisions. Critics feared that such legislative oversight could indirectly limit India's strategic freedom. Legally, India is bound only by the bilateral 123 Agreement and IAEA safeguards—not by the Hyde Act. The Ministry of External Affairs clarified in 2006 that the Act "does not bind India." However, India's civilian nuclear sector remains dependent on imported uranium, reactors, and technology, meaning disruptions in U.S. cooperation could affect ongoing and future projects. While legal sovereignty is intact, operational dependence creates practical constraints, linking strategic choices to global interdependence. The Act reignited debates on strategic autonomy. Some analysts argued it could deter India from future nuclear testing, while others viewed interdependence as a defining feature of modern diplomacy. As K. Subrahmanyam observed, "Strategic autonomy means freedom of action within interdependence." Reflecting this view, Anil Kakodkar asserted that despite risks, the agreement ensured long-term fuel security without compromising India's nuclear deterrence.
Conclusion	The Indo–U.S. nuclear deal was more than an energy agreement; it was a strategic breakthrough that reshaped India's global standing. By ending decades of "nuclear apartheid," it facilitated energy security, advanced technology access, and elevated India's diplomatic stature. Opposition to the deal was rooted in concerns of sovereignty, liability, and transparency, reflecting India's robust democratic debate. As for the Hyde Act, it does not legally curtail India's foreign policy independence, but it does create practical constraints by attaching costs to certain strategic choices. In the words of former NSA Shivshankar Menon: *"The deal did not diminish India's freedom of action. It expanded our options."* Ultimately, the agreement exemplifies the art of balancing sovereignty with global integration — a lesson that continues to define India's foreign policy in the 21st century.
Model Question	"Critically examine India's quest for membership in the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG). Discuss how India's non-signatory status to the NPT affects its bid, and analyze the strategic, diplomatic, and economic implications of NSG membership for India's nuclear and foreign policy."
Value Addition	**INDIA'S NUCLEAR TRIAD**

	• **Land Vector:** Prithvi-II (350 km), Agni-1 (700 km), Agni-2 (2,000 km), Agni-3 (3,000 km) & Agni-5 (over 5,000 km) missiles inducted by the Strategic Forces Command • **Air Vector:** Sukhoi-30MKI, Mirage-2000, Jaguar & Rafale fighters can deliver nuclear gravity bombs • **Sea Vector:** Only 1 nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarine (SSBN), the 6,000-tonne **INS Arihant**, fully operational ✓ Armed with 750-km range K-15 nuclear missiles ✓ 6,000-tonne INS Arighat undergoing final trials; will be commissioned this year ✓ Will be followed by two 7,000-tonne SSBNs (called S-4 & S-4*), being built at Vizag ✓ Over 13,000-tonne S-5 class SSBNs to be built later ✓ K-4 missiles (3,500-km range) have completed developmental trials ✓ Development of K-5 (5,000 km) and K-6 (6,000 km) SLBMs in progress
20. Write an essay on the recent achievement of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) which has launched 10 satellites by PSLV-C9. (APPSC, 2008)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Current Affairs
Write	Write
Approach	• Introduce by briefly describing the PSLV-C9 launch event (date, payloads, and mission type) and highlight its historical and technological importance within ISRO's journey. • Explain the vehicle configuration (PSLV-CA), stages, payload mass, orbit type, and sequence of satellite deployments, establishing the technical foundation of the essay. • Discuss Cartosat-2A, IMS-1, and international nanosatellites, underlining India's mix of indigenous development and international cooperation. • Analyse the mission's scientific, strategic, and commercial implications, showing how it strengthened India's Earth observation, global launch credibility, and policy confidence. • Connect the technological lessons from PSLV-C9 to later missions like PSLV-C37 (104 satellites), Chandrayaan-3, Aditya-L1, XPoSat, and upcoming Gaganyaan, showing continuity and evolution. • Critically assess technical challenges (orbital management, payload constraints) and the need for heavy-lift vehicles like GSLV Mk-III, along with balancing commercial and societal goals. • Conclude by emphasizing PSLV-C9's role as a foundation for India's space leadership, highlighting ISRO's vision of blending innovation, inclusivity, and peaceful space exploration
Introduction	On 28 April 2008, the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) achieved a significant milestone by launching ten satellites in a single mission through the Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV-C9) from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre, Sriharikota. The launch placed all satellites into a sun-synchronous polar orbit at an altitude of around 635 kilometers, demonstrating India's growing prowess in precision launch operations. This mission was not only a technological feat but also a strategic statement, symbolizing India's readiness to participate in the global space economy and to contribute to peaceful space exploration. The PSLV-C9 launch set the foundation for ISRO's later achievements, such as Chandrayaan-3 (2023), Aditya-L1 (2023), and the forthcoming Gaganyaan human spaceflight mission, all of which rest upon ISRO's accumulated expertise in reliable launch operations and satellite integration.

Body & Infographic Representation	**ISRO's PSLV-C9: A Landmark in India's Multi-Satellite Launch Capability** **Technical Overview of the Mission** PSLV-C9 was launched in the Core-Alone configuration (PSLV-CA), without strap-on boosters. This four-stage vehicle, using alternating solid and liquid propulsion systems, carried a payload of approximately 824 kilograms. The mission lasted around 19 minutes, deploying satellites sequentially into their precise orbits. The primary payload, Cartosat-2A, an advanced remote sensing satellite weighing about 690 kilograms, was accompanied by IMS-1 (Indian Mini Satellite-1) weighing 83 kilograms. In addition, eight foreign nanosatellites from Canada, Denmark, Germany, Japan, and the Netherlands, were launched under commercial contracts facilitated by Antrix Corporation, ISRO's commercial arm. The mission showcased ISRO's high-precision separation mechanisms, ensuring safe deployment of all payloads in their designated orbits, without collision or orbital deviation, a benchmark in orbital mechanics and systems engineering. **The Payloads — India's Scientific Vision and Global Cooperation** The Cartosat-2A was a high-resolution earth observation satellite equipped with a panchromatic camera capable of capturing sub-meter resolution images. It provided invaluable data for urban planning, infrastructure development, land use mapping, and border surveillance. Cartosat-2A enhanced India's indigenous capability in spatial data acquisition, a resource crucial for governance, agriculture, and defence applications. The IMS-1 (Indian Mini Satellite), developed by ISRO's Space Applications Centre, served as a technology demonstrator for miniaturized satellite components and advanced imaging payloads. It paved the way for India's later series of small-satellite missions, including the Microsat and INS (Indian Nanosatellite) programs, aligning with global trends toward miniaturized, cost-effective platforms. The eight international nanosatellites—including CanX-2 and CanX-6 (Canada), AAUSAT-II (Denmark), CUTE-1.7 (Japan), Delfi-C3 (Netherlands), and COMPASS-1, RUBIN-8 (Germany), reflected ISRO's growing stature as a trusted global launch partner. These academic and research payloads were part of collaborative experiments in communications, space environment study, and student research. Their inclusion demonstrated ISRO's commitment to space diplomacy, using technology as a bridge for international cooperation and education. **Strategic and Technological Significance** The PSLV-C9 mission had multidimensional significance. Technically, it validated ISRO's ability to deploy multiple satellites from a single rocket with precise control, reinforcing the PSLV's reputation as a "workhorse launcher." The mission underscored India's mastery in systems integration and orbit optimization, skills essential for present missions such as PSLV-C58/XPoSat (2024), dedicated to studying X-ray polarization, and PSLV-C57/Aditya-L1, India's first mission to study the Sun. Commercially, the mission was a turning point. By launching foreign nanosatellites, ISRO proved its cost-effective and reliable access to space, attracting global customers. This commercial potential has since been institutionalized through NewSpace India Limited (NSIL), which now markets ISRO's launch services to the world. India's continued success with PSLV-C56 (2023) and PSLV-C58 (2024) reflects how the C9 mission laid the foundation for sustained international engagement. Strategically, the deployment of Cartosat-2A enhanced India's earth observation capabilities vital for national security, border monitoring, and natural resource management. The data from such satellites now feed into the Bhuvan geoportal, aiding developmental planning and disaster response. The mission also strengthened ISRO's

	confidence for ambitious deep-space programs, forming the technological bedrock for Chandrayaan and Mangalyaan (Mars Orbiter Mission) that followed. **Linking the Past to Present: Evolution of PSLV** The PSLV-C9 mission marked a transitional phase from demonstration to diversification. It showcased ISRO's operational maturity in multi-satellite launches, a capability later expanded in the record-setting PSLV-C37 (2017) mission, which placed 104 satellites in orbit, setting a world record. These missions established ISRO as a pioneer in rideshare launch services, supporting global constellations and small-satellite startups. Today, PSLV continues to serve as India's backbone launcher, with its versatility extended to navigation (NavIC), climate monitoring (Oceansat), and scientific research (XPoSat). In the near future, PSLV will complement newer vehicles like the Small Satellite Launch Vehicle (SSLV), developed to provide rapid, on-demand access to orbit for small payloads, expanding India's share in the global space economy. **Policy, Industrial, and Educational Impact** The success of PSLV-C9 reverberated beyond technology. It strengthened policy confidence in India's capability to handle complex missions, encouraging a more ambitious space roadmap. This policy momentum has now culminated in ISRO's Vision 2047, which includes interplanetary exploration missions such as Shukrayaan-1 (Venus mission), Mangalyaan-2, and Gaganyaan, India's first human spaceflight programme. The mission also stimulated industry participation in the space ecosystem. With the opening of the sector to private players under the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorization Centre (IN-SPACe), startups and MSMEs now contribute to manufacturing, subsystem design, and small-satellite launches. The roots of this public-private synergy can be traced back to the success of PSLV missions like C9, which demonstrated India's ability to deliver reliable space services. Educationally, PSLV-C9 inspired collaboration between ISRO and academic institutions, leading to student satellite programs such as Jugnu (IIT Kanpur), SRMSat (SRM University), and Anusat (Anna University). These initiatives democratized access to space technology and cultivated a generation of young space scientists contributing to ISRO's modern missions. **Challenges and Limitations** Furthermore, multi-satellite launches like PSLV-C9 demand meticulous synchronization of orbital parameters, propulsion sequencing, and real-time telemetry, increasing mission complexity. Each additional payload multiplies operational risks, necessitating precise trajectory modelling and post-deployment tracking to prevent orbital congestion. The limitations of payload capacity also highlighted India's dependence on foreign launchers for heavier communication satellites until GSLV Mk-III became operational. While ISRO's growing commercial engagements through NSIL and IN-SPACe have unlocked new revenue streams, maintaining equilibrium between profit-driven launches and socially oriented missions, such as agriculture monitoring, disaster management, and education connectivity, remains vital to preserve ISRO's developmental ethos.
Conclusion	The PSLV-C9 mission remains a cornerstone in India's space odyssey. It symbolized a technological leap, a commercial breakthrough, and a diplomatic gesture, all within a single launch. It proved ISRO's ability to deliver complex missions with precision, reliability, and cost-effectiveness, qualities that continue to define India's space programme today. The technological insights and operational experience gained from PSLV-C9 have directly contributed to the success of Aditya-L1, Chandrayaan-3, and the

	upcoming Gaganyaan mission, all reflecting India's march toward self-reliance and global leadership in space science. In essence, PSLV-C9 was not just a launch, it was a Launchpad for India's future in space exploration. It exemplified how a developing nation, through vision, innovation, and perseverance, could achieve world-class excellence, inspiring the next generation of missions that seek not only to explore outer space but also to transform life on Earth.
Model Question	Analyse how Gaganyaan aligns with India's long-term space vision, particularly in the context of future missions such as Bharatiya Antariksha Station, Shukrayaan-1, and deep space exploration.
Value Addition	**Bharatiya Antariksha Station (BAS)**: • The Indian government has announced plans to set up a fully functional Bharatiya Antariksha Station (BAS) by 2035 and send Indian astronauts to the Moon by 2040, in line with the vision of building a developed India (Viksit Bharat) by 2047. • The Bharatiya Antariksha Station (BAS) will be India's own space station, similar to the International Space Station (ISS). It will orbit the Earth at an altitude of around 400 to 450 kilometres and serve as a hub for scientific experiments and research in space. • The station will be built in multiple phases and consist of five main modules. The first module (Base Module) is planned to be launched by 2028, and the entire station is expected to become fully operational by 2035.
(ii) Socio – Economic Issues	
21. Gig Economy in India: A Catalyst for Employment or a Challenge to Workers' Rights? (APPSC, 2025)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Approach	• Start with the definition of the Gig economy. • Mention Opportunities like employment for youth, women, migrants, flexibility, boost to digital India, and start-ups. • Mention Challenges like no job security, absence of social security, wage uncertainty, and algorithmic exploitation. • State Legal response, which recognizes gig and platform workers; states working on welfare boards. • Mention Global parallels. • Mention how Balance is required. • Conclude by stating that the Gig economy is a double-edged sword and India must harness its potential while protecting worker dignity.
Introduction	The changing nature of work in the twenty-first century has given rise to what is popularly known as the gig economy, a system where short-term contracts, freelance work, and digital platforms dominate labour relations instead of traditional long-term employment. Enabled by the rapid growth of internet penetration, smartphones, and digital payment systems, India has emerged as one of the fastest-growing gig economies in the world. Companies like Ola, Uber, Swiggy, Zomato, and Urban Company have transformed urban employment patterns by creating new opportunities for flexible work, especially for youth, migrants, and women. Yet, this new world of work has triggered debates on whether the gig economy is truly empowering or whether it erodes hard-won labour rights. As NITI Aayog noted in its 2022 report, "India's Booming Gig and Platform Economy," the gig workforce is expected to expand from 7.7 million in 2020 to 23.5 million by 2030, making it a crucial pillar of employment. The question is whether this expansion will become a catalyst for inclusive job creation or a driver of precarious livelihoods.

Body & Infographic Representation	**Gig Economy as a Driver of Employment** The gig economy has undoubtedly created vast employment opportunities, particularly in urban India. For a country with nearly one million people entering the labour force every month, traditional industries and the formal sector have been unable to absorb this surplus workforce. Digital platforms have provided a quick alternative. Swiggy and Zomato together employ over 500,000 delivery workers, while Ola and Uber are estimated to engage around 2 million driver-partners. This not only offers livelihoods to the underemployed but also provides flexibility, allowing workers to balance personal commitments with earning opportunities. Women in semi-urban areas have also benefited from gig platforms like UrbanClap (now Urban Company), which connect beauticians, domestic workers, and service providers with urban households. Moreover, the gig economy contributes significantly to the national economy. With India aiming to become a $5 trillion economy, this sector could act as a crucial accelerator. The International Labour Organization (ILO) also acknowledges that digital labour platforms provide new forms of inclusion for marginalized groups such as migrants and differently-abled persons. Thus, the gig economy offers an opportunity to bridge gaps in employment where traditional industries have failed. **Challenges to Workers' Rights in the Gig Economy** However, beneath the promise of employment lies a darker reality of exploitation, precarity, and the absence of social security. Gig workers, often referred to as "partners" or "independent contractors" by companies, fall outside the traditional definitions of employees under Indian labour law. This legal ambiguity strips them of entitlements such as minimum wages, paid leave, health insurance, pension, and collective bargaining rights. For instance, during the COVID-19 lockdown, millions of delivery workers and ride-hailing drivers faced income collapse with little safety net, exposing the vulnerability of gig-based livelihoods. While customers relied on gig workers for essential deliveries, many of these workers lacked health insurance or protective gear. The situation highlighted what Guy Standing terms as the rise of the "precariat", a class of workers trapped in unstable jobs without protections. Furthermore, algorithmic management, where digital apps monitor and control workers through ratings and automated decisions, creates new forms of digital exploitation. Workers often face penalties, sudden deactivations, or pay reductions without due process, undermining their dignity and bargaining power. **Legal and Policy Responses in India** Recognizing these challenges, the Indian state has begun to take steps to regulate the gig economy. The Code on Social Security, 2020, for the first time legally recognized "gig workers" and "platform workers" as distinct categories eligible for certain welfare benefits. This opens the door for creating social security funds financed jointly by the government, platforms, and possibly workers themselves. Some states have taken proactive measures. Rajasthan passed a landmark Gig Workers' Welfare Act in 2023, mandating registration of gig workers and establishing a welfare board to ensure access to social security schemes. Karnataka and Tamil Nadu are also exploring similar frameworks. International experiences also provide useful lessons. The European Union is drafting directives to ensure platform workers enjoy fair wages and algorithmic transparency. India can learn from this model but must also design context-specific regulations that balance worker welfare with innovation. **Economic and Social Implications of an Expanding Gig Economy**

	The expansion of the gig economy has wider socio-economic implications. On the positive side, it promotes entrepreneurship and reduces entry barriers to work, as anyone with basic skills and a smartphone can join. It also fosters consumer convenience, creating a thriving urban service economy. Yet, unchecked expansion without safeguards can deepen inequality. A study by the International Institute for Population Sciences revealed that a significant share of gig workers belong to economically weaker sections, making them highly vulnerable to wage suppression and a lack of protection. Moreover, the gig economy risks creating a dual labour market, one where formal sector workers enjoy social protections and another where gig workers are trapped in informality. This duality undermines the spirit of India's constitutional vision of social justice. It also raises gender concerns: while women find flexible entry into the workforce through gig platforms, they often face unsafe working conditions, wage discrimination, and a lack of maternity benefits. **Balancing Flexibility with Security** The central policy challenge is how to preserve the flexibility and entrepreneurial spirit of the gig economy while ensuring fairness and security for workers. A multi-pronged approach is needed. First, the state must enforce minimum wage guarantees for gig workers, irrespective of their classification. Second, social security mechanisms such as health insurance, accident coverage, and retirement savings should be made portable, allowing workers to carry them across platforms. Third, greater transparency in algorithmic management is necessary to prevent arbitrary decisions. The Supreme Court of India has, in several cases, emphasized the importance of dignity in labour, which must extend to the digital workplace as well. Finally, strengthening trade unions and worker collectives in the gig economy is critical. Organizations like the Indian Federation of App-based Transport Workers (IFAT) have already mobilized for fairer policies, showing that collective bargaining remains relevant even in digital labour markets.
Conclusion	The gig economy in India is both an opportunity and a challenge. On the one hand, it has emerged as a catalyst for employment generation, providing millions with livelihoods in an economy struggling to create jobs. On the other hand, it threatens to undermine workers' rights, perpetuate informality, and create a precarious labour force vulnerable to exploitation. The path forward lies in striking a balance between innovation and protection, ensuring that technological progress does not come at the cost of human dignity. As Nobel laureate Amartya Sen reminds us, "Development is freedom." True development through the gig economy will occur only when workers are free from insecurity and exploitation, empowered with both economic opportunities and social protections. India's challenge, therefore, is to shape its gig economy into a model of inclusive growth where flexibility coexists with fairness, and digital innovation strengthens, rather than weakens, the foundations of labour rights.
Model Question	Assess whether the rise of the gig economy in India promotes job creation or undermines the social security and rights of workers.
Value Addition	The Code on Social Security, 2020 is an Indian law enacted to consolidate and amend existing laws related to social security, aiming to extend benefits to all workers, including those in the organized, unorganized, gig, and platform sectors. It replaces nine previous labour laws and introduces new provisions for social security benefits like life insurance, disability cover, health, maternity, and old age protection for a broader range of workers, including women, home-based workers, and migrant workers.

22. Is economic development a panacea for overcoming social inequality? Comment. (TGPSC, 2024)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Comment
Approach	• Introduce with real-life anecdote highlighting the contrast between growth beneficiaries and excluded groups. • Discuss the promise of economic development - GDP growth, poverty reduction, infrastructure, and rising consumption. • Highlight why growth alone cannot reduce inequality- return asymmetry, urban–rural and sectoral disparities, social exclusion, and intergenerational effects. • Present government initiatives aimed at inclusive growth like MGNREGA, PMJDY, Ayushman Bharat, social infrastructure schemes, and fiscal measures. • Show real-world evidence - include data on unemployment, women's participation in the workforce, SDG India Index scores, and results from government welfare programs. • Conclusion by linking growth to SDGs, inclusivity, equitable policies, and India's 2047 development vision.
Introduction	When Meena, a daily-wage labourers in rural Uttar Pradesh, heard about a new textile factory opening nearby, she imagined a stable income and schooling opportunities for her children. Yet, the bulk of factory jobs went to migrant male workers from outside, leaving her family still dependent on uncertain agricultural wages. In contrast, Ravi, a young engineer from Pune, secured a lucrative IT job soon after graduation, quickly purchasing his own apartment and achieving upward mobility. These contrasting stories reflect the paradox of India's growth story: while economic development creates remarkable opportunities for some, many remain trapped in cycles of exclusion and vulnerability. The question, therefore, is whether economic growth by itself can overcome entrenched social inequalities or whether deliberate policies and redistributive measures are indispensable.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Is economic development a panacea for overcoming social inequality?** **Growth and its promise:** India's economic journey since liberalization has been remarkable. Sustained GDP growth has elevated the country into the ranks of the world's largest economies, with a GDP of nearly $4 trillion in 2024, making it the fifth-largest economy globally (IMF). The World Bank notes that extreme poverty in India fell from 22.5% in 2011–12 to below 10% by 2019, and despite pandemic setbacks, recovery has been strong. The Economic Survey 2024–25 highlighted India's resilience, estimating real GDP growth at 6.4% in FY 2024–25 and projecting growth in the range of 6.3–6.8% for FY 2025–26, despite global inflationary and geopolitical shocks. Millions have benefited from new employment opportunities in services, manufacturing, and digital sectors. Expansions in physical infrastructure, over 1.5 lakh km of highways built since 2014 and the world's fastest-growing digital economy with over 12 billion monthly UPI transactions in 2023, have spurred connectivity and commerce. Rising consumption levels are evident in the swelling middle class, which is projected to reach 800 million by 2030. These aggregate gains provide the state with greater revenues and fiscal space, evident from a threefold rise in tax collections since 2014, which in turn finances welfare schemes like PM-KISAN, Ayushman Bharat, and PM Awas Yojana. From an absolute poverty-reduction perspective, economic development has undeniably played a transformative role in uplifting living standards and positioning India on a trajectory toward its ambitious "Viksit Bharat 2047" goal. **The inequality paradox:**

Despite this progress, growth has not translated evenly across all sections of society. Reports from the World Inequality Lab and Oxfam repeatedly highlight that the top 1% of Indians continue to capture a disproportionate share of national wealth and income, with inequality widening in the post-liberalization period. While urban elites benefit from capital-intensive growth sectors such as IT, finance, and real estate, rural workers remain confined largely to low-paying informal jobs.

Regional disparities are stark, with states like Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, and Gujarat racing ahead while Bihar, Odisha, and parts of the North-East lag behind. Social hierarchies rooted in caste and gender further exacerbate this divide. Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes continue to face barriers to quality education, credit, and formal employment, while India's female labor-force participation remains among the lowest in the world. The persistence of these structural inequalities underscores that economic growth alone is insufficient to erase deep-rooted social disadvantages.

Why growth alone cannot equalize:

The inability of growth to automatically translate into equality is rooted in several structural dynamics. Economic gains tend to flow disproportionately to those with capital and skills, meaning that wealthy households can expand assets faster than poorer ones. This return asymmetry has been visible in India's expanding wealth concentration.

Further, growth has been concentrated in urban, skill-intensive sectors, leaving vast rural areas and low-skilled workers relatively excluded. Social discrimination compounds these trends: caste-based exclusion, gender barriers, and unequal access to land and education prevent entire groups from fully participating in the growth process. As a result, inequalities often persist across generations, despite overall national progress.

Government efforts to make growth inclusive:

Recognizing these challenges, successive Indian governments have sought to pair growth with redistributive policies and social protection. Flagship initiatives such as the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) have provided rural households with income security and resilience against shocks. Financial inclusion schemes under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana, combined with Aadhaar-enabled Direct Benefit Transfers, have expanded access to banking and reduced leakages in welfare delivery. Health inequalities are being addressed through Ayushman Bharat (PM-JAY), which aims to provide insurance coverage for millions of poor households. Similarly, social infrastructure programmes like the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana for housing, Ujjwala for clean cooking fuel, and Swachh Bharat for sanitation have significantly improved non-income aspects of well-being. These programmes demonstrate that when growth is channeled through deliberate policy frameworks, it can produce more equitable outcomes.

Evidence from practice:

Empirical findings show both the promise and the limitations of these efforts. Evaluations of MGNREGA suggest that the scheme not only reduced rural poverty but also enhanced women's labour participation in some states — for instance, women accounted for about 45% of total work days in Uttar Pradesh in FY 2025-26. The Jan Dhan Yojana has led to a remarkable expansion of financial inclusion, with over 50 crore bank accounts opened by 2023, more than half belonging to women, though translating access into productive credit remains a challenge. Ayushman Bharat has increased insurance coverage, with over 36 crore Ayushman cards issued and 6.8 crore hospital admissions by early 2025, but without simultaneous improvements in public healthcare

	capacity, financial protection remains incomplete. Meanwhile, the SDG India Index 2023-24 shows India's score improving to 71, yet states like Bihar (57) and Jharkhand (62) continue to struggle on health, education, and gender-equality indicators. These mixed outcomes highlight that inclusive growth requires both robust programmes and strong governance capacity. **Towards inclusive and equitable development:** For economic development to truly act as a remedy for inequality, India must prioritize structural reforms and sustained investment in human capital. Progressive fiscal policies can ensure that resources generated by growth are redistributed through education, healthcare, and social protection. Expanding quality public services is essential for breaking intergenerational cycles of disadvantage. Equally, job-centered growth through support for labor-intensive sectors and MSMEs can ensure that employment creation matches the needs of India's large workforce. Balanced regional development through targeted infrastructure investment is also necessary to reduce spatial inequality. Finally, strong enforcement of anti-discrimination laws, continued affirmative action, and programs specifically designed for women, SC/STs, and other marginalized groups are critical to dismantling entrenched hierarchies.
Conclusion	Economic development is a prerequisite for social transformation, generating the fiscal and material resources that allow governments and households to improve living standards. Yet, growth alone cannot be a panacea for inequality. Without conscious redistributive policies and social reforms, development risks creating islands of prosperity amid oceans of deprivation. India's experience over the last three decades reflects this paradox: impressive poverty reduction and rising global economic stature alongside growing wealth concentration and persistent social exclusions. The challenge is to align development with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly SDG 1 (No Poverty), SDG 5 (Gender Equality), SDG 8 (Decent Work), and SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities). NITI Aayog's SDG India Index shows progress is uneven across states and social groups. India's ambitious vision of becoming a developed nation by 2047 (Amrit Kaal) stresses the need for inclusive growth that expands access to education, healthcare, financial systems, and decent work while protecting the environment (SDG 13). Bridging rural–urban divides and dismantling barriers rooted in caste, gender, and region is essential. Only by embedding inclusivity into its development strategy can India ensure that growth drives GDP expansion and advances the SDGs, fulfilling the promise of an equitable and prosperous society by 2047.
Model Question	"Skill development is India's pathway to employment and inclusive growth." Discuss.
Value Addition	**Multi-dimensional Poverty:** India has registered a significant decline in multidimensional poverty in India from 29.17% in 2013-14 to 11.28% in 2022-23 i.e. a reduction of 17.89 percentage points. Uttar Pradesh registered the largest decline in the number of poor with 5.94 crore people escaping multidimensional poverty during the last nine years followed by Bihar at 3.77 crore, Madhya Pradesh at 2.30 crore and Rajasthan at 1.87 crore. According to the Discussion Paper, "Multidimensional Poverty in India since 2005-06", India has registered a significant decline in multidimensional poverty in India from 29.17% in 2013-14 to 11.28% in 2022-23 i.e. a reduction of 17.89 percentage points. Uttar Pradesh registered the largest decline in the number of poor with 5.94 crore people escaping multidimensional poverty during the last nine years followed by Bihar at 3.77 crore, Madhya Pradesh at 2.30 crore and Rajasthan at 1.87 crore.

23. 'In India the economic inequalities and regional disparities increased in the process of Liberalisation, Privatisation and Globalisation.' Discuss. (TGPSC, 2024)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Briefly introduce LPG reforms (1991) and their objectives; use a real-life example to show uneven growth. • Discuss rising income and wealth disparities; cite top 1–10% income share. • Compare developed vs. underdeveloped states; highlight per capita income and industrial growth gaps. • Explain how services/IT benefited urban areas, agriculture lagged, and manufacturing growth was limited. • Address Social Dimensions like caste, gender, and marginalized communities affected by inequality. • Highlight how insufficient infrastructure, poor connectivity, and uneven policy implementation exacerbate inequalities and regional disparities. • Conclude by mentioning government initiatives and emphasize the need for inclusive and equitable growth.
Introduction	In the early 1990s, India faced a severe balance of payments crisis, prompting a paradigm shift in its economic policies. The government, led by then-Finance Minister Dr. Manmohan Singh, embarked on a journey of economic reforms known as Liberalisation, Privatization, and Globalization (LPG). These reforms aimed to integrate India into the global economy, reduce state control, and promote market-driven growth. While the economic growth trajectory post-reforms has been commendable, it has also brought to the forefront significant challenges, notably the widening economic inequalities and regional disparities. For instance, the state of Telangana, particularly Hyderabad, has witnessed rapid urbanization and economic growth, attracting multinational corporations and fostering a burgeoning tech industry. In contrast, regions like Telangana's Adilabad district remain predominantly agrarian, grappling with issues of poverty, limited infrastructure, and underdeveloped human capital. This juxtaposition underscores the uneven benefits of economic reforms across different regions. This essay delves into the multifaceted impact of LPG on India's economic landscape, examining how these reforms have exacerbated economic inequalities and regional disparities.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Economic inequalities and regional disparities increased in the process of Liberalisation, Privatisation and Globalisation:** **Economic Inequality Post-Reforms:** The liberalization era ushered in rapid economic growth, with India's GDP expanding at an average annual rate of 6-7%. However, this growth has not been inclusive. According to the World Inequality Lab, in 2022-23, the top 1% of India's population garnered 22.6% of the national income, while the top 10% received 57.5%. This concentration of income is the highest recorded since 1922, surpassing even the colonial period. Several factors contribute to this rising inequality. The shift from a labor-intensive economy to one driven by capital-intensive industries has disproportionately benefited those with access to capital and advanced skills. The rapid growth of the services sector, particularly in urban centers, has created high-paying jobs for a select few, while the agricultural sector, which employs a significant portion of the rural population, has seen stagnation. Moreover, the influx of foreign direct investment (FDI) has led to the emergence of large conglomerates, further consolidating wealth at the top. The government's focus on promoting ease of doing business and reducing labor regulations has often sidelined the interests of workers, leading to job insecurity and wage stagnation for the majority.

Regional Disparities in Economic Development:

The benefits of economic reforms have been unevenly distributed across India's vast and diverse regions. States like Maharashtra, Gujarat, Tamil Nadu, and Karnataka have capitalized on liberalization, attracting significant investments and fostering industrial growth. In contrast, states such as Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, and Odisha have lagged behind, grappling with infrastructural deficits, poor governance, and limited access to quality education and healthcare.

The Economic Survey 2023-24 highlights that while certain states have shown remarkable progress in human development indicators, others continue to face challenges in improving basic amenities and services. The disparity in per capita income between states is a testament to this uneven development. For example, in 2022, Delhi's per capita income was approximately ₹4.5 lakh, while Bihar's was around ₹50,000, illustrating a stark contrast in economic prosperity.

One of the primary reasons for these regional disparities is the historical neglect of certain areas during the pre-reform era. Policies like the Freight Equalization Policy, which aimed to equalize transportation costs across regions, inadvertently discouraged industrial development in resource-rich states like Jharkhand and Odisha, as it reduced the incentive to set up industries in these areas.

Sectoral Imbalances and Their Implications:

The post-reform period has witnessed a significant shift in the structure of India's economy. The services sector has emerged as the dominant contributor to GDP, accounting for over 50% of the economic output. Conversely, the agricultural sector's share has declined, despite employing a substantial portion of the population.

This structural shift has implications for employment and income distribution. The services sector, particularly Information Technology (IT) and Business Process Outsourcing (BPO), has created high-paying jobs concentrated in urban centers. However, these sectors require specialized skills, leaving a large segment of the population in rural areas without access to quality employment opportunities.

The manufacturing sector, which has the potential to generate mass employment, has not grown at the anticipated rate. Factors such as inadequate infrastructure, complex labor laws, and competition from countries with lower production costs have hindered the expansion of this sector. As a result, many regions remain dependent on agriculture, which is characterized by low productivity and vulnerability to climatic changes.

Social Dimensions of Inequality:

Economic inequalities are often intertwined with social factors such as caste, gender, and education. Studies have shown that marginalized communities, including Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs), and Other Backward Classes (OBCs), face systemic barriers in accessing quality education and employment opportunities. This perpetuates a cycle of poverty and limits social mobility.

Gender disparities further exacerbate social inequalities. Women, particularly in rural areas, have limited access to education, healthcare, and employment opportunities. The National Family Health Survey (NFHS)-5 data reveals that women in rural areas have lower literacy rates and higher maternal mortality rates compared to their urban counterparts.

Policy Responses and Recommendations:

Recognizing the challenges posed by economic inequalities and regional disparities, the government has initiated several policy measures. The Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana aims to provide financial inclusion to the unbanked population, while the Skill India Mission focuses on enhancing employability through vocational training.

	Additionally, the government has emphasized the development of infrastructure in backward regions through schemes like the Bharatmala and Sagarmala projects. These initiatives aim to improve connectivity and promote industrial growth in underserved areas. However, these measures need to be complemented by policies that address the structural causes of inequality. This includes investing in quality education and healthcare, promoting inclusive growth through targeted welfare programs, and ensuring equitable distribution of resources.
Conclusion	The LPG reforms have undeniably transformed India's economic landscape, propelling the country onto the global stage and enabling it to emerge as one of the fastest-growing major economies. These reforms have spurred technological advancement, increased foreign investment, and created hubs of industrial and service-sector growth. However, the benefits of this economic transformation have been unevenly distributed across regions and social groups. While urban centres and skilled professionals have prospered, many rural areas and marginalized communities continue to face poverty, limited infrastructure, and low access to quality education and healthcare. Addressing these persistent economic inequalities and regional disparities through inclusive and sustainable policies is essential. Ensuring that growth translates into shared prosperity for all citizens is critical for realizing the vision of a truly equitable and inclusive India.
Model Question	"Examine the impact of economic reforms and development policies in India on gender equality. How have these reforms affected women's participation in education, employment, and decision-making? Suggest measures to enhance gender-inclusive growth."
Value Addition	**Aspirational Districts Programme:** • The Aspirational Districts Programme (ADP), launched by the Prime Minister in January 2018, is a government initiative to improve core human development indicators in the country's 112 most underdeveloped districts. • It uses a model of "3Cs" approach - Convergence, Collaboration, and Competition to achieve progress across five key socio-economic themes: Health & Nutrition, Education, Agriculture & Water Resources, Financial Inclusion & Skill Development, and Basic Infrastructure. • Progress is measured through monthly delta rankings based on 49 Key Performance Indicators (KPIs), and the programme is driven by states as main drivers, focusing on incremental improvements and inclusive growth. • President of Singapore, Tharman Shanmugaratnam lauded the Aspirational Districts programme calling it the "interesting example of innovation that can be of interest beyond India, elsewhere in the developing world".
24. "The uneven development has led to the growth of regionalism in India.' Discuss. (TGPSC, 2024)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Introduce the essay with a quote or anecdote regarding regionalism and its link to uneven development. • Explain regionalism in India and how disparities create perceptions of neglect. • Discuss various causes of regionalism like Economic, infrastructural, human development, cultural-identity overlap. • Add relevant Illustrations / Case Studies to validate your points– Telangana, Vidarbha, Kalyana Karnataka, Gorkhaland, and Mithila. • Discuss various Consequences both positive (equity demands, cultural recognition) and negative (parochialism, secessionism).

	• Explain how is the India's response like Constitutional measures, fiscal transfers, decentralization, and role of regional parties. • Conclude by balanced regional growth, granular planning, inclusive policies; end with vision of unity through equity.
Introduction	"A nation's strength depends not only on the tallest towers in its cities but also on the roads, schools and hope in its remotest villages." This observation captures the dilemma of modern India. Every September, people in Kalyana Karnataka (formerly Hyderabad-Karnataka) commemorate "Liberation Day." While the region formally integrated into India in 1948, its districts such as Bidar, Raichur, and Yadgir still suffer from poor infrastructure, high poverty, and underemployment compared to more prosperous regions of Karnataka. The contrast creates a deep sense of neglect and fuels identity-based demands for recognition and resources. Similar stories can be found in Telangana, Vidarbha, Bodoland and Mithila. These examples illustrate how uneven development has been a fertile ground for regionalism in India, shaping the political, economic and social fabric of the republic.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The Uneven Development and Growth of Regionalism in India:** **Understanding Regionalism through Unequal Growth:** Regionalism, at its core, is an expression of loyalty or attachment to one's region, often manifested through political mobilization or demands for greater autonomy. While cultural identity and linguistic pride have historically played a role, the more pressing trigger has been uneven economic development. When certain regions secure disproportionate benefits in terms of investment, employment, infrastructure or political influence, other areas develop a sense of deprivation and exclusion. Regional disparities in literacy, per capita income and access to health care are stark across states and even within states. "Regionalism in India is often a response to the uneven development and the perception of relative deprivation." **Economic Fault Lines of Growth:** Independent India's planning strategy, with its emphasis on heavy industry, often concentrated development in certain industrial belts like western India, coastal Andhra, and southern Karnataka. Meanwhile, tribal belts, hilly regions and interior districts remained locked out of these benefits. Over time, areas with robust infrastructure and political influence accelerated their growth, while peripheral regions stagnated. This is evident in Telangana's trajectory before statehood: Hyderabad emerged as a hub of IT and industry, but the surrounding Telangana districts complained of fund diversion and agricultural neglect in favor of coastal Andhra. The eventual formation of Telangana in 2014 was a direct response to decades of uneven growth. A more recent example can be seen within Telangana itself. The Socio-Economic Outlook 2025 report shows that Hyderabad and Rangareddy contribute majorly to the state's GDP, while northern districts such as Adilabad and Mahbubnagar lag behind. The irony is striking: a state created on the plank of regional disparity is now grappling with intra-state inequality, fueling fresh grievances. This reinforces the point that regionalism is not a static phenomenon; it continuously evolves with shifting patterns of development. **Beyond Economics: Culture and Identity Intertwined:** Uneven development does not operate in isolation. It often overlaps with distinct cultural or linguistic identities, which serve as powerful rallying points. The demand for Gorkhaland in West Bengal, for example, draws strength not only from perceptions of economic neglect of the Darjeeling hills but also from the distinct Nepali-speaking identity of its people. Similarly, the Mithila movement in Bihar revives the argument that

cultural uniqueness combined with economic backwardness justifies separate statehood. This blend of cultural assertion and developmental disparity makes regionalism resilient and deeply emotive.

Contemporary Ripples of Discontent:

Recent developments highlight that uneven growth continues to animate regional politics. In 2025, the Karnataka government admitted that despite Article 371-J status, the Kalyana Karnataka region still suffers from underutilization of funds, teacher vacancies and incomplete irrigation projects. In Bihar, the Mithila State Movement gained fresh momentum through public rallies and demands for recognition of Maithili language and economic justice. Meanwhile, Vidarbha in Maharashtra remains a hotbed of agrarian distress, with activists alleging that successive state governments have focused disproportionately on Mumbai-Pune industrial corridors while ignoring Vidarbha's farmers. These instances underline that India's economic successes at the national level often mask sharp regional divides at the sub-state level.

The Two Faces of Regionalism:

It would, however, be simplistic to view regionalism only as a threat. In many cases, it has been a constructive force compelling governments to address regional neglect. The creation of states like Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Uttarakhand gave greater administrative focus to tribal, mineral-rich and hilly areas. Even when statehood is not granted, regional movements often result in targeted welfare schemes. Telangana's recent "Indira Solar Giri Jal Vikasam," a ₹12,600-crore programme for tribal farmers, is a recognition of the need for region-specific development. Similarly, the Union government's "Aspirational Districts Programme" identifies backward districts and directs special funds and monitoring, precisely to mitigate grievances of uneven growth.

Yet, regionalism also carries risks. At its extreme, it can degenerate into separatist tendencies, as seen in earlier movements in Punjab or in violent insurgencies of the Northeast. It can foster parochialism, making people view fellow citizens as outsiders. The "sons-of-the-soil" politics in Maharashtra or the attacks on migrant workers in some states reflect such exclusivist strands. Moreover, the creation of new states is not always a panacea. Telangana's example shows that internal disparities can persist or even worsen within a new political unit, generating fresh rounds of regionalism.

Managing Regional Aspirations in a Federal Framework:

India's response to regionalism has been a mixture of accommodation and reform. The States Reorganization Act of 1956, based largely on linguistic lines, was itself a recognition that suppressing regional identity is counterproductive. Constitutional provisions under Articles 371 and beyond grant special autonomy or development boards to backward regions such as Vidarbha, Marathwada and Kalyana Karnataka. Fiscal transfers through the Finance Commission and centrally sponsored schemes are designed to redistribute resources. Decentralization through Panchayati Raj has further empowered local communities to articulate their developmental needs.

At the same time, successive governments have used political negotiation to integrate regional parties into coalition politics at the Centre, turning potential divisive forces into stakeholders of the Union. This democratic engagement has been one of India's greatest strengths: regionalism is channeled through ballots rather than bullets in most cases.

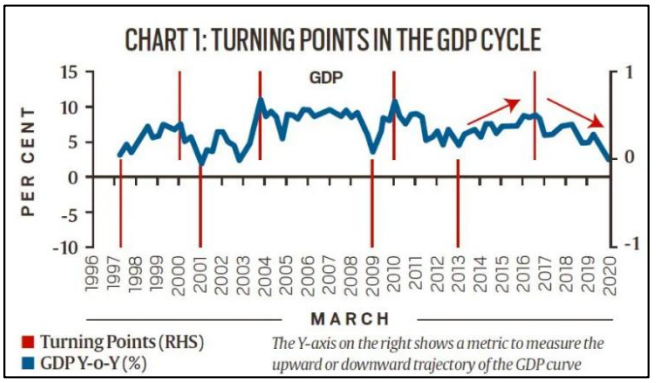
Towards Balanced Development:

Yet, persistent disparities suggest that existing mechanisms are not enough. A more granular approach is necessary, focusing on district-level development indicators

	rather than broad state averages. Transparent allocation of funds, strict monitoring of their utilization, and accountability of local bureaucracies are vital. Equally important is the recognition of cultural and linguistic aspirations like teaching in local languages, celebrating regional festivals, and ensuring representation in institutions can reduce the sense of alienation. Finally, balanced industrialization and infrastructure development must deliberately prioritize lagging regions, with fiscal incentives for industries to set up outside traditional hubs.
Conclusion	The story of regionalism in India is, in many ways, the story of uneven development. From Telangana's statehood movement to the simmering demands of Vidarbha and Mithila, the underlying grievance is the same: a feeling of being left out of India's growth story. Regionalism will continue to exist as long as disparities persist, but it need not be destructive. If handled wisely, it can serve as a barometer for identifying neglected areas and directing resources more equitably. India's federalism must constantly "balance unity with diversity, growth with equity, and national interest with regional aspirations." The challenge, therefore, is not to suppress regionalism but to transform it into a force for inclusive development. Only then can India's unity in diversity become not just a slogan but a lived reality across all its regions.
Model Question	How do cultural, ethnic, religious, or linguistic identities influence regionalist aspirations in India?
Value Addition	**Interstate Border Disputes in India** • Himachal Pradesh–Uttarakhand: Six places in Dehradun district. • Gujarat–Rajasthan: Gujarat claims half of Mangadh Hills, currently in Rajasthan. • Bihar–Uttar Pradesh: Boundary fluctuating due to rivers changing course. • Arunachal–Assam: Arunachal claims territory in Assam on basis of history. • Assam–Nagaland: Nagaland claims 5,000 sq. miles in Assam "on historical grounds." • Karnataka–Maharashtra: Marathi-speaking border areas, as well as Belgaum in Karnataka. • Karnataka–Kerala: Kasaragod district, currently in Kerala. • Odisha–Andhra Pradesh: 63 villages in Odisha. • Odisha–West Bengal: Five villages in Balasore and Mayurbhanj districts, Odisha. • Odisha–Jharkhand: Seven villages in Mayurbhanj and Keonjhar districts. • Odisha–Chhattisgarh: Three villages in Nuapada district.
25. Does the Rise or Fall of the Economic Growth Rate Really Make a Difference to the Poorest of the Poor? (APPSC, 2020)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Does
Approach	• Start by explaining economic growth and poverty alleviation. • Mention India's experience of high GDP growth and its mixed impact on poverty. • State Growth can generate employment and welfare resources. • Mention that inequality and exclusion often prevent the poorest from benefiting. • Cite data: Oxfam inequality reports, World Bank poverty decline figures. • Mention Examples: China's growth-led poverty reduction vs. India's uneven success. • Stress the role of redistribution, social security, and human capital. • Conclude that only inclusive growth benefits the poorest sustainably.
Introduction	The debate over the relationship between economic growth and poverty reduction has occupied economists, policymakers, and social thinkers for decades. Economic

	growth, measured primarily through GDP, is often considered a proxy for development. Yet, the central question remains whether the rise or fall of the economic growth rate really makes a difference to the poorest of the poor, who are at the bottom rung of society. For India, a country with deep socio-economic inequalities and a large population vulnerable to deprivation, this question has significant policy implications. While high growth can generate jobs, raise incomes, and expand state resources for welfare, it does not automatically guarantee the eradication of poverty unless the growth process is inclusive and equitable.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Economic Growth and Poverty Reduction: The Conceptual Relationship** Economic growth and poverty reduction are linked but not synonymous. Classical economic theory suggested a "trickle-down effect," where growth eventually reaches the poorest sections through job creation and improved consumption. Simon Kuznets even proposed an inverted-U hypothesis, where inequality rises in early growth phases but declines later as wealth spreads. However, Amartya Sen and the human development school emphasised that growth alone cannot uplift the poor unless it translates into improved capabilities like access to health, education, and social opportunities. Thus, growth may be necessary, but it is not sufficient to reduce poverty among the poorest of the poor. **India's Trajectory of Growth and Poverty Reduction** India's economic history illustrates the complex relationship between growth and poverty. In the early decades after independence, growth remained slow, averaging around 3.5 per cent, the so-called "Hindu rate of growth", and poverty reduction was minimal. The 1991 liberalisation reforms ushered in higher growth rates averaging 6–7 per cent, which coincided with significant poverty reduction. According to the UNDP, India lifted around 415 million people out of multidimensional poverty between 2005 and 2021, the largest decline recorded globally. At the same time, inequality deepened. Oxfam India's 2023 report pointed out that the richest 1 per cent of Indians held over 40 per cent of the country's wealth, while the bottom 50 per cent owned just 3 per cent. This paradox highlights that while growth enabled poverty reduction, its benefits were not evenly distributed, and the poorest did not always gain proportionately. **When Growth Benefits the Poorest of the Poor** There are strong instances where rising growth directly or indirectly improved the conditions of the poorest. The most prominent global case is China, which recorded near-double-digit growth for three decades and lifted more than 800 million people out of poverty. In India, higher growth during 2003–2008 boosted government revenues, enabling large-scale welfare initiatives like the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA), the National Food Security Act (NFSA), and the expansion of mid-day meal schemes. These programmes had measurable impacts on reducing extreme poverty and hunger. Empirical evidence from the Reserve Bank of India (2019) also shows that in years of higher growth, rural poverty declined faster due to non-farm employment expansion and better wages. Growth also enabled states like Tamil Nadu and Kerala to invest heavily in social sectors, ensuring that welfare reached marginalised communities. **When Growth Fails the Poorest of the Poor** Yet, there are also clear situations where economic growth failed to touch the lives of the poorest. India's growth in IT, real estate, and financial sectors generated wealth but remained largely urban-centric and skill-intensive, leaving rural labourers and the informal sector behind. The phenomenon of "jobless growth" emerged, where GDP increased without a corresponding rise in employment opportunities. The Periodic

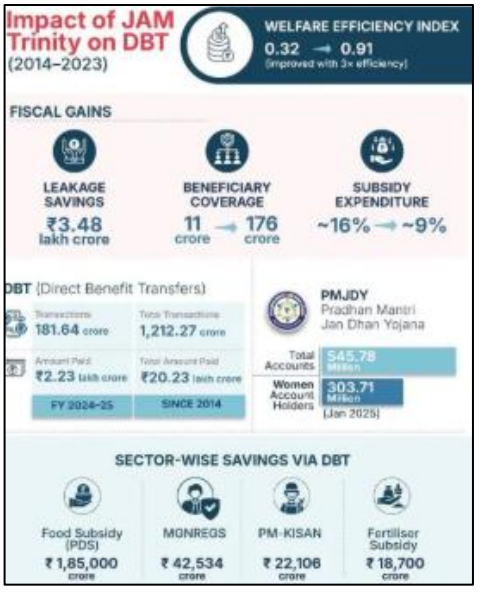
Labour Force Survey (2017–18) reported unemployment at a 45-year high despite robust GDP growth, highlighting this disconnect. The COVID-19 pandemic deepened the crisis. As the economy contracted by nearly 6.6 per cent in 2020–21, migrant workers, daily wage labourers, and slum dwellers bore the brunt. This demonstrates that the fall in growth has a disproportionately harsh impact on the poorest, who lack savings and social security buffers.



Structural Barriers and Inequality

Whether growth makes a difference to the poorest also depends on structural inequalities in access to land, education, healthcare, and skills. The National Multidimensional Poverty Index (2023) revealed that 14.96 per cent of Indians remain multidimensionally poor, suffering deprivations in nutrition, schooling, and housing despite decades of growth. Marginalised groups such as the Scheduled Tribes, the Scheduled Castes, and women are disproportionately represented among the poorest of the poor. Thomas Piketty's global studies on inequality show that if growth benefits are disproportionately captured by the top 1 per cent, the poorest remain excluded from its advantages. Thus, rising growth rates without equitable distribution can even exacerbate relative deprivation.

Empirical Evidence and Comparative Experience



Global experiences strengthen this argument. East Asian economies such as South Korea and Taiwan combined high growth with land reforms, universal education, and industrialization policies, ensuring that the poorest shared in the growth process. Sub-Saharan Africa, in contrast, recorded decent growth in the 2000s but poverty levels remained stagnant due to weak institutions, poor redistribution, and inequality. Within India, Kerala's "human development model" demonstrates that moderate growth combined with investments in health and education can produce stronger poverty outcomes than high but unequal growth elsewhere. These examples underline that growth matters, but its pattern and inclusiveness determine its impact on the poorest.

Towards Inclusive and Pro-Poor Growth

To ensure that growth benefits the poorest, it must be designed to be inclusive and employment-intensive. Policies like skill development, rural infrastructure creation, micro-irrigation, and women's self-help groups enable the poor to participate in the

	growth process. Social safety nets such as direct benefit transfers, food security schemes, and universal healthcare reduce vulnerability during downturns. For instance, the Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-Mobile (JAM) trinity has enabled direct benefit transfers to over 450 million bank accounts, reducing leakages and reaching the poor directly. Similarly, Telangana's Mission Bhagiratha and Andhra Pradesh's YSR Cheyutha channel resources from growth into social development. As Amartya Sen rightly emphasised, it is not just the size of growth but its conversion into human capabilities, freedom from hunger, and access to knowledge, and dignity that makes a difference to the poorest.
Conclusion	The rise or fall of the economic growth rate undeniably makes a difference to the poorest of the poor, but the difference is complex and contingent. Rising growth can create jobs, expand fiscal capacity, and fund welfare, but unless it is inclusive and equitable, the poorest may remain untouched. Conversely, a fall in growth has immediate and devastating impacts on the poor, as seen during economic crises and the pandemic. Growth, therefore, is a necessary but not sufficient condition for poverty eradication. Mahatma Gandhi's talisman that we must recall the face of the poorest before every decision remains the ultimate yardstick to judge whether growth has meaning. For India, the challenge is not only to accelerate growth but to ensure that it is just, inclusive, and sustainable so that the poorest of the poor are not left behind but are placed at the centre of the development process.
Model Question	Critically examine whether fluctuations in India's GDP growth have a tangible impact on the lives of the most marginalized sections of society.
Value Addition	The JAM trinity refers to India's integrated strategy of using Jan Dhan (bank accounts), Aadhaar (biometric ID), and Mobile phones to deliver government welfare and subsidies directly to citizens. This initiative has significantly enhanced financial inclusion by opening bank accounts for the poor, provided a unique identity for beneficiaries, and enabled a widespread mobile network for transactions. The goal of the JAM trinity is to create a transparent, efficient system for Direct Benefit Transfers (DBT), reduce leakages and corruption, and empower citizens with access to financial services.
26. "Most of India's college graduates are unemployable," said ex-President Pranab Mukherjee during his tenure. The crisis in higher education needs to be addressed through policy measures. Comment. (APPSC, 2017)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Comment
Approach	• Start with Pranab Mukherjee's quote to emphasise the employability crisis among Indian graduates. • State that higher education expansion hasn't translated into quality, citing the India Skills Report or NASSCOM data (over 50% graduates are unemployable). • Mention issues like outdated curriculum, faculty shortage, rote learning, and weak industry-academia linkages. • Include lack of research culture, poor funding, and regulatory rigidity (UGC/AICTE overlap). • Highlight youth unemployment, skill mismatch, and loss of demographic dividend. • Suggest reforms like NEP 2020 implementation, academic autonomy, vocational integration, and digital learning. • Quote schemes like PM-YUVA, SWAYAM, and Skill India that aim to improve employability. • Conclude that transforming higher education into skill- and innovation-driven learning is vital to unlock India's demographic potential.

Introduction	Education is the foundation of national development, serving as both an instrument of social transformation and economic empowerment. Yet, India's higher education system, despite its rapid quantitative expansion, faces a profound crisis of quality and employability. The observation of former President Pranab Mukherjee, who remarked that "most of India's college graduates are unemployable," reflects this grim reality. The crisis stems from a disconnect between academic learning and the skill requirements of a modern economy. As India aspires to become a global knowledge hub and harness its demographic dividend, the inefficiencies in higher education have emerged as a major developmental bottleneck. Therefore, the issue demands comprehensive policy measures to realign educational outcomes with national economic and social objectives.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The Context of India's Higher Education Landscape** India has the third-largest higher education system in the world, with over 1,168 universities, 45,473 colleges, and nearly 4.33 crore students enrolled, according to the All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) 2023. While this expansion has democratised access, it has not translated into employability or global competitiveness. Reports such as the India Skills Report 2024 reveal that only 45.9% of graduates are employable, with large disparities across disciplines like engineering (54%), management (51%), and arts (39%). This mismatch between degrees and job market readiness underscores a deeper structural malaise. India's higher education system remains overly focused on theoretical instruction, rote learning, and examination-centric evaluation. As a result, students often graduate with academic qualifications but lack practical, analytical, and communication skills. The World Economic Forum (2023) noted that India's higher education institutions lag in aligning curricula with the Fourth Industrial Revolution (Industry 4.0) skills such as critical thinking, data analysis, and digital literacy. The crisis, therefore, is not one of enrollment but of relevance and quality. **Nature and Dimensions of the Crisis in Higher Education** The crisis in India's higher education is multidimensional, encompassing curriculum design, pedagogy, governance, and employability. The curriculum in most institutions remains outdated, with minimal linkage to industry needs or emerging technologies. Faculty quality and shortages further aggravate the problem; the University Grants Commission (UGC) estimates that nearly 30% of reserved teaching posts in public universities remain vacant. The pedagogical methods often emphasise rote memorisation rather than conceptual understanding or creativity. There is also a lack of interdisciplinary learning, which is crucial in today's interconnected world. Research and innovation, the lifeblood of higher learning, are alarmingly low; India's Gross Expenditure on Research and Development (GERD) remains at 0.7% of GDP, far below the global average of 2.2%. Universities are primarily teaching-oriented, with few incentives for research or collaboration with industry. Administrative inefficiency and excessive bureaucratic control also hinder innovation. Regulatory bodies like the UGC and AICTE operate under rigid frameworks that restrict institutional autonomy. Moreover, the commercialisation of education has led to the mushrooming of private colleges with poor infrastructure and negligible academic standards. As a result, a large segment of graduates, though educated on paper, lack the competencies required for employability. **Employability as the Core of the Crisis** Employability is the ability of graduates to secure and sustain employment, and is the most visible manifestation of the higher education crisis. The disconnect arises from

poor communication skills, a lack of problem-solving ability, and insufficient exposure to real-world work environments.

This gap also has socio-economic implications. Youth unemployment among educated sections has been rising sharply, as the PLFS 2023 data shows that unemployment among graduates stands at over 13.4%, which is higher than the national average. This mismatch not only wastes human capital but also fuels frustration and underemployment. The World Bank (2022) warned that unless India bridges this employability gap, its demographic dividend could turn into a demographic burden by the 2030s.

Structural and Policy Causes of the Employability Crisis

The roots of the higher education crisis lie in systemic deficiencies. Firstly, there is fragmentation and duplication of governance, with multiple overlapping bodies such as UGC, AICTE, and NCTE leading to policy confusion. Secondly, funding constraints limit capacity-building, faculty recruitment, and research development. The average public expenditure on higher education in India is far lower than in advanced economies such as the United States or South Korea.

Thirdly, there is a lack of accountability and quality assurance. Accreditation processes are often formalities rather than rigorous evaluations. Internships, apprenticeships, and vocational integration, which are common in developed countries, are sporadic in India, leaving graduates ill-prepared for practical work environments.

Fifth, the digital divide further worsens inequality. The pandemic revealed how technology-enabled education benefits urban learners while leaving rural students behind due to poor connectivity and a lack of digital access. Thus, structural inequities reinforce educational and employability disparities.

Policy Measures and Government Initiatives to Reform Higher Education

Recognising these challenges, successive governments have attempted to reform higher education through multiple policy interventions. The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 is a landmark initiative that seeks to overhaul the system by promoting flexibility, multidisciplinary learning, and skill integration. The NEP proposes a four-year undergraduate programme, an Academic Bank of Credits, and multiple entry-exit options to enhance student mobility and learning outcomes.

Schemes such as Pradhan Mantri Uchchatar Shiksha Abhiyan (PM-USHA) aim to improve state universities through quality funding and infrastructure support. The National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF) promotes healthy competition among institutions by benchmarking performance on parameters like research and employability. The Skill India Mission (2015) and Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY) are bridging the skills gap through vocational training and apprenticeship-based learning. Similarly, digital platforms like SWAYAM have expanded access to quality education through open online courses.

Yet, the success of these policies depends on effective implementation, coordination among central and state bodies, and a cultural shift toward innovation-led education. Public-private partnerships, curriculum reforms co-designed with industries, and faculty development programmes can operationalise these policy visions into outcomes.

Global Comparisons and Lessons for India with respect to Higher Education

A comparative view reveals that countries like Germany, Singapore, and South Korea have successfully aligned higher education with national economic strategies. Germany's dual vocational education model integrates classroom learning with industry training, ensuring that over 90% of its graduates are job-ready. Singapore emphasises outcome-based education through continuous curriculum updating and

	international benchmarking. These models demonstrate the importance of policy coherence, skill alignment, and institutional accountability, the principles India can adopt within its federal framework. **The Role of Technology and Innovation in addressing India's higher education crisis** It can play a transformative role in addressing India's higher education crisis. Artificial intelligence, machine learning, and big data analytics can personalise learning experiences and bridge skill gaps. EdTech platforms such as BYJU's, Coursera are already redefining accessibility and affordability. However, technology must complement, not replace, pedagogy. Faculty training in digital teaching methods and equitable digital infrastructure in rural institutions is essential to ensure inclusive progress. **The Way Forward** To overcome the employability crisis, India's higher education system must undergo a paradigm shift from degree-oriented education to skill- and competency-based learning. Institutions must develop outcome-based curricula, integrate industry internships, and promote research and innovation ecosystems. Faculty recruitment should prioritise quality and continuous professional development. Regulatory frameworks must be streamlined through the proposed Higher Education Commission of India (HECI) for efficiency and accountability. Moreover, public investment in higher education should be increased to at least 1.5% of GDP to meet global standards. Policy coherence is key. NEP 2020 must not remain aspirational but operational, supported by state-level implementation frameworks. Collaboration between universities and industries should become institutionalised through skill councils, joint research projects, and innovation hubs. Most importantly, education must foster not only employability but also creativity, ethical reasoning, and citizenship are the hallmarks of holistic learning.
Conclusion	The crisis in India's higher education, as highlighted by Pranab Mukherjee, is not merely about unemployment but about the ineffective translation of education into capability. It symbolises the gap between aspiration and execution, policy and practice. In a nation where over 60% of the population is below 35 years of age, higher education must serve as the engine of empowerment, not frustration. The need of the hour is to create an ecosystem where knowledge, skills, and values intersect to produce competent and employable graduates. As Amartya Sen observed, "Education is among the basic capabilities that empower people to participate effectively in the economy and society." Only through structural reforms, quality assurance, and policy-driven transformation can India turn its demographic dividend into a true developmental dividend and realise its vision of a knowledge-based economy.
Model Question	India faces a serious mismatch between higher education outcomes and the employability of graduates. Examine the causes and suggest appropriate policy interventions.
Value Addition	The National Digital University (NDU) is a proposed public university by the Ministry of Education (India) under the National Education Policy 2020, aiming to revolutionise higher education by offering accessible, affordable, and personalised online degree programs through a hub-and-spoke model. It plans to collaborate with renowned public and private institutions, allowing students to earn credits from various sources via the Academic Bank of Credits, and leverage the SWAYAM platform for course delivery. The goal is to bridge educational gaps and provide quality education to students across India, regardless of their location or circumstances

27. Regional disparity is one of the key factors for demand of bifurcation of States in India. In light of this, how can balanced regional development be ensured in the State of Andhra Pradesh? (APPSC, 2017)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	How
Approach	• Introduce the concept of regional disparity and its role in state bifurcations in India, mentioning the Andhra Pradesh bifurcation (2014). • Explain why addressing regional disparity is critical for political stability, economic growth, and social equity in Andhra Pradesh. • Discuss various principles for balanced regional development, such as spatially-targeted investment, inclusive economic planning, and institutional decentralization. • Include fiscal and human development interventions, such as outcome-based budgeting, ring-fenced funds for backward districts, education, health, skill development, and social protection measures. • Explain governance, decentralization, and the role of the private sector, including strengthening local planning bodies with fiscal autonomy and aligning private investment with local employment. • Highlight the importance of transparent project selection, social audits, and citizen scorecards for accountability. • Stress the importance of monitoring and evaluation using various indicators, such as per-capita GSDP, literacy, health outcomes, and road connectivity (Regional Convergence Index).
Introduction	When Andhra Pradesh was bifurcated in 2014, a tractor procession in rural Guntur reported in national newspapers captured more than a parade, it captured expectation. Farmers, engineers, and small traders who had watched Hyderabad's skyline for jobs and investment suddenly found the familiar magnet gone. For some it was the chance to build a fresh capital (Amaravati); for many others it was the anxiety of where investment, institutions, and opportunities would go next. That mix of hope and grievance is the practical starting point for any honest analysis of balanced regional development in Andhra Pradesh: the question is not merely how to grow the state, but how to make growth reach every district, caste group, and occupation that felt the shock of bifurcation.
Body & Infographic Representation	**How Regional Disparity Became the Trigger** Regional disparities that feed demands for bifurcation are rarely about size or geography alone. They often reflect uneven urban primacy, where one city or zone concentrates capital, institutions, and services, while other districts lag behind. In Andhra Pradesh, the loss of Hyderabad - the economic, industrial, and administrative hub, created an immediate need to redistribute public investment and opportunities. Post-bifurcation, the state registered respectable GSDP growth, but growth patterns exposed inequities. Coastal districts benefitted more from ports, power plants, and irrigation, while Rayalaseema and tribal belts remained relatively deprived. This unequal spread of projects created political contestation and highlighted the urgency of addressing regional balance not just for equity, but also for long-term political stability. **Principles and Pathways for Balanced Growth** Balanced regional development requires a guiding framework that converts promises into measurable outcomes. Three principles stand out. First, spatially targeted investment that reduces locational disadvantages and creates opportunities in lagging regions. Second, inclusive economic planning that ties private sector projects to local employment and procurement. Third, institutional decentralization that empowers districts to design interventions suited to their socio-economic realities.

In practical terms, investments in roads, power, ports, and digital connectivity must go hand in hand with skill training, access to credit, and local governance reforms. Growth must therefore be both physical and human, ensuring that connectivity translates into real opportunity.

Strategic Investments and Balanced Urbanization

A major lever of convergence is infrastructure and connectivity. Transport corridors, port-led development, reliable electricity, and digital networks act as multipliers. Corridor-based strategies that link backward districts with growth poles like Visakhapatnam and special economic zones are critical. Importantly, success must be measured, for instance, how many blocks or villages are brought within two hours of a growth node, and funds earmarked for disadvantaged regions to avoid excessive concentration.

Equally vital is a multi-node urban strategy. Instead of depending on a single capital city, Andhra Pradesh can strengthen cities such as Tirupati, Kurnool, Ongole, Nellore, and Vizianagaram by building universities, medical hubs, logistics centres, and light industry. This reduces pressure on one capital, spreads employment, and avoids the irrecoverable risks witnessed in the Amaravati controversy, where heavy concentration in one site triggered financial and political backlash.

Agriculture Modernization and Non-Farm Opportunities

Agriculture continues to employ a large share of Andhra Pradesh's population. Strengthening this base while linking it to non-farm opportunities is central to balanced growth. Investments in irrigation projects, crop diversification, farmer producer organizations, and food processing facilities can raise rural incomes. Agro-processing parks and small manufacturing clusters near rural belts ensure that income gains are not restricted to productivity alone but are extended into jobs and entrepreneurship.

However, lessons from large irrigation projects like Polavaram must guide future investments. While such projects promise water security and agricultural prosperity, they also create displacement and ecological risks. Ensuring robust rehabilitation, social safeguards, and environmental protections is vital to prevent development from deepening existing vulnerabilities.

Fiscal Equity, Human Capital and Social Protection

Balanced development is equally a question of fiscal policy. The 2025–26 Andhra Pradesh budget allocates 12.1% to education, 6.7% to health, 6.2% to rural development (above the national state average), 4.8% to agriculture, and nearly 17.8% to SC/ST/OBC welfare. In 2024–25, the state earmarked ₹16,739 crore for Panchayat Raj and rural development, ₹29,909 crore for school education, and ₹18,421 crore for health and family welfare. These allocations demonstrate a strong focus on social sectors, but efficiency and outcome orientation remain the challenge.

Outcome-based budgeting can bridge this gap, tying disbursements to measurable improvements such as school enrollment, immunization, or employment placements. Investments in health, nutrition, education, and gender-sensitive programs reduce inter-generational inequality. Incentives like housing or career progression for teachers and doctors in rural areas can close the urban–rural gap in services. Simultaneously, social protection measures like PDS reforms, direct transfers, and health insurance can shield vulnerable households, enabling them to invest in children's education or micro-enterprises.

Governance, Decentralization and Private Sector Role

Institutional decentralization is crucial to translate policy into outcomes. Empowering district planning cells with fiscal autonomy and skilled professionals allows tailored

	interventions. Strengthening local bodies with predictable revenue ensures community priorities, feeder roads, market yards, or skill centers are addressed effectively. The private sector too must be aligned with regional equity. Land pooling with local participation, tax incentives linked to local job creation, and procurement clauses favoring local producers can ensure projects benefit host communities. Industrial training institutes aligned with emerging industries prevent skill mismatches. Public-private partnerships should include enforceable clauses on employment and social outcomes, monitored by independent agencies to reduce elite capture. **Managing Flagship Projects and Tracking Convergence** Large flagship projects like new capitals or irrigation megaprojects can reshape economies but also risk generating conflict. The Amaravati experience demonstrated how contested capital projects can stall progress, while Polavaram highlighted displacement and environmental concerns. To ensure these initiatives serve regional balance, rigorous appraisal, meaningful consultation, fair resettlement, and decentralized benefit-sharing must be mandatory. Equally vital is the capacity to measure outcomes. Andhra Pradesh could adopt a Regional Convergence Index, combining indicators such as per-capita GSDP, poverty reduction, literacy, healthcare, and all-weather road access. Current disparities are stark: literacy ranges from 74% in West Godavari to 58% in Vizianagaram; infant mortality is higher in tribal belts than the state average of 30 per 1,000; and only 57% of Rayalaseema habitations have all-weather roads compared to 80% in coastal districts. Publishing district dashboards and tying a portion of grants to improvements would strengthen accountability. NITI Aayog's fiscal analysis already provides a baseline to set realistic convergence targets.
Conclusion	Balanced regional development after bifurcation is not a technocratic checklist but a political compact between the state and its citizens. Andhra Pradesh's pathway must combine smart public investment, decentralized governance, human-capital expansion, and private-sector levers designed with accountability. Turning the political energy of bifurcation into targeted and inclusive action, backed by independent monitoring, can convert initial anxieties into a sustainable model of shared growth. Progress will take time, but with measurable targets and consistent implementation, Andhra Pradesh has the opportunity to become a national model of how a post-bifurcation state can heal regional imbalances and deliver equitable development.
Model Question	"From Hyderabad to Amaravati: How Andhra Pradesh can convert bifurcation challenges into a model of inclusive development."
Value Addition	**Regional disparity:** • Regional disparity refers to a situation where different indicators such as per capita income, consumption level, food availability, agricultural and industrial development, infrastructural development are not similar among regions. • The problems of regional development is mostly universal in nature except its intensity differs in different countries (developed/developing). Almost all countries face the regional disparity during their process of development. • Sharp differences are observed in the theoretical analysis of regional disparity. There is general agreement for an inverted U-shapes curve of regional disparities with growth. • The development theories put forwarded by the regional experts like Simon Kuznets (1963), Hirschman (1958), and Mera (1965), opined for a regional disparity during the socio-political development and modernisation. • According to these theories, urban primacy, socio-spatial and individual inequalities increase during the initial period of development, but this will reduce over time with the advanced stage of development.

28. "Government of India announced special package but did not grant special status to Andhra Pradesh". Explain whether special status would have any advantage over the present special package? (APPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Explain
Approach	• Introduce with the background of Andhra Pradesh bifurcation (2014). • Explain the concept of Special Category Status (SCS), its historical rationale, and the fiscal advantages it provides, such as higher grant-to-loan ratios, preferential access to central schemes, and reduced borrowing pressure. • Discuss the special package announced by the Government of India, highlighting its focus on revenue deficit grants, capital formation, backward district development, etc. • Analyze the comparative advantages and limitations of SCS versus the special package, considering fiscal relief, sustainability, predictability, governance, and implementation realities, as well as the impact of 14th Finance Commission reforms on the relevance of SCS. • Emphasize the importance of outcome-based budgeting, ring-fenced funds for backward regions, and transparency mechanisms like social audits for efficient fund utilization. • Explain why granting SCS to Andhra Pradesh was challenging, including Union budget constraints, precedent for other states, and long-term fiscal implications. • Suggest how a combination of predictable multi-year grants, targeted special packages, and institutional reforms could achieve the objectives that SCS would have otherwise offered. • Conclude by stressing that the focus should be on structured fiscal support, governance reforms, and capacity building rather than symbolic labels, to ensure Andhra Pradesh's long-term developmental trajectory.
Introduction	The bifurcation of Andhra Pradesh in 2014 left the residuary State with immediate fiscal, administrative and development challenges — loss of capital, disruption of revenue streams and the need to build new institutions and infrastructure. The Centre responded with a variety of measures: legislative provisions in the Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation Act, targeted grant packages and programmatic support to ease the transition. Yet political debate has focused on what was *not* granted — the much-requested Special Category/"special" status — and whether that label would have delivered materially better outcomes than the special package actually announced. This essay analyses the legal-fiscal differences between special category status (SCS) and special packages, weighs their relative advantages, examines implementation realities, and offers a reasoned view on policy priorities for Andhra Pradesh's long-term development.
Body & Infographic Representation	**What "special category/status" meant historically — fiscal mechanics and rationale** Historically, Special Category Status (SCS) was a classification used by the Centre to extend preferential central assistance to states facing structural disadvantages like hilly terrain, sparse population, border sensitivity or infrastructure backwardness. Economically the most consequential feature of SCS was its treatment under central plan assistance: for many centrally-sponsored transfers and plan grants, SCS states received a much larger share in the form of *grants* rather than *loans* (for example, assistance under the Net Central Assistance or similar channels was often split roughly 90% grant and 10% loan for SCS states, versus ratios skewed toward loans for general category states). This composition improved fiscal space and lowered debt burdens

for beneficiary states. In addition, SCS states were often given priority for centrally-sponsored schemes and special concessional funding windows.

The special package approach: targeted, time-bound, conditional support

By contrast, the Centre's response after bifurcation combined statutory guarantees (in the Reorganisation Act) with a special package focused on revenue deficit grants, funds for capital creation, and targeted schemes for backward districts and displaced populations. These packages were framed as time-bound and conditional: specific sums earmarked for certain years (and some tied to performance or usage norms), along with programmatic support routed through ministries and agencies. The special package approach is more discretionary and project-specific: it can be calibrated to immediate post-bifurcation needs (capital city development, pensions, transitional grants), but tends to lack the structural fiscal transformation that comes from long-term high-grant ratios under SCS.

Would SCS have been materially better? Comparative advantages

On paper, SCS offers clear fiscal advantages. A higher share of grants lowers the state's borrowing requirement, easing debt dynamics and interest costs, an important benefit for a state required to finance a new capital and large infrastructure. SCS also often translates into higher and faster access to central funds for flagship programmes, enabling a larger public investment program without immediate tax increases. For a fiscally stressed state like Andhra Pradesh after bifurcation, this could have eased budgetary pressures and allowed faster delivery of public goods.

However, SCS is a blunt instrument. It is not unconditional "free money": many of the transfers under central schemes are tied to design, agency capacities and matching contributions. Moreover, the 14th Finance Commission's recommendations changed the fiscal architecture by reducing the salience of the old SCS framework (leaving SCS mostly to certain northeastern/hill states and narrowing its practical application), making the politics of extending SCS to new large states more complicated and fiscally sensitive for the Union budget. In short, while SCS could have helped Andhra Pradesh's fiscal ratios, it would have required systemic adjustments in Union-State fiscal flows and might have set a precedent with large fiscal implications. **Implementation realities: packages can be targeted but suffer from unpredictability**

Special packages, if well-designed and timely can focus on the most urgent needs (capital city infrastructure, landless pensions, irrigation projects, transitional staff costs). The Centre did announce measures and sanctioned special grants for backward districts and transition support; such targeted injections can be efficient if funds are disbursed predictably and accompanied by oversight. The downside is political risk and temporal limits: packages are usually time-bound and subject to annual budgetary pressures, and subsequent governments may renegotiate or rescind elements. For instance, guarantees in parliamentary debates can be interpreted politically, but the fiscal machinery (14th FC norms, GST compensation, and revised devolution formulas) ultimately governs recurring transfers.

Distributional and institutional considerations

Beyond headline numbers, what matters is how funds translate to development on the ground. Special status that simply increases grant inflows without strengthening state capacity, project selection, and transparency can produce inefficient spending. Conversely, a focused special package that includes conditionalities for institutional strengthening (better public investment management, project appraisal, anti-corruption safeguards) and ring-fenced funds for human development can produce better outcomes per rupee. The NITI Aayog and state finance studies emphasize that

	sustainable improvements require reforms in revenue mobilization, expenditure quality and debt management, not merely larger transfers. Andhra Pradesh's fiscal indicators (debt-to-GSDP, contingent liabilities) suggest that a one-time label or package is insufficient without accompanying governance reforms. **Political economy and precedent: why the Centre hesitated** Granting long-term SCS to a large, economically significant state like Andhra Pradesh would have wide fiscal and political consequences. Other states could press for parity, and the Union budgetary calculus would be affected. After the 14th Finance Commission institutionalized greater devolution to states, the space for discretionary SCS was reduced; hence governments preferred special packages targeted to specific needs rather than broad, permanent reclassification. This explains the Centre's preference for packages in 2014-15, a politically expedient but fiscally cautious approach. **A pragmatic synthesis: what would have been ideal?** Rather than treating the question as binary, SCS versus special package, the policy lesson is to combine the best elements of both. Andhra Pradesh needed the predictability and grant composition advantages historically associated with SCS, and the targeting and conditionality of special packages. Practically, this could have meant a multi-year guaranteed grant envelope (with high grant: loan ratio for core capital formation and social protection), coupled with strong governance conditions: outcome-based budgeting, independent project appraisal, ring-fenced funds for backward districts, and enhanced transparency (social audits, public dashboards). Embedding fiscal responsibility measures (clear debt targets) and capacity building (public investment management) would ensure funds were both adequate and productive.
Conclusion	Special Category Status would have offered Andhra Pradesh clear fiscal relief by shifting the composition of central assistance toward grants and reducing borrowing pressure. Yet its political feasibility and systemic consequences after the 14th Finance Commission made it an imperfect and contentious solution. The special package that was announced could have matched many SCS benefits if it had been structured as a multiyear, predictable grant envelope with strict governance and performance conditions. Going forward the policy priority for Andhra Pradesh is not a symbolic label but a combination of guaranteed, predictable central support for capital formation and human development; rigorous public investment management; and structural reforms to expand own-revenue mobilization while protecting poor and backward districts. If the Centre and state can institutionalize multi-year fiscal support with transparency and capacity building, Andhra Pradesh's developmental trajectory will be strengthened irrespective of labels.
Model Question	"Special Category Status has historically been granted to North-Eastern states to address structural disadvantages. Critically analyse the rationale, benefits, and limitations of SCS in promoting regional development, with reference to fiscal and social indicators."
Value Addition	**What is special category status?** • Special category status is a classification of regions or states by the central government to provide special assistance in the form of tax benefits and financial support for development of the region. It was first introduced in 1969 based on the recommendations of the Fifth Finance Commission. **What are the criteria to provide special status to a state?** **The criteria listed by the government include** • Hilly and difficult terrain

	• Low population density and / or sizeable share of tribal population • Strategic location along the borders with neighboring countries • Economic and infrastructural backwardness • Non-viable nature of state finances.
29. "Despite huge gains in economic output, our current social, political and economic systems are exacerbating inequalities, rather than reducing them". In view of the above statement, discuss the importance of inclusive growth? (APPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Start with the definition of inclusive growth = growth with equity, participation, and sustainability. • Quote statement like economic gains exist, but inequality (Oxfam reports, NSS data) is rising. • Show social inequalities such as caste, gender, region, and rural-urban divide. • Mention Political exclusion, such as weaker representation of marginalised in decision-making. • State Economic exclusion, like jobless growth, farmer distress, and informal labour vulnerability. • Explain why inclusive growth is crucial for the ability, poverty reduction, and social justice. • Mention govt initiatives like MNREGA, JAM Trinity, DBTs, Start-up India, skill programs. • Conclude that only inclusive growth can ensure India's democracy and economy remain sustainable.
Introduction	Economic growth in India over the past three decades has been remarkable, with GDP expanding at an average of over 6 per cent since liberalisation in 1991. India is now the world's fourth-largest economy, with milestones such as a $3.91 trillion GDP in 2024 and robust sectors like IT, manufacturing, and services. However, this expansion has not translated into equitable outcomes for all sections of society. The paradox of growth accompanied by rising inequality is evident in reports such as Oxfam's Inequality Report 2023, which highlighted that the top 1 per cent of India's population owns more than 40 per cent of its wealth, while the bottom 50 per cent owns only 3 per cent. This widening gap underscores the relevance of the statement that our current social, political, and economic systems are exacerbating inequalities rather than reducing them. In this context, the idea of inclusive growth becomes vital, as it emphasises not merely the pace of growth but also its spread and depth across society.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Understanding Inclusive Growth** Inclusive growth goes beyond traditional GDP-centric measures of development. The Planning Commission of India defined it as "growth that is broad-based across sectors and inclusive of a large part of the country's labour force." The Eleventh Five-Year Plan explicitly underscored the need for "inclusive and sustainable growth" by linking economic performance with social justice. Unlike trickle-down theories, inclusive growth is rooted in distributive justice, participatory decision-making, and equal access to opportunities. It is about ensuring that the benefits of growth reach marginalised groups such as the Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, minorities, women, and rural populations. Nobel laureate Amartya Sen, in his capability approach, argued that development must expand people's freedoms and opportunities, not merely incomes. Thus, inclusive growth is not just an economic necessity but a moral and social imperative.

The Social Dimensions of Inequality

Social systems in India continue to perpetuate exclusion and inequality. Caste hierarchies restrict access to education, healthcare, and employment for marginalised groups. The National Sample Survey (2024) revealed that Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes still face poverty rates nearly twice as high as upper castes. Gender inequality remains entrenched, as highlighted by India's rank of 131 out of 146 in the Global Gender Gap Report 2025. These figures show that while economic output has surged, vulnerable communities have not proportionately shared in the prosperity. Inclusive growth must therefore dismantle these social barriers through affirmative action, skill development, and universal social protection.

The Political Dimensions of Inequality

Democracy, in theory, should empower all citizens equally, but political systems often reflect the dominance of powerful groups. Representation of women in legislatures, despite the recent Women's Reservation Bill, is still only around 15 percent in the Lok Sabha. Marginalized groups struggle to influence policymaking, leading to policies skewed in favour of corporate elites rather than ordinary citizens. Corruption and clientelism divert resources away from welfare schemes towards patronage networks. Inclusive growth requires deepening political inclusivity by strengthening local governance, empowering Panchayati raj institutions, and ensuring participatory decision-making. It also requires enforcing accountability in welfare delivery systems so that entitlements genuinely reach the poor rather than being siphoned off.

The Economic Dimensions of Inequality

The economic system has increasingly produced a pattern of jobless growth. Between 2012 and 2019, India's GDP grew at an average of 7 per cent, but employment generation remained stagnant. The Periodic Labour Force Survey (2022–23) showed that youth unemployment is over 18 per cent, particularly acute among educated graduates. Informal labour continues to dominate, with nearly 80 percent of India's workforce lacking formal contracts or social security. Rural distress is exacerbated by low agricultural incomes, climate shocks, and inadequate irrigation. The agrarian crisis is reflected in continued farmer suicides. Inclusive growth, in this backdrop, must prioritise labour-intensive sectors, social security nets, and rural development programs that reduce vulnerability.

Why Inclusive Growth is Crucial for India

Inclusive growth is not just about equity but about sustaining economic momentum. Persistent inequalities weaken domestic demand, as the majority of people lack purchasing power, thereby limiting market expansion. This was evident during the COVID-19 pandemic, when migrant workers bore the brunt of lockdowns, revealing the fragility of exclusionary growth models. Inclusive growth also ensures social stability. As global examples like the Arab Spring show, high inequality fuels unrest and undermines political order. In India, regional disparities between prosperous coastal Andhra and drought-prone Rayalaseema, or between urban Delhi and rural Bihar, risk destabilising federal harmony. Furthermore, inclusive growth enhances human capital by investing in health and education. The National Education Policy 2020 and Ayushman Bharat are steps in this direction, but more needs to be done to reach universal standards.

Government Initiatives Towards Inclusive Growth

India has made attempts to foster inclusivity. The Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) has provided livelihood security to over 90 million households annually. The JAM Trinity, Jan Dhan, Aadhaar, and Mobile have

	enabled direct benefit transfers, reducing leakages in welfare schemes. Schemes such as Stand-Up India and Start-up India aim to encourage entrepreneurship among women and marginalised communities. The Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana has sought to provide housing for all, while Ayushman Bharat aims to expand healthcare coverage to 500 million people. However, gaps in implementation, inadequate funding, and exclusion errors persist. Oxfam India's 2022 report observed that welfare spending on education and health as a percentage of GDP remains below global averages, limiting the transformative potential of these schemes. **Global Perspectives on Inclusive Growth** International experiences offer valuable insights. South Korea's growth story demonstrates how land reforms, investment in universal education, and industrial policy created equitable development. The Nordic countries exemplify how strong welfare states can combine efficiency with equity. In contrast, Latin America for much of the 20th century suffered inequality-induced instability until countries like Brazil adopted redistributive programs like Bolsa Família. For India, the lesson is that growth alone does not guarantee inclusivity; deliberate policy interventions are essential. Inclusive growth must be designed as an institutional framework, not a by-product of GDP expansion. **The Road Ahead** To truly realise inclusive growth, India must focus on three critical areas. First, investing in human capital is paramount. UNESCO estimates that every $1 invested in education yields $10 in economic returns, highlighting the multiplier effect of knowledge. Second, structural transformation in agriculture, through irrigation, storage, and farmer-producer organisations, is needed to enhance rural incomes. Third, social protection systems must be universalised, providing unemployment insurance, health coverage, and pension security. Moreover, inclusive growth in the 21st century must embrace digital inclusivity. With initiatives like Digital India, bridging the digital divide between rural and urban, rich and poor, becomes crucial for equitable access to opportunities.
Conclusion	India's economic rise has been impressive, yet the persistence of inequality raises fundamental questions about the meaning of development. Growth that bypasses large sections of society is unsustainable and unjust. Inclusive growth, therefore, is not a luxury but a necessity for India's long-term survival as a democratic and prosperous nation. It aligns with constitutional ideals of justice, equality, and fraternity, and with global commitments under the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly Goal 10 on reducing inequality. It was aptly said, "A nation's greatness is measured by how it treats its weakest members." For India to achieve its aspiration of becoming a developed economy by 2047, growth must be inclusive, ensuring that every citizen like irrespective of caste, gender, or region, shares in the prosperity. Only then can India truly claim to be on the path of inclusive growth that is equitable, sustainable, and enduring.
Model Question	Economic growth without equity is meaningless. In this context, analyse why inclusive development is essential for India's long-term social stability and economic sustainability.
Value Addition	**Salient features of inclusive growth** • **Skill Development**– Harnessing the demographic dividend will depend upon the employability of the working age population, their health, education, vocational training and skills. Skill development plays a key role here. • **Financial Inclusion** – Financial inclusion is crucial for inclusive growth because it encourages saving, which fuels economic growth.

	• **Technological Advancement–** Depending on how they're employed, technological advances can reduce or increase inequality. The government has implemented several measures, such as the Digital India Mission, to exploit technology to reach out to millions deprived on multiple fronts. • **Social Development** – Empowerment can be achieved by upgrading social institutions, such as hospitals, schools, and universities. Investing in social structures will enhance GDP and develop a healthy, capable workforce.
30. Examine the role of self-help groups (SHGS) and micro finance institutions (MFIs) in meeting the credit requirements of rural people in Andhra Pradesh? (APPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Examine
Approach	• Start with the context that rural people often face a lack of formal credit due to collateral issues and dependence on moneylenders. • Define SHGs and MFIs as small voluntary groups and financial intermediaries providing microcredit. • Mention Andhra Pradesh's success, such as "DWCRA" and "Velugu/IKP" programs empowered women SHGs. • State that SHGs provide thrift, savings, and low-interest loans, promoting self-employment and social capital. • Mention that MFIs extend microfinance where banks are absent; e.g., SKS Microfinance based in AP. • Highlight positive impacts like women's empowerment, poverty reduction, and reduced dependence on usury. • Also note issues like over-indebtedness, high interest rates, and 2010 microfinance crisis in AP. • Conclude that SHGs + MFIs are vital for rural credit, but need regulation, financial literacy, and sustainability.
Introduction	Access to credit has long been a cornerstone of rural development, directly influencing agricultural productivity, entrepreneurship, and poverty alleviation. In India, particularly in Andhra Pradesh, formal financial institutions have historically struggled to reach the hinterlands due to a lack of collateral, poor infrastructure, and high transaction costs. Farmers, artisans, and small entrepreneurs often relied on informal moneylenders at exorbitant interest rates, which perpetuated cycles of indebtedness. Against this backdrop, Self-Help Groups (SHGs) and Microfinance Institutions (MFIs) emerged as vital instruments to meet the credit needs of rural communities. These institutions not only provide small loans but also integrate social development, financial literacy, and community participation, making them central to inclusive rural growth. Andhra Pradesh has been a pioneering state in implementing SHG-based microfinance programs, offering a model for other states in India.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Self-Help Groups (SHGs): Concept and Structure** Self-Help Groups are small voluntary associations, typically comprising 10 to 20 members, who pool savings and provide credit within the group. In Andhra Pradesh, the concept gained prominence through programs like the Integrated Rural Development Programme and later the Indira Kranthi Patham (IKP), which empowered women SHGs across the state. By fostering regular savings, peer pressure for repayment, and community solidarity, SHGs create a sustainable credit ecosystem at the grassroots. They often receive revolving credit from banks under the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD) linkage scheme, allowing them to extend loans for

agriculture, animal husbandry, micro-enterprises, and emergency needs. This demonstrates the scale and significance of SHGs in rural credit delivery.

Microfinance Institutions (MFIs): Expanding Financial Access

Microfinance Institutions, both non-governmental and commercial, supplement SHGs by providing credit directly to rural households who may be excluded from bank-linked programs. In Andhra Pradesh, MFIs like SKS Microfinance, Spandana, and BASIX have been instrumental in bridging gaps where SHGs or formal banking were absent. MFIs typically provide small, short-term loans for income-generating activities, often coupled with financial literacy and social development programs. MFIs also introduced innovations such as group lending, flexible repayment schedules, and doorstep banking, reducing transaction costs and encouraging timely repayment.

Impact on Rural Credit and Livelihoods

The combined efforts of SHGs and MFIs have significantly increased access to formal credit, particularly for women and marginalised communities. Women, who constitute over 90 per cent of SHG membership, gain not only financial resources but also social empowerment. For instance, in districts like Prakasam and Guntur, SHG participation has enabled women to start small enterprises such as tailoring, poultry, and dairy farming, increasing household income by 20–30 per cent on average, according to IKP program reports. By reducing reliance on informal moneylenders charging 36–60 per cent interest annually, SHGs and MFIs have curtailed exploitative debt cycles. Empirical evidence from the Andhra Pradesh Microfinance Crisis (2010) showed that the sector had reached over 2.2 crore borrowers, demonstrating the scale at which rural credit needs were being met before regulatory interventions.

MFIs, in particular, addressed credit gaps in regions where SHG penetration was low, providing loans for crop inputs, micro-enterprises, and emergency expenditures. They also played a role in risk diversification, enabling households to smooth consumption during crop failures or droughts, which are frequent in Rayalaseema and northern Andhra Pradesh. Studies by the International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI) indicate that access to microfinance increased agricultural investment and improved school enrolment rates for children in MFI-supported households, illustrating both economic and social impact.

Women's Empowerment and Social Inclusion

One of the most significant outcomes of SHGs and MFIs in Andhra Pradesh is women's empowerment. SHG participation fosters leadership, negotiation skills, and confidence among rural women, enabling them to participate in household decision-making and local governance. The Indira Kranthi Patham reports that women who received loans through SHGs also engaged in collective activities such as watershed management, sanitation campaigns, and health awareness programs. MFIs, through group-lending models, reinforced social accountability and mutual support, creating social capital that extends beyond financial transactions. By targeting marginalised groups, including Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, these institutions promote social inclusion and reduce vulnerability, aligning with the broader objectives of inclusive rural development.

Challenges and Limitations

Despite their successes, SHGs and MFIs face multiple challenges. Over-indebtedness emerged as a critical issue during the 2010 microfinance crisis in Andhra Pradesh, when aggressive lending led to repayment defaults and social unrest. High-interest rates, though lower than informal moneylenders, remain a concern for some MFIs. Inadequate financial literacy among members can result in misuse of credit or inability

	to manage repayments effectively. Operational challenges, such as delays in bank linkage, insufficient monitoring, and a lack of technological integration, limit efficiency. Moreover, political interventions sometimes disrupt credit flow, as seen during state-level policy shifts impacting SHG-bank linkages. Addressing these challenges is essential to sustaining the positive impact of SHGs and MFIs. **Government and Institutional Support** The government and regulatory bodies have played a crucial role in supporting SHGs and MFIs. NABARD, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), and state programs provide credit guarantees, training, and capacity-building support. Andhra Pradesh's Indira Kranthi Patham is one of the largest and most comprehensive SHG programs in India, covering over 60 lakh women members, with direct links to banks for revolving credit. Post-2010, regulatory reforms introduced by RBI, including interest rate caps, client protection guidelines, and transparent reporting requirements, have strengthened the sector and restored public confidence. Collaborative partnerships between SHGs, MFIs, NGOs, and government institutions have also enhanced outreach, accountability, and sustainability.
Conclusion	Self-Help Groups and Microfinance Institutions have transformed the landscape of rural credit in Andhra Pradesh by making finance accessible, affordable, and socially empowering. SHGs have mobilised savings, strengthened community bonds, and enabled women to play a central role in rural economic activities, while MFIs have filled gaps where formal banking remains absent. Together, they have reduced dependence on moneylenders, promoted entrepreneurship, and contributed to poverty alleviation. However, challenges like over-indebtedness, operational inefficiencies, and regulatory pressures require careful management. The Andhra Pradesh experience demonstrates that with robust institutional support, financial literacy, and participatory mechanisms, SHGs and MFIs can continue to play a pivotal role in meeting rural credit needs, promoting social inclusion, and fostering sustainable rural development. As it has been emphasised, "Microfinance is not just a loan; it is a tool to empower the poor and reduce inequality," reflecting the transformative potential of SHGs and MFIs in the state.
Model Question	Assess how Self-Help Groups (SHGs) and Microfinance Institutions (MFIs) have contributed to enhancing financial inclusion and reducing rural indebtedness in Andhra Pradesh.
Value Addition	Indira Kranthi Patham Programme was launched in 2005 by the Government of Andhra Pradesh to reduce poverty and promote rural development. It is a poverty alleviation and rural development programme in Andhra Pradesh, India. It includes several components, such as microfinance, watershed development, and skill development.
31. "Primary education is the foundation for empowerment of Children". Discuss the impact on the democratic rights of the children and discrimination between rich and poor children, in light of heavy commercialization of primary education? (APPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Introduce by highlighting the constitutional and moral basis of primary education, Articles 21A, 45, and the RTE Act (2009) and its role in nurturing democratic values and equality. • Explain how early education builds cognitive skills, emotional intelligence, and civic awareness essential for democratic participation and nation-building. • Define commercialization, trace its rise due to privatization, urbanization, and policy shifts, and show how it transforms education from a right to a purchasable commodity.

	• Analyze how profit-driven schooling undermines equality, participation, and inclusivity, violating the spirit of the Constitution and the RTE framework. • Discuss widening educational disparities, rural-urban divides, and intergenerational inequality resulting from unequal access to quality education. • Integrate recent initiatives such as NIPUN Bharat, PM eVIDYA, Samagra Shiksha 2.0, and Vidya Samiksha Kendras aimed at restoring equity, inclusion, and public accountability. • Conclude by reaffirming education as a public good aligned with SDG 4 (Quality Education) and India's vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.
Introduction	Primary education forms the bedrock of a child's intellectual, emotional, and moral development. It is during these formative years that children first experience the values of equality, justice, cooperation, and participation, ideals that give life to India's democratic Constitution. The Right to Education (RTE) Act, 2009, grounded in Articles 21A and 45, affirms free and compulsory education as a fundamental right essential for human dignity and empowerment. Similarly, the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 underscores foundational learning as the cornerstone of lifelong growth and citizenship. Yet, over recent decades, the increasing commercialization of primary education has gradually transformed this constitutional guarantee into a market commodity. Schools driven by profit motives often equate quality with affordability, making meaningful learning a privilege of the few. This shift not only weakens the democratic rights of children but also entrenches inequality, eroding the inclusive and egalitarian spirit envisioned by the Constitution.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Primary Education and the Democratic Spirit** Primary education is not merely about literacy; it is a formative space where children learn to question, reason, and participate, all vital to citizenship. As per NCERT and UNESCO reports, foundational learning ensures critical thinking, empathy, and civic responsibility. Schools thus serve as miniature democracies, teaching equality in daily practice. Yet, the shift toward profit-oriented schooling, where education is treated as a market good, erodes this spirit. Elite schools cultivate confidence, leadership, and exposure, while poor children in underfunded government schools struggle with infrastructural gaps, absentee teachers, and inadequate materials. This divergence creates unequal democratic capability: only a few grow up equipped to engage meaningfully in civic life. **Commercialization and Inequality: A Growing Divide** The Unified District Information System for Education Plus (UDISE+) 2024-25 data from the Ministry of Education reveal a rising share of enrolment in private unaided schools, particularly in urban and semi-urban areas. Many parents, disillusioned with government schools, turn to private institutions even at unsustainable cost. The result is an education market stratified by income. Commercialization generates "educational enclaves", islands of privilege surrounded by oceans of deprivation. Rich children study in resource-rich schools with advanced pedagogy, digital tools, and extracurricular exposure; poor children often remain in classrooms lacking basic amenities. Such segregation deprives society of shared spaces where children from diverse backgrounds interact, weakening social cohesion. "Education that separates children by class fractures the democratic fabric of the nation." **Impact on Democratic Rights of Children** The commercialization of primary education undermines two pillars of democracy, equality and participation. When schooling becomes a commodity, access is no longer

universal; it becomes conditional on affordability. Children from low-income groups are systematically excluded from the best learning environments. This exclusion translates into limited life choices, poor self-confidence, and constrained civic engagement.

Furthermore, privatized models prioritize consumer satisfaction and brand value over inclusion. The RTE Act's provision of 25% reservation for disadvantaged children in private schools is poorly enforced. Many institutions resist or stigmatize such admissions, as highlighted by NITI Aayog. Consequently, the constitutional vision of equal educational opportunity remains unrealized in practice.

Recent Government Initiatives to Restore Equity

Recognizing the challenges posed by commercialization and inequality, the Government of India has launched several initiatives to rebuild inclusivity and strengthen public primary education. Guided by the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, these reforms aim to ensure that every child, regardless of socio-economic background, has access to foundational literacy, digital tools, and equitable learning opportunities.

A key intervention is the NIPUN Bharat Mission (2021), the *National Initiative for Proficiency in Reading with Understanding and Numeracy*, which seeks to achieve foundational literacy and numeracy by Grade 3. Implemented through Samagra Shiksha, it emphasizes competency-based learning and teacher training under NISHTHA-FLN. The mission promotes participatory and outcome-oriented learning, ensuring that education remains child-centric and inclusive.

To bridge the digital divide, the government launched PM eVIDYA, offering multi-modal access to quality content through television (*One Class, One Channel*), radio, podcasts, and the DIKSHA platform. The upgraded DIKSHA 2.0 integrates AI-based tools, multilingual content, and sign-language options, while the Bal Vatika PM eVIDYA channel provides early learning content for children aged 3–6 years.

The revamped Samagra Shiksha 2.0 integrates school education from pre-primary to secondary levels, emphasizing inclusive infrastructure and real-time learning assessments. Vidya Samiksha Kendras (VSKs) track student progress and outcomes, enabling data-driven decision-making and accountability. State-led programmes like Odisha's *CAMaL Ka Camp* and Delhi's *Mission Buniyaad* further strengthen foundational learning through localized, community-based approaches. The Union Budget 2025–26 reinforced these commitments by increasing funding for Samagra Shiksha, supporting digital learning in underserved regions, and expanding PM–SHRI Schools (Prime Minister's Schools for Rising India), model institutions setting benchmarks in quality, pedagogy, and inclusivity.

Socio-Economic and Psychological Implications

Commercialization shapes how children perceive themselves and others. In elite schools, many develop a sense of competition and privilege, while those in under-resourced institutions often feel excluded and inferior. This segregation fosters class consciousness early, weakening empathy and shared citizenship, the very foundation of democracy. The rural-urban divide worsens these inequalities, as private schools cluster in cities, leaving rural children reliant on uneven public schooling. Girls from marginalized communities face the harshest impact; rising costs and poor access push many out of classrooms. Such exclusion not only limits their empowerment but also deepens social and gender inequalities, betraying the promise of universal education.

The Way Forward: Reclaiming Education as a Public Good

The road to *Viksit Bharat 2047* must pass through equitable classrooms. To re-establish education's democratic purpose, public investment must increase toward NEP's 6%

	GDP target. Government schools should be modernized with adequate teachers, inclusive curricula, and safe infrastructure. Strengthened School Management Committees (SMCs) can enable community participation in governance. Private schools, meanwhile, require stronger regulation such as transparent fee policies, inclusive admission, and accountability for learning outcomes. Public-private partnerships should align with social objectives rather than profit motives. Initiatives like NIPUN Bharat, PM eVIDYA, and Samagra Shiksha need sustained financing and periodic independent evaluations to ensure they reach the most disadvantaged learners.
Conclusion	Primary education is not merely a stage of schooling but the moral foundation of democracy. It is where children first learn equality, empathy, and citizenship, values enshrined in the Preamble of the Constitution. Yet, the commercialization of education turns a collective right into a private privilege, fragmenting classrooms and excluding millions. This inequity undermines SDG 4 on quality education and weakens SDG 10 on reducing inequalities. As India aspires for Viksit Bharat 2047, restoring education's public character is essential. Strengthening government schools, regulating private institutions, and ensuring universal foundational learning can reassert education as a public good. Only through equitable access and shared learning can education truly empower every child, foster social cohesion, and uphold the democratic spirit envisioned by the Constitution.
Model Question	"The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 aims to transform India's education system to make it more holistic, flexible, multidisciplinary, and aligned with the needs of the 21st century. Critically examine how NEP 2020 balances access, equity, and quality in education, while addressing the challenges of implementation across diverse socio-economic contexts."
Value Addition	**PM SHRI Schools:** • The centrally sponsored PM SHRI (PM Schools for Rising India) scheme was approved by Cabinet on 7 September, 2022. Under the scheme there is provision of setting up of more than 14500 PM SHRI Schools by strengthening the existing schools from amongst schools managed by Central government/State/UT Government/local bodies. PM SHRI schools showcase the implementation of the National Education Policy 2020 and emerge as exemplar schools over a period of time, and also offer leadership to other schools in the neighbourhood. The total cost of the project will be Rs.27360 crore spread over a period of 5 years which includes central share of Rs.18128 crore.

32. Urbanisation can create more opportunities and can erase social hierarchies. However, a massive shift towards cities could create significant challenges for policymakers and administrators. What are these challenges, and what are your suggestions to address these challenges? (TGPSC, 2016)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	What
Approach	• Start with the definition of urbanisation and its transformative potential in India. • Highlight positives: job creation, social mobility, weakening of caste barriers. • Mention rapid urbanisation trends. • Discuss challenges: infrastructure deficit, housing shortage, slums, pollution. • Bring in governance issues: migration, inequality, waste management, urban crime. • Suggest solutions: smart cities, inclusive planning, affordable housing, decentralisation. • Mention need for "balanced regional development" to reduce rural-urban pressure. • Conclude with the Gandhian ideal of sustainable villages coexisting with vibrant cities.

Introduction	Urbanisation has emerged as one of the most transformative socio-economic processes of the twenty-first century. In India, it is often described as both a driver of economic growth and a force capable of erasing entrenched social hierarchies. Cities offer opportunities for employment, education, innovation, and social mobility. As the World Bank report projects, nearly 40% of India's population will live in urban areas by 2036, compared to 31% in 2011. However, this rapid migration towards cities also creates formidable challenges for policymakers and administrators. Striking a balance between reaping the benefits of urbanisation and addressing its complex problems is central to sustainable governance.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Urbanisation as a Driver of Opportunities and Equality** Cities act as engines of economic growth. According to the World Bank, Indian cities contribute nearly 63% to the national GDP, a figure expected to rise to 75% by 2030. The agglomeration of industries, services, and knowledge economies fosters innovation and entrepreneurship. For many rural migrants, cities provide escape from agrarian distress, limited job opportunities, and rigid caste hierarchies. In metropolitan spaces, merit and skills often outweigh caste, class, or gender identity, creating the possibility of social mobility. The rise of middle-class migrants in cities such as Hyderabad, Bengaluru, and Pune demonstrates how urban spaces weaken traditional hierarchies. Urban centres also offer better access to healthcare, education, and infrastructure, which improves human development indicators. Thus, urbanisation can potentially transform India's socio-economic landscape. **The Emerging Challenges of Rapid Urban Growth** Yet, the unregulated and massive move towards cities creates daunting challenges. One of the most visible problems is the growth of slums and informal settlements. According to the Census of India (2011), over 65 million people lived in slums, lacking adequate housing, sanitation, and drinking water. The Dharavi slum in Mumbai symbolises both resilience and neglect, where entrepreneurial activities thrive amidst abysmal living conditions. Housing shortages and rising land prices push vulnerable populations into unsafe and congested environments, perpetuating urban poverty. Urban infrastructure is another serious concern. Municipal bodies struggle to provide basic services such as drinking water, sewage treatment, waste disposal, and electricity. The Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) report 2021 stated that sewage generation from urban areas in the country is estimated at 72,368 million litres per day (MLD), against which sewage treatment capacity of 31,841 MLD was available. Congestion and traffic snarls in cities like Hyderabad and Delhi reduce productivity and cause severe health problems due to vehicular emissions. In the 2024 World Air Quality Report, India was ranked as the fifth most polluted country in the world, indicating the environmental cost of unchecked urbanisation. Migration also generates social tensions. Cities witness competition for limited jobs, housing, and public services, sometimes resulting in xenophobia and violence against migrant communities. The 2008 violence against North Indian migrants in Mumbai is a grim reminder of how urban migration can strain social harmony. Rising urban crime, including theft, sexual harassment, and organised crime, further complicates governance. **Institutional and Governance Challenges** Urbanisation has exposed the weaknesses of India's governance structures. Most urban local bodies lack financial autonomy, administrative capacity, and adequate manpower to manage expanding populations. While the 74th Constitutional Amendment mandated decentralisation, in practice, municipal bodies remain

dependent on state governments for funds and decision-making powers. For example, the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation struggles with insufficient revenue, leading to poor waste management and flooding during monsoons.

The Smart Cities Mission and AMRUT (Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation) were launched to modernise urban governance, but their implementation has been uneven. According to a 2022 report by NITI Aayog, many smart city projects are delayed due to land acquisition hurdles, weak planning, and lack of integration with local needs. Moreover, rapid urbanisation poses federal challenges, as water resources, transport networks, and pollution often cut across state boundaries, requiring coordinated governance mechanisms.

Social Inequality and Urban Exclusion

While cities promise equality, urbanisation often reproduces inequality in new forms. Informal sector workers, who constitute nearly 80% of India's urban workforce, lack social security, healthcare, and stable incomes. Migrants, street vendors, domestic workers, and construction labourers are among the most vulnerable, as seen during the COVID-19 lockdown of 2020, when millions of migrant workers were left stranded without shelter, food, or transport. This humanitarian crisis highlighted the fragility of urban inclusion. Women and marginalised groups also face disproportionate challenges in urban spaces. Safety concerns, inadequate public transport, and lack of affordable housing prevent women from fully benefiting from urbanisation.

Environmental and Sustainability Concerns

Unchecked urbanisation has severe ecological consequences. The conversion of wetlands, lakes, and forests into urban spaces intensifies flooding, water scarcity, and heat island effects. The Chennai floods in 2015 and Bengaluru floods in 2022 were aggravated by unregulated urban expansion over natural drainage systems. Urban water stress is alarming. NITI Aayog's Composite Water Management Index (2018) predicted that 21 Indian cities, including Hyderabad, Bengaluru, and Delhi, could face zero groundwater levels by 2020. Climate change further amplifies these vulnerabilities, making cities hotspots of environmental and health risks.

Suggestions for Addressing Urbanisation Challenges

Addressing the urbanisation challenge requires a multi-pronged approach rooted in sustainability, inclusivity, and good governance. First, balanced regional development is essential to reduce the excessive pressure on mega cities. Strengthening rural infrastructure, promoting small towns, and developing economic corridors can ensure equitable growth. Second, affordable housing policies such as the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY) must be scaled up with a focus on slum redevelopment and rental housing. Third, urban planning must integrate ecological principles, protecting wetlands, green belts, and traditional water systems.

Improving governance is critical. Empowering municipal bodies with financial independence, skilled manpower, and technology-driven solutions will enhance service delivery. Cities like Indore, which topped the Swachh Survekshan rankings, demonstrate the potential of effective waste management when governance is participatory and accountable. Public transport infrastructure, such as metro rail networks, must be expanded to reduce congestion and emissions, while non-motorised transport like cycling should be promoted.

Social inclusion requires targeted measures for vulnerable groups. Strengthening labour rights, providing social security for informal workers, and creating safe urban spaces for women are crucial steps. Urbanisation must be aligned with the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly Goal 11, which calls for making cities inclusive, safe, resilient, and sustainable.

Conclusion	Urbanisation in India represents both an opportunity and a challenge. It has the power to create new livelihoods, weaken age-old hierarchies, and transform the nation into a global economic power. Yet, without careful planning, it can deepen inequality, degrade the environment, and overwhelm governance structures. As Mahatma Gandhi once remarked, "The future of India lies in its villages." Yet in the twenty-first century, it is equally true that the future of India lies in its cities. Policymakers must therefore embrace a vision of sustainable, inclusive, and resilient urban development, where opportunities are maximised, hierarchies are erased, and challenges are effectively managed.
Model Question	Rapid metropolitan growth has the potential to drive economic development, but it also generates urban governance challenges. Critically examine the issues and suggest measures for sustainable urban management.
Value Addition	**Central Pollution Control Board:** • It is a statutory organisation constituted in September 1974, under the Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1974. • Further, CPCB was entrusted with the powers and functions under the Air (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1981. • It serves as a field formation and also provides technical services to the Ministry of Environment and Forests under the provisions of the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986.
33. Write an essay on the crisis in agriculture and farmers suicides in India. (APPSC, 2012)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Write
Approach	• Begin by describing the paradox of Indian agriculture employing over 45% of the population yet contributing less than 18% to GDP. • Highlight stagnating productivity, rising input costs, erratic monsoons, and low profitability leading to deep agrarian distress. • Explain indebtedness, dependence on informal credit, market volatility, and poor price realisation due to weak MSP coverage. • Discuss gaps in irrigation, extension services, insurance, procurement, and land fragmentation, which worsen farmers' vulnerability. • Mention isolation, loss of dignity, and mental stress driving farmers toward suicides, especially in Maharashtra, Telangana, and Punjab. • Refer to schemes like PM-KISAN, PMFBY, e-NAM, Soil Health Cards, and the need for effective debt relief and MSP reforms. • Suggest structural reforms: diversification, irrigation investment, agro-processing, cooperative credit, and mental health support. • Conclude that addressing the agrarian crisis demands a humane, multi-dimensional approach ensuring economic security and social dignity for farmers.
Introduction	Agriculture has long been the backbone of India's economy, sustaining nearly 45% of the population while contributing around 17% to the national GDP as per the Economic Survey 2023–24. Despite this centrality, Indian agriculture faces a profound structural and livelihood crisis. The recurring phenomenon of farmers' suicides, first widely reported in the mid-1990s, has since become a tragic and persistent symbol of agrarian distress. As per the NCRB's 2023 report, over 10,700 farmer suicides took place, reflecting a grim reflection of systemic failures in policy, credit, and market structures. The crisis in agriculture is, therefore, not merely an economic issue but also a social, institutional, and moral challenge confronting India's development model.
	Nature and Dimensions of the Agrarian Crisis

Body & Infographic Representation	The agrarian crisis in India is multi-dimensional, encompassing economic stagnation, ecological degradation, technological exhaustion, and policy neglect. Since the 1990s, the shift towards market-oriented reforms and reduced public investment in agriculture has led to widening income disparities between rural and urban India. The Department of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare, in its Annual Report for 2018–19, notes that the real Gross Value Added (GVA) of the agriculture and allied sector registered a growth of 5.0% in 2017–18, which was below the 6–7% growth target envisaged by the Doubling Farmers' Income Report (2017). Farmers face declining terms of trade, rising input costs, poor access to irrigation, and volatile prices, pushing many into chronic indebtedness. This structural stagnation has made small and marginal farmers, who constitute over 86% of India's farming households, highly vulnerable to even minor climatic or market shocks. **Economic and Financial Dimensions** Economic distress remains the most visible face of India's agricultural crisis. Input costs, such as seeds, fertilisers, electricity, and pesticides, have risen sharply, while output prices have failed to keep pace. In the absence of assured procurement, farmers are forced to sell below MSP in local markets. Indebtedness is another critical factor driving agrarian distress. A significant portion of the debt is owed to informal moneylenders, especially in states like Maharashtra, Telangana, and Karnataka, where suicides are concentrated. The lack of accessible, low-interest institutional credit traps farmers in cycles of borrowing and distress, often culminating in despair and suicide. **Environmental and Climatic Factors** Agriculture in India continues to be heavily monsoon-dependent, with most of the gross cropped area under irrigation. Erratic rainfall, recurrent droughts, and extreme weather events linked to climate change have intensified farmers' vulnerabilities. Frequent droughts in Maharashtra's Vidarbha region, combined with water-intensive cash crops like cotton and sugarcane, have created a deadly combination of ecological unsustainability and financial debt. Moreover, excessive use of chemical fertilisers and depletion of groundwater have degraded soil fertility, locking farmers into a low-productivity trap. **Institutional and Policy Failures** The agrarian crisis is also rooted in institutional weaknesses and policy inconsistencies. Public investment in agriculture has declined from 18% of total plan outlay in the 1980s to below 6% today. Agricultural research, extension services, and marketing infrastructure remain grossly inadequate. The failure to reform the Agricultural Produce Market Committee (APMC) system has left farmers at the mercy of middlemen, while smallholders lack bargaining power in both input and output markets. The 2016 demonetization, coupled with GST implementation, disrupted rural cash flows and input purchases, aggravating rural distress. Similarly, the three Farm Laws (2020), though later repealed, revealed deep mistrust between farmers and the state. While the government has introduced welfare schemes such as PM-KISAN, Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY), and Soil Health Card Scheme, the implementation gaps, delayed compensation, and limited coverage have diluted their impact. **Socio-Psychological and Human Dimensions** Beyond economics, the agrarian crisis has severe psychological and social dimensions. The erosion of dignity, increasing social isolation, and cultural pressure to repay debts have created a mental health emergency in rural India. Studies by the Tata Institute of

	Social Sciences (TISS) and ICSSR indicate that most suicide cases are associated with debt, crop failure, and lack of institutional support. The gender dimension is equally significant; widows of farmers often face social stigma, exclusion from compensation, and a lack of livelihood opportunities. As M.S. Swaminathan poignantly remarked, "If agriculture goes wrong, nothing else will go right in the country." This underscores the moral urgency of addressing the human suffering behind the statistics of farmer suicides. **Regional Dimensions and Case Studies** Certain regions like Vidarbha (Maharashtra), Telangana, Rayalaseema (Andhra Pradesh), and northern Karnataka have become epicentres of agrarian distress. The Indira Gandhi Institute of Development Research (IGIDR) study showed that over 70% of farmer suicides occurred in five states: Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, and Chhattisgarh. Common patterns include monocropping, dependence on rain-fed agriculture, lack of institutional credit, and high-cost cultivation of commercial crops like cotton. In contrast, states with robust cooperative structures, such as Kerala's Kudumbashree and Punjab's cooperative credit societies, have shown relatively fewer suicides, reflecting the importance of institutional resilience. **Government Initiatives and Policy Responses** Over the years, multiple committees, including the Swaminathan Commission (2006), have suggested measures to ensure remunerative prices (C2 + 50%), strengthen cooperative credit, and invest in rural infrastructure. The PM-KISAN Yojana (2019) provides direct income support of ₹6,000 annually to small farmers, while PMFBY aims to offer risk coverage against crop loss. The e-NAM initiative seeks to create a unified national market for agricultural produce. However, the effectiveness of these programs remains limited due to poor implementation, inadequate awareness, and bureaucratic hurdles. Experts argue that piecemeal subsidies or loan waivers are insufficient; structural reforms ensuring sustainable income, diversification, and climate resilience are imperative. **Way Forward: Towards a Sustainable Agrarian Future** Addressing India's agrarian crisis requires a multi-dimensional strategy rooted in inclusivity, sustainability, and dignity. First, there is a need to restructure agricultural credit systems to prioritise smallholders through cooperative and self-help models. Second, diversification towards horticulture, dairy, and agro-processing can stabilise incomes. Third, climate-resilient practices, watershed management, and investment in micro-irrigation must become central to agricultural policy. Fourth, institutional reforms in MSP, procurement, and rural marketing can enhance price realisation. Lastly, mental health support and social safety nets should form part of a humane rural welfare policy. As Amartya Sen observed, "Development is freedom", and for India's farmers, true freedom will come only when agriculture becomes both viable and dignified.
Conclusion	The crisis in Indian agriculture and the tragedy of farmers' suicides are not isolated events but the cumulative outcome of decades of structural neglect, policy incoherence, and ecological degradation. While India has achieved food security, it has failed to secure the lives and livelihoods of those who produce that food. Sustainable solutions lie not merely in economic relief but in restoring farmers' faith in the system — through fair prices, equitable policies, and social justice. Revitalizing agriculture, therefore, is not only an economic necessity but also a moral imperative for India's inclusive development.
Model Question	Critically analyse the structural factors responsible for the agrarian distress and increasing farmers' suicides in India.

Value Addition	**Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY):** PMFBY is a crop insurance scheme aimed at providing financial support to farmers in the event of crop failure, helping to reduce the economic burden on them. It aims to provide farmers with a simple, affordable, and comprehensive crop insurance solution. The scheme protects farmers from crop losses caused by non-preventable natural risks like droughts, floods, cyclones, hailstorms, pest attacks, and plant diseases. PMFBY covers the entire crop cycle, from pre-sowing to post-harvest, including damage during storage if caused by a notified calamity. It offers timely financial support, helping farmers manage risks and avoid falling into debt. PMFBY follows the principle of "One Nation, One Crop, One Premium", ensuring uniformity and fairness in premium rates across the country. By reducing the financial risks of farming, PMFBY encourages farmers to invest in better seeds, improved technology, and sustainable farming practices, helping them build a more secure future.
34. With Portugal, Greece, Italy and Spain staring at a bleak future, the world economic situation can be considered to be in a dire state. With developing economies being highly dependent on their developed counterparts for investments, there will be an effect on stock markets, employment and balance of payments. State your reasons whether or not the developing world will be affected. (APPSC, 2011)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Approach	• Introduce with European Union's global economic role and vulnerabilities of Portugal, Greece, Italy, and Spain. • Define the possible nature of the crisis - debt, stagnation, or financial turmoil, and why it matters globally. • Analyze transmission channels: trade slowdown, capital flows, stock markets, FDI, remittances, and tourism. • Assess impacts on developing economies: employment, balance of payments, debt sustainability, and poverty. • Highlight differential impacts - resilient vs. vulnerable developing countries. • Suggest national strategies (reserves, diversification) and multilateral responses (IMF, WTO, World Bank support). • Conclude with a forward-looking note on interdependence and building economic resilience.
Introduction	The European Union (EU) remains one of the most significant economic blocs in the world, accounting for nearly one-sixth of global GDP and trade and by purchasing-power parity the EU's share is about 14.1% of world GDP. Within the bloc, Portugal, Greece, Italy and Spain, the "southern periphery" carry outsized vulnerabilities because of high sovereign debt burdens, weak productivity growth and episodic banking fragilities; recent IMF surveillance for the euro area stresses that growth is likely to remain moderate in 2025–27 and flags the region's fiscal and financial risks. If these economies slip into protracted stagnation or financial distress, knock-on effects on developing countries will be transmitted through several measurable channels: a fall in EU import demand that dents export earnings (WTO and UNCTAD point to an ongoing global trade slowdown that disproportionately hits low-income exporters), tighter cross-border bank and portfolio flows that raise borrowing costs in emerging markets (World Bank Global Economic Prospects warns of financial tightening and higher debt-service pressures), and drops in tourism and remittances that hit household incomes in many developing economies.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Will developing economies be affected if Portugal, Greece, Italy and Spain stare at a bleak future?** **The European Slowdown: Nature of the Shock**

Economic stagnation in Portugal, Greece, Italy and Spain can take different forms: low domestic demand, high fiscal deficits, sovereign debt distress, or political instability leading to investor uncertainty. A mild growth slowdown will primarily hurt trade and investment, while a severe financial crisis could spill over globally through capital markets and banking channels. The IMF's 2025 Euro Area Consultation highlights how uneven growth and fiscal fragility in southern Europe pose systemic risks to global markets. The European Commission's 2025 spring forecast also signals that high debt in Italy and weak competitiveness in Greece and Portugal could prolong stagnation, raising the risk of contagion.

Trade Linkages: Declining Exports from Developing Countries

The EU is one of the largest destinations for exports from developing countries, particularly in Africa, Asia and Latin America. Southern Europe imports agricultural commodities, textiles, intermediate goods and energy. A slowdown would reduce this demand, hitting export revenues in developing economies. WTO's *World Trade Report 2024* and UNCTAD's *Trade and Development Report* note that falling advanced economy demand has already contributed to a global trade slowdown. For countries heavily reliant on the EU, such as Morocco (agri-exports), Bangladesh (garments), and sub-Saharan states (commodities), reduced European consumption would directly affect employment, government revenues, and current account balances.

Tourism is another trade-related link. Greece, Spain and Italy are major tourist destinations; reduced outbound tourism from these countries would hurt developing economies in North Africa, the Middle East and Asia that depend on European tourists for foreign exchange.

Financial Contagion: Capital Flows and Banking Stress

Perhaps the most powerful transmission channel is finance. European banks are significant lenders to emerging markets; weakness in their balance sheets reduces cross-border credit. During the 2010–12 Eurozone debt crisis, countries from India to Brazil experienced currency volatility, rising bond yields, and equity outflows. If southern Europe faces renewed banking stress, investors will shift away from riskier assets, pulling money out of developing markets.

The World Bank's *Global Economic Prospects 2025* warns that financial tightening in advanced economies can trigger sudden stops in capital inflows to developing countries. For nations with high external debt such as Sri Lanka, Ghana or Zambia this would raise default risks. Even relatively stable economies like India could see stock market corrections and rupee volatility if global risk sentiment worsens.

Foreign Direct Investment and Employment Impacts

European nations are important sources of foreign direct investment (FDI) in infrastructure, manufacturing and services across Asia and Africa. A downturn in Portugal, Greece, Italy and Spain would reduce outward investment, particularly in energy, construction, and tourism projects. World Bank data shows that global FDI flows contract sharply whenever advanced economies stagnate.

Employment in developing countries tied to European FDI would also be at risk. For instance, Italian companies have invested in Indian manufacturing clusters, while Spanish firms are active in Latin American energy projects. A freeze or withdrawal of such investment directly affects jobs and local growth.

Remittances: A Socially Sensitive Channel

Millions of migrant workers from North Africa, South Asia and Latin America live in southern Europe. Spain and Italy alone host large numbers of migrant labourers from Morocco, Bangladesh, Egypt and the Philippines. A slowdown in these host economies

	can lead to job losses, wage stagnation, and stricter immigration policies, thereby reducing remittance inflows. Since remittances form a vital part of GDP for countries like Nepal, Morocco, and the Philippines, such reductions could push households into poverty and undermine consumption-driven growth. Various reports have highlighted how remittances act as countercyclical stabilizers for developing nations. Their contraction would have disproportionate social impacts, particularly on health, education and food security. **Balance of Payments and Debt Sustainability** Developing economies often depend on export revenues, remittances and FDI inflows to manage their balance of payments. A European crisis that undermines all three simultaneously would lead to widening current account deficits, pressure on foreign exchange reserves, and higher external borrowing costs. According to the World Bank, developing countries are already facing record debt servicing burdens in 2025, with interest payments crowding out social spending. Any new shock could push several low-income countries into debt distress, triggering requests for IMF bailouts. The contagion is not only economic but political. Prolonged fiscal stress can fuel social unrest, populist policies, and instability in developing democracies, as seen after the 2012 Euro crisis. **Differential Impact Across Developing Countries** The impact will not be uniform. Economies closely integrated with Europe, such as North African states, Eastern European non-EU members, and Latin American nations with strong Spanish and Italian ties, will be most affected. Asian economies with diversified trade partners, like India and Vietnam, will be relatively insulated but still vulnerable to capital flow reversals. Commodity exporters will suffer if reduced European demand depresses global prices for oil, metals and agricultural products. Countries with large foreign exchange reserves and stable macroeconomic policies (Eg: India, Indonesia) can withstand the storm better than those with weak fiscal positions (Eg: Pakistan, Ghana). Thus, the degree of exposure and resilience determines the extent of damage. **Policy Responses: National and Multilateral** Developing countries must strengthen macroeconomic buffers: maintaining adequate reserves, managing debt prudently, and diversifying export markets. Strengthening domestic capital markets can reduce dependence on volatile foreign flows. On the multilateral front, institutions like the IMF and World Bank must be prepared to offer precautionary credit lines and debt restructuring facilities. The WTO and UNCTAD warn against protectionism and call for preserving open trade regimes to prevent a downward spiral. Coordinated international action, akin to the G20's collective measures during the 2008 global financial crisis, will be crucial to safeguard developing economies against spillovers.
Conclusion	The bleak economic outlook for Portugal, Greece, Italy and Spain cannot be dismissed as a regional problem. In today's integrated world, developing economies will indeed be affected, through lower exports, weaker remittances, declining FDI, and financial contagion. The severity of the impact depends on the depth of the European crisis and the resilience of individual developing economies. While some countries may absorb the shock with stronger reserves and diversified markets, vulnerable economies with high debt and weak buffers face serious risks of instability. The lesson is clear: global economic interdependence means that crises in one corner can reverberate across continents. Building resilience at the national level, coupled with robust international cooperation, remains the best safeguard for the developing world in uncertain times.

Model Question	"In the present context of rising global conflicts, from the Russia - Ukraine war to West Asia tensions and the Indo-Pacific rivalry, critically analyse their implications on global economic stability, energy security, and the prospects for developing nations. Suggest policy measures at both national and multilateral levels to mitigate these challenges."
Value Addition	**IMF Global Economic Outlook:** • The International Monetary Fund (IMF) has revised its forecast for India's economic growth to 6.4 percent for both 2025 and 2026. Earlier in its April 2025 World Economic Outlook, IMF had projected India's GDP growth at 6.2 percent for 2025 and 6.3 percent for 2026. • Reaffirming India's position as the world's fastest-growing major economy, IMF attributed the upward revision to a more benign external environment than anticipated in its April forecast. For India, projections are based on the calendar year, with the agency noting that India's growth projections are 6.7 percent for 2025 and 6.4 percent for 2026 based on financial year data. • The IMF has also modestly raised its global growth outlook to 3.0 percent in 2025 and 3.1 percent in 2026, citing lower-than-expected impact from tariffs, a weaker US dollar, and improved financial conditions. China is forecast to grow at 4.8 percent in 2025 and 4.2 percent in 2026, while the US is expected to expand 1.9 percent in 2025 and 2.0 percent in 2026.

35. The concept of development is pushed down from the top by the MNCs bypassing nation states. This misplaced conception of development is not totally favoured by the states and the people in the developing world for socio-economic and political reasons. Is there a way to integrate or combine the two different conceptions of development of the free market and the individual state? (APPSC, 2011)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Is there a way
Approach	• Define the competing conceptions of development: MNC-led globalisation vs. state-led welfare-driven development. • Highlight how MNCs promote FDI, technology transfer, and free-market integration. • Explain state concerns like sovereignty, socio-cultural disruption, inequality, and dependency. • Mention Developing World Resistance and Cite examples (Latin America's dependency theory, India's SEZ protests, African resource exploitation). • Stress Integration Approach, such as suggesting "regulated globalisation" like balancing free-market forces with strong state policy. • Mention Examples like India's calibrated liberalisation post-1991; China's state-led market economy; Brazil's developmental state. • State Challenges such as WTO pressures, digital monopolies, climate-linked development vs. national interests. • Conclude in a way by arguing for a hybrid model: state-guided markets ensuring equity, while leveraging MNC capital for growth.
Introduction	Development in the contemporary world is no longer defined merely as economic growth but as a comprehensive process encompassing social justice, political sovereignty, and cultural integrity. With the onset of globalisation, multinational corporations (MNCs) have emerged as powerful actors shaping development trajectories. Their top-down approach pushes the concept of development largely through the lens of the free market, foreign direct investment, and global capital flows, often bypassing the authority of nation states. However, this misplaced conception of development is not totally favoured by states and peoples in the developing world due

	to socio-economic disparities, cultural dislocations, and political concerns. The pressing question, therefore, is whether it is possible to integrate or combine the two competing conceptions of development: the free market driven by MNCs and the sovereign development model of the individual state.
Body & Infographic Representation	**MNC-Led Development and Its Characteristics** MNCs are seen as engines of globalisation, promoting trade liberalisation, financial integration, and technological advancement. They embody the free market conception of development by creating global supply chains, generating foreign investment, and transferring advanced skills and technologies. For instance, India's IT sector has benefited immensely from collaborations with multinational firms such as Microsoft, IBM, and Accenture, which have created millions of jobs and enhanced service exports. Similarly, automobile giants such as Hyundai in Chennai and Suzuki in Gurugram have integrated India into their global production networks. Statistical evidence shows that in 2024–25, India attracted nearly USD 81.04 billion in gross FDI inflows, a significant portion of which was from MNCs seeking to capitalise on the country's market potential. From the perspective of neoliberal economics, this reflects efficiency, competitiveness, and opportunities for growth. **The Limits of the Free Market Approach to Development** Yet, the MNC-driven conception of development remains inadequate, particularly for the developing world. The free market focuses on profit maximisation rather than inclusive growth, thereby creating inequalities. Dependency theorists like Andre Gunder Frank have argued that such development reinforces the "centre–periphery" divide, keeping developing nations structurally dependent on advanced economies. The socio-economic reasons for resistance are visible in rising income gaps, rural distress, and displacement caused by large projects. Politically, MNCs bypass nation-states through lobbying and investor-state dispute settlement mechanisms under trade agreements, undermining sovereignty. For example, in many African nations, extractive industries dominated by foreign corporations have led to resource exploitation without translating into substantial welfare benefits for local populations. In India too, protests against Special Economic Zones (SEZs) in Nandigram and Singur highlighted how people perceive MNC-led projects as a threat to land, livelihoods, and cultural identity. **Nation-State Conception of Development** In contrast to the free market vision, the nation state conceives development as a sovereign project rooted in national priorities, welfare commitments, and political legitimacy. States in the developing world often view development not only as GDP growth but as the expansion of human capabilities, as articulated by Amartya Sen. Post-independence India provides a classical example where the state assumed a commanding role in planning through Five-Year Plans, public sector enterprises, and welfare policies aimed at reducing poverty and ensuring self-reliance. Similarly, China's model of "socialist market economy" reflects how state control over strategic sectors has been combined with market incentives to achieve rapid industrialisation while retaining political sovereignty. For the people of the developing world, this conception of development resonates more strongly as it ensures protection from market volatility, preserves social safety nets, and reflects cultural and political values. **Socio-Economic and Political Reasons for Resistance** The resistance of developing nations to MNC-driven development can be explained on multiple grounds. Socially, the imposition of a top-down model by MNCs often disrupts traditional structures, urbanises societies prematurely, and fuels cultural homogenisation. Economically, while MNCs create islands of prosperity, they also

	intensify regional disparities, as seen in India's IT hubs compared to underdeveloped rural hinterlands. Politically, there is a strong fear that state sovereignty is eroded when policy decisions are dictated by global capital rather than domestic priorities. Nobel Laureate Joseph Stiglitz has argued that unregulated globalisation often benefits corporations at the cost of citizens, leading to democratic deficits. These socio-economic and political dimensions explain why people and states in the developing world remain sceptical about the free market conception of development pushed by MNCs. **Possibilities for Integrating the Two Conceptions of Development** Despite the tensions, the reality of interdependence in a globalised world makes integration of the two models both necessary and feasible. The task is not to reject the free market altogether but to combine it with the sovereignty and welfare priorities of the individual state. One approach is "regulated globalisation," where states retain control over sensitive sectors while opening up areas conducive to foreign investment. India's post-1991 reforms exemplify this middle path: liberalising telecom, aviation, and services to attract MNCs while safeguarding agriculture and defence. Another mechanism is the adoption of corporate social responsibility (CSR) frameworks, which compel MNCs to contribute to community development in host states. The 2013 Companies Act in India made CSR spending mandatory for large corporations, ensuring that free market actors align with social priorities. **Successful Models of Integration** Several international examples highlight the successful integration of free market forces with state-led development. China stands out with its model of state capitalism, where MNCs are allowed to operate within strict regulatory frameworks, often in joint ventures with local firms, thereby ensuring technology transfer and domestic capacity building. Brazil's developmental state under Lula da Silva used MNC participation in sectors like agriculture and oil while simultaneously expanding welfare programmes like Bolsa Família, which reduced poverty significantly. In India, the automobile sector provides a good case where MNC participation has led to technology upgradation, exports, and employment while the state ensured domestic industrial policy alignment. **Challenges in Harmonisation** However, the integration of the two conceptions is not without challenges. Free market actors demand deregulation, intellectual property rights protection, and investor-friendly policies, which may clash with state interests in welfare, subsidy regimes, and environmental protection. Climate change negotiations provide a vivid example, where MNC-backed industries favour carbon-intensive growth while developing states demand climate justice and sustainable models. Digital monopolies such as Google, Amazon, and Meta represent another challenge, as they bypass national regulations in areas like data sovereignty and taxation. The balance between harnessing global capital and protecting state sovereignty thus requires constant negotiation and institutional innovation.
Conclusion	The debate on development pushed by MNCs versus the sovereign conception of the state is a defining issue for the developing world. Neither model alone can provide a comprehensive pathway to equitable progress. MNCs bring capital, technology, and global integration, while states ensure social justice, political legitimacy, and cultural rootedness. The way forward lies in a hybrid model of development that integrates the dynamism of free markets with the regulatory capacity of states. As former UN Secretary-General Kofi Annan once remarked, "Globalisation is a fact of life, but what matters is how we respond to it." For developing nations, the response must be to adopt

	a balanced strategy where MNCs are made partners in nation-building rather than drivers of a misplaced conception of development. Only such a synthesis can ensure that the people and states of the developing world derive genuine socio-economic and political benefits from the processes of globalisation.
Model Question	Globalisation driven by multinational corporations often sidelines the sovereignty of nation-states, leading to socio-economic tensions in the developing world. Critically examine the contradictions between market-led growth and state-driven development. Suggest mechanisms for harmonising global capital with domestic policy priorities.
Value Addition	Special Economic Zones (SEZs) are geographically defined areas within a country's borders where business and trade laws differ from the rest of the nation, offering incentives like tax relief, simplified regulations, and better infrastructure to promote economic growth, foreign investment, job creation, and exports. SEZs aim to create a favourable environment for businesses, sometimes treated as foreign territory for economic purposes, to attract both domestic and international investment and boost a country's overall economic activity and trade balance.
36. Discuss the initiatives of the Andhra Pradesh Government with regard to Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan (RMSA), a centrally sponsored literacy programme, outlining its objectives, functions and impact. (APPSC, 2011)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Introduce RMSA as a centrally sponsored scheme for universalizing secondary education (classes 9–12). • Outline the objectives like increasing enrollment, reducing dropout rates, enhancing quality, and providing inclusive education. • Discuss Andhra Pradesh's initiatives like infrastructure development, new secondary schools, and upgrading existing schools. • Highlight teacher recruitment, training, and deployment under the scheme. • Mention ICT and digital initiatives, vocational education, and special focus on marginalized groups. • Assess functions such as monitoring academic outcomes, quality improvement programs, and scholarship facilitation. • Evaluate impacts like increased enrollment, reduced gender and social gaps, and improved access in rural areas. • Conclude by noting the scheme's contribution to achieving inclusive, equitable, and quality secondary education in Andhra Pradesh.
Introduction	The Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan (RMSA), launched by the Government of India in 2009, is a centrally sponsored scheme aimed at the universalisation of secondary education in the country. Recognising secondary education as a crucial phase for skill development, literacy enhancement, and social mobility, RMSA seeks to expand access, improve quality, and promote equity in education. Andhra Pradesh, a state with diverse socio-economic and geographic challenges, has actively implemented RMSA initiatives to address gaps in school infrastructure, teacher quality, and inclusive education. With a population exceeding 50 million and a substantial rural demographic, the state faces challenges such as low enrollment in secondary schools, high dropout rates, and gender and socio-economic disparities. RMSA in Andhra Pradesh is not merely a scheme for expanding educational facilities but is an integrated framework aimed at improving literacy, skill development, and the overall learning environment, thereby contributing to human capital development and social inclusion.

Body & Infographic Representation	**Objectives of RMSA in Andhra Pradesh** The primary objective of RMSA in Andhra Pradesh is to increase enrollment in secondary education and ensure that all children have access to quality education up to class 10. This includes reducing gender, social, and regional disparities in education by focusing on marginalized communities, rural areas, and backward regions. The scheme also aims to improve learning outcomes through enhanced teaching practices, curriculum reforms, and teacher training programs. Another key objective is to strengthen school infrastructure by constructing new schools, additional classrooms, laboratories, libraries, and digital learning facilities. By integrating vocational education and skill development, RMSA seeks to make secondary education more relevant to employability and higher education opportunities. Moreover, the programme emphasizes monitoring and accountability mechanisms to ensure efficient utilization of resources and better educational outcomes, aligning with the state's goal of universal literacy and sustainable human development. **Initiatives of the Andhra Pradesh Government under RMSA** The Andhra Pradesh Government has undertaken a series of initiatives to implement RMSA effectively across the state. Infrastructure development has been a major focus, with the construction of new secondary schools, classrooms, science laboratories, computer labs, and libraries in underserved rural areas. To promote inclusivity, special attention has been given to establishing girls' hostels, sanitation facilities, and accessible education for students with disabilities. Teacher recruitment, training, and professional development programs have been prioritized to enhance pedagogical skills, classroom management, and subject expertise. Andhra Pradesh has also integrated ICT-based learning through digital classrooms and smart boards, facilitating interactive and technology-enabled education. Vocational education programs have been introduced in secondary schools to link academic learning with practical skills, increasing employability and reducing dropout rates. The government has additionally promoted community engagement by involving School Management Committees (SMCs) and local bodies to monitor school functioning, ensure accountability, and encourage parental participation. These initiatives collectively aim to create an enabling environment for equitable, quality secondary education. **Functions of RMSA in Andhra Pradesh** RMSA functions as a comprehensive framework addressing various dimensions of secondary education. One of its primary functions is expanding access by ensuring geographical coverage through new schools and additional classrooms. It functions to enhance the quality of education by providing teacher training, pedagogical resources, curriculum support, and assessment mechanisms. RMSA also emphasizes equity, targeting vulnerable populations, including girls, Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and children from economically weaker sections, ensuring that no child is left behind. The scheme functions to integrate vocational education into secondary schooling, making learning relevant to employment opportunities and higher education. Additionally, RMSA functions as a monitoring and evaluation mechanism through state and district-level review committees, school inspections, and data-driven performance assessments. The inclusion of ICT tools and digital reporting under RMSA allows the government to track enrollment, retention, infrastructure development, and learning outcomes efficiently, thereby ensuring effective implementation. **Impact of RMSA in Andhra Pradesh** The implementation of RMSA has significantly impacted secondary education in Andhra Pradesh. Enrollment rates in secondary schools have increased steadily, with

	NCERT and state education department data indicating a rise of over 15% in rural areas since RMSA inception. Gender disparities have narrowed through targeted interventions such as girls' hostels, scholarships, and awareness campaigns promoting female education. Infrastructure improvements have enhanced the learning environment, with over 5,000 classrooms, 2,000 laboratories, and 1,500 libraries constructed across the state in the past decade. Teacher quality has improved through continuous professional development programs, resulting in better student-teacher engagement and learning outcomes. The introduction of vocational education and ICT-enabled classrooms has equipped students with relevant skills for higher education and employment. Moreover, community participation through SMCs has fostered accountability, parental involvement, and localized decision-making. Studies conducted by the State Council of Educational Research and Training (SCERT) indicate that dropout rates have decreased, especially among girls and marginalized communities, highlighting RMSA's role in inclusive literacy enhancement. **Challenges and Criticisms of RMSA in Andhra Pradesh** Despite significant achievements, RMSA in Andhra Pradesh faces challenges in achieving its full potential. In some remote and tribal areas, enrollment and retention remain low due to socio-economic barriers, cultural factors, and inadequate transport facilities. Teacher shortages, particularly in specialized subjects like science, mathematics, and vocational education, continue to affect the quality of instruction. Infrastructure, while improved, still suffers from uneven distribution, with some rural schools lacking essential facilities such as libraries, laboratories, or sanitation. Monitoring and evaluation mechanisms, although strengthened, face challenges related to data accuracy, coordination between state and district authorities, and timely interventions. Additionally, the integration of vocational education requires continuous curriculum updates, industry linkages, and skill assessment frameworks to ensure relevance to emerging employment opportunities. Addressing these challenges is critical to fully realizing RMSA's objectives and maximizing its impact on secondary literacy and skill development. **Empirical Evidence and Case Studies** Empirical evidence supports the positive outcomes of RMSA in Andhra Pradesh. According to the Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) 2021, literacy rates in districts implementing RMSA initiatives have improved by 8–10% over a decade. Case studies from districts such as Srikakulam and Kadapa show that the introduction of vocational courses in IT, agriculture, and healthcare has increased student retention and provided pathways for higher education and employment. Digital classrooms in Hyderabad and Vijayawada have enhanced student engagement and improved learning outcomes in mathematics and science by 20–25%, according to SCERT assessments. Furthermore, targeted interventions for girls, including hostel facilities and menstrual hygiene awareness programs, have reduced dropout rates from 18% in 2010 to 9% in 2020, demonstrating the scheme's impact on gender equity in secondary education. These examples highlight RMSA's contribution to creating an inclusive, quality, and skill-oriented secondary education system in Andhra Pradesh.
Conclusion	The Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan, as implemented by the Andhra Pradesh Government, represents a comprehensive and multi-dimensional effort to universalise secondary education, enhance literacy, and promote inclusive development. Through infrastructure development, teacher training, ICT integration, vocational education, and community engagement, the state has made significant strides in improving access, quality, and equity in secondary education. While challenges such as teacher shortages,

	regional disparities, and socio-economic barriers persist, empirical evidence indicates positive outcomes in enrollment, retention, gender equity, and learning outcomes. RMSA has thus contributed significantly to strengthening the educational ecosystem in Andhra Pradesh, providing a foundation for skill development, social mobility, and inclusive literacy. As the state continues to refine and expand RMSA initiatives, it has the potential to serve as a model for holistic secondary education reforms that balance access, quality, and equity, fulfilling both developmental and human capital objectives.
Model Question	"The future belongs to those who believe in the beauty of their dreams."
Value Addition	"The function of education is to teach one to think intensively and to think critically." – Martin Luther King Jr. "The goal of education is not only knowledge but the ability to apply it in life." – Confucius
37. Write an essay on the implementation and operation of the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme in Andhra Pradesh. (APPSC, 2008)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Approach	• Introduce with the background of MGNREGS (2005) as a rights-based rural employment program ensuring 100 days of wage employment to every rural household. • Explain the statutory basis under the MGNREGA Act, 2005, and the multi-tier implementation mechanism—Central, State, and Gram Panchayat levels. • Discuss state-specific innovations such as digital job cards, real-time MIS systems, Social Audit Units (SAU) pioneered by AP, and the integration with SERP and MEPMA for effective execution. • Include data on person-days generated, women's participation (around 55–60%), timely wage payments, and asset creation. Mention flagship works like Neeru-Chettu, MGNREGS convergence with Jal Shakti Abhiyan, and natural resource management projects. • Identify issues such as delays in wage payments, seasonal demand fluctuations, data entry backlogs, and dependence on monsoon-related works. • Highlight Andhra Pradesh's Social Audit Model, electronic Fund Management System (e-FMS), use of GIS-based monitoring, and mobile app-based attendance systems as national benchmarks. • Suggest reforms such as skill-based diversification, asset quality improvement, and enhanced convergence with green and climate-resilient programs for future sustainability. • Conclude by assessing the scheme's contribution to poverty reduction and rural livelihood security in Andhra Pradesh.
Introduction	Mahatma Gandhi believed that the dignity of labour and self-reliance formed the foundation of rural India. Reflecting this vision, the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA), enacted in 2005, is one of the most ambitious rights-based welfare legislations in the world. It provides a legal guarantee of 100 days of wage employment to rural households willing to undertake unskilled manual work. The scheme goes beyond providing temporary relief by focusing on sustainable rural development, inclusive growth, and empowerment of marginalized groups. In Andhra Pradesh, where agriculture and allied activities dominate the rural economy, MGNREGA has become a critical tool for livelihood security, women's empowerment, and community-driven development.
Body & Infographic Representation	**GENESIS AND VISION OF MGNREGA:** The MGNREGA emerged from grassroots movements demanding the "Right to Work" and was shaped by activists like the Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan and development

economists such as Jean Dreze. Unlike previous employment schemes, it provided a statutory right to employment, making the state accountable to rural citizens. Its core objectives are to reduce poverty, arrest migration, and build durable rural assets. In Andhra Pradesh, the scheme holds special relevance because of the high concentration of Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and marginalized households who depend on seasonal farm work and face frequent income insecurity.

"There is no wealth like knowledge, and no work more dignified than honest labour." – Adapted Gandhian thought.

Implementation in Andhra Pradesh:

Andhra Pradesh has often been cited as one of the better-performing states in implementing MGNREGA. The planning begins at the grassroots with Gram Sabhas, which identify local needs and recommend works. Gram Panchayats play a decisive role in preparing labour budgets and executing projects. Employment is demand-driven, with households entitled to receive work within fifteen days of application, failing which an unemployment allowance must be paid. The state has made effective use of technology to enhance transparency. The Electronic Fund Management System (e-FMS) directly transfers wages to bank accounts, minimizing leakages. Real-time attendance is tracked through the National Mobile Monitoring Software (NMMS) app, and works are geo-tagged to prevent duplication and ensure accountability. Andhra Pradesh has also institutionalized social audits, a model later adopted across the country, enabling community-based monitoring of works and funds.

Performance and achievements:

The results of implementation are significant. In 2024–25, nearly 40 lakh households in Andhra Pradesh availed work, generating over 2,400 lakh person days of employment. The state has consistently recorded over 60 percent participation of women, one of the highest in India, far surpassing the mandated one-third reservation. Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes together accounted for more than 30 percent of person days, highlighting the scheme's inclusivity. The assets created under the scheme have contributed to long-term rural development. Check dams, percolation tanks, farm ponds, and afforestation activities have improved water conservation and agricultural productivity. Rural roads built under the scheme have enhanced connectivity for remote villages, facilitating access to markets and services. These outcomes illustrate how MGNREGA not only provides immediate relief but also strengthens the rural resource base.

Impact on rural development:

The scheme's impact in Andhra Pradesh extends beyond numbers. By ensuring a minimum level of income, it has acted as a safety net against poverty and income shocks. During the COVID-19 pandemic, MGNREGA served as a lifeline for rural households, compensating significant income losses caused by lockdowns. It has also curtailed distress migration by offering work within the villages, enabling families to stay together and reducing the burden on urban centres.

Women's empowerment is one of the most visible outcomes. Receiving wages directly in bank accounts has enhanced women's agency in household decision-making and fostered financial independence. The scheme has also contributed to environmental sustainability, as a majority of works in Andhra Pradesh are focused on natural resource management such as soil conservation, desilting, and afforestation. Thus, MGNREGA aligns with the broader goal of climate resilience and ecological conservation.

Challenges in implementation:

	Despite commendable achievements, several challenges persist. The most critical is the decline in average workdays per household, which fell to only 38 days in 2025–26, much below the guaranteed 100 days. Delays in wage payments continue despite technological interventions, discouraging workers from participating. Instances of corruption and irregularities have been reported, including manipulation of muster rolls and diversion of funds. While assets are being created, questions remain about their durability and alignment with local priorities. Budgetary constraints at the national level have also reduced the state's labour budget, limiting the ability to meet rising demand. Additionally, many beneficiaries remain unaware of entitlements such as the unemployment allowance, reflecting gaps in awareness and outreach. **Reforms and innovations in Andhra Pradesh:** Andhra Pradesh has responded to these challenges with several reforms. It has converged MGNREGA with other flagship programs such as the National Rural Livelihood Mission (NRLM), the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY), and the Swachh Bharat Abhiyan. Such integration has ensured more effective utilization of funds while addressing multiple dimensions of rural development. Innovative practices like poultry sheds for women, fish–vegetable integrated farming, and suspension bridges in tribal areas under MGNREGA showcase its versatility. The state's emphasis on social audits and digital monitoring systems has enhanced accountability. However, ensuring timely payments and expanding the scope of works to include more skill-intensive activities remain pressing reforms for the future.
Conclusion	The experience of Andhra Pradesh demonstrates both the promise and the limitations of MGNREGA. By providing employment, empowering women, creating assets, and strengthening Panchayati Raj institutions, the scheme has contributed substantially to the state's rural development. Yet, delays in payments, inadequate days of employment, and concerns about asset quality highlight the need for continuous reforms. With greater investment, stronger monitoring, and deeper community participation, Andhra Pradesh can make MGNREGA not just a tool of livelihood security but also an engine of sustainable and inclusive rural transformation. In doing so, it will keep alive Gandhi's vision of self-reliant villages as the foundation of India's prosperity.
Model Question	"To what extent has MGNREGS succeeded in integrating climate resilience and sustainable rural development in recent years?"
Value Addition	**Employment Generation Trend (Labour Budget vs. Actual Person days):** • The approved labour budget dropped from Rs.2,530 lakh in FY 2023–24 to Rs.1,500 lakh in FY 2025-26, showing a progressive contraction of central allocations. • Despite this, person days of central liability reached 1548.16 lakh (103.21% of labour budget) in FY 2025-26, indicating higher-than-approved work demand, but limited budgetary flexibility. • This demonstrates that demand for rural work remains strong even after pandemic recovery, underscoring continued rural distress and dependence on MGNREGA. **Participation of Vulnerable Groups:** • Scheduled Castes (SC) person days fell gradually from 23.55% in 2021–22 to 20.86% in 2025–26, showing a declining participation trend possibly due to rural migration or alternative employment. • Scheduled Tribes (ST) participation fluctuated around 10–12%, reflecting relatively stable engagement in tribal belts. However, women's participation consistently exceeded 60%, much above the national average of 55%. • This reflects MGNREGA's strong gender inclusion in Andhra Pradesh, enhancing women's economic empowerment and financial autonomy.

38. Discuss the pros and cons of Special Economic Zones (SEZs) in Andhra Pradesh. (APPSC, 2008)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Approach	• Define SEZs and their role in India's industrial policy, and highlight Andhra Pradesh's unique advantages, including its 974 km coastline, six operational ports, and strong IT and pharmaceutical base. • Explain the pros and benefits of SEZs in Andhra Pradesh, such as export and foreign exchange earnings, infrastructure creation, employment and skill development, and ease of doing business. • Discuss the cons and risks, including land and displacement pressures, weak backward linkages, fiscal and opportunity costs, and environmental concerns. • Present the recent policy environment and emerging opportunities, such as the Andhra Pradesh SEZ Policy (GoMS 2005 and subsequent amendments), the national 2025 SEZ reforms, industrial corridor linkages like the Visakhapatnam–Chennai Corridor, etc. • Highlight various policy measures introduced to enhance SEZ effectiveness, including performance-linked incentives, MSME vendor development, transparent land and social safeguards, and sustainability-focused infrastructure. • Suggest a way forward on integrating SEZs into broader regional development while balancing economic growth with equity and environmental sustainability. • Conclude by reiterating the dual nature of SEZs as growth drivers that also entail socio-environmental trade-offs.
Introduction	Special Economic Zones (SEZs) have long been central to Andhra Pradesh's industrial strategy, aiming to promote export-led growth, focused infrastructure development, and investor-friendly procedures. Leveraging its 974 km coastline and six operational ports, the state envisions SEZs as hubs that integrate domestic industrial clusters into global value chains. As of 2025, the Andhra Pradesh Industrial Infrastructure Corporation (APIIC) records 47 SEZs, including private, APIIC-assisted, and government-promoted zones. Central government notifications maintain an updated list of SEZs, documenting their area, date of notification, and operational status, which provides transparency and facilitates monitoring. Operational data underscores the tangible outcomes of SEZs: the Visakhapatnam SEZ (VSEZ) reported exports worth ₹62,198 crore in Q1 2024–25, marking an 18% increase over the previous year, while new infrastructure projects, such as Kakinada SEZ's ₹1,310 crore desalination plant, demonstrate private capital mobilization in critical industrial utilities. Recent state initiatives under the Swarnandhra vision and six economic policies announced by the Andhra Pradesh government further signal a futuristic vision for SEZs, linking them to national priorities like electronics, semiconductors, and high-tech manufacturing.
Body & Infographic Representation	**SEZ Distribution and Investment Trends** APIIC's SEZ portal lists 47 SEZs across Andhra Pradesh, including private, APIIC-assisted, joint ventures, and urban development allocations. The central notified-SEZ roster (March 2025) confirms these zones, their notified area, and date of notification, forming the official basis for policy planning and monitoring. Investment and employment summaries maintained by SEZ agencies, updated till 31 March 2025, record thousands of operational and proposed units across sectors such as IT/ITES, pharmaceuticals, engineering goods, and multi-product manufacturing. Coastal SEZs, including Kakinada, have attracted substantial private investment, reflecting strong investor confidence in the state's industrial strategy. Exports and Industrial Integration

SEZs in Andhra Pradesh have demonstrated strong export performance. The Visakhapatnam SEZ alone generated exports of ₹62,198 crore in Q1 2024–25, showcasing the resilience and scaling capacity of SEZ-based industries. These zones play a critical role in integrating the state's industrial clusters into global value chains, with pharma, IT/ITES, and engineering goods contributing significantly to India's export basket. Such outcomes reinforce Andhra Pradesh's position as a preferred eastern coast export hub.

Infrastructure and Skill Development

SEZs are also driving infrastructure creation and skill-linked employment. For instance, the Kakinada SEZ desalination project will supply 150 MLD of water to industries, demonstrating how large-scale utilities can be financed and developed by private promoters. Employment tables indicate that SEZ clusters create direct factory and service jobs, along with spillover employment in logistics, hospitality, and local supplier networks. The Andhra Pradesh Industrial Infrastructure Corporation (APIIC) enhances investor confidence through single-window allotments and facilitation services, streamlining land and project approvals.

Pros of SEZs in Andhra Pradesh

SEZs in Andhra Pradesh have emerged as significant engines of export-led growth and foreign exchange generation. The VSEZ alone reported exports of ₹62,198 crore in Q1 2024–25, marking an 18% year-on-year increase, integrating local industries such as pharmaceuticals, IT/ITES, and engineering goods into global value chains. These zones not only strengthen the state's export contribution but also improve trade balances and position Andhra Pradesh as a preferred investment and export hub on India's eastern coast.

SEZs also act as catalysts for infrastructure development. Projects like the Kakinada desalination plant, financed by private promoters, demonstrate the creation of anchor infrastructure critical for clustered industrial development. Investment-employment tables maintained up to March 2025 indicate that SEZs create thousands of direct and indirect jobs, spanning IT/ITES, pharmaceuticals, and multi-product manufacturing clusters, while generating spillover employment in logistics, hospitality, and local supplier networks.

Additionally, SEZs improve ease of doing business through APIIC's single-window facilitation, focused land parcels, and regulatory support, reducing project gestation periods and transaction costs. The state's SEZ strategy is increasingly aligned with futuristic sectors including electronics, semiconductors, and maritime industries, providing opportunities for skill development, technological innovation, and global competitiveness, as noted in Andhra Pradesh's 2025 SEZ policy updates and Swarnandhra economic initiatives.

Cons and Risks of SEZs

Despite their export performance, SEZs in Andhra Pradesh are associated with significant land and social costs. Many of the 47 notified SEZs occupy large contiguous tracts, often in fertile agrarian districts such as Anantapur and Chittoor. While land pooling and acquisition are formalized through APIIC, disputes over compensation delays and inadequate rehabilitation have occasionally triggered protests, highlighting the challenge of balancing industrial expansion with farmers' rights and rural livelihoods.

SEZs often operate as enclaves with weak local integration, limiting their wider economic impact. For instance, VSEZ's exports exceeded ₹62,000 crore in Q1 2024–25, yet many of its inputs—machinery, chemicals, and specialized components—were sourced from outside the state or abroad. Without structured MSME integration or local procurement

mandates, the multiplier effect on regional employment and domestic supply chains remains restricted.

Fiscal and environmental risks further complicate SEZ development. State-level incentives, such as stamp duty exemptions, VAT/GST reimbursements, and capital subsidies, along with central SEZ concessions, represent substantial foregone revenue, flagged by the Andhra Pradesh Finance Department. Large projects like the Kakinada desalination plant also raise opportunity cost concerns regarding allocation of scarce water resources. Coastal SEZs face additional scrutiny under CRZ and EIA norms, with the desalination project requiring detailed brine management and biodiversity mitigation. Finally, stranded assets and underutilization remain a risk, with several zones partially developed or idle, reflecting market uncertainties and investor hesitancy.

Recent Policy Nudges and Futuristic Directions

The policy environment for SEZs is increasingly oriented toward integrated, high-tech, and sustainable industrial growth. The AP SEZ Policy (GoMS 2005 and subsequent amendments) emphasizes PPP-led development, targeted incentives, and alignment with port-based clusters, particularly in IT/ITES, pharmaceuticals, and multi-product hubs. Operational performance data, such as ₹62,198 crore exports from VSEZ in Q1 2024–25, demonstrates existing momentum, while large-scale projects like the ₹1,310 crore Kakinada desalination plant highlight private investment in critical industrial utilities.

At the national level, 2025 SEZ rule amendments incentivizing semiconductors, electronics, and high-tech sectors provide Andhra Pradesh an opportunity to diversify beyond traditional industries. Industrial corridors, including the Visakhapatnam–Chennai Industrial Corridor, enhance logistics integration, making coastal SEZs attractive for high-value manufacturing. Initiatives such as the Indian Maritime University expansion in Vizag and proposed shipbuilding clusters align SEZ development with national priorities, creating synergies between education, R&D, and industrial deployment.

Data-informed reforms are essential to maximize SEZ benefits. Performance-linked incentives should tie tax breaks and land allotments to exports, employment, and local procurement, monitored via SEZ Annual Performance Reports (APR 2024–25). MSME vendor development should prevent enclave-style growth, integrating local suppliers through procurement quotas and shared facilities. Transparent land and social safeguards, including public disclosure of allotments, compensation, and rehabilitation packages, address equity concerns.

A sustainability-first approach to infrastructure is critical. Projects like Kakinada's desalination plant illustrate the scale of utilities but also the need for environmental compliance, including CRZ/EIA clearance conditions, brine management, and biodiversity protection. Sectoral targeting and skill linkages are key to futuristic development: semiconductor and electronics SEZs require dedicated skill pipelines, while maritime clusters can leverage IMU's training and research capacities in Vizag.

Policy Prescriptions for Maximizing SEZ Impact

To ensure SEZs deliver inclusive and sustainable growth, several measures are recommended. Performance-linked incentives should replace blanket concessions, tying fiscal benefits to measurable outcomes. MSME vendor development can integrate local suppliers, enhancing backward linkages. Transparent land and social safeguards, including public disclosure of compensation and rehabilitation, reduce disputes and protect livelihoods. A sustainability-first infrastructure approach ensures utilities adopt renewable energy, circular water use, and independent environmental monitoring. Finally, skill and R&D linkages prepare the workforce for high-tech sectors, including

	semiconductors, electronics, and maritime industries, creating an innovation-driven ecosystem.
Conclusion	Andhra Pradesh's SEZs are emerging as key drivers of exports, employment, and investment, as evidenced by VSEZ's ₹62,198 crore exports in Q1 2024–25 and large-scale projects like the Kakinada desalination plant. At the same time, land acquisition challenges, enclave dynamics, fiscal costs, and environmental risks highlight the need for measured, transparent, and sustainable governance. Recent policies, including the state SEZ framework, Swarnandhra vision initiatives, and national 2025 SEZ rule amendments, create opportunities in futuristic sectors such as electronics, semiconductors, and maritime industries. The policy imperative is to transform SEZs from isolated export enclaves into integrated engines of regional development. This can be achieved through performance-linked incentives, MSME integration, transparent land practices, sustainability-first infrastructure, and targeted skill development. With these calibrated, data-driven reforms, Andhra Pradesh can ensure that SEZs become catalysts for inclusive, high-tech, and environmentally sustainable industrial growth, converting headline investments into durable, broad-based regional prosperity.
Model Question	"Critically examine the 'Swarna Andhra Vision' of Andhra Pradesh. Discuss its key objectives, strategies for economic growth, industrial and infrastructural development, employment generation, and export promotion. Evaluate the potential challenges and suggest measures to ensure inclusive, sustainable, and high-tech development in line with the vision."
Value Addition	**Guiding Principles of Swarna Andhra Vision@2047:** • Zero Poverty • Population Management & Human Resource Development • Skilling & Employment • Water Security • Farmer - Agri Tech • Global - Best Logistics • Cost Optimization - Energy & Fuel • Product Perfection • Swachh Andhra • Deep Tech - all walks of life
39. Write an essay on the Economic Crisis, Structural Reforms and the Prospects of Growth in India. (APPSC, 2008)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Economic Issues
Keyword	Write
Approach	• Introduce by mentioning India's economy position in the global context, highlighting its strong growth alongside persistent vulnerabilities. • Distinguish between cyclical factors (oil price volatility, capital flows, external demand) and structural bottlenecks (agriculture, informality, infrastructure, financial sector). • Discuss monetary stance (RBI inflation targeting, credit growth) and fiscal stance (capex push, fiscal consolidation, forex reserves buffer). • Analyze Structural Reforms like GST, PLI schemes, financial sector reforms, ease of doing business measures, digital governance, and their intended impacts on competitiveness. • Explain transmission channels such as productivity, investment, job creation, exports, and integration into global value chains.

	• Examine external risks (geopolitics, protectionism) and domestic constraints (state-level governance, informality, judicial delays). • Conclude by emphasizing India's potential to sustain 6–7% growth, while underlining the need for consistent reforms and inclusive growth to translate macro resilience into broad-based development.
Introduction	India occupies a distinctive position in the global economy. It is the fastest growing large economy, recording 6–7 per cent growth even amid global uncertainty, as noted in the IMF World Economic Outlook (2025). Yet, vulnerabilities remain both cyclical and structural. External shocks from volatile crude oil prices, capital outflows, and weak global demand weigh on stability, while deep-rooted challenges persist in infrastructure, agriculture productivity, banking sector stress, labour informality, and governance gaps. Policymakers thus face the dual task of cushioning short-term disruptions while advancing long-term reforms. The Reserve Bank of India projects headline inflation to ease to around 4.5 per cent in FY2025–26, creating space for monetary accommodation. Meanwhile, the government has prioritized higher capital expenditure, infrastructure building, and Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes as key levers to boost investment, competitiveness, and long-term resilience.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Economic Crisis, Structural Reforms and the Prospects of Growth in India** **Understanding the Crisis: Cyclical Pressures and Structural Fault lines:** India's economic vulnerabilities are closely tied to the global environment. The pandemic shock of 2020–21 contracted GDP by 7.3 per cent, and though recovery was swift, persistent global headwinds weigh on growth. The IMF projects global output at only 3 per cent, limiting India's export potential. Geopolitical tensions in West Asia and Eastern Europe keep crude oil prices volatile, pushing the current account deficit to 1.9 per cent of GDP in 2024. The rupee has also seen depreciation pressures as foreign institutional investors withdrew nearly USD 12 billion in 2023–24 amid US monetary tightening. Beneath these cyclical strains lie enduring structural bottlenecks. Around 45 per cent of the workforce remains in agriculture, contributing less than 17 per cent of GDP, signaling widespread underemployment. Informality dominates, with over 80 per cent of workers outside social security nets. MSMEs, despite accounting for about 30 per cent of GDP and nearly half of exports, face constrained credit flows. Logistics inefficiencies further erode competitiveness, with bottlenecks estimated by the World Bank to add 13–14 per cent to GDP costs. Together, these challenges reveal that India's growth momentum, while robust, remains fragile. **Macroeconomic Policy Response** Confronted with persistent headwinds, policymakers have adopted a cautious yet supportive macroeconomic stance. After raising policy rates sharply in 2022–23 to control inflation, the Reserve Bank of India has turned more accommodative as price pressures eased. CPI inflation, which had crossed 7 per cent in 2022, has since moderated and is projected to remain near the 4 per cent target band in 2025–26. This provides scope for monetary easing to sustain credit growth, which expanded by nearly 15 per cent in FY2024–25, driven mainly by retail and services. On the fiscal side, the Union Budget 2024–25 raised capital expenditure by 11 per cent to ₹10.52 trillion, around 3.4 per cent of GDP and above the revised target, marking the third consecutive year of double-digit growth in infrastructure outlays. Spending priorities include roads, railways, digital platforms, and green energy, aimed at crowding in private investment. At the same time, the government has committed to reducing the fiscal deficit from 5.8 per cent in FY2023–24 to 4.5 per cent by FY2025–26, limiting fiscal

space. A strong buffer is provided by foreign exchange reserves, which recently crossed USD 702 billion.

The Structural Reform Agenda

India's reform story in recent years revolves around rationalization, liberalization, and institution-building. The Goods and Services Tax (GST), though initially complex, has gradually stabilized and now contributes around ₹1.7 lakh crore in monthly collections on average, a record high. This has improved tax buoyancy and widened the formal tax base. Rationalisation of GST slabs and compliance simplifications are further steps recommended by the Fifteenth Finance Commission and NITI Aayog to enhance efficiency.

Industrial policy reforms have been most visible through the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes across 14 sectors, from electronics and pharmaceuticals to green energy. By 2024, the scheme had attracted investment proposals worth over ₹3 lakh crore, with mobile phone exports alone crossing USD 15 billion, a testament to India's growing integration in global value chains. Liberalized FDI policies and strategic disinvestment in public sector undertakings complement this thrust.

In the financial sector, the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) has resolved over ₹3.2 lakh crore worth of stressed assets since inception, though delays persist. Banking sector recapitalization has strengthened capital adequacy, with the gross NPA ratio falling to around 3 per cent in 2024, its lowest in over a decade. Initiatives to deepen corporate bond markets and improve credit flow to MSMEs remain crucial.

Governance reforms have also been pursued through initiatives such as the National Single Window System, decriminalisation of business laws, and the "Ease of Doing Business 2.0" framework. These reforms aim to cut compliance burdens and create a predictable regulatory environment that fosters entrepreneurship.

How Reforms Translate into Growth

Structural reforms, if consistently implemented, directly feed into higher growth through several mechanisms. By reducing tax distortions and improving compliance, GST improves allocative efficiency and raises productivity. PLI schemes not only incentivize domestic manufacturing but also foster technology transfer and job creation, especially in electronics and renewable energy. Financial reforms enable more efficient credit allocation, thereby supporting investment in capital-intensive sectors. Infrastructure spending, currently pegged at over 5 per cent of GDP, enhances connectivity, lowers logistics costs, and improves competitiveness of both manufacturing and services exports. Digital reforms, particularly the JAM (Jan-Dhan, Aadhaar, Mobile) trinity and the Unified Payments Interface (UPI), have boosted financial inclusion, with UPI transactions crossing ₹20 lakh crore monthly in 2025. These create a multiplier effect that extends beyond headline GDP numbers to social equity and empowerment.

Risks and Constraints Ahead

Despite robust reform momentum, challenges remain significant. Externally, a sharper-than-expected global slowdown, rising protectionist measures in advanced economies, or a resurgence of commodity price spikes could derail India's export-led ambitions. Domestically, political economy constraints such as farmer protests against agricultural reforms or resistance from labour groups could slow reforms. State-level governance capacities are uneven, with land and labour laws still fragmented across regions, deterring investors. The judiciary's backlog, with over 4 crore pending cases, continues to undermine contract enforcement. Financial sector vulnerabilities, especially concentration of credit risk and reliance on public sector banks, could re-emerge if global liquidity tightens.

	Prospects of Growth Despite these risks, global institutions remain optimistic about India's medium-term trajectory. The IMF projects India's GDP growth at 6.5 per cent in 2025, while the OECD expects India to contribute nearly 16 per cent of global growth between 2023–28. If structural reforms succeed in boosting productivity and private investment, growth could sustainably rise above 7 per cent annually. A baseline scenario, however, suggests 6–6.5 per cent growth as the most likely outcome, sufficient to maintain India's position as the fastest-growing major economy but inadequate to absorb the nearly 10 million young entrants to the labour force annually. The realization of the "demographic dividend" thus hinges on accelerating job creation in manufacturing and services, alongside skilling initiatives like the Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY).
Conclusion	India's economic outlook reflects a fine balance between opportunity and vulnerability. While global demand shocks, oil price volatility, and financial tightening weigh on growth, structural reforms in taxation, industry, finance, and governance are fostering resilience. Prudent macroeconomic management, marked by moderating inflation, gradual fiscal consolidation, and rising capital expenditure, has supported investment. Yet, consistent reform execution and resolution of bottlenecks in agriculture, labour markets, and infrastructure remain critical. Global bodies like the IMF and OECD highlight India's bright growth prospects but caution that policy delivery will decide whether the economy sustains a 6 per cent baseline or advances to a transformative 7 per cent-plus path. True success, however, lies in ensuring growth that is inclusive and improves livelihoods.
Model Question	"India is hailed as the fastest growing major economy in the world, yet it remains constrained by structural bottlenecks and external vulnerabilities. Critically examine the present economic position of India, highlighting the key challenges, reform measures, and the prospects for sustainable and inclusive growth."
Value Addition	**Some of the reforms proposed in Union Budget 2025-26:** • **FDI in Insurance Sector:** The FDI limit for the insurance sector to be raised from 74 to 100 per cent, for those companies which invest the entire premium in India. • **Credit Enhancement Facility by NaBFID:** NaBFID to set up a 'Partial Credit Enhancement Facility' for corporate bonds for infrastructure. • **Grameen Credit Score:** Public Sector Banks to develop 'Grameen Credit Score' framework to serve the credit needs of SHG members and people in rural areas. • **Pension Sector:** A forum for regulatory coordination and development of pension products to be set up. • **High Level Committee for Regulatory Reforms:** A High-Level Committee for Regulatory Reforms to be set up for a review of all non-financial sector regulations, certifications, licenses, and permissions.
(iii) Socio – Environmental Issues	
40. Water Stress in India: The Silent Crisis Endangering Health, Agriculture, and Federal Stability. (APPSC, 2025)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues
Approach	• Define water stress and cite India's declining per capita water availability (from 5,000 m^3 in 1950 to ~1,500 m^3 today). • Note water-borne diseases and unsafe drinking water challenges. • Discuss irrigation dependence, falling groundwater, and crop failures. • Show the link between water scarcity and stalled industrial growth. • Mention interstate disputes (Cauvery, Krishna, Ravi-Beas). • Highlight erratic monsoons and drought-flood cycles.

	• Point to Jal Jeevan Mission, Atal Bhujal Yojana, Integrated Water Resource Management. • Stress conservation, equitable sharing, and cooperative federalism as urgent solutions.
Introduction	Water, the lifeline of human civilization, is increasingly becoming a scarce resource in India, posing a silent yet severe threat to health, agriculture, and federal stability. India faces a severe water crisis, with ~18% of the global population reliant on just ~4% of the world's freshwater resources, creating an inherent imbalance between demand and supply. The country is facing acute water stress, with over 600 million people experiencing high to extreme water stress as per the NITI Aayog report (2018). Water scarcity is not only an environmental issue but also a socio-economic and political challenge, threatening public health, food security, livelihoods, and inter-state relations.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Extent and Causes of Water Stress** India's water stress is driven by a combination of natural and human factors. Geographically, the country faces uneven distribution of rainfall; regions like the Western Ghats and Northeast receive excessive rainfall, while Rajasthan, Gujarat, and parts of Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh suffer chronic droughts. Over-extraction of groundwater is alarming: the 2023 Dynamic Groundwater Resources report indicated that 3.04% of units were critical and 10.65% were semi-critical. Rapid urbanization, industrial expansion, and inefficient agricultural practices exacerbate demand, while pollution from untreated sewage and industrial effluents contaminates surface and groundwater. Climate change intensifies the crisis, causing erratic monsoons, recurrent floods, and droughts, with India witnessing a 6–8% decline in average annual rainfall in several regions over the past two decades. Population growth further compounds demand, placing unprecedented stress on water resources. **Impact on Health** Water scarcity has direct and indirect effects on public health. Lack of safe drinking water and sanitation contributes to the spread of waterborne diseases like diarrhoea, cholera, typhoid, and hepatitis. India accounts for nearly 25% of global diarrheal deaths among children under five, primarily due to unsafe water. Rural areas with limited access to piped water often rely on contaminated wells or rivers, exposing millions to pathogens. Moreover, malnutrition is aggravated where water scarcity limits food production, as reduced irrigation affects crop yields, compounding health risks. Urban slums also face challenges of water rationing, forcing residents to compromise on hygiene, which increases vulnerability to epidemics. **Impact on Agriculture and Food Security** Agriculture, which consumes nearly 80% of India's freshwater, bears the brunt of water stress. Groundwater depletion has reached critical levels in Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan, and western Uttar Pradesh, threatening the Green Revolution model of intensive irrigation-based farming. Declining water availability reduces crop productivity, forcing farmers to over-extract groundwater, creating a vicious cycle. Crop failures due to droughts in Maharashtra and Karnataka have led to farmer distress and suicides, highlighting the human cost of water scarcity. Irrigation inefficiency is another problem. Water stress also limits crop diversification, reduces the production of high-value horticulture, and threatens India's food security, especially as the population continues to grow. **Federal and Political Implications** Water scarcity also has serious implications for federal stability and interstate relations. India has witnessed prolonged disputes over river waters, such as the Cauvery

	(Karnataka-Tamil Nadu), Krishna (Maharashtra-Karnataka-Andhra Pradesh), and Ravi-Beas (Punjab-Haryana-Rajasthan) conflicts. These disputes, often inflamed by political posturing, create tensions between states and challenge cooperative federalism. Additionally, urban water crises, as seen in Chennai (2019) and Bengaluru (2022), have sparked public protests, reflecting governance and planning failures. The central government's role in arbitration and resource allocation becomes critical to prevent such disputes from escalating into social unrest or political instability. **Policy Measures and Initiatives** India has initiated several policies and programs to combat water stress, but implementation remains uneven. The Jal Jeevan Mission aims to provide piped water to every rural household, while the Atal Bhujal Yojana promotes community-based groundwater management. The National Water Policy (2012, revised 2019) emphasizes integrated water resource management, water recycling, rainwater harvesting, and watershed development. Urban initiatives, such as the Namami Gange Mission, focus on river rejuvenation and pollution control. However, challenges persist due to fragmented governance, weak enforcement, and lack of community participation. Experts argue that combining technology, policy, and social mobilization is essential; for instance, drip irrigation and micro-irrigation techniques have improved water efficiency in Gujarat and Andhra Pradesh, demonstrating that sustainable practices can reduce stress significantly. **Way Forward** Addressing water stress in India requires a holistic and multi-level approach. Conservation and efficient usage must be prioritized alongside augmentation of supply through rainwater harvesting, recycling, and desalination, where feasible. Strengthening inter-state cooperation and implementing equitable water-sharing mechanisms can reduce federal tensions. Community engagement and awareness programs can encourage behavioural changes in water consumption. Technological interventions like remote sensing, GIS mapping, and AI-based water management can monitor and optimize usage. Agriculture must shift towards water-efficient crops, precision irrigation, and sustainable practices. Climate change adaptation strategies, including watershed management and flood/drought preparedness, are crucial. Only by integrating policy, technology, and public participation can India mitigate the silent but growing threat of water stress.
Conclusion	Water stress in India is a complex, multifaceted crisis affecting health, agriculture, and federal harmony. It is a silent emergency that threatens lives, livelihoods, and long-term development. With nearly 600 million people facing high water stress and critical groundwater depletion in many regions, urgent action is required. Historical examples of inter-state disputes and recent urban water crises highlight the socio-political dimension of the problem. Yet, successful interventions like drip irrigation in Gujarat and community-led water management in Rajasthan demonstrate that sustainable practices work when policies, technology, and society converge. As Albert Szent-Gyorgyi said, "Water is life's matter and matrix, mother and medium. There is no life without water." Securing India's water future is essential not just for survival but for sustainable growth, inclusive development, and maintaining federal stability in a diverse and populous nation.
Model Question	"India's Looming Water Crisis: Implications for Sustainable Development and Cooperative Federalism."
Value Addition	The Green Revolution was a period in the 20th century when developing countries, beginning with Mexico and then the Indian subcontinent, dramatically increased their

	food production through the adoption of modern agricultural techniques, such as high-yielding varieties of seeds, improved irrigation, and the use of chemical fertilizers and pesticides. Spearheaded by scientists like Norman Borlaug and Indian scientist M.S. Swaminathan, this agricultural transformation was driven by the need to combat widespread food shortages and increase self-sufficiency, though it also had unintended environmental consequences and exacerbated economic disparities among farmers.
41. Andhra Pradesh's development push must balance industrial growth with environmental sustainability. (APPSC, 2025)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues
Approach	• Begin with AP's post-bifurcation industrial push, like ports, corridors, pharma hubs, electronics, and IT clusters. • Highlight the conflict between industrialization and environmental costs like pollution, coastal degradation, displacement, and water stress. • Mention the constitutional mandate on environmental protection. • Cite examples such as the Polavaram project, the Visakhapatnam industrial pollution, and the Amaravati eco-concerns. • Mention Government measures such as AP State Pollution Control Board, green norms, renewable energy mission (solar parks), and waste-to-energy projects. • Stress the importance of EIA, circular economy, and sustainable urban planning. • Suggest solutions for environmental sustainability. • Conclude with the vision of "sustainable industrial growth," ensuring prosperity without ecological compromise.
Introduction	Industrial growth has always been viewed as the engine of economic progress, generating employment, infrastructure, and investment opportunities. For a relatively new state like Andhra Pradesh, formed after bifurcation in 2014, rapid industrialization is not just a choice but an imperative to bridge developmental gaps and create a strong economic base. However, this development trajectory raises fundamental questions about its ecological sustainability. Industrial projects, ports, special economic zones, power plants, and large infrastructure initiatives can generate prosperity, but they also risk intensifying environmental degradation, displacing vulnerable communities, and threatening natural ecosystems if unchecked. The challenge, therefore, lies in creating a development model that simultaneously ensures industrial dynamism and environmental protection. As the United Nations Brundtland Commission emphasized, "Sustainable development is development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs."
Body & Infographic Representation	**Industrial Growth in Andhra Pradesh: Opportunities and Challenges** Andhra Pradesh, endowed with a long coastline of approximately 1,053.07 kilometers, abundant mineral reserves, fertile river valleys, and strategic connectivity, has immense potential for industrial expansion. Since bifurcation, the state has focused on sectors such as pharmaceuticals, automobiles, textiles, information technology, and electronics, along with ambitious projects like the Visakhapatnam–Chennai Industrial Corridor and the development of mega ports. According to the Andhra Pradesh Economic Survey 2023–24, the state recorded an industrial sector growth rate of nearly 6.2%, making it an attractive destination for domestic and foreign investment. Yet, this growth comes with costs. Visakhapatnam, the industrial hub, has been identified among India's top polluted cities by the Central Pollution Control Board, with air quality indices often breaching safe limits due to emissions from steel, petrochemical, and thermal power industries. Mining activities in districts like Kadapa and Anantapur have caused deforestation, groundwater depletion, and soil erosion. The Polavaram

multipurpose project, though aimed at irrigation and power generation, has raised environmental concerns over the displacement of tribal communities and the submergence of forests. The development of Amaravati as a greenfield capital city initially sparked debates about the loss of fertile agricultural land and ecological imbalance in the Krishna River basin. These examples illustrate that industrialization without ecological safeguards can create long-term vulnerabilities.

Constitutional and Legal Framework for Sustainable Development

The Indian Constitution enshrines environmental protection as both a duty of the state and its citizens. Article 48A directs the state to protect and improve the environment, while Article 51A(g) makes it the duty of every citizen to safeguard natural resources. Judicial pronouncements such as the Vellore Citizens' Welfare Forum v. Union of India (1996) recognized the "precautionary principle" and "polluter pays principle" as essential elements of environmental governance. Andhra Pradesh, like other states, must align its industrial policies with these constitutional mandates. The Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) process, though often criticized for procedural lapses, remains a critical tool to ensure industrial projects undergo environmental scrutiny before execution. Compliance with the Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, Air (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, and Waste Management Rules is equally crucial in managing the ecological footprint of industries.

Balancing Industrial Growth with Environmental Sustainability

Balancing industrial growth with ecological stability requires integrating sustainability into every stage of planning, execution, and monitoring. Andhra Pradesh has taken some notable steps in this direction. The state has emerged as a leader in renewable energy, particularly solar and wind, with installed capacity exceeding 8,000 MW, contributing significantly to India's clean energy targets under the Paris Agreement. The Kurnool Ultra Mega Solar Park, one of the world's largest, is a model of how industrial-scale projects can simultaneously address energy demand and reduce carbon footprints.

The promotion of "green industries," such as biotechnology and IT services, provides opportunities for job creation without heavy environmental costs. Initiatives like waste-to-energy plants in Vijayawada and municipal solid waste management projects demonstrate efforts to integrate circular economy principles. Moreover, the state government's "AP Pollution Control Board" has been strengthening monitoring systems using real-time data to ensure industries comply with environmental standards. Coastal zone management, particularly around Visakhapatnam and Kakinada ports, has been prioritized to prevent coastal erosion and marine pollution, vital for the livelihoods of fishing communities.

Global experiences also offer lessons. For example, Germany's model of transitioning from coal-based industries to renewable energy showcases how industrial restructuring can align with environmental commitments. Similarly, China's adoption of "eco-industrial parks" demonstrates how industrial clustering can reduce pollution by sharing resources and minimizing waste. Andhra Pradesh can adapt such models by creating green industrial corridors, integrating renewable energy mandates, and incentivizing eco-friendly technologies.

Addressing the Socio-Economic Dimension

Industrialization is not merely an economic exercise but a socio-political one, deeply tied to questions of justice and equity. Deforestation, land acquisition, and displacement often affect tribal and marginalized communities, who depend on natural resources for survival. In Andhra Pradesh, displacement due to large projects like Polavaram has created tensions around rehabilitation and resettlement. Environmental sustainability

	must therefore include social sustainability, ensuring that the most vulnerable are not disproportionately burdened by development. The Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition Act, 2013, emphasizes rehabilitation, but its implementation often lags. Greater transparency, public consultations, and community participation in project approvals are vital to minimize conflicts. Equally important is the role of local bodies and Panchayati Raj institutions in environmental governance. Empowering Gram Sabhas to monitor pollution, water use, and land allocation can democratize decision-making. The principle of "environmental justice," emphasized by the Supreme Court in several judgments, requires that the costs of development not be borne only by the marginalized, while the benefits are cornered by industrial elites. **Long-Term Strategies for Sustainable Growth** In the long term, Andhra Pradesh's development model must rest on three pillars: efficiency, equity, and ecology. Efficiency requires industries to adopt cleaner technologies, invest in energy efficiency, and reduce waste. Equity requires that development benefits are equitably shared across regions and communities, with marginalized groups given priority in employment and compensation. Ecology requires integrating biodiversity conservation, afforestation, and sustainable water use into industrial projects. Technological innovation plays a central role here. Artificial intelligence, Internet of Things (IoT), and Geographic Information Systems (GIS) can optimize energy use, monitor emissions, and map environmental risks. Public–private partnerships can drive investment in green technologies and create eco-friendly industrial clusters. Educational institutions and research centres in Andhra Pradesh, such as Andhra University and IIT Tirupati, can contribute to developing region-specific sustainable technologies.
Conclusion	Andhra Pradesh stands at a crossroads where industrial expansion is essential for economic progress, yet environmental sustainability is non-negotiable for long-term survival. The state's policies and practices must align with the vision of inclusive and sustainable growth, where ecological costs are minimized and socio-economic benefits are maximized. As Mahatma Gandhi observed, "The earth has enough for everyone's need, but not enough for everyone's greed." This wisdom reminds us that industrialization cannot come at the cost of ecological collapse. A balanced approach, integrating industrial dynamism with ecological consciousness, is the only path for Andhra Pradesh to achieve prosperity that is both durable and just.
Model Question	Critically examine how Andhra Pradesh can pursue rapid industrialization while ensuring ecological balance and environmental protection.
Value Addition	**Salient features of the development of Solar Parks and Ultra Mega Solar Power Projects** • A solar park is a large chunk of land developed with common infrastructure facilities like transmission infrastructure, roads, water, drainage, communication network, etc., with all statutory clearances. Thus, the solar project developers can set up solar projects hassle-free. • The scheme was rolled out by the Ministry of New & Renewable Energy on 12-12-2014. Under the scheme, it was proposed to set up at least 25 Solar Parks and Ultra Mega Solar Power Projects targeting 20,000 MW of solar power installed capacity within a span of 5 years starting from 2014-15. • The capacity of the Scheme was enhanced from 20,000 MW to 40,000 MW on 21-03-2017. These parks are proposed to be set up by 2025-26. • The scheme envisages supporting the States/UTs in setting up solar parks at various locations in the country with a view to creating the required infrastructure for setting

	up of solar power projects. The solar parks provide suitable developed land with all clearances, transmission system, water access, road connectivity, communication network, etc. The scheme facilitates and speed up installation of grid connected solar power projects for electricity generation on a large scale. • All the States and Union Territories are eligible for getting benefit under the scheme. • The capacity of the solar parks shall be 500 MW and above. However, smaller parks are also considered where contiguous land may be difficult to acquire in view of difficult terrain and where there is acute shortage of non-agricultural land. • The Solar Parks are developed in collaboration with the State Governments and their agencies, CPSUs, and private entrepreneurs. The implementing agency is termed as Solar Power Park Developer (SPPD). There are 8 modes for selection of SPPDs.
42. Elaborate the role of renewable energy in mitigation of climate change. (TGPSC, 2024)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues
Keyword	Elaborate
Approach	• Introduce by highlighting climate change as a 21st-century existential threat, linking it to fossil fuel dependence and environmental degradation. • Explain what renewable energy entails (solar, wind, hydro, biomass, green hydrogen) and its alignment with India's civilizational ethos (Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam) and sustainable living. • Discuss how renewables reduce emissions, enable electrification of transport and industry, support green hydrogen, and strengthen energy security. • India's Renewable Energy Journey: Highlight policy initiatives, targets (e.g., 50% non-fossil capacity by 2030), installed capacity, state-level innovations, and global positioning. • Discuss various Challenges & Roadblocks such as intermittency, grid integration, financing, land/environmental conflicts, and technological dependence. • Conclude by emphasizing India's long-term climate goals, sustainable development, just energy transition, and potential to emerge as a global leader in low-carbon technologies.
Introduction	The 21st century faces its gravest existential threat in climate change, manifested through rising global temperatures, melting glaciers, extreme weather events, and accelerating biodiversity loss. This crisis stems largely from unsustainable development models fuelled by fossil fuels. In this context, renewable energy (RE) emerges not merely as an alternative power source but as a transformative tool to reconcile economic growth with ecological balance. Solar, wind, hydro, biomass, and green hydrogen technologies enable low-carbon development, electrification of transport and industry, and the decarbonisation of hard-to-abate sectors. For India, abundant sunlight, wind potential, and policy initiatives like the National Solar Mission and Green Hydrogen Mission make RE central to its climate strategy. Beyond technology, renewable energy embodies ethical stewardship, reflecting the Indian ethos of "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam", treating the planet and its inhabitants as one interconnected family.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Climate Change and the Energy Dilemma** Climate change is fundamentally an energy problem. According to the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC, AR6), energy-related activities contribute nearly 73% of global greenhouse gas emissions, largely from burning coal, oil, and natural gas. While fossil fuels powered the Industrial Revolution, they are now principal drivers of planetary destabilization. In India, the energy sector accounts for roughly 70% of total CO_2 emissions, with coal alone providing nearly 75% of electricity generation (Central Electricity Authority, 2024). As the nation's economy grows, energy demand is projected

to double by 2040 (IEA, India Energy Outlook). This scenario underscores the intrinsic link between climate action and energy policy: mitigating climate change requires a decisive transition to clean, renewable energy that can support economic growth while reducing emissions.

Renewable Energy: Definition and Philosophical Essence

Renewable energy (RE) derives from resources that are naturally replenished—solar, wind, hydro, biomass, and geothermal. Beyond its technical definition, renewable energy embodies a moral philosophy: the principle of living within nature's limits. Ancient Indian traditions, such as the Rig Vedic hymn "Mata bhumih putro ham pṛithivyah" (The Earth is my mother, I am her son), echo this ethos of ecological balance. Unlike fossil fuels, renewable energy sources are non-depleting and decentralized, aligning with Mahatma Gandhi's ideal of "production by the masses rather than mass production." This perspective positions renewable energy not merely as a technological evolution but as a civilizational return to harmony between human needs and natural cycles.

Mechanisms of Climate Change Mitigation through Renewables

Renewable energy mitigates climate change in multiple ways. First, it directly reduces CO_2 emissions, as solar and wind power produce negligible greenhouse gases during operation. Replacing coal-fired power plants with renewable sources can displace nearly 0.8 tonnes of CO_2 per megawatt-hour of solar electricity compared to coal-based generation (IEA, 2024). Second, renewables enable the electrification of end-use sectors such as transport, industry, and buildings, thereby decarbonizing sectors that would otherwise rely on fossil fuels. Third, they facilitate the production of green hydrogen through electrolysis, offering a pathway to decarbonize industrial sectors like steel, fertilizer, and cement, where direct electrification is challenging. India's National Green Hydrogen Mission (2023) aims to produce five million metric tonnes per annum of green hydrogen by 2030, potentially avoiding 50 million tonnes of CO_2 annually (MNRE). Finally, renewables contribute indirectly by reducing pressure on forests, lowering air pollution, and enhancing energy security, cutting India's crude oil and LNG import bills by an estimated ₹8 lakh crore annually by 2030.

India's Renewable Energy Journey: Policy to Practice

India's renewable energy trajectory reflects a combination of ambitious policy and implementation. The country's Updated Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs, 2022) commit to achieving 50% cumulative electric power capacity from non-fossil sources by 2030 and reducing GDP emissions intensity by 45% relative to 2005 levels. Foundational initiatives include the National Solar Mission (2010), targeting 280 GW of solar capacity by 2030, the Wind Energy Mission, and the National Bioenergy Programme. Complementary measures, such as the Renewable Purchase Obligations (RPO) and the Energy Storage Obligation (2023), mandate a 43% renewable purchase by 2029-30, while the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme for solar manufacturing aims to reduce import dependence. As of August 2025, India's installed renewable capacity exceeds 123 GW, with solar at 74 GW, wind at 46 GW, and small hydro at 5 GW, making India the fourth-largest renewable energy market globally.

Innovative Models and State-Level Initiatives

Several states have emerged as pioneers in integrating renewable energy into their grids. Karnataka and Gujarat lead in solar-wind hybrid parks, while Ladakh's 13 GW Renewable Energy Park combines green hydrogen production and storage. Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu have achieved high wind penetration, occasionally meeting over 90% of state electricity demand. These regional success stories illustrate that renewable energy is transitioning from a peripheral supplement to a mainstay of India's energy system.

	Global Context: Renewables as the Backbone of Climate Action Globally, renewable energy is central to meeting climate goals. The IPCC's 2023 Mitigation Report identifies renewables as the largest contributor to emission reductions required to limit warming to 1.5°C. Policies such as the European Union's Green Deal, China's renewable expansion, and the U.S. Inflation Reduction Act (IRA, 2022) position renewable energy at the heart of climate action. In 2023, global investments in renewables exceeded USD 600 billion, surpassing fossil fuel investments for the first time (IEA, 2024). This trend demonstrates a decoupling of economic growth from emissions, a paradigm shift toward green capitalism and technological humanism. **Challenges in Renewable Energy Deployment** Despite their promise, renewable energy systems face challenges. Solar and wind are intermittent, and grid integration requires advanced storage and transmission infrastructure. Policy uncertainty and high capital costs can undermine investor confidence, as seen in past tariff renegotiations in Andhra Pradesh (2020). Large-scale solar parks often trigger land acquisition conflicts and biodiversity concerns, necessitating a just transition that respects communities and ecosystems. Moreover, India remains heavily dependent on imported solar modules (about 80%), emphasizing the need for indigenous R&D and manufacturing to achieve true energy self-reliance. **The Way Forward: A Just and Green Energy Transition** The future of climate mitigation hinges on systemic reforms. Accelerating grid modernization and battery storage (target 50 GW by 2030) and strengthening Green Energy Corridors can address intermittency challenges. Decentralized renewable models, including rooftop solar, solar pumps under the KUSUM scheme, and community mini-grids, empower rural areas and reduce transmission losses. Green hydrogen integration into industrial corridors and ports can decarbonize hard-to-electrify sectors. Ensuring regulatory stability, enhancing Renewable Purchase Obligations, and incentivizing green bonds and ESG investments are crucial for investor confidence. Finally, skill development initiatives must prepare the workforce for installation, maintenance, and manufacturing in the green economy, ensuring a just and inclusive energy transition.
Conclusion	Renewable energy is both a technological necessity and a moral imperative for climate change mitigation, enabling emission reduction, green industrial growth, and sustainable development. India, with its abundant solar and wind resources, demographic dividend, and policy momentum, is poised to achieve its futuristic climate goals, including 50% cumulative non-fossil power capacity by 2030, net-zero emissions by 2070, and large-scale green hydrogen adoption. Realising this vision requires addressing systemic challenges such as grid integration, technology dependence, and ensuring an inclusive, just transition. Beyond powering homes and industries, renewable energy reflects India's civilizational ethos of harmony with nature. Strategically harnessed, it can make India a low-carbon, technologically self-reliant, and globally influential leader in climate action, demonstrating that economic progress, environmental justice, and sustainable development can advance together.
Model Question	"India has pledged to achieve Net Zero greenhouse gas emissions by 2070. Comment
Value Addition	***India's Updated INDCs (Panchamrit) announced at COP-26:*** • To increase its non-fossil fuel energy capacity to 500 gigawatt (GW) by 2030. • To meet 50% of energy requirements from renewable sources by 2030. • The total projected carbon emissions will be reduced by 1 billion tonnes from now through 2030. • The carbon intensity of its economy will be brought down to less than 45%.

	• Net Zero carbons emissions by 2070.
43. "The world is now in the middle of a new mobility revolution- Examine India's efforts at accelerating the deployment of electric vehicles (EVs). (APPSC, 2023)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues
Keyword	Examine
Approach	• Start with the global shift to sustainable transport as part of the mobility revolution. • Mention India's push towards EVs for reducing oil imports, pollution, and carbon footprint. • State Government schemes like FAME I & II, PLI for ACC batteries, and EV30@30 target. • State EV policies (Telangana, Delhi, Maharashtra) promoting charging infra and subsidies. • Mention EV sales surge (over 1.5 million in 2023, Vahan data), showing early success. • Stress Challenges like high upfront costs, charging infra gaps, and battery dependency on China. • Conclude that EV adoption is central to India's net-zero 2070 target and future energy security, but requires faster infra, R&D, and private participation.
Introduction	The 21st century has witnessed an unprecedented transformation in mobility, driven by technological innovation, sustainability imperatives, and global commitments to mitigate climate change. The world is undoubtedly in the middle of a new mobility revolution, where the transition from fossil fuel–based vehicles to electric vehicles (EVs) has become the cornerstone of sustainable transportation. India, as the world's third-largest automobile market and one of the fastest-growing economies, stands at a critical juncture in this global transition. With its rapidly urbanising population, increasing energy demands, and rising concerns about air pollution and carbon emissions, India has initiated a multipronged approach to accelerate the deployment of EVs. The government, private sector, and civil society are collectively shaping this transition, though challenges of affordability, infrastructure, and technology persist.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Global Context of the Mobility Revolution** Globally, the mobility revolution is being shaped by two major forces: decarbonization and digitalisation. The International Energy Agency (IEA) projects that by 2030, EVs could account for over 40% of total vehicle sales worldwide, up from just 13% in 2022. Countries such as Norway, which has mandated a complete shift to zero-emission vehicles by 2025, and China, which accounts for more than 60% of the world's EV sales, have set examples of large-scale adoption. In this backdrop, India's efforts are crucial not only for its domestic sustainability goals but also for the global fight against climate change, as transport contributes nearly 14% of global greenhouse gas emissions. **India's Policy Push for Electric Vehicles** India's EV journey has been guided by ambitious policy frameworks and visionary targets. The National Electric Mobility Mission Plan (NEMMP) 2020, launched in 2013, laid the groundwork for electric mobility by envisioning the adoption of 6–7 million EVs by 2020. Building on this, the Faster Adoption and Manufacturing of Electric Vehicles (FAME) scheme was introduced, with FAME I (2015) providing subsidies for hybrid and electric vehicles, and FAME II (2019–2024) allocating ₹10,000 crore for demand incentives, charging infrastructure, and electrification of public transport. The government has also unveiled the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme for Advanced Chemistry Cell (ACC) batteries with an outlay of ₹18,100 crore to encourage domestic battery manufacturing and reduce dependence on imports. In addition, the

target of the EV30@30 campaign, endorsed by India at the Clean Energy Ministerial, commits the country to achieving 30% EV sales across categories by 2030. These policies signify that India is not merely responding to global trends but actively shaping its domestic trajectory in line with sustainable development goals.

Institutional and State-Level Interventions for Electric Vehicle Mobility

While central policies provide a broad framework, state governments have played a pioneering role in accelerating EV deployment. Delhi's EV Policy (2020) offers purchase incentives up to ₹30,000 for two-wheelers and ₹1.5 lakh for four-wheelers, along with waiver of road tax and registration fees. Similarly, states like Telangana, Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, and Gujarat have introduced comprehensive EV policies offering capital subsidies for manufacturing units, incentives for charging stations, and targets for EV penetration. For instance, Telangana has positioned itself as an EV manufacturing hub, attracting investments from global players such as Olectra Greentech and Amara Raja Batteries. Such subnational initiatives reflect India's federal approach to the mobility revolution.

Market Trends and Industry Response to Mobility revolution

The Indian EV market has witnessed exponential growth in recent years. The growth has been driven primarily by two-wheelers, which account for nearly 60% of total EV sales, led by companies like Ola Electric, Ather Energy, and Hero Electric. The electric bus segment is also expanding, with state transport undertakings procuring thousands of e-buses under the FAME II scheme. The private sector is complementing government efforts with large-scale investments: Tata Motors has become the leader in the electric car market, while Mahindra & Mahindra and Hyundai are expanding their EV portfolios. Furthermore, energy companies like Reliance and Adani are venturing into EV charging infrastructure, signalling convergence between the automobile and energy sectors.

Charging Infrastructure and Technological Innovations for Electric vehicles

One of the central challenges of EV adoption is the availability of reliable charging infrastructure. India has made progress in this direction with the Ministry of Power's guidelines mandating charging stations every 25 km on highways. Startups like Statiq and Sun Mobility are experimenting with innovative solutions such as battery swapping, which is particularly suited for commercial fleets and two-wheelers. Technological advancements are also being driven by indigenous research in lithium-ion alternatives such as solid-state batteries, sodium-ion, and green hydrogen for heavy transport, ensuring that India's mobility revolution is aligned with its Atmanirbhar Bharat vision.

Environmental and Economic Implications of EV mobility

The transition to EVs carries profound environmental and economic benefits. According to the Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) noted that a 30% EV sales share by 2030 would result in savings on crude oil imports worth ₹1.1 lakh crore ($14.1 billion). Given that India spends nearly $100 billion each year on crude oil imports, this transition has the potential to enhance energy security and reduce vulnerability to global oil price shocks. On the environmental front, EV adoption directly contributes to India's net-zero by 2070 commitment, made at COP26 in Glasgow. Cities like Delhi, which rank among the most polluted in the world, could see significant improvement in air quality if EV penetration is scaled up, offering co-benefits for public health.

Challenges and Roadblocks for the Mobility Revolution in India

Despite these advances, India's EV transition faces several challenges. High upfront costs, largely due to expensive batteries, deter mass adoption. With lithium and cobalt reserves concentrated in a few countries such as China and the Democratic Republic of Congo, supply chain vulnerabilities persist. Charging infrastructure remains inadequate,

	especially in rural areas, limiting EV adoption beyond urban centres. Moreover, the power sector itself is heavily dependent on coal, raising questions about the true greenness of EVs unless powered by renewables. Policy uncertainty and frequent changes in subsidy structures also affect consumer confidence and industry planning. These challenges highlight the need for a holistic ecosystem approach rather than piecemeal interventions. **Global Comparisons and Lessons for India** Countries leading in EV adoption provide valuable lessons for India. Norway's success stems from aggressive tax exemptions and extensive charging infrastructure, while China's dominance is built on state-led manufacturing incentives and control over the battery supply chain. The European Union has set ambitious carbon emission standards, forcing automobile manufacturers to transition to EVs. For India, adapting these lessons requires balancing affordability with sustainability, ensuring that EVs are not just aspirational products for the elite but accessible to the masses, particularly in the two-wheeler and three-wheeler segments.
Conclusion	The world is indeed in the middle of a new mobility revolution, and India is emerging as an important player in this transformation. With strong policy support, growing industry participation, and rising consumer awareness, India's EV journey reflects both ambition and pragmatism. Yet, the road ahead requires sustained efforts in building infrastructure, securing raw materials, fostering indigenous R&D, and ensuring integration with renewable energy sources. As Mahatma Gandhi once said, "The future depends on what we do in the present." For India, accelerating the deployment of EVs is not merely about keeping pace with global trends but about ensuring a sustainable, secure, and inclusive future for its citizens. The mobility revolution, if steered wisely, has the potential to reshape India's energy economy and reinforce its leadership in global climate action.
Model Question	"India aspires to achieve a clean energy transition in the transport sector. Critically analyse the policy measures, challenges, and prospects of promoting electric mobility in India."
Value Addition	The FAME-III scheme is India's planned third phase of the Faster Adoption and Manufacturing of (Hybrid &) Electric Vehicles initiative, but it has been replaced by the PM Electric Drive Revolution in Innovative Vehicle Enhancement (PM E-DRIVE) Scheme. Launched on September 29, 2024, and effective from October 1, 2024, to March 31, 2026, the PM E-DRIVE scheme has a budget of ₹10,900 crore and aims to promote the adoption of electric vehicles, including e-2W, e-3W, e-trucks, e-buses, and e-ambulances, while also supporting charging infrastructure development.
44. The Draft Environment Impact Assessment (EIA) Notification of 2020: An Analysis. (APPSC, 2020)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues
Keyword	Analysis
Approach	• Start with the importance of EIA in sustainable development. • Trace the evolution of EIA in India (1994, 2006 notifications). • Summarize key provisions of Draft 2020 (post-facto approvals, reduced public consultation). • Highlight rationale: ease of doing business, faster clearances. • Discuss criticisms: dilution of environmental safeguards, curtailed community rights. • Give examples (Vizag gas leak, coal mining in biodiversity zones). • Balance by presenting the need for both development and ecological sustainability. • Conclude with suggestions: transparent process, participatory governance, stronger enforcement.

Introduction	Environmental governance in India has evolved as a response to the twin challenges of development and ecological sustainability. The Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) framework, introduced in 1994 and strengthened through the EIA Notification of 2006, is a crucial regulatory tool to assess the potential environmental costs of industrial and developmental projects. However, the Draft EIA Notification of 2020 sparked intense debate, drawing both support for its focus on streamlining clearances and criticism for allegedly diluting safeguards. Against the backdrop of increasing environmental degradation, India ranks 180 out of 180 in the 2022 Environmental Performance Index. This notification represents a critical juncture in balancing growth with sustainability.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Evolution of the EIA Framework in India** The EIA system in India traces its roots to the Environment Protection Act, 1986, enacted after the Bhopal Gas Tragedy of 1984. Initially, it was an administrative measure, later formalized through the 1994 EIA Notification, which made prior environmental clearance mandatory for certain projects. The 2006 Notification decentralized the process, introduced public consultation, and categorized projects into A (central clearance) and B (state clearance). This framework aligned with global sustainable development goals, ensuring that environmental concerns were integrated into decision-making. Over time, however, delays, bureaucratic red tape, and allegations of misuse led to demands for reform, setting the stage for the Draft EIA Notification of 2020. **Key Provisions of the Draft EIA Notification 2020** The Draft EIA 2020 sought to replace the 2006 framework with a more streamlined structure. Among its key provisions was the introduction of post-facto environmental clearances, allowing projects to operate even if they had commenced without prior approval, subject to penalties. It also proposed reducing the frequency of compliance reporting from every six months to once a year, thereby lessening the regulatory burden. The draft curtailed the scope of public consultation, exempting certain projects such as modernization of irrigation systems, linear projects like highways and pipelines, and those of "strategic importance" decided by the government. Additionally, validity periods for environmental clearances were extended, for instance, mining projects from 30 to 50 years, and river valley projects from 10 to 15 years, thereby reducing the need for frequent re-assessment. **Rationale and Support for the Draft Notification** The government justified these provisions as necessary to improve the ease of doing business and accelerate infrastructure growth. India, as one of the fastest-growing economies, needs rapid approvals for industries, energy projects, and urban development. The Ministry of Environment, Forest, and Climate Change (MoEFCC) argued that the reforms would reduce bureaucratic delays, encourage investment, and create jobs. Proponents cited examples where delays in environmental clearances had stalled critical infrastructure such as highways, ports, and power plants, adversely impacting economic growth. They also argued that the draft introduced greater transparency through digital portals and monitoring mechanisms. In a country ranked 63rd in the World Bank's Ease of Doing Business 2020 report, aligning environmental regulations with development needs was presented as a pragmatic step. **Criticisms and Concerns: Dilution of Safeguards** Despite the rationale, the Draft EIA 2020 drew sharp criticism from environmentalists, civil society groups, and the judiciary. The post-facto clearance provision was seen as legitimizing violations, undermining the very purpose of prior assessment. The Supreme Court in Common Cause vs Union of India (2017) had already ruled that ex-post facto approvals are contrary to environmental law. Similarly, reducing public participation was

viewed as regressive. Public hearings have historically empowered local communities, as seen in resistance to projects like the Vedanta mining in Niyamgiri Hills, where tribal voices were critical in halting ecologically destructive projects. Exemptions for "strategic projects," without clear definitions, raised fears of misuse, potentially allowing environmentally sensitive projects to bypass scrutiny.

Case Studies Highlighting Risks

Several recent incidents illustrate the dangers of diluted environmental oversight. The Vizag Gas Leak (May 2020) at LG Polymers occurred in a plant operating without proper environmental clearance, causing 12 deaths and affecting thousands. Similarly, the Chardham road project in Uttarakhand, classified as a linear project, bypassed stringent scrutiny despite concerns about landslides and Himalayan fragility. The coal mining clearances in Dehing Patkai Elephant Reserve in Assam highlighted how biodiversity-rich areas could be jeopardized by weakened environmental assessments. These cases underline the argument that strong EIA regulations are not a hurdle but a safeguard against irreversible ecological damage.

Public Response and Legal Challenges

The Draft EIA 2020 received widespread public backlash. The Ministry reportedly received over 1.8 million objections and suggestions from citizens, NGOs, and experts during the consultation period. Critics argued that the draft violated the principle of intergenerational equity, recognized in international law and upheld in Indian jurisprudence, notably in the Vellore Citizens' Welfare Forum vs Union of India (1996). In August 2020, the Delhi High Court extended the deadline for public feedback, recognizing the importance of participatory democracy in environmental governance. Petitions were also filed in various courts challenging the legality of post-facto clearances.

Balancing Development and Environment

The debate around EIA 2020 reflects the broader dilemma of balancing development with ecological sustainability. India faces pressing development needs like housing, jobs, infrastructure, and energy, while also being one of the most vulnerable nations to climate change. The Global Climate Risk Index 2021 ranked India among the top ten most affected countries by extreme weather events. Development projects, if poorly assessed, can exacerbate disasters, as seen in the Joshimath subsidence crisis (2023), where unregulated construction and hydropower projects destabilized the fragile Himalayan ecosystem. Thus, while efficiency in approvals is necessary, environmental due diligence cannot be compromised.

Comparative Global Perspectives

Globally, EIAs are recognized as vital tools for sustainable development. The United States introduced NEPA (National Environmental Policy Act) in 1970, mandating environmental assessments for federal projects. The European Union has stringent directives requiring extensive public participation and cumulative impact assessments. China, though criticized for weak enforcement, has gradually strengthened its EIA regime after facing severe ecological crises. In comparison, the Draft EIA 2020 was seen as regressive, moving India away from global best practices and undermining its commitments under the Paris Climate Agreement (2015) and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly SDG 13 (climate action) and SDG 15 (life on land).

Way Forward: Towards Inclusive and Sustainable EIA

Reforming the EIA framework is necessary, but it must be done in a manner that strengthens environmental safeguards while addressing development concerns. Digitalization of clearance processes can enhance transparency, but exemptions that

	limit public participation must be reconsidered. Periodic review of projects should be retained, ensuring that long-term impacts are monitored in light of climate change. Strengthening state-level capacity, investing in independent expert committees, and ensuring accountability of violators through strict penalties are essential. Most importantly, environmental governance must prioritize the principle of sustainable development, enshrined in Article 21 of the Constitution as part of the right to life. As former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi stated at the 1972 Stockholm Conference, "We do not want to impoverish the environment any further and yet we cannot for a moment forget the grim poverty of large numbers of people."
Conclusion	The Draft EIA Notification of 2020 is a significant attempt to reform environmental regulation, but its provisions raise serious concerns about weakening safeguards, reducing accountability, and side-lining local voices. At a time when India faces the dual crises of climate change and ecological degradation, environmental governance must be strengthened, not diluted. The challenge lies in creating a framework that simultaneously accelerates development and ensures ecological sustainability. As the 1987 Brundtland Report on sustainable development emphasized, the needs of the present must be met without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs. For India, this means an EIA framework that is transparent, participatory, and uncompromising in protecting its natural heritage while enabling inclusive growth.
Model Question	"Balancing ecological sustainability with economic growth is the biggest governance challenge of the 21st century." Critically analyze with reference to India.
Value Addition	The 1972 Stockholm Conference, officially the United Nations Conference on the Human Environment, was the first major UN conference on environmental issues, held in Stockholm, Sweden, from June 5-16, 1972. It placed ecological concerns on the international agenda, fostering dialogue between developed and developing nations, and resulted in the Stockholm Declaration and a UN Action Plan for the environment. The conference led to the establishment of the UN Environment Programme (UNEP) and is considered a pivotal moment in the birth of international environmental politics and diplomacy.
45. How to maintain a proper balance between developmental activities and water conservation? (APPSC, 2020)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues
Keyword	How
Approach	• Begin with the conflict between rapid development and water depletion. • Note industrialisation, urbanisation, and irrigation as stress factors. • Highlight problems of groundwater overuse and pollution. • Suggest integrated water resource management and conservation. • Mention policies like Jal Jeevan Mission, Atal Bhujal Yojana. • Cite Examples such as Mission Kakatiya (Telangana), micro-irrigation in AP. • Stress sustainable technologies, water audits, and strict EIAs. • Conclude that true development ensures water security for future generations.
Introduction	Water is the elixir of life and the backbone of civilization, yet it is also one of the most stressed natural resources of the twenty-first century. With India's rapid economic growth, urbanization, and industrial expansion, the demand for water has multiplied, leading to over-extraction, pollution, and mismanagement. The NITI Aayog's Composite Water Management Index (2018) warned that 21 Indian cities, including Hyderabad, Bengaluru, and Chennai, are likely to run out of groundwater soon, threatening the lives of 100 million people. At the same time, developmental activities such as infrastructure building, agricultural expansion, and industrialisation are indispensable for economic

	progress. The challenge lies in how to maintain a proper balance between developmental activities and water conservation so that growth does not compromise sustainability. Achieving this balance is not just an environmental necessity but also a developmental imperative.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The Conflict Between Development and Water Resources** Developmental activities exert enormous pressure on water resources. The construction of dams, highways, and urban settlements alters natural hydrological cycles. Industrial activities consume vast quantities of water and discharge pollutants into rivers and groundwater. Agriculture, which accounts for nearly 80 per cent of India's freshwater use, often relies on unsustainable irrigation practices. Climate change further compounds the crisis by making rainfall erratic, causing droughts and floods. The World Bank's 2022 report highlights that India is one of the world's most water-stressed countries. This conflict between development and water availability demands innovative solutions to ensure that economic progress does not lead to ecological collapse. **Importance of Water Conservation for Sustainable Development** Water conservation is vital not only for ecological reasons but also for maintaining economic and social stability. Without water, industries halt, agriculture collapses, and cities face crises of drinking water supply. The United Nations' Sustainable Development Goal 6 emphasises universal access to clean water and sanitation, underscoring its centrality to global development. It was rightly said, "Every drop of water is precious; every drop must be conserved." In India, recurring droughts in states like Maharashtra and Rajasthan have demonstrated how water scarcity can disrupt livelihoods, fuel farmer distress, and trigger migration. Thus, balancing developmental activities with water conservation is critical to sustaining growth, reducing poverty, and ensuring inter-generational equity. **Policy Initiatives for Balancing Development and Water Use** India has undertaken several policy measures to integrate development with water conservation. The Jal Jeevan Mission, launched in 2019, aims to provide piped drinking water to every rural household by 2024, emphasising source sustainability through rainwater harvesting and groundwater recharge. The Atal Bhujal Yojana focuses on community-led groundwater management in water-stressed regions. Telangana's Mission Kakatiya, which revived over 46,000 tanks, has significantly improved groundwater levels and irrigation potential, providing a model of decentralised water conservation. Andhra Pradesh has promoted micro-irrigation and drip systems, enhancing water use efficiency in agriculture. These initiatives show that when development is aligned with conservation, both objectives can be met. **Role of Technology and Innovation** Technology offers promising solutions for balancing development with water conservation. Satellite-based monitoring of groundwater levels, artificial intelligence-driven irrigation systems, and smart water meters help optimise usage. The Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchai Yojana emphasises "more crop per drop" through precision irrigation. Israel's example of using drip irrigation in 90 per cent of its agriculture demonstrates how technology can reconcile high productivity with water efficiency. An area of 83.46 lakh hectares has been covered under Micro Irrigation in the Country under Per Drop More Crop (PDMC) from 2015-16 to 2023-24, but it still covers only a fraction of the total cultivated land. Expanding such technologies can reduce agricultural water consumption while sustaining productivity. Similarly, industrial water recycling and zero liquid discharge technologies are being adopted in sectors like textiles and pharmaceuticals to minimize pollution.

	Community and Traditional Knowledge in Water Conservation Balancing development with water conservation also requires leveraging traditional wisdom and community participation. India has a rich history of indigenous water management practices such as baolis (step wells), johads (earthen ponds), and tank irrigation systems. Rajendra Singh, known as the "Waterman of India," revived traditional johads in Rajasthan, transforming drought-prone villages into water-secure communities. Community-led initiatives in Maharashtra's Hiware Bazar, where collective watershed management revived groundwater, demonstrate the power of social mobilization. Such models show that development and conservation are not contradictory but mutually reinforcing when communities are empowered. **Case Studies of Imbalance and Its Consequences** The consequences of failing to maintain a proper balance are evident in several parts of India. The drying up of Chennai's reservoirs in 2019 brought the city to a standstill, forcing industries and households to depend on costly tanker water. Excessive groundwater extraction in Punjab and Haryana for water-intensive crops like paddy has led to a fall in groundwater tables by 0.5 meters annually, threatening long-term agricultural sustainability. Pollution of the Yamuna and Ganga rivers by untreated industrial effluents undermines not only aquatic ecosystems but also public health. These examples demonstrate that unchecked developmental activities without conservation strategies lead to ecological and economic disasters. **Integrating Water in Development Planning** A proper balance requires mainstreaming water conservation into all developmental planning. Environmental Impact Assessments (EIA) must rigorously evaluate the water footprints of projects. Urban planning should incorporate rainwater harvesting, recycling, and stormwater management. Agriculture policies should promote less water-intensive crops, crop diversification, and sustainable practices. Inter-basin water transfers, while controversial, can be explored with ecological safeguards. International experiences such as Singapore's "Four National Taps" strategy, which combines imported water, desalination, recycling, and rainwater harvesting, provide useful lessons for India.
Conclusion	Maintaining a proper balance between developmental activities and water conservation is one of the defining challenges of contemporary India. Development is essential to create jobs, build infrastructure, and enhance living standards, but it cannot be pursued at the cost of exhausting water resources, which are fundamental to life itself. The key lies in adopting a holistic approach that integrates technology, policy, traditional wisdom, and community participation. It was said, "Saving our planet, lifting people out of poverty, advancing economic growth, these are the same fight." In this light, water conservation must not be viewed as a constraint on development but as a foundation for sustainable and resilient progress. True development is that which secures water for both present and future generations while ensuring that economic aspirations and ecological necessities walk hand in hand.
Model Question	Discuss strategies for reconciling rapid economic development with sustainable management of water resources in India.
Value Addition	Singapore's "Four National Taps" is a water resource management strategy that creates a diversified and sustainable water supply by utilizing four primary sources: local catchment water collected from rainfall, imported water from other countries, NEWater (reclaimed and treated used water), and desalinated water from the sea. This integrated approach, managed by the Public Utilities Board (PUB), aims to reduce the nation's reliance on any single water source and ensure long-term water security, overcoming the challenges of being a small, land-scarce country with no natural freshwater sources.

46. In Stephen Hawking's words, "Mankind must move to outer space within a century". In the backdrop of his prediction, what are the factors leading to pessimism in turning around the global environmental degradation? Discuss (APPSC, 2017)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues
Keyword	What and discuss
Approach	• Quote Hawking's warning on planetary survival, linking it to current environmental crises. • Mention global inaction despite scientific awareness. • State Climate change inertia, such as rising emissions despite Paris Agreement goals. • Stress on Deforestation, biodiversity loss, and water scarcity is worsening ecosystems. • Mention Overconsumption & inequality between developed vs developing countries blame game. • State Weak global governance, like failures of COP summits, and reliance on fossil fuels. • Argue that pessimism persists due to slow collective action; unless sustainable development is prioritised, Hawking's vision may become reality.
Introduction	When Stephen Hawking warned that mankind must move to outer space within a century for survival, it was not merely a futuristic vision of space colonisation but a grim reflection on the deteriorating health of our planet. His statement underscores the magnitude of the environmental crisis confronting humanity, where traditional solutions often fall short and the pace of degradation far outstrips the pace of corrective measures. Despite decades of awareness, international treaties, and technological progress, pessimism continues to dominate global environmental discourse. Rising carbon emissions, biodiversity collapse, unsustainable resource extraction, and weak global governance mechanisms all fuel the belief that reversing environmental degradation remains an elusive goal.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Climate Change and the Inertia of Action** One of the strongest drivers of pessimism is the failure of the global community to effectively combat climate change. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) in its Sixth Assessment Report (2022) warned that global warming has already reached 1.1°C above pre-industrial levels, with catastrophic consequences such as extreme weather events, floods, and droughts becoming more frequent. Despite commitments under the Paris Agreement to limit warming to well below 2°C, global greenhouse gas emissions continue to rise. According to UNEP's Emissions Gap Report 2023, current pledges would still lead to a temperature rise of 2.5–2.9°C by the end of the century. Such stark projections reveal a dangerous gap between promises and performance, reinforcing pessimism about humankind's capacity to avert climate catastrophe. **Biodiversity Collapse and Ecosystem Loss** Another factor deepening pessimism is the unprecedented decline in biodiversity. The Living Planet Report 2022 by WWF shows a 69% decline in wildlife populations between 1970 and 2018. Deforestation in the Amazon, loss of coral reefs, and desertification in Sub-Saharan Africa point to the widespread destruction of ecosystems critical for ecological balance. The United Nations Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD) had earlier set the Aichi Targets for 2020, yet not a single target was fully met. The failure of the international community to conserve biodiversity, despite its central role in food

security, climate regulation, and cultural identity, demonstrates humanity's limited resolve in reversing environmental destruction.

Overconsumption and Unsustainable Resource Use

The unsustainable exploitation of natural resources adds to the gloom. The Global Footprint Network estimates that humanity currently consumes resources equivalent to 1.7 Earths annually, indicating overshoot far beyond the planet's regenerative capacity. Rising consumption in developed nations and the aspiration-driven consumption in developing countries are straining Earth's resources. Water scarcity is another pressing issue, with the World Resources Institute warning that nearly 2.3 billion people face high water stress today. Similarly, overfishing has led to the depletion of 90% of global fish stocks. These patterns of overconsumption fuel pessimism as they suggest that humanity is locked in an extractive trajectory that disregards planetary boundaries.

Inequality and the Global North-South Divide

Global environmental degradation is also shaped by inequality and power imbalances between developed and developing countries. While developed nations are historically responsible for the bulk of greenhouse gas emissions, it is developing countries like India, Bangladesh, and island states that bear the brunt of climate-induced disasters. Climate justice remains elusive, with the promised $100 billion annual climate finance by developed countries under the Paris Agreement still unmet. The lack of accountability, coupled with the disproportionate vulnerability of poorer nations, creates pessimism about the fairness and inclusivity of global climate governance. As Mahatma Gandhi once remarked, "The Earth provides enough to satisfy every man's need but not every man's greed." The failure to equitably share responsibility fuels mistrust and hampers collective action.

Weak International Environmental Governance

The repeated failures of international summits highlight the fragility of global environmental governance. The COP summits, though important, often result in diluted outcomes due to conflicting national interests. For example, COP27 in Sharm el-Sheikh made some progress with the agreement on a Loss and Damage Fund, but fell short of concrete emission reduction commitments. International treaties like the Kyoto Protocol and the Paris Agreement, while symbolically significant, have lacked enforcement mechanisms. The absence of binding obligations and the dominance of economic interests over ecological priorities reflect systemic weaknesses in global institutions, leading to scepticism about the ability to effectively govern environmental challenges.

Technological Optimism and Its Limitations

While technology has been hailed as a saviour, it has also contributed to pessimism due to its limitations and unintended consequences. Renewable energy, electric vehicles, and carbon capture technologies are important steps, but their scalability and affordability remain limited. For instance, solar and wind energy still face intermittency challenges, and rare earth mining for batteries poses new environmental risks. Geoengineering, often proposed as a solution to climate change, raises ethical and ecological concerns. The over-reliance on technological fixes without addressing root causes, such as overconsumption and fossil fuel dependency, creates doubts about the sufficiency of human innovation to reverse degradation.

Population Pressure and Urbanisation

The sheer scale of population growth and urban expansion also fuels pessimism. The global population crossed 8 billion in 2022, placing unprecedented pressure on land, water, and energy resources. Rapid urbanisation, particularly in Asia and Africa, has led to unsustainable patterns of land use, congestion, and pollution. According to UN-

	Habitat, cities consume over 70% of global energy and emit more than 60% of greenhouse gases, despite occupying just 2% of the world's land area. The expansion of megacities without sustainable planning worsens air quality and depletes green cover, making environmental reversal a daunting task. **Corporate Influence and Political Will** The influence of powerful corporate lobbies, particularly fossil fuel industries, continues to obstruct meaningful environmental reforms. Reports from watchdog groups show that major oil and coal companies invest heavily in lobbying against stricter climate policies while greenwashing their public image. Political will is often compromised by short-term electoral considerations, leading to delayed or diluted policies. The intertwining of profit motives with governance weakens long-term ecological commitments, creating widespread pessimism about whether governments can resist corporate pressures to genuinely prioritise environmental sustainability. **Cultural Attitudes and Human Behaviour** Underlying all structural and policy failures are cultural attitudes and behavioural patterns that resist sustainable change. Consumerism, the pursuit of economic growth at all costs, and apathy toward environmental concerns are deeply entrenched. Behavioural economics suggests that individuals often undervalue long-term ecological benefits compared to immediate gains, leading to overuse of resources. While awareness campaigns and environmental movements like Fridays for Future have raised consciousness, they have yet to achieve the large-scale behavioural transformation needed to reverse degradation. This inertia of human behaviour adds a psychological dimension to pessimism, making it appear that environmental sustainability remains a distant ideal.
Conclusion	Stephen Hawking's cautionary statement serves as both a metaphor and a warning. The call to move to outer space within a century reflects a deep pessimism about humanity's ability to reverse environmental degradation. This pessimism arises from the cumulative weight of factors such as climate change inertia, biodiversity loss, overconsumption, inequality, weak governance, technological limitations, and entrenched behavioural patterns. Yet, while the outlook appears bleak, it also compels humanity to recognise the urgency of change. The same human ingenuity that fuels destruction has the potential to drive solutions if political will, equity, and collective responsibility are prioritised. As the Indian philosopher Rabindranath Tagore once wrote, "Faith is the bird that feels the light when the dawn is still dark." Despite the pessimism, it is only through renewed hope, decisive action, and global solidarity that mankind can ensure survival on Earth, rather than seeking refuge in outer space.
Model Question	"Despite global environmental agreements and technological advancements, ecological deterioration continues unabated. Discuss the underlying causes of this pessimism in reversing environmental decline."
Value Addition	The Aichi Targets were 20 global biodiversity targets, adopted by the Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD) in 2010 as part of a 10-year plan (2011-2020) to address the loss of biodiversity. These targets, named after Nagoya, Japan, where they were adopted, focused on reducing pressures on biodiversity, improving its status, and enhancing the implementation of the plan. They were succeeded by the Global Biodiversity Framework, adopted in 2022.
47. "River linking is a panacea for the woes of farmers of Andhra Pradesh". In light of the above statement, explain how river linking can solve the problem of water scarcity in Andhra Pradesh. Also, describe the Pattiseema project of Andhra Pradesh and its benefits? (APPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues

Keyword	Explain and Describe
Approach	• Introduce the problem that Andhra farmers face, like recurring droughts, uneven water distribution (Rayalaseema vs. coastal). • Mention River linking envisaged as a panacea for inter-basin transfer of surplus to deficit areas. • State Benefits like irrigation, drinking water, groundwater recharge, and flood mitigation. • Mention Specific AP projects such as Godavari-Krishna (Pattiseema), Godavari-Penna, and Krishna-Penna links. • Explain Pattiseema project. • Mention Benefits like the irrigated Krishna delta, stabilised crops, and saved Polavaram construction time. • State Challenges like ecological impact, displacement, cost burden, and interstate disputes. • Conclude that River linking can address scarcity, but requires ecological balance, cooperation, and sustainability.
Introduction	Water has always been central to the prosperity of Andhra Pradesh, a state with vast agricultural potential but uneven distribution of resources. While the Godavari and Krishna rivers nourish the coastal belts, regions like Rayalaseema and parts of Prakasam face recurring droughts. Agriculture, which supports nearly 60 per cent of the state's population, is vulnerable to seasonal monsoons and water scarcity. Against this backdrop, river linking has been described as a panacea for the woes of farmers, offering a structural solution to chronic shortages. The vision of linking surplus rivers with deficit basins is not new; it was originally mooted in the 1970s by the National Water Development Agency. However, Andhra Pradesh stands out for implementing one of India's earliest inter-basin transfer projects, like the Pattiseema Lift Irrigation Scheme, which links the Godavari with the Krishna. Analysing river linking in Andhra Pradesh, with special emphasis on Pattiseema, highlights its potential, benefits, and challenges in addressing water scarcity.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The Problem of Water Scarcity in Andhra Pradesh** Andhra Pradesh's geography and climate accentuate disparities in water availability. The coastal districts of East and West Godavari and Krishna are well irrigated, while Rayalaseema and southern districts like Anantapur and Kadapa are drought-prone. Anantapur alone records an average annual rainfall of barely 500 mm, among the lowest in India, compared to over 1,000 mm in the coastal belt. With groundwater depletion accelerating, Central Groundwater Board data shows many mandals in Rayalaseema are already overexploited, and farmers face uncertainty and crop failures. The agricultural distress is evident in recurring farmer suicides. The imbalance between surplus and deficit basins makes river linking a compelling necessity for equitable distribution. **River Linking as a Panacea for Farmers' Woes** The principle of river linking lies in diverting surplus waters from rivers like the Godavari, which discharges nearly 3,000 TMC into the sea annually, to deficit basins such as the Krishna, Pennar, and Cauvery. For Andhra Pradesh, this offers multiple benefits. It ensures irrigation for drought-prone regions, stabilises command areas dependent on uncertain rainfall, and enhances drinking water availability. It also supports industrial growth and power generation, fostering balanced regional development. By reducing farmers' dependence on monsoons, river linking can directly address agricultural distress. The Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO) has observed that every rupee invested in irrigation infrastructure yields a multiplier effect on agricultural GDP,

reinforcing why river linking can be transformative. For Andhra farmers, whose livelihoods are precariously tied to water, such projects can indeed act as a panacea.

The Pattiseema Lift Irrigation Scheme: An Overview

The Pattiseema Project, inaugurated in 2016, is a pioneering example of interlinking rivers in India. Located in West Godavari district, it lifts water from the Godavari's Polavaram right canal and diverts it to the Krishna river through the Pattiseema Lift Irrigation Scheme. The project comprises 24 pumping units, each with a capacity of 12.5 MW, making it one of the largest lift irrigation systems in Asia. With the ability to transfer around 100 TMC of water annually, Pattiseema stabilises the Krishna delta and supplements water availability to drought-prone districts. The project was completed in a record time of one year at a cost of about ₹1,300 crore, demonstrating political will and administrative efficiency. It has been hailed by the NITI Aayog and the Ministry of Water Resources as a model for other states.

Benefits of the Pattiseema Project

The benefits of Pattiseema are multifold. First, it has ensured the stabilisation of the Krishna delta, which supports over 13 lakh acres of agriculture, including rice, pulses, and horticultural crops. By diverting Godavari water, it has reduced pressure on the Srisailam and Nagarjuna Sagar reservoirs, allowing their waters to be redirected to Rayalaseema and Telangana. Second, the project has provided drinking water security to major cities like Vijayawada and Guntur, as well as to rural populations across the Krishna basin. Third, by ensuring water availability, Pattiseema has prevented crop losses, thereby reducing farmer indebtedness and distress. According to government data, the project has enabled the cultivation of an additional 7 lakh acres annually, boosting rural incomes. Fourth, it has enhanced groundwater recharge in parched areas, providing a long-term ecological benefit. Beyond agriculture, the project also contributes to hydro-power management by optimising reservoir levels.

Social and Economic Impact of River Linking

River linking projects like Pattiseema have broader socio-economic implications. They reduce rural-to-urban migration by stabilising agricultural livelihoods, thus sustaining rural economies. They create direct employment during construction and indirect opportunities through increased agricultural productivity. Studies by the International Water Management Institute (IWMI) highlight that inter-basin transfers can improve equity in water distribution, narrowing rural-urban divides. For women, who bear the burden of fetching water in rural areas, enhanced drinking water access has significant social implications. Furthermore, stabilised irrigation encourages diversification into high-value crops like fruits and vegetables, boosting farmers' incomes and state revenue. In the long run, such projects also attract agro-industries and food processing units, creating a virtuous cycle of growth.

Challenges and Criticisms

Despite its promise, river linking is not without challenges. Environmentalists caution that large-scale interlinking can alter river ecosystems, affect biodiversity, and displace communities. The Pattiseema project itself faced criticism over high energy costs for lifting water, as the pumps consume nearly 100 MW of power. The financial sustainability of such projects requires long-term subsidies. Interstate disputes are another challenge, especially since Krishna and Godavari waters are shared among Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Karnataka, and Maharashtra. Political contestations over allocations could undermine cooperative water sharing. Moreover, climate change introduces uncertainty, as surplus flows in the Godavari may decrease in the future, limiting transfer potential. Thus, while river linking holds immense potential, it must be pursued with ecological caution, fiscal prudence, and interstate collaboration.

	Comparative Perspectives Globally, water transfer projects provide mixed lessons. China's South-North Water Transfer Project demonstrates how large-scale inter-basin transfers can support industrial and agricultural growth in deficit regions, but also highlights ecological stresses and massive displacement. In contrast, smaller-scale watershed management initiatives in countries like Israel and Spain show how decentralised water management can complement river linking. For Andhra Pradesh, the lesson is to balance mega-projects like Pattiseema with micro-level interventions such as rainwater harvesting, drip irrigation, and tank rejuvenation, creating a holistic water management framework. **Future of River Linking in Andhra Pradesh** The Pattiseema project is only the beginning. The state has envisioned linking the Godavari with the Penna and further exploring interlinkages with the Cauvery basins. If realized, these projects could transform Andhra Pradesh into a water-secure state, ensuring irrigation across the length and breadth of its territory. The Polavaram project, once completed, will further enhance the Godavari's potential for interlinking. However, future efforts must incorporate environmental impact assessments, transparent rehabilitation measures for displaced families, and participatory planning with local communities. Digital technologies like GIS mapping and satellite-based water monitoring can enhance efficiency and accountability. By integrating traditional water conservation practices with modern engineering, Andhra Pradesh can pioneer a balanced model of water security.
Conclusion	Water scarcity has long plagued farmers of Andhra Pradesh, undermining agricultural productivity and rural livelihoods. River linking, by redistributing surplus to deficit basins, offers a structural solution that can indeed be described as a panacea for farmers' woes. The Pattiseema project stands as a testament to the possibilities of inter-basin transfer, having stabilised the Krishna delta, improved drinking water supply, and enhanced agricultural resilience. However, the long-term success of river linking depends on sustainable practices, interstate cooperation, and ecological safeguards. As it was once remarked, "Water is wealth, and control over water means control over development." For Andhra Pradesh, the challenge lies in harnessing this wealth responsibly, ensuring that every farmer, irrespective of region, reaps the benefits. If managed wisely, river linking can not only secure the state's water future but also uphold the promise of equitable and inclusive development.
Model Question	Interlinking of rivers has been projected as a solution to recurring droughts and water shortages in Andhra Pradesh. Discuss the role of river-linking projects in ensuring water security and explain the significance of the Pattiseema Lift Irrigation Scheme.
Value Addition	India's river linking projects, managed by the National Water Development Agency (NWDA), aim to transfer water from surplus river basins to deficit areas through a network of canals and reservoirs. The major initiatives include the Himalayan Component and the Peninsular Component, with prominent links such as the Ken-Betwa Link Project and the Godavari-Krishna link. The Ken-Betwa Link Project is currently being implemented to address water scarcity in the drought-prone Bundelkhand region.
48. What are global initiatives implemented by the United Nations for Sustainable Development? Discuss. (TGPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues
Keyword	What, Discuss
Approach	• Introduce with the historical evolution of the UN's development agenda, from post-war reconstruction and aid-based models to the integrated, universal 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

	• Explain the idea of sustainable development as defined in key reports like Brundtland Report (1987) and its adoption in global discourse. • Discuss landmark UN-led frameworks such as Agenda 21 (1992), Millennium Development Goals (MDGs), and the 2030 Agenda (SDGs). • Elaborate on key UN bodies and programmes — UNDP, UNEP, UNFCCC, UNESCO, FAO, WHO and their roles in implementing SDGs. • Include recent efforts such as the UN Decade of Action (2020–2030), Our Common Agenda (2021), High-Level Political Forum (HLPF), COP28 outcomes, and Global Biodiversity Framework (2022). • Analyze obstacles like financing deficits, geopolitical tensions, climate vulnerability, and uneven progress, especially in Global South nations. • Suggest strategies for strengthening multilateral cooperation, sustainable financing (SDG Stimulus), and integrating local action with global goals. • Conclude with the UN's pivotal role in steering humanity toward a just, resilient, and sustainable future.
Introduction	The United Nations' approach to sustainable development has undergone a significant transformation from fragmented, aid-driven programmes to a comprehensive, rights-based and universal agenda. The adoption of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development in 2015 marked a historic moment, committing all 193 UN Member States to pursue prosperity that is inclusive, equitable, and environmentally sound. At its core lie the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and 169 targets, which integrate the three pillars of sustainability such as economic growth, social inclusion, and environmental protection. Unlike earlier frameworks such as the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs), the SDGs apply universally to both developed and developing nations, emphasizing partnership, accountability, and shared responsibility. Guided by principles of "leaving no one behind" and "interconnected progress," this agenda positions the UN as a global convener, aligning nations, private actors, and civil society toward collective, transformative action.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The SDGs as the organizing framework: coordination and country support** At the centre of UN action are the SDGs themselves, which shape programming across agencies. UNDP, UNESCO, WHO, FAO, UNEP, UN Women and others align their country programmes to SDG targets and provide technical assistance, financing advice and institutional capacity building. UNDP's role as the UN's development arm focuses on policy advice, poverty reduction, democratic governance and climate-resilient development, helping governments translate global goals into national plans and budgets. Recent UN system strategies emphasize integrated country-level implementation, leaving no one behind and accelerating progress through partnerships. **Global acceleration mechanisms: summits, platforms and financing tools** Recognizing slow progress and setbacks from the pandemic, climate shocks and conflicts, the UN has created high-level mechanisms to accelerate delivery. The SDG Summit (held in 2023) and the subsequent Acceleration and Accountability Platform invite Member States, business, civil society and finance actors to register concrete, high-impact actions and commitments. The UN's "Our Common Agenda" and associated proposals (for example, a revamped social contract, SDG stimulus ideas, and a renewed multilateralism) aim to retool global governance for delivery. The UN also promotes blended finance, debt-for-nature swaps, and the Financing for Development process to mobilize resources for SDG implementation. **Thematic UN initiatives: education, climate, health, and disaster resilience**

Beyond the architecture, the UN runs substantive global initiatives that meet specific SDG targets. UNESCO's Education for Sustainable Development (ESD for 2030) mainstreams sustainability into curricula, teacher training and learning outcomes; it hosts partnerships such as the Greening Education Partnership to climate-proof learning systems. The UNFCCC process (including the Paris Agreement) and UN-led climate platforms (e.g., Race to Zero, Race to Resilience) mobilize mitigation and adaptation action and finance. WHO spearheads health security and universal health coverage. The Sendai Framework, replicated through UNDRR, coordinates disaster risk reduction to protect development gains. These thematic programmes create common norms, technical guidance, and country support for meeting SDG targets.

Recent global initiatives: acceleration, science and partnerships

In recent years the UN has launched several targeted initiatives to overcome implementation gaps. The SDG Summit (2023) produced an emphasis on "accelerators" and the SDG Acceleration and Accountability Platform invites concrete, time-bound commitments. UNESCO and partners have advanced the International Decade of Sciences for Sustainable Development (2024–2033) to marshal science, technology and innovation behind SDG solutions. UNDP's Climate Promise and other system strategies (2022–2025) prioritized supporting countries to meet their NDCs (nationally determined contributions) and to transition to green, inclusive economies. The UN Global Compact and associated private-sector initiatives have updated guidance to align corporate strategies with SDGs and with a renewed emphasis on accountability and reporting. These recent initiatives sharpen the UN's focus on mobilizing finance, science and multi-stakeholder partnerships.

Country implementation and localization: how the UN helps translate goals into action

A recurring lesson is that global goals succeed when adapted to national contexts. The UN supports localization by helping countries build indicator frameworks, strengthen statistical systems and deploy integrated national financing frameworks. UN agencies help states prepare SDG roadmaps and poverty diagnostics, and facilitate capacity-building for subnational governments. For example, India's SDG India Index and national monitoring exercises have been developed with UN encouragement and technical support, enabling targeted state-level interventions. Such localization, backed by the UN's technical know-how and convening power, bridges the gulf between global ambition and local delivery.

Financing, private sector engagement and partnerships (SDG 17)

SDG delivery demands adequate financing, functioning markets, and strong partnerships. The UN system promotes innovative financing through blended mechanisms, de-risking tools, and concessional lending in collaboration with multilateral development banks. Platforms such as the UN Global Compact, the Financing for Development Forum, and the SDG Investment Fair help attract private investment and philanthropic contributions aligned with sustainable goals. Alongside these efforts, the UN advocates for policy measures that include progressive taxation, universal social protection, and public investment to ensure fairness and stability in financing. The overarching message is that private capital should complement, not replace, public funding, with both sectors working together to advance inclusive and resilient development.

Monitoring, reporting and accountability: the knowledge backbone

Monitoring progress against the SDGs has driven innovations in data systems. The UN Statistical Commission, UN-led global reporting (SDG Report, 2024–25 series) and national indicator frameworks improve transparency and policy targeting. The SDG

	Acceleration Platform doubles as a public registry of commitments and progress. Yet global assessments remind us that progress is uneven, official reports show many targets off track, demanding renewed ambition and course correction. **Impact, challenges and critiques: equity, geopolitics and implementation gaps** Despite considerable architecture and programmes, SDG progress is constrained by persistent inequalities, weak institutions, fragmented aid, and rising geopolitical tensions. Critics argue that global initiatives sometimes produce pilot projects rather than systemic transformation and that too much reliance on voluntary private finance risks perpetuating inequality. The UN has acknowledged these risks and promoted reforms in governance, transparency and citizen engagement as part of "Our Common Agenda." Moreover, climate crises and conflicts have reversed progress in several regions, highlighting the need for resilience and crisis-responsive SDG pathways. **India and the UN: examples of country-level cooperation** India's collaboration with the UN illustrates how global initiatives can be adapted domestically. UNDP-India supports poverty reduction, inclusive energy transitions and disaster risk management, while UNESCO partners on education for sustainable development. India's SDG India Index and the NITI Aayog-UN engagements show the localization of measurement and policy. Recent India-UN partnerships on disaster management and youth innovation (Eg: Youth Co: Lab) demonstrate how UN mechanisms support national priorities through technical assistance and catalyzed financing. **Policy lessons and the way forward: from rhetoric to resilient systems** To accelerate transformation, the UN and its Member States must prioritize four key areas. First, integrated national planning should embed SDGs within budgets, policies, and laws. Second, data and accountability must be strengthened through robust statistical systems and citizen-led monitoring. Third, finance and policy coherence should blend concessional funds with domestic resource mobilization aligned to sustainability. Fourth, science, innovation, and local participation are vital for context-specific solutions. Recent initiatives like SDG acceleration platforms and revitalized multilateral frameworks offer critical tools. Success ultimately depends on national ownership, political will, and inclusive partnerships across society.
Conclusion	The United Nations continues to serve as the central pillar of global sustainable development efforts, providing vision, coordination, and legitimacy to collective action. Through its Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), thematic agencies, and financing frameworks, the UN offers countries a shared platform to align policies, mobilize resources, and monitor progress. In recent years, the focus has shifted from goal-setting to tangible implementation, emphasizing accountability, measurable outcomes, and adequate financing. Initiatives like the SDG Stimulus Plan (2023), High-Level Political Forum (HLPF) reviews, and the Our Common Agenda (2021) underscore this action-oriented approach. However, achieving the 2030 Agenda demands stronger institutional capacities, fairer access to climate and development finance, and genuine multi-stakeholder partnerships. Sustained political commitment, UN system coherence, and global solidarity are essential to turn these aspirations into lived realities for present and future generations.
Model Question	"The United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) plays a pivotal role in advancing global environmental governance and steering the world toward a sustainable, low-carbon future. Critically examine the key initiatives and strategies undertaken by UNEP to address contemporary challenges such as climate change, biodiversity loss, and pollution, while balancing developmental priorities of the Global South."

Value Addition	**UN Sustainable Development Solutions Network (SDSN):** • The UN Sustainable Development Solutions Network (SDSN) operates under the auspices of the UN Secretary-General, mobilizing the world's largest knowledge network to drive action on the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and the Paris Agreement on Climate Change. • Established in 2012 by the former UN Secretary-General, Ban Ki-Moon, and world-renowned economist and professor, Jeffrey Sachs, the SDSN promotes integrated approaches to sustainable development through education, research, policy analysis, and global cooperation. • In partnership with UN agencies, multilateral financing institutions, governments, academia, civil society, and the private sector, the SDSN develops science-based pathways for SDG implementation, promotes independent monitoring and accountability for sustainable development progress, identifies persisting gaps and priorities through feedback loops to adapt long-term SDG strategies, and facilitates peer-to-peer learning, knowledge sharing, and the exchange of best practices.
49. Critically examine the measures taken by the Indian government for the improvement of food security. (TGPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues
Keyword	Critically examine
Approach	• Introduce the concept of food security and its significance for India's population and economy. • Mention India's constitutional commitment to food security and the challenge of malnutrition. • Highlight key national schemes like Public Distribution System (PDS), National Food Security Act (NFSA), Mid-Day Meal Scheme, and Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS). • Discuss innovations like targeted subsidies, digital ration cards, and e-POS machines. • Analyze strengths such as coverage expansion, reduction of hunger, and improved nutritional outcomes. • Critically examine limitations like leakage, corruption, exclusion errors, regional disparities, and implementation gaps. • Suggest policy improvements such as better monitoring, community participation, and strengthening local procurement. • Conclude by evaluating the overall impact of government measures on enhancing food security in India.
Introduction	Food security, defined as access to sufficient, safe, and nutritious food for an active and healthy life, is a cornerstone of national development. In India, ensuring food security has been a persistent challenge due to its vast population, socio-economic disparities, and agricultural vulnerabilities. Despite significant progress in agricultural production post-Green Revolution, malnutrition and undernourishment remain pressing concerns. According to the Global Hunger Index 2025, India ranks 105th out of 121 countries, highlighting persistent food insecurity despite economic growth. The Government of India has initiated a range of measures to enhance food security, encompassing legal frameworks, welfare schemes, public distribution mechanisms, and nutritional interventions. These measures aim to provide affordable food access, reduce hunger, and improve nutritional outcomes, while also addressing regional and socio-economic inequities. However, the effectiveness of these initiatives depends on their implementation, coverage, and adaptability to emerging challenges like climate change, urbanisation, and rising food prices.

Body & Infographic Representation	**National Food Security Act (NFSA) and Public Distribution System (PDS)** The enactment of the National Food Security Act (NFSA) in 2013 marked a paradigm shift in India's food security framework, legally entitling nearly two-thirds of the population to subsidized food grains. The Act provides up to 5 kg of rice, wheat, or coarse grains per person per month at highly subsidized prices. Complementing this, the Public Distribution System (PDS) functions as the backbone of India's food security mechanism, ensuring the delivery of essential commodities to targeted beneficiaries. Digital innovations such as Aadhaar-linked ration cards and e-POS machines have improved transparency, reduced leakages, and enhanced accountability. For instance, the World Bank estimates that the integration of technology has reduced diversion in PDS by nearly 10–15% in states like Tamil Nadu and Chhattisgarh. Despite these advances, challenges persist, including exclusion errors, regional disparities, irregular supply chains, and political interference, which undermine the effectiveness of PDS in ensuring equitable food access. **Nutritional Interventions and Welfare Programs for the improvement of food security** India's food security measures extend beyond mere caloric sufficiency to focus on nutrition, particularly for vulnerable populations. Programs like the Mid-Day Meal Scheme provide cooked meals to over 120 million schoolchildren, improving attendance, retention, and nutritional intake. The Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS) targets children under six, adolescent girls, and pregnant and lactating women, offering supplementary nutrition, health check-ups, and immunization. Empirical evidence from the Ministry of Women and Child Development shows that districts with effective ICDS implementation report a 12–15% reduction in stunting and underweight prevalence among children. Furthermore, the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana (PMGKAY), introduced during the COVID-19 pandemic, distributed free food grains to over 800 million beneficiaries, demonstrating the government's capacity to respond to food crises. These interventions highlight India's commitment to comprehensive food security, encompassing both availability and nutritional adequacy. **Agricultural Measures and Supply Chain Improvements** Food security in India is intricately linked to agricultural productivity and supply chain efficiency. The government has implemented measures such as the Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchai Yojana (PMKSY) for irrigation, the Paramparagat Krishi Vikas Yojana (PKVY) for organic farming, and the e-National Agriculture Market (e-NAM) for improved market access. These initiatives aim to increase crop production, reduce post-harvest losses, and stabilize prices. According to the Ministry of Agriculture, post-harvest losses in India account for 15–20% of total food grain production, emphasizing the need for cold storage, logistics infrastructure, and digital market linkages. Additionally, the Minimum Support Price (MSP) system provides a safety net for farmers, ensuring remunerative prices for staple crops. While these measures contribute to food availability, critics argue that they inadequately address smallholder farmer welfare, climate vulnerability, and regional disparities in productivity, which directly affect food security outcomes. **Critical Analysis of Implementation Challenges** Despite robust policies and programs, India's food security measures face significant implementation challenges. Corruption, leakage, and inefficiencies in the PDS remain persistent problems, particularly in rural and remote areas. NFSA coverage gaps exclude marginalized populations, including migrant workers and urban poor, leaving millions vulnerable. Regional disparities also persist; for instance, states like Uttar Pradesh and Bihar face higher food insecurity due to poor infrastructure and administrative

	weaknesses compared to states like Tamil Nadu and Kerala. Furthermore, rising food inflation, climate change-induced crop failures, and Urbanisation exacerbate food access challenges. Scholars argue that a purely supply-side approach is insufficient; food security requires integrated strategies combining nutrition-sensitive interventions, social protection, agricultural resilience, and market reforms. **Innovations and Policy Reforms for improved food security** Recent policy reforms and technological innovations have improved India's food security framework. Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) schemes link subsidies and food entitlements directly to beneficiaries' bank accounts, reducing diversion and enhancing efficiency. Mobile applications for ration card verification, grievance redressal, and real-time supply monitoring improve transparency. Climate-resilient agriculture initiatives, including drought-resistant crop varieties and precision farming, address production vulnerabilities. Nutrition-sensitive agriculture and biofortification, such as vitamin-A-enriched sweet potatoes and iron-fortified rice, aim to combat hidden hunger. Public-private partnerships, community engagement, and decentralized procurement under schemes like NFSA enhance local accountability. However, the scalability and uniform adoption of these innovations remain uneven, highlighting the need for capacity building, monitoring, and adaptive governance. **Impact and Outcomes of government measures on food security** Government measures have significantly improved food availability and accessibility, particularly for vulnerable populations. NFSA and PDS coverage ensure basic caloric intake for over 800 million beneficiaries. Mid-Day Meal and ICDS programs have enhanced school attendance, reduced child malnutrition, and improved maternal health outcomes. Studies by the National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER) indicate that PDS and subsidized food grains have reduced extreme poverty rates by 4–6% over the past decade. Nonetheless, the persistence of undernutrition, micronutrient deficiencies, and regional inequalities underscores the need for continual policy refinement. Empirical evidence suggests that achieving holistic food security requires integrating supply-side, nutrition-sensitive, and social protection measures within a coherent, inclusive framework.
Conclusion	India has implemented a multifaceted approach to improving food security, combining legal entitlements, welfare programs, agricultural support, and technological innovations. The National Food Security Act, Public Distribution System, Mid-Day Meal Scheme, ICDS, and agricultural reforms collectively aim to ensure access to adequate, safe, and nutritious food. While significant progress has been made in reducing hunger, improving nutrition, and safeguarding vulnerable populations, implementation gaps, regional disparities, and systemic inefficiencies continue to challenge the effectiveness of these measures. Critically, food security is not merely an agricultural or economic issue but a socio-political and developmental imperative that requires integrated, adaptive, and inclusive policies. Strengthening monitoring mechanisms, enhancing community participation, leveraging technology, and addressing regional and demographic vulnerabilities are essential for achieving sustainable food security in India. As highlighted by the FAO, "Food security is achieved not when food is merely available, but when every individual has access to adequate nutrition to live a healthy life," emphasising the ongoing challenge and responsibility of the Indian government in this domain.
Model Question	"India has achieved self-sufficiency in food production but not in nutrition." Comment
Value Addition	• The One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC) scheme is a major digital reform in India's Public Distribution System (PDS) that makes food security "portable." The system

	uses technology to break the link between a beneficiary and a specific "fair price shop" (FPS). ✓ Aadhaar Integration: Your ration card must be linked (seeded) with your Aadhaar number. ✓ ePoS Devices: Every ration shop is equipped with an electronic Point of Sale (ePoS) device. ✓ Biometric Authentication: You simply provide your Aadhaar or ration card number and verify your identity via fingerprint or iris scan at the shop. ✓ Real-time Data: The system checks your balance in a central database and updates it instantly, preventing anyone from claiming the same ration twice.
50. What are the aims and objectives of the National Water Policy? How are they reflected in the state water policies? Explain. (TGPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues
Keyword	What, How and Explain
Approach	• Begin with the context that water is a scarce and vital resource; India framed the National Water Policy (2012) for sustainable management. • Mention Aims/objectives like integrated water resource management, equitable distribution, prioritisation (drinking > irrigation > industry), conservation, pricing, participatory irrigation. • Stress focus on climate change adaptation, river basin planning, and minimising inter-state conflicts. • Mention Andhra Pradesh State Water Policy aligns with NWP, which emphasises irrigation efficiency, participatory water management, and river-linking. • Mention Telangana's Water Policy stresses Mission Kakatiya, Mission Bhagiratha, equitable tank rejuvenation, and drinking water access. • Highlight how both states prioritise agriculture and drinking water, while also balancing industrial needs. • Discuss challenges like over-extraction of groundwater, interstate disputes (Krishna, Godavari), and ecological sustainability. • Conclude that NWP provides a guiding framework, states adapt it to local socio-economic and ecological needs.
Introduction	Water is the lifeline of any economy and society, sustaining agriculture, industry, and domestic needs. India, despite abundant river systems and monsoon rainfall, faces acute water stress due to uneven distribution, over-extraction, and climate variability. Recognising these challenges, the Government of India formulated the National Water Policy (NWP), with its latest version released in 2012. The policy serves as a framework for integrated water resource management, aiming to optimise utilisation, ensure equitable distribution, and maintain ecological sustainability. Its objectives include prioritising water allocation for drinking and irrigation, promoting water conservation, enhancing efficiency in use, and involving communities in water governance. State governments are expected to align their water management strategies with the principles of NWP, adapting them to local hydrological, socio-economic, and ecological conditions. Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, as water-sensitive states, have formulated policies that reflect NWP objectives while addressing regional challenges such as droughts, inter-basin water disputes, and groundwater depletion.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Aims and Objectives of the National Water Policy** The NWP seeks to provide a comprehensive and integrated approach to water resource management. One of its primary aims is equitable distribution across sectors, prioritising drinking water, followed by irrigation, industrial, and ecological needs. It emphasises

efficient use of water through measures like micro-irrigation, modern drainage systems, and reduction of water losses. Another objective is water conservation and augmentation, encouraging rainwater harvesting, recharge of aquifers, and revival of traditional water bodies. The policy also advocates participatory water management, involving local communities, Panchayati raj institutions, and stakeholders in decision-making. It stresses river basin management as the unit of planning, ensuring integrated development and avoiding conflicts between states or regions. NWP additionally addresses inter-state and international water disputes, recommending transparent negotiation and dispute-resolution mechanisms. Sustainability, ecological balance, and climate adaptation are central, highlighting the need to maintain environmental flows in rivers and wetlands. The policy, therefore, serves as a guiding framework for states to plan water resources efficiently, equitably, and sustainably.

Reflection of NWP in Andhra Pradesh Water Policy

Andhra Pradesh has incorporated NWP objectives into its state-level water policies and programs. The state faces challenges such as uneven rainfall, drought-prone Rayalaseema, and over-dependence on the Krishna and Godavari river basins. To address these, the Andhra Pradesh Water Policy emphasises integrated water resources management, river-linking projects, and sustainable irrigation practices. Programs like Pattiseema Lift Irrigation, Polavaram Project, and the rejuvenation of tanks under the Jalayagnam initiative reflect the policy's objective of augmenting water availability and ensuring equitable allocation. Emphasis on micro-irrigation and efficient water use aligns with NWP's efficiency mandate. The policy also prioritises drinking water security, evident in projects such as Mission Bhagiratha, which aims to provide safe piped water to every household, reflecting NWP's principle of giving drinking water the highest allocation priority. Furthermore, participatory management is promoted through water user associations and SHG-led tank maintenance programs, echoing NWP's call for community involvement.

Reflection of NWP in Telangana Water Policy

Telangana, carved out of Andhra Pradesh in 2014, faces unique water challenges with a semi-arid climate and uneven river distribution. Its State Water Policy (2015) mirrors NWP objectives, focusing on equitable allocation, water conservation, and sustainability. Mission Kakatiya, aimed at restoring 46,000 minor irrigation tanks, and exemplifies water conservation and augmentation. Mission Bhagiratha ensures potable water supply to rural and urban households, highlighting drinking water prioritisation. The policy also emphasises efficient irrigation technologies, crop planning, and groundwater recharge, reflecting NWP's efficiency and conservation goals. River basin planning is incorporated for the Krishna and Godavari basins to minimise inter-district conflicts. Participation of local bodies and communities in water management, encouraged through Tank User Associations and watershed committees, aligns with NWP's participatory principles. Both Andhra Pradesh and Telangana have adapted NWP objectives to suit local contexts, balancing state priorities with national guidelines.

Challenges in Implementation

While state policies reflect NWP objectives, practical challenges remain. Over-extraction of groundwater continues in Rayalaseema and Telangana, with many mandals classified as "over-exploited" by the Central Ground Water Board. Inter-state disputes, particularly over Krishna and Godavari waters, pose legal and administrative hurdles, delaying project implementation. Climate variability and unpredictable monsoon patterns reduce the reliability of surface water, complicating planning. Infrastructure bottlenecks, inadequate maintenance of tanks and canals, and delays in river-linking projects impede

	efficient water management. Financial constraints further limit investment in micro-irrigation, water recycling, and community-based projects. Despite policy alignment, operationalising NWP objectives at the state and grassroots levels remains a key challenge requiring continuous monitoring, capacity building, and stakeholder coordination. **Impact on Agriculture and Rural Development** Implementation of NWP-aligned state policies has significant socio-economic benefits. Stabilised irrigation through tanks, canals, and river-linking projects improves agricultural productivity and reduces dependence on erratic rainfall. For example, the Pattiseema project has augmented Krishna delta irrigation and supported over 13 lakh acres of agriculture, increasing farmer income and reducing distress. Mission Kakatiya in Telangana has rejuvenated traditional tanks, improving groundwater recharge and crop yields. Drinking water projects like Mission Bhagiratha ensure health benefits, reduce water-borne diseases, and save time, particularly for women, who spend hours fetching water in rural areas. Efficient water use and conservation practices promoted by state policies also support environmental sustainability, reflecting NWP's emphasis on ecological balance. **Comparative and Global Perspectives** Globally, integrated water resource management, as emphasised in NWP, is seen in countries like Israel, Singapore, and Australia, where efficient allocation, conservation, and community participation underpin water security. Israel's drip irrigation techniques and Singapore's NEWater projects provide models for efficiency and augmentation. Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, by aligning state policies with NWP, adapt such global principles to local conditions, emphasising river-linking, tank rejuvenation, and participatory governance. This comparative perspective underscores the importance of policy coherence between national and state levels for sustainable water management.
Conclusion	The National Water Policy serves as a guiding framework for sustainable, equitable, and efficient water resource management in India. Its aims, prioritisation of drinking water, efficiency, conservation, participatory management, river basin planning, and ecological sustainability, are reflected in the state water policies of Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. Projects like Pattiseema, Jalayagnam, Mission Bhagiratha, and Mission Kakatiya exemplify the operationalisation of NWP objectives in the states, addressing both irrigation and drinking water needs. However, challenges such as groundwater over-extraction, climate variability, interstate disputes, and implementation bottlenecks persist. Effective monitoring, participatory governance, technological integration, and financial investment are crucial to fully realise the policy objectives. By aligning state initiatives with the principles of NWP, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana can ensure water security, agricultural stability, and sustainable rural development, reflecting the core principle that water management is not just a technical task but a social and economic imperative. As it was emphasised, "Water is life, and access to it is a fundamental right," highlighting the necessity of integrated policies to secure this vital resource for all citizens.
Model Question	Critically analyse the principles of the National Water Policy and evaluate how these principles are operationalised in the water management policies of Andhra Pradesh and Telangana.
Value Addition	The Jal Shakti Abhiyan was initiated in 2019 to address the acute water stress in various parts of the country. The campaign was divided into two phases: the first phase was during the monsoon season from July 1 to September 15, 2019, and the second phase from October 1 to November 30, 2019, for states receiving the Northeast retreating

	monsoons. The campaign's primary focus was on water-stressed districts and blocks, emphasising the need for local-level interventions and community participation.
51. With constant rise in global temperatures, greenhouse gases and global sea levels, it is disastrous that climate change talks at Copenhagen between major nations have failed to comet to a consensus. Explain why our leaders have failed to come to a mutual understanding for combating climate change. (APPSC, 2011)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues
Keyword	Explain
Approach	• Introduce with highlighting rising global temperatures, greenhouse gases, sea-level rise, and the urgency of climate action. • Provide context on the Copenhagen summit (COP15) and its failure to achieve a binding agreement. • Analyze political reasons such as divergent national interests, North–South equity disputes, and geopolitical tensions. • Discuss institutional and procedural issues such as weak UNFCCC mechanisms, negotiation complexity, and trust deficits. • Highlight economic and domestic factors: vested fossil fuel interests, financial constraints, and technology gaps. • Include India's perspective: balancing development needs with climate commitments, and demands for finance and technology transfer. • Conclude by noting the need for stronger international cooperation, transparent finance, and political will to achieve consensus.
Introduction	The failure of the Copenhagen summit (COP15, 2009) to produce a binding global agreement remains a defining moment in climate diplomacy. It revealed tensions that still hinder progress, divergent national interests, contested fairness, weak institutions, vested interests, and a gap between scientific urgency and political will. Scientific assessments, from the IPCC's AR4 (2007) to the AR6 Synthesis Report (2023), stress that limiting warming to well below 2°C requires steep emission cuts, yet political commitments continue to lag. The UNEP Emissions Gap Report (2024) warns that current pledges fall far short of a 1.5°C pathway, reflecting inertia visible in 2009. Institutions like the UNFCCC continue to struggle with reconciling equity with urgent action. The WMO's 2024 climate report confirms global averages already exceeding 1.5°C in some years, showing that warnings ignored in Copenhagen are now realities, and structural challenges remain unresolved.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Why world leaders failed to reach a consensus at Copenhagen on combating climate change?** **Scientific urgency versus political timetables:** By the time of Copenhagen scientists were already warning that limiting warming to 2°C, let alone 1.5°C, required very rapid emissions reductions. Since then the science has only become more urgent. The WMO's State of the Global Climate shows that 2024 was likely the first calendar year to exceed 1.5°C above pre-industrial levels (with the 2024 global mean near-surface temperature about 1.55°C ± 0.13°C above 1850–1900), underscoring how little time remains for stringent action. This intensification of climate indicators like rising temperatures, accelerating sea-level rise and record concentrations of CO_2, methane and nitrous oxide, heightens the mismatch between the timelines demanded by science and the longer political cycles of democracies, which are oriented toward short-term growth, jobs and electoral cycles. The political unwillingness to take decisions whose costs are immediate but whose benefits mostly accrue decades later is therefore a structural barrier that Copenhagen brought into sharp relief.

North–South divisions and the politics of equity

A core stumbling block at Copenhagen was the unresolved debate over burden-sharing. Developing countries argued that historical emissions and ongoing development needs required differentiated obligations. Developed countries, while accepting leadership responsibilities in principle, were often reluctant to take on open-ended financial and legally enforceable commitments at the scale demanded. This disagreement resulted in a stalemate. Developing countries, led by India, China, and others, emphasized the principle of "common but differentiated responsibilities" and sought strong guarantees on climate finance and technology transfer. Meanwhile, developed countries pressed for economy-wide targets and broader participation from emerging economies. This fundamental dispute over fairness, legal form, and conditionality was decisive in producing only a political accord rather than a binding treaty. Recent institutional analyses and retrospectives on COP15 highlight that the North–South impasse remained the single largest obstacle to reaching a comprehensive global agreement.

Institutional design, negotiating complexity and procedural failure

Copenhagen produced extraordinarily complex negotiating text across multiple tracks, and the conference's procedural design concentrated decision-making in last-minute, high-level bilateral deals rather than in transparent multilateral negotiation. That process aggravated suspicions of back-room deals and left many delegations feeling excluded. The lack of an agreed institutional architecture for predictable finance, technology transfer and verification at the time meant negotiators had little to anchor a robust, enforceable deal upon. The failure was therefore as much about negotiation architecture and process design as it was about substance. Independent reviews of the summit highlight the dangers of hurried summit diplomacy when a durable, technical treaty requires patient, inclusive bargaining.

Finance, technology and trust deficits

Finance and the credibility of finance commitments was another decisive factor. Developing countries sought predictable concessional finance and secure mechanisms for technology transfer to enable low-carbon development. Copenhagen's outcome, the Copenhagen Accord, lacked the legal architecture and binding financial commitments that many countries required. The subsequent decade saw repeated debates over the scale and predictability of climate finance, with UNEP's Emissions Gap Report 2024 underscoring that national pledges remain far short of what is needed and that credible finance is essential to unlock mitigation in developing economies. Without predictable, measured and transparent financing and technology pathways, trust deficits between rich and poor countries persist, and trust is the currency of successful multilateral deals.

Domestic political economy and vested interests

The domestic political economy of energy and vested interests is a perennial constraint. Coal, oil and gas sectors, large utilities and related labour constituencies have strong political influence in many countries. These actors resist rapid structural shifts that could render assets stranded and cost votes. Lobbying and campaign finance distort policy choices in ways that favor incrementalism over radical restructuring. Analyses since Copenhagen, including governance and lobbying studies, show how private interest capture and uneven access to negotiators can harden national positions toward delay or dilution, undermining the scope for ambitious collective action.

Geopolitics, power asymmetries and the absence of decisive leadership

Climate diplomacy does not occur in a geopolitical vacuum. At Copenhagen, and since, the absence of a single credible leadership coalition able to broker trade-offs across major emitters magnified technical disagreements into political impasses. Strategic

	competition and broader diplomatic tension mean that climate bargaining often sits behind other foreign-policy cleavages; where major powers are consumed by geopolitical rivalry, their willingness to compromise on economically sensitive issues like fossil-fuel phase-out or cross-border technology flows is reduced. The effect is that collective leadership, a coalition willing and able to finance and underwrite transitions for poorer countries while securing domestic political buy-in at home, has been thin on the ground. **Emissions trends and the policy gap** Adding to the diplomatic and political failures is a stark empirical reality: global emissions have continued to rise. The Global Carbon Project reported that fossil CO_2 emissions in 2024 are projected to reach about 37.4 billion tonnes, an increase from 2023. UNEP's Emissions Gap Report 2024 shows that total greenhouse gas emissions in 2023 were roughly 57.1 $GtCO_2e$, and current national commitments leave a significant gap between projected emissions and levels compatible with limiting warming to 1.5°C or even 2°C. These data-driven realities make Copenhagen's political failure even more consequential. Not only was a durable institutional solution missed at the time, but the window to convert incremental pledges into the deep near-term cuts required by science is narrowing rapidly. **The Indian perspective: development imperatives and pragmatic engagement** India's position at Copenhagen and across subsequent climate talks illustrates the balancing act between development and mitigation. New Delhi has consistently insisted on the developmental priority — energy access, poverty alleviation and continued industrialization, while recognizing the need for emissions intensity reductions and expanded renewable capacity. India's updated NDC (2022) commits to reducing emissions intensity of GDP by 45% by 2030 (from 2005 levels), achieving 50% of cumulative electric power installed capacity from non-fossil sources, and creating an additional carbon sink of 2.5–3 billion tonnes of CO_2 equivalent by 2030. At the same time, India has rapidly expanded its renewable capacity and recorded significant additions in 2024, demonstrating that national policy can combine growth objectives with substantial low-carbon investment. However, India, like many developing countries, conditions its deeper mitigation on access to affordable finance and technology transfer, the very elements that Copenhagen failed to lock into a durable architecture. **Why these lessons matter today?** The scientific and empirical record since Copenhagen has only increased the stakes. WMO analyses show record temperatures and accelerating sea-level rise; IPCC syntheses continue to stress that pathways consistent with 1.5°C require immediate, deep and sustained emissions cuts across all sectors. At the same time, global CO_2 and total greenhouse gas emissions remain high, and UNEP's gap diagnostics warn that current commitments, even if fully implemented, are insufficient. Thus the barriers we saw in Copenhagen, fairness disputes, weak finance institutions, domestic political constraints, procedural weaknesses and lack of decisive leadership, are not mere relics of 2009 but active, present obstacles. Overcoming them will require reforms in negotiation architecture, clearer and verifiable finance instruments, insulation of policymaking from vested-interest capture, and credible leadership coalitions that can offer concrete, funded pathways for developing countries to leapfrog to low-carbon development.
Conclusion	Copenhagen's failure resulted from a combination of political, institutional, and material factors. Scientific urgency clashed with short electoral timetables, while deep North–South equity disputes remained unresolved. In addition, finance was often inadequate

	and unpredictable, procedural missteps in diplomacy created mistrust, domestic vested interests resisted ambitious action, and the geopolitical environment limited the formation of a leadership coalition capable of bridging trade-offs. Quantitative evidence from the WMO, UNEP, the Global Carbon Project, and the IPCC shows that the cost of repeated diplomatic failure is increasing rapidly in both physical and socio-economic terms. Achieving durable global consensus requires not only stronger scientific evidence but also reformed negotiation processes, transparent and binding finance mechanisms, protection of negotiators from lobbying influence, and political leadership willing to reconcile equity with credible climate ambition. Without these changes, international summits risk producing rhetoric rather than the transformative action the planet and vulnerable communities urgently need.
Model Question	"India's net-zero target by 2070 requires robust governance, policy coordination, and institutional mechanisms. Critically evaluate India's current climate policies and suggest ways to enhance their effectiveness."
Value Addition	**Some of the Key decisions taken at UN Climate Change Conference (COP29): Baku, Azerbaijan** • **New global climate finance goal:** It calls on "all actors" to raise at least $1.3 trillion per year, and on developed countries to lead the mobilization of at least $300 billion, by 2035. It launched a "Baku-Belem Roadmap to 1.3T" - a conversation to scale up finance in 2025. • The parties agreed on a new climate finance goal with two parts: ✓ Core funding of at least USD 300 billion per year by 2035. ✓ An additional layer of up to USD 1.3 trillion, mainly from private investments. • Carbon market rules were finalized under the Paris Agreement, creating mechanisms like the Paris Agreement Crediting Mechanism (PACM). • Article 6 of the Paris Agreement was operationalized to allow carbon trading through two pathways: ✓ Article 6.2: Direct trading between countries (bilateral deals). ✓ Article 6.4: A separate UN-backed marketplace for carbon credits. • A centralized UN trading system for green credits will be launched to help countries trade carbon credits efficiently.

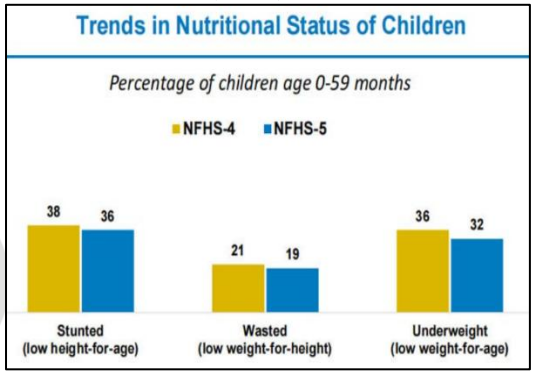
52. What is 'Drought'? What are the implications of drought? Discuss the various steps taken by the government in this regard. How do you tackle the problem there is drought continuously for three years? (APPSC, 2008)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Environmental Issues
Keyword	What, Discuss, How
Approach	• Start with a clear definition of drought (meteorological, hydrological, agricultural, socio-economic). • Mention its severe implications like agricultural losses, farmer distress, migration, food insecurity, depletion of groundwater, and rural poverty. • Highlight historical examples like AP droughts in Rayalaseema and Telangana. • Discuss government steps such as Drought Prone Area Programme, NREGS, crop insurance schemes, Mission Kakatiya, and Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana. • Add recent measures like groundwater recharge, micro-irrigation, and watershed management. • Emphasize the role of technology. • Conclude by saying drought management must combine short-term relief with long-term resilience.

Introduction	Drought is one of the most complex natural disasters that has haunted civilizations for centuries, leaving behind a trail of hunger, poverty, and displacement. It is not merely the absence of rainfall but a prolonged deficiency that disrupts agriculture, depletes water resources, and paralyzes socio-economic systems. The World Meteorological Organization classifies drought into meteorological, hydrological, agricultural, and socio-economic types, all of which can overlap to create a crisis of survival. In India, where nearly 55% of agriculture is rain-fed and more than 60% of the rural population depends on farming for livelihood, drought poses a severe threat to food security and economic stability. Andhra Pradesh, with its vulnerable dryland regions such as Rayalaseema and Telangana, has repeatedly faced drought-induced distress, underscoring the need for comprehensive drought management.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Implications of Drought** The implications of drought extend far beyond parched fields. Agriculture, the backbone of rural India, is the first casualty, as rain-fed crops like pulses, groundnut, and Jowar fail under prolonged dry spells. In Andhra Pradesh, the Rayalaseema region has historically witnessed distress migrations during severe drought years, with families moving to urban centres in search of work. According to the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR), drought reduces crop yields by 20% in Rainfed rice and a 40% reduction in wheat by 2080, threatening national food grain targets. Livestock mortality rises as fodder and water become scarce, aggravating rural poverty. Drought also impacts groundwater reserves, as excessive borewells dependence leads to over-extraction. Studies by the Central Groundwater Board reveal that several blocks in Anantapur and Mahabubnagar have reached "over-exploited" status. Socially, drought widens inequalities as marginalized farmers, landless labourers, and women bear a disproportionate burden of the crisis. Migration from drought-prone villages to Hyderabad, Bengaluru, and Vijayawada has created new urban pressures. Public health deteriorates as water scarcity leads to outbreaks of diseases like cholera and diarrhoea, while malnutrition increases due to food shortages. Environmental degradation further worsens as deforestation, soil erosion, and desertification accelerate in drought-hit regions. In the long run, drought jeopardizes federal stability too, as disputes over river water sharing, such as between Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, and Telangana, become intense during years of scarcity. **Government Measures for Drought Management** Recognizing the devastating impacts of drought, successive governments have taken both short-term and long-term measures. Historically, British colonial rule introduced famine codes to manage drought relief, but these were limited and exploitative. Post-independence, India integrated drought mitigation into its planning framework. The Drought Prone Areas Programme (DPAP) launched in 1973, targeted chronically dry regions, including parts of Andhra Pradesh, through soil and water conservation. Employment Guarantee schemes, later expanded into the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) in 2005, became crucial for providing wage employment and creating drought-resilient assets such as check dams, farm ponds, and bunding. At the state level, Andhra Pradesh has implemented innovative water conservation programs. The Mission Kakatiya initiative, launched in Telangana before bifurcation, aimed at restoring thousands of tanks and lakes to enhance irrigation security. Similarly, the Andhra Pradesh Micro Irrigation Project has expanded drip and sprinkler irrigation to conserve water in drought-prone belts. The National Crop Insurance Programme, later merged into the Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY), offers financial protection

	to farmers against crop loss due to drought, though coverage and timely compensation remain challenges. Technological interventions have been scaled up. The Indian Meteorological Department (IMD) uses advanced forecasting models and satellite imagery to monitor rainfall anomalies, while the National Remote Sensing Centre in Hyderabad provides real-time drought maps to guide policy. The Andhra Pradesh government has also used digital platforms to disseminate advisories on crop planning during weak monsoons. Financial packages, input subsidies, and debt relief measures have been periodically announced, as seen during the 2002 and 2015 droughts, to mitigate rural distress. **Tackling Continuous Drought for Three Years** When drought persists for three consecutive years, the crisis escalates from temporary hardship to structural devastation, requiring extraordinary responses. Agriculture cannot survive on traditional crops; hence, crop diversification becomes critical. Drought-resistant varieties of millets, pulses, and oilseeds developed by ICAR and ICRISAT in Hyderabad need to be widely promoted. Millets like Ragi, bajra, and foxtail not only withstand low rainfall but also contribute to nutritional security, earning them the title of "climate-smart crops." Water management strategies must go beyond ad-hoc relief. Large-scale watershed management, rejuvenation of tanks, and rainwater harvesting are essential to recharge groundwater. Andhra Pradesh's pioneering Community Managed Natural Farming initiative, which reduces water use and dependence on chemical fertilizers, is a sustainable model that can be scaled during consecutive droughts. Livelihood diversification becomes necessary as exclusive dependence on agriculture during prolonged droughts leads to collapse. Rural households must be supported in accessing non-farm employment through skill training, cottage industries, and rural enterprises. Livestock safety nets are equally important since cattle are the backbone of rural livelihoods. Establishing fodder banks, encouraging silage storage, and subsidizing cattle feed can prevent distress sales of livestock. Social protection schemes must be expanded, ensuring Public Distribution System (PDS) supplies, nutritional support for children through ICDS, and employment under MGNREGA are available without interruption. Migration can be addressed through urban–rural employment linkages, ensuring dignity and security for displaced workers. Institutionally, drought governance must adopt a long-term resilience framework. The Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction, to which India is a signatory, emphasizes "build back better," focusing on preparedness over crisis response. Policy lessons from Israel's water management, which combines desalination, recycling, and drip irrigation, can inspire India's drought mitigation strategies. International cooperation with agencies like the FAO can also bring new insights into sustainable dryland farming.
Conclusion	Drought is a silent disaster, creeping in without the dramatic visuals of floods or cyclones, yet leaving behind deeper scars on agriculture, society, and the economy. Its implications are multidimensional, ranging from farmer suicides to rural migration and environmental degradation. Governments in India and Andhra Pradesh have initiated several programs for drought mitigation, yet the challenge intensifies when drought continues for multiple years. The solution lies not merely in relief distribution but in building long-term resilience through sustainable agriculture, water conservation, crop diversification, and livelihood security. As Mahatma Gandhi once said, "Earth provides enough to satisfy every man's needs, but not every man's greed." The wisdom of balancing human needs with ecological limits is the true key to combating drought. A

	resilient Andhra Pradesh and India will emerge not through short-term crisis management but by embedding sustainability into every aspect of development policy.
Model Question	Define drought and analyze its consequences on society and the economy. Evaluate the measures initiated by the government for drought management. How would you address the challenges if drought persists for three successive years?
Value Addition	**Pradhan Mantri Kisan SAMPADA Yojana:** It is a comprehensive package which will result in creation of modern infrastructure with efficient supply chain management from farm gate to retail outlet. It will not only provide a big boost to the growth of food processing sector in the country but also help in providing better returns to farmers and is a big step towards doubling of farmers income, creating huge employment opportunities especially in the rural areas, reducing wastage of agricultural produce, increasing the processing level and enhancing the export of the processed foods.
(iv) Socio – Political Issues	
53. Demographic Dividend or Burden? Rethinking the Population Explosion Narrative. (APPSC, 2025)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Approach	• Define demographic dividend and link it to India's youth-heavy population. • Highlight potential for growth if education, skills, and jobs align with youth aspirations. • Note risks of unemployment, poverty, and social unrest if opportunities lag. • Contrast with East Asia's success vs. Sub-Saharan Africa's burden. • Cite stats (Median age ~28; 65% population below 35). • Mention skilling programs, education reforms, women's participation, health. • Stress that policies decide whether youth are a dividend or liability. • Assert that India's demographic dividend must be converted into inclusive growth.
Introduction	India's population, crossing 1.4 billion, is both its greatest strength and a potential challenge. The concept of a demographic dividend refers to the economic growth potential that arises from a high proportion of working-age population relative to dependents. If harnessed effectively, India's youth can become the engine of growth, propelling the country into the ranks of global economic leaders. However, if opportunities for education, employment, and skill development are inadequate, the same population can turn into a demographic burden, exacerbating poverty, unemployment, and social instability. As Nobel laureate Amartya Sen noted, "Population growth is not a problem per se, but a problem of ensuring justice, opportunity, and capability." Thus, rethinking India's population narrative is crucial to ensuring inclusive development and sustained growth.
	Population Dynamics in India India is experiencing a unique demographic phase: over 65% of its population is below 35 years, and the median age is approximately 28 years. This youth bulge provides a rare window to leverage human capital for economic growth. Comparatively, China's population has already started aging, while Sub-Saharan Africa struggles with a youth population with insufficient educational and employment opportunities. India's working-age population is expected to peak around 2040, providing a potential 25–30-year window to maximize productivity and innovation. Yet, the challenge lies in creating adequate employment, upskilling the workforce, and ensuring gender-inclusive participation in the labour. The Directorate General of Employment (DGE) reported the unemployment rate on a usual status for youth (15-29 years) as 12.4% for 2021-22, highlighting the gap between demographic potential and economic reality. **Demographic Dividend: Opportunities and Potential**

Body & Infographic Representation	The demographic dividend offers multiple economic and social opportunities. A large working-age population can accelerate industrial growth, increase savings, and foster entrepreneurship. The IT and services sector in India exemplifies how a skilled young workforce can contribute to global competitiveness, making India the world's third-largest startup ecosystem. Programs like Skill India and the Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY) aim to provide vocational training to millions, enabling them to participate productively in the economy. Moreover, higher labour participation can increase tax revenues, allowing the government to invest in infrastructure, health, and education, further stimulating growth. International experiences reinforce this potential: East Asian nations such as South Korea and Japan leveraged demographic dividends during the 1970–2000 period to achieve rapid industrialization, underscoring the importance of policy alignment. **Demographic Burden: Risks and Challenges** Despite the potential, India's population can also become a demographic burden if growth outpaces opportunity. Rapid population growth places immense pressure on healthcare, education, housing, and social security systems. Malnutrition remains a significant concern; the National Family Health Survey-5 (2021) reports that 35% of children under five are stunted, undermining the future workforce's productivity. Unemployment and underemployment among youth can fuel social unrest, migration, and crime. Gender inequality compounds the problem: female labour force participation in India is only around 21%, limiting the full realization of the demographic dividend. Further, regional disparities mean that while urban centres may absorb the workforce, rural areas remain dependent on agriculture, which is highly vulnerable to climate shocks and mechanization. Population pressure on natural resources, water, and land can exacerbate ecological challenges, making the demographic dividend contingent on sustainable development practices.  **Policy Interventions and Strategies** To transform the youth bulge into a demographic dividend, India requires multi-sectoral policy interventions. Education remains the cornerstone; programs like the National Education Policy 2020 aim to provide skills, vocational training, and digital literacy, aligning youth competencies with market demands. Employment generation through initiatives such as Make in India, Startup India, and MGNREGA can create both formal and informal sector opportunities. Health policies, including Ayushman Bharat, address malnutrition and healthcare access, ensuring a healthier workforce. Gender inclusion is critical; empowering women through education, entrepreneurship, and workforce participation can significantly enhance productivity. Internationally, countries like South Korea invested heavily in health and education during their demographic transition, yielding long-term economic benefits. Similarly, India's success will depend on integrating demographic planning with economic, social, and environmental policies, ensuring balanced regional development to avoid urban congestion and rural distress. **Empirical Evidence and Global Comparisons** Empirical evidence suggests that demographic dividends are neither automatic nor guaranteed. A World Bank (2017) study indicated that countries with high youth

	populations but weak governance, poor education, and limited employment opportunities often experience higher instability, as seen in parts of Sub-Saharan Africa. In contrast, East Asian economies maximized their demographic advantage through coordinated investment in education, industrialization, and healthcare. India's regional disparities also matter: states like Kerala and Tamil Nadu have effectively harnessed education and female participation to realize socio-economic gains, while Bihar and Uttar Pradesh face high fertility, low female literacy, and youth unemployment, demonstrating uneven potential across the country. This highlights that the demographic dividend is conditional on human capital development, governance, and equitable policy interventions. **Social and Cultural Dimensions** The demographic dividend is not merely an economic concept; it carries social and cultural implications. Youth-driven entrepreneurship, technology adoption, and innovation can accelerate social mobility. Programs promoting financial literacy, digital skills, and civic engagement empower the youth to participate in governance and societal development. On the other hand, neglecting cultural and social factors such as caste-based disparities, gender inequality, and regional marginalization can exacerbate conflicts and reduce economic potential. Nobel laureate Amartya Sen emphasizes that "development is freedom," implying that without social justice and equal opportunity, population growth becomes a burden rather than a boon.
Conclusion	India stands at a crossroads in its demographic journey. Its vast youth population presents an unprecedented opportunity to propel the nation toward economic prosperity and global leadership. Yet, without investment in education, skills, healthcare, employment, and gender equality, the same population could become a demographic burden, leading to unemployment, social unrest, and ecological stress. International and domestic experiences underscore that the dividend is not automatic; it requires coordinated policy planning, inclusive growth strategies, and regional balancing. As it was observed that "The youth of today are the builders of India tomorrow." Harnessing this demographic potential is essential not just for economic growth but for social stability, inclusive development, and the realization of India's aspirations as a developed, equitable, and prosperous nation.
Model Question	"Youth Bulge in India: Engine of Economic Growth or Trigger of Social Unrest?"
Value Addition	The Make in India initiative is a Government of India program launched on September 25, 2014, to boost domestic and foreign investment, foster innovation, develop manufacturing and design capabilities, and make India a global hub for these sectors. It focuses on improving the "ease of doing business," creating world-class infrastructure, enhancing skill development, and promoting both domestic and foreign investment across 27 key sectors, including manufacturing and services. The initiative also supports the "Vocal for Local" philosophy, emphasizing Indian production standards and increasing local value addition
54. Ethnic conflicts in India: A growing threat to national integration and inclusive development. (APPSC, 2025)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Approach	• Define ethnic conflicts and highlight India's pluralism as both a strength and a challenge. • Trace colonial divide-and-rule and Partition as seeds of ethnic strife. • Note Northeast insurgencies, caste violence, communal riots, and language disputes. • Explain how they weaken unity, federal relations, and national identity.

	• Show how conflicts cause displacement, economic stagnation, and inequality. • Mention constitutional safeguards, peace accords, and affirmative action. • Stress inclusive growth, decentralization, impartial justice, and inter-community dialogue. • End with a visionary note that unity in diversity is India's true strength.
Introduction	India, often celebrated as the world's largest democracy and a land of unity in diversity, is a multi-ethnic and multi-religious society where pluralism is woven into its very identity. However, beneath this celebrated diversity lies a persistent challenge: ethnic conflict. Ethnic conflicts, rooted in religion, caste, language, or regional identity, have long posed a threat to India's national integration and its pursuit of inclusive development. From communal riots and caste-based clashes to insurgencies in border states, these conflicts not only destabilize social harmony but also weaken economic progress. Understanding the roots, manifestations, and consequences of these conflicts is vital to safeguarding India's unity and developmental aspirations.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Historical and Structural Roots of Ethnic Conflicts:** The origins of ethnic conflict in India are deeply historical and structural. During colonial rule, the British deliberately categorized people into religious and caste groups through census operations and policies of divide and rule. The Partition of 1947, which claimed the lives of nearly a million people and displaced around 14 million, left deep wounds in the subcontinent's psyche, institutionalizing mistrust between communities. After independence, socio-economic inequalities, uneven regional development, and lack of access to political representation for marginalized groups fuelled ethnic discontent. In states like Assam and Nagaland, indigenous groups felt culturally alienated and politically side-lined, while in central India, tribals faced displacement due to industrial projects and forest laws. As Amartya Sen argued in Identity and Violence, "Violence is fomented by the imposition of singular identities over the multiple identities that human beings cherish." In India's context, emphasizing religious or caste identities over shared national identity has consistently fuelled conflict. **Contemporary Manifestations of Ethnic Conflicts** In present-day India, ethnic conflicts manifest in multiple forms across the country. The Northeast has long been a hotspot of ethnic insurgency, with Naga, Mizo, and Bodo movements demanding greater autonomy or even independence. In Manipur, the recent 2023 clashes between the Meitei and Kuki communities resulted in over 250 deaths and the displacement of more than 60,000 people, creating one of the gravest humanitarian crises in the region in decades. Similarly, Assam has witnessed recurring violence over migration-related demographic changes, most notably the Nellie massacre of 1983. Beyond the Northeast, caste violence remains persistent, particularly against Dalits and tribal communities, with the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) documenting over 50,000 cases of atrocities against Scheduled Castes annually. Communal violence, too, has scarred India, from the 1984 anti-Sikh riots and the 2002 Gujarat riots to the Delhi riots of 2020, each leaving lasting divisions. These events demonstrate that ethnic conflicts are not isolated incidents but systemic challenges that reappear in different forms and regions. **Humanitarian and Developmental Costs** The humanitarian impact of ethnic conflicts is profound. Thousands of lives have been lost, families uprooted, and entire communities forced into displacement camps. The Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre (IDMC) reported that in 2022, conflict and violence displaced millions worldwide, with India contributing significantly due to ethnic clashes. Displaced populations suffer from malnutrition, lack of healthcare, and long-

term psychological trauma. Women and children are disproportionately affected, facing gender-based violence, loss of education, and economic insecurity. Developmentally, conflicts divert resources from welfare to security operations, weaken investor confidence, and obstruct infrastructure projects. For instance, the insurgency-affected areas of the Northeast and central tribal belts remain underdeveloped compared to the rest of India, with lower literacy rates, poor health indicators, and weak industrial growth. The World Bank estimates that conflict-ridden economies may lose up to 15 percent of their per capita GDP within five years, underscoring how violence directly undermines growth and inclusive development.

Threat to National Integration

Ethnic conflicts erode the delicate fabric of national unity. By fostering competing loyalties, they weaken the sense of shared citizenship and belonging. The Kashmir insurgency has long posed challenges to national integration, with sections of the population questioning the legitimacy of Indian state institutions. Similarly, the demand for secession by Naga insurgents or the repeated assertion of linguistic and regional identities in states like Tamil Nadu highlight how ethnic assertions can sometimes overshadow national loyalty. Such conflicts also strain federal relations, as states accuse the centre of insensitivity or high-handedness in managing sensitive issues. The perception of bias in law enforcement or the judiciary during episodes of communal violence further alienates minorities, as witnessed after the 1984 Sikh riots and the 2002 Gujarat riots. As B.R. Ambedkar cautioned, "Without equality, liberty would produce the supremacy of the few over the many," emphasizing that exclusion and discrimination undermine the basis of unity.

Implications for Inclusive Development

Ethnic conflict directly obstructs the vision of inclusive development. When marginalized communities are trapped in cycles of violence, displacement, and insecurity, they are denied access to education, healthcare, and livelihoods. The Sachar Committee Report (2006) revealed that Muslims, one of India's largest minority groups, lagged in almost every socio-economic indicator, from literacy to bank credit availability. Such disparities are exacerbated in conflict-affected regions where welfare schemes fail to reach vulnerable groups. Additionally, investors avoid conflict-prone regions, leading to economic stagnation and unemployment. Social capital, too, is eroded, as mistrust among communities diminishes cooperation essential for inclusive policies. Women in conflict areas bear the brunt of exclusion, often losing access to healthcare, employment, and security. The pursuit of Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, thus remains incomplete when ethnic conflicts deny entire communities the benefits of development.

Policy Responses and Success Stories

India has attempted multiple strategies to address ethnic conflict, with mixed outcomes. The Constitution provides safeguards through the Fifth and Sixth Schedules, protecting tribal land rights and offering autonomy to tribal councils. Affirmative action through reservations has empowered marginalized castes, though challenges remain in effective implementation. Political accommodation has proved effective in certain cases: the linguistic reorganization of states in 1956 diffused secessionist tensions, while the 1986 Mizo Accord successfully ended decades of insurgency, transforming Mizoram into one of the most peaceful states in the Northeast. Similarly, peace accords with Bodo insurgents in Assam have brought relative calm, though not without challenges. Judicial interventions have ensured accountability, as seen in the Supreme Court's scrutiny of communal riot cases. Yet, gaps persist in ensuring fair policing, timely justice, and inclusive governance.

	Way Forward Resolving ethnic conflicts in India requires a comprehensive and inclusive approach. Strengthening economic inclusion by investing in health, education, and infrastructure in conflict-affected regions can reduce alienation. Political empowerment through decentralization, greater autonomy, and effective implementation of constitutional safeguards can foster trust among marginalized groups. Strengthening the rule of law, ensuring impartial policing, and delivering speedy justice are crucial to rebuilding faith in institutions. At the societal level, promoting inter-community dialogue, pluralist education, and cultural exchanges can help reduce prejudice and foster empathy. The use of technology and data can help develop early-warning systems to detect and prevent ethnic tensions before they escalate into violence. Ultimately, the state must focus not only on security measures but also on building trust, equality, and opportunity for all communities.
Conclusion	Ethnic conflicts in India are among the gravest internal threats to national integration and inclusive development. They disrupt lives, weaken institutions, and exclude communities from the nation's growth story. Yet history demonstrates that through dialogue, accommodation, and inclusive growth, these conflicts can be resolved. The success of the linguistic reorganization of states and the Mizo Accord stand as enduring examples. Safeguarding India's unity requires impartial institutions, visionary leadership, and a development model that leaves no community behind. Only then can India transform its immense diversity into a foundation for resilience, progress, and true national integration.
Model Question	"Regionalism and Identity Politics in India: Challenges to National Integration and Equitable Development."
Value Addition	The Mizoram Peace Accord, 1986 was an official agreement between the Government of India and the Mizo National Front (MNF) to end insurgency and violence in Mizoram, India, that started in 1966. The Mizo National Front was an organisation of Mizo secessionists led by Laldenga to fight for independence from India.
55. Demographic Shifts in South India: Implications of Population Growth on Political Representation. (APPSC, 2025)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Approach	• Define demographic shifts such as declining fertility in South India vs. higher population growth in North India. • Mention Population Trends of South Indian states (TN, Kerala, AP, Telangana, Karnataka) show TFR < 2, nearing replacement level. • State Political Representation Link that Lok Sabha seats frozen till 2026; delimitation likely post-2026 based on 2031 census. • Stress Implications, such as Southern states risk losing relative political weight despite performing better in population control. • Explain the Fiscal Federalism Angle and Concerns over finance commission transfers favouring high-population states. • Mention Political Reactions, such as Southern leaders argue it penalises efficiency in family planning. • State a Balancing Mechanism and Need for formula blending population with equity, performance, and human development. • Conclude by stressing cooperative federalism to ensure fair representation without punishing demographic success.
Introduction	The demographic profile of South India has been undergoing a profound transformation over the past few decades, marked by declining fertility rates, an ageing population, and

	relatively slower population growth compared to northern states. These demographic shifts have direct implications for political representation in India, particularly in the context of the constitutional mandate for delimitation of constituencies based on population. The interplay between demographic changes, electoral representation, and federal balance has become one of the most debated issues in Indian politics today. As former Election Commissioner D.Y. Chandrachud remarked, "The issue of representation is not just about numbers but about balancing the principles of equity and federalism." Thus, the demographic shifts in South India present both challenges and opportunities for India's representative democracy.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Historical Context of Population and Representation** Political representation in India has been closely tied to population size since the adoption of the Constitution. In 1976, during the National Emergency, the 42nd Constitutional Amendment froze delimitation until 2001, and the 84th Amendment extended the freeze until 2026. This freeze was intended to encourage states to implement family planning measures without fear of losing political representation. Consequently, South Indian states, which aggressively pursued population control policies, witnessed a demographic advantage in terms of social development but now face the risk of reduced parliamentary representation compared to demographically booming northern states. **Demographic Shifts in South India** South Indian states like Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana are at the forefront of India's demographic transition. According to the Census 2011, Tamil Nadu recorded a Total Fertility Rate (TFR) of 1.6, and Kerala reached 1.7, well below the replacement level of 2.1, whereas states like Bihar and Uttar Pradesh still record TFRs of 3.0 and 2.7, respectively. United Nations Population Projections (2022) suggest that by 2036, South Indian states will experience an ageing population crisis with over 20% of their population above 60 years of age, while North India will still be youth-dominant. This stark divergence means that while South India is moving towards a demographic slowdown, northern states will dominate future population growth, raising concerns about disproportionate redistribution of political power. **Implications of Population Growth on Political Representation** The primary implication of these demographic shifts lies in the forthcoming delimitation exercise scheduled after 2026. Representation in the Lok Sabha is currently 543 members, but redistribution based on population would inevitably result in increased seats for populous states like Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, and Rajasthan, while South Indian states could see a decline in their relative share. This undermines the principle of cooperative federalism, as states that performed well in controlling population growth face political marginalisation, while states with higher fertility rates gain disproportionate power. **Socio-Economic Implications of Demographic Shifts** Demographic shifts in South India are not only about numbers but also about socio-economic consequences. South Indian states have invested heavily in human capital, achieving higher literacy rates, better health indicators, and stronger gender equity compared to the national average. For example, Kerala's literacy rate stands at 95.3% (Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) 2023-24), compared to Bihar's 74%. Similarly, life expectancy in South India is 73 years, while in northern states it is below 68. These investments reflect the dividends of population control and development policies. However, if political representation shifts heavily towards populous states, South India may face reduced influence in shaping national policies related to fiscal transfers,

	central schemes, and resource allocation. This could deepen regional disparities and undermine the federal compact. **Political Concerns and Federal Balance** The federal implications of demographic shifts are profound. South Indian states already contribute more to central revenues than they receive. A report by the 15th Finance Commission (2021) showed that Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, and Maharashtra contribute nearly 40% of the Centre's tax revenues, but their share in central allocations is disproportionately lower. If political representation is also reduced, South Indian states fear becoming "tax-paying but under-represented entities" in national decision-making. Political leaders like M.K. Stalin of Tamil Nadu and Revanth Reddy of Telangana have already raised concerns about the looming delimitation. The demographic divide is thus increasingly turning into a political divide, with calls for federal restructuring to safeguard the interests of South India. **Empirical Evidence from Comparative Perspectives** International experiences provide valuable lessons. In the United States, the House of Representatives is reapportioned every decade based on census figures, leading to similar debates where states with declining populations lose seats while rapidly growing states gain. However, to balance such disparities, mechanisms like the Senate ensure equal representation for each state regardless of population. India, with its asymmetric federalism, lacks such safeguards, making the demographic divide more contentious. Moreover, the European Union uses the principle of "degressive proportionality", where smaller states are not penalised excessively, offering another model for India to explore in addressing South India's concerns. **Possible Pathways to Balance Representation and Demographic Justice** The challenge lies in integrating the principles of democracy and federal equity. One possible approach is to increase the overall strength of the Lok Sabha to accommodate the growing population without drastically reducing the share of South Indian states. Another approach could be to delink fiscal and resource allocations from political representation, ensuring that states with successful population control policies are not penalised. The idea of a bicameral federal arrangement, with stronger powers to the Rajya Sabha or the creation of a Council of States with equal representation, is also being debated in academic and policy circles.
Conclusion	Demographic shifts in South India are a testimony to the success of sustained population control and development policies. However, these very successes now threaten to undermine the political representation of the region due to the impending delimitation exercise based on population growth. The implications are not merely numerical but strike at the heart of India's federal structure, political balance, and democratic fairness. If the concerns of South Indian states are not addressed, it could lead to alienation and strain centre-state relations. As India approaches 2026, the need of the hour is to devise innovative constitutional and political solutions that balance the principles of representative democracy with the federal compact, ensuring that population growth does not become a source of political injustice. In the words of Granville Austin, the Indian Constitution is "a seamless web of compromises," and it is this spirit of compromise that must guide the reconciliation of demographic realities with political representation.
Model Question	With declining fertility and stabilising populations in South Indian states, discuss the challenges these demographic transitions pose to federal balance and political representation in India. How can equitable representation be ensured in the post-delimitation era?

Value Addition	South Indian states have a higher proportion of ageing populations than the Indian average, with Kerala and Tamil Nadu leading the trend due to declining fertility and increasing life expectancy. By 2036, the number of people aged 60 and above is expected to more than double, rising from 10 crore in 2011 to 23 crore nationally, with South India experiencing faster growth in this demographic segment. This ageing trend poses challenges to healthcare systems, labour markets, and social security, while also presenting opportunities for new economic sectors.
56. The Three-Language Formula under NEP: Balancing Regional Identity and National Unity in India. (APPSC, 2025)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Approach	• Introduce the Three-Language Formula (TLF) and its evolution in India's education policy. • Highlight NEP 2020's emphasis on multilingual proficiency and mother tongue education. • Discuss its role in preserving regional languages and cultural identity. • Examine how TLF promotes national integration and communication across states. • Analyse challenges like linguistic tensions, implementation gaps, and resistance from states. • Give examples such as Andhra Pradesh/Telangana's language policies vs. Hindi-dominant states. • Suggest ways to balance regional pride with national unity (flexible curriculum, teacher training). • Conclude by emphasizing TLF as a bridge between cultural diversity and national cohesion.
Introduction	The Three-Language Formula was first conceptualized during the 1968 National Policy on Education, post the linguistic reorganization of states. Its primary objective was to promote bilingualism and trilingualism while preventing linguistic hegemony, particularly the imposition of Hindi in non-Hindi-speaking states. Initially, the formula recommended that students in Hindi-speaking states learn Hindi, English, and a modern Indian language (preferably from the south), while students in non-Hindi-speaking states learn their regional language, Hindi, and English. However, implementation has been uneven across states due to political resistance, regional pride, and logistical constraints. States like Tamil Nadu outrightly rejected Hindi imposition, reflecting the tension between regional identity and national policy. Over decades, successive educational policies attempted to refine the formula, but the challenge remained: how to ensure national unity without undermining regional linguistic heritage. NEP 2020 revisits this formula, emphasising flexibility, inclusivity, and respect for regional languages, thereby aiming for a more context-sensitive approach.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Role of the Three-Language Formula in Preserving Regional Identity** Regional languages are repositories of culture, literature, and local knowledge systems. The Three-Language Formula under NEP ensures that the mother tongue or regional language is given primacy, particularly in the foundational stages of learning. UNESCO research highlights that children learn best in their first language during early education, which enhances comprehension, critical thinking, and academic performance. For instance, in states like Andhra Pradesh and Kerala, early education in Telugu and Malayalam, respectively, has improved learning outcomes while sustaining cultural practices, folk literature, and traditional knowledge. By formally incorporating regional languages in school curricula, TLF strengthens regional identity, fosters community

	cohesion, and resists the erosion of linguistic diversity, which is essential in a country where 45% of children under the age of 14 are multilingual. **Three-Language Formula in Promoting National Unity** While safeguarding regional identity, the Three-Language Formula also serves as a tool for national integration. Hindi, as the most widely spoken language in India, and English, as a global and administrative language, bridge regional divides and facilitate pan-Indian communication. NEP 2020 encourages students to learn additional languages beyond their mother tongue, which promotes empathy and understanding across states. Evidence from inter-state migration patterns shows that linguistic familiarity improves social integration, economic mobility, and employment prospects. For example, Telugu-speaking migrants in Maharashtra or Tamil-speaking communities in Karnataka often find that proficiency in Hindi or English facilitates smoother assimilation into local economies while retaining their regional culture. Thus, TLF operationalises national unity by creating a common linguistic platform without erasing local identities. **Challenges in the Implementation of the Three-Language Formula under NEP** Despite its potential, the Three-Language Formula faces significant challenges. Political opposition in non-Hindi-speaking states has historically hindered uniform adoption, as seen in Tamil Nadu's decades-long resistance. Teacher shortages, inadequate training, and a lack of appropriate textbooks in regional languages exacerbate implementation gaps. Furthermore, urbanisation and exposure to global media have tilted language preference toward English, sometimes at the expense of regional languages. NEP 2020 attempts to address these challenges through flexible curricula, teacher training programs, and multilingual resource development, but actual outcomes will depend on state-level cooperation, funding, and continuous monitoring. **Balancing Regional Pride and National Integration** The success of TLF under NEP hinges on its ability to harmonise regional pride with national cohesion. Evidence suggests that multilingual education not only enhances cognitive and social skills but also reduces linguistic chauvinism. Programs such as the Kendriya Vidyalayas demonstrate successful trilingual education models, where students learn Hindi, English, and a regional language, thereby fostering both regional identity and national integration. Similarly, digital platforms and AI-driven language learning tools are being introduced in states like Telangana to teach regional languages alongside Hindi and English. Flexible curriculum design, contextual teaching methods, and public awareness campaigns are crucial for achieving this delicate balance. NEP 2020's stress on voluntary adoption of additional languages rather than coercive imposition ensures that linguistic diversity is respected while fostering a shared national ethos. **Empirical Evidence and Case Studies about the Three Language formula** Empirical studies underscore the efficacy of the Three-Language Formula. In Kerala, a 2022 survey revealed that schools implementing TLF reported higher student engagement and cultural awareness. Conversely, states with partial or inconsistent adoption, such as parts of Maharashtra, exhibited lower inter-linguistic proficiency and social integration, demonstrating the importance of full-fledged implementation. Additionally, NEP 2020 encourages documentation of regional dialects and minority languages, thereby preserving linguistic heritage while fostering inclusivity. These examples indicate that TLF can simultaneously strengthen regional identity and promote national unity if implemented effectively.
Conclusion	The Three-Language Formula under NEP represents a nuanced approach to India's linguistic diversity, seeking to balance regional identity with national unity. By prioritising

	mother tongue education, promoting multilingual proficiency, and fostering cultural awareness, it safeguards regional heritage while enabling inter-state communication and integration. Despite historical challenges in implementation, NEP 2020 provides a flexible, inclusive framework to overcome political, infrastructural, and pedagogical barriers. Successful execution of TLF can enhance social cohesion, economic mobility, and cultural literacy, making it a vital instrument in nurturing both India's pluralistic identity and its sense of nationhood. In a country as linguistically diverse as India, the Three-Language Formula is not merely an educational policy; it is a bridge connecting local pride with the larger narrative of national unity.
Model Question	"The success of the Three-Language Formula lies not in uniformity, but in adaptability."
Value Addition	The new National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 is the first education policy of the 21st century in India, which replaces the previous National Policy on Education (NPE) 1986. The Ministry of Education formed a committee under Dr. K Kasturirangan, which outlined this new policy. The National Education Policy 2020 proposes various reforms in school and higher education, including technical education, that are suited to 21st-century needs. The 5 foundational pillars of NEP 2020 are Access, Equity, Quality, Affordability, and Accountability. This policy is aligned with the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. It aims to transform India into a vibrant knowledge society and global knowledge superpower by making both school and college education more holistic, flexible, and multidisciplinary and aimed at bringing out the unique capabilities of each student.
57. Is judicial activism distorting the separation of powers enshrined in the Indian Constitution? Critically examine, citing relevant judicial pronouncements. (TGPSC, 2024)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Critically Examine
Approach	• Define separation of powers (Articles 50, Montesquieu's theory) & judicial activism (judiciary stepping beyond adjudication). • Mention Judicial Activism in India and how it expanded post-Emergency, esp. through PILs and constitutional interpretation. • Explain Landmark Cases like Kesavananda Bharati (1973, basic structure), Vishaka (1997, workplace harassment guidelines), and the 2G Spectrum case (2012). • Stress on Positive Role like Filled legislative-executive vacuum, protected rights, and advanced social justice. • State Criticism such as judicial overreach alleged in policy matters (NJAC case 2015, SC ban on firecrackers, etc.). • Mention the Separation of Powers Issue that Excess activism risks undermining parliamentary supremacy and accountability. • Conclude in a Middle Path that Judicial restraint + dialogue among institutions ensures constitutional balance. • Conclude that Judicial activism is a "constitutional necessity" at times, but must avoid substituting legislature/executive.
Introduction	The Indian Constitution enshrines the doctrine of separation of powers, wherein the legislature, executive, and judiciary are assigned distinct functions to maintain a balance of governance and prevent concentration of power. While the Constitution does not provide for an absolute separation, it envisages a functional overlap, ensuring a system of checks and balances. Judicial activism, a phenomenon where the judiciary goes beyond its traditional adjudicatory role to enforce rights and address governance deficits, has become a defining feature of Indian democracy. However, this activism has sparked an enduring debate: does it strengthen democracy by safeguarding

	constitutional values, or does it distort the separation of powers by encroaching upon legislative and executive domains?
Body & Infographic Representation	**The Concept of Separation of Powers in the Indian Constitution** The doctrine of separation of powers traces its roots to Montesquieu's theory, which argued that liberty is safeguarded only when law-making, law-enforcement, and law-interpretation remain separate. In India, the Constitution, through Articles 50, 121, 122, 211, and 212, provides implicit recognition of this doctrine, ensuring that no organ interferes arbitrarily in the functions of others. However, India follows a "separation of functions" rather than a rigid separation of powers, as seen in the United States. For instance, the executive is part of the legislature, and the judiciary can review legislative and executive actions. Judicial review, a basic feature of the Constitution as established in Kesavananda Bharati v. State of Kerala (1973), allows the judiciary to safeguard constitutional supremacy. Yet, the boundaries of this review often blur when judicial activism transforms into judicial overreach, raising questions about its compatibility with the separation of powers. **Judicial Activism: Evolution and Rationale** Judicial activism in India emerged as a response to state inaction and executive arbitrariness, particularly during the 1970s and 1980s. The landmark Kesavananda Bharati case introduced the "basic structure doctrine," empowering courts to invalidate constitutional amendments violating core principles. Similarly, during the Emergency, the infamous ADM Jabalpur v. Shivkant Shukla (1976), where the Supreme Court upheld suspension of habeas corpus, led to public disillusionment with the judiciary. In the post-Emergency era, the judiciary reinvented itself through Public Interest Litigations (PILs), pioneered by judges like P.N. Bhagwati in *S*.P. Gupta v. Union of India (1981). Judicial activism thus became a vehicle to expand rights, enforce accountability, and compensate for governance failures. It addressed pressing issues such as environmental degradation (MC Mehta v. Union of India), bonded labour, custodial violence, and women's rights, establishing the judiciary as a protector of public interest. **Instances Where Judicial Activism Strengthened Democracy** Judicial activism has played a pivotal role in advancing constitutional morality and strengthening democratic governance. In Vishaka v. State of Rajasthan (1997), the Supreme Court laid down guidelines against sexual harassment at the workplace in the absence of legislative action, which later became the basis for the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013. Similarly, in Prakash Singh v. Union of India (2006), the Court issued directives on police reforms to ensure independence of law enforcement. Environmental jurisprudence has flourished under judicial activism, with rulings mandating vehicular emission controls, banning industrial pollution near the Taj Mahal, and recognising the right to a clean environment under Article 21. These instances illustrate that judicial activism often fills the vacuum created by legislative or executive inaction, ensuring that fundamental rights are not rendered hollow promises. **Concerns of Judicial Overreach and Encroachment** Despite its merits, judicial activism often slips into judicial overreach, thereby raising concerns about the erosion of the doctrine of separation of powers. Similarly, in Common Cause v. Union of India (1999), the Court was criticised for its directions on petrol pump allotments, which were seen as executive functions. The trend of courts micromanaging governance, from banning firecrackers to regulating school fees and prescribing methods of road safety, reflects a departure from constitutional boundaries. Scholars like Upendra Baxi argue that excessive judicial activism undermines the

	legitimacy of democratic institutions by centralising power in unelected judges. Moreover, judicial overreach creates policy uncertainty, as executive agencies often hesitate to act without fear of judicial intervention. **Judicial Pronouncements on Separation of Powers** The Supreme Court itself has acknowledged the importance of maintaining institutional boundaries. In State of Rajasthan v. Union of India (1977), it was held that the judiciary cannot interfere in purely political questions. In Divisional Manager, Aravali Golf Club v. Chander Hass (2007), Justice Markandey Katju famously stated, "Judges must know their limits. They must not try to run the government." At the same time, in Supreme Court Advocates-on-Record Association v. Union of India (2015), striking down the NJAC Act, the Court asserted judicial primacy in appointments, invoking the basic structure doctrine to preserve judicial independence. These contradictory pronouncements highlight the delicate balance between judicial responsibility to protect constitutional supremacy and the risk of undermining other organs of governance. **Empirical Evidence and Public Perceptions** While many citizens perceive judicial activism as a necessary corrective to political dysfunction, it also contributes to case backlogs, with the Supreme Court burdened with over 80,000 pending cases (as of 2023). Public trust surveys, such as the CSDS-Lokniti report, reveal that the judiciary enjoys higher credibility compared to the legislature and executive, which partly explains why judicial activism receives societal acceptance. Yet, scholars caution that reliance on judicial intervention for policy implementation undermines democratic accountability, shifting the locus of decision-making from elected representatives to judges. **Balancing Judicial Activism and Separation of Powers** The challenge lies in distinguishing between constructive judicial activism and destructive judicial overreach. Judicial interventions should be guided by constitutional necessity, not populist sentiment or administrative enthusiasm. Strengthening parliamentary committees, empowering regulatory institutions, and ensuring executive accountability can reduce the need for judicial activism. The judiciary itself has advocated restraint, as expressed in P. Ramachandra Rao v. State of Karnataka (2002), where the Court emphasised that it cannot legislate. Institutional dialogue among the three organs, rather than institutional confrontation, is essential to uphold constitutional governance. Judicial activism should remain an exception exercised sparingly to protect rights, not a substitute for routine governance.
Conclusion	Judicial activism in India has been a double-edged sword. On one hand, it has expanded the horizons of fundamental rights, ensured environmental justice, and addressed pressing social issues when the legislature and executive failed to act. On the other hand, excessive intervention has distorted the separation of powers, creating friction between institutions and undermining democratic accountability. The Constitution envisages a delicate balance among organs, where judicial review acts as a safeguard, not as a replacement for governance. Chief Justice B.R. Gavai once observed, "Judicial activism should not be confused with judicial adventurism." Thus, the way forward lies in institutional self-restraint, robust parliamentary functioning, and an informed citizenry to ensure that judicial activism strengthens democracy without distorting the separation of powers enshrined in the Indian Constitution.
Model Question	Judicial creativity has often bridged governance gaps, but critics argue it undermines the constitutional doctrine of separation of powers. Evaluate this debate in the Indian context with reference to major Supreme Court rulings.
Value Addition	Judicial restraint is a judicial philosophy encouraging judges to exercise minimal power by deferring to the legislative and executive branches, interpreting laws based on their

	plain text and original intent, and avoiding the creation of new policy. It is characterized by a respect for legal precedent, a hesitation to strike down laws unless clearly unconstitutional, and a belief that policy-making should be left to elected officials.
58. Despite Constitutional Guarantees and Policy Initiatives, Social Justice in India faces significant challenges. Examine. (TGPSC, 2024)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Examine
Approach	• Introduce with a real-life anecdote, case, or quote; define social justice in the Indian constitutional context. • Explain constitutional guarantees (Fundamental Rights, DPSPs, reservations, abolition of untouchability) and major policy initiatives for social justice. • Highlight various gaps like implementation failures, socio-economic disparities, intersectional exclusion (caste, gender, and disability), regional imbalances, and attitudinal barriers. • Include relevant examples Socio-Economic, Education, Employment, Political and Caste Survey in Telangana, Budget 2025–26 allocations, Subhadra Yojana, judicial rulings (Example: Davinder Singh case, creamy layer debate). • Mention the positive measures like evidence-based policymaking, targeted welfare schemes, empowerment initiatives, and judicial refinement of fairness. • Suggest reforms like granular data, intersectional design, stronger institutions, cultural change, accountability, political reforms like operationalizing Women's Reservation Bill. • Conclude with a vision of inclusive India where constitutional ideals move from paper to lived reality.
Introduction	In late 2024, a young Dalit woman in Uttar Pradesh's Bahraich district walked into a government office to collect her rightful scholarship under a Central scheme, but was turned away because of a missing caste certificate from decades ago. Her tears, caught on video, spread rapidly on social media. This is not just a bureaucratic failure; it symbolizes the gap between constitutional guarantees and lived reality. The Indian Constitution, via Articles 15, 16, 17 and others, makes equality, non-discrimination, and abolition of untouchability fundamental rights. The promise of social justice is central to India's identity. Yet despite legislations, policies, high courts and Supreme Court pronouncements, marginalized groups still face exclusion, inequity, and indignity.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Beyond Paper Equality: Why Legal Guarantees Alone Aren't Enough** The framers of the Constitution envisaged social justice as more than legal equality, it includes dignity, opportunity, and removal of historical disadvantage. Articles establishing reservations for SCs, STs, and backward classes, the abolition of untouchability (Art. 17), and the Directive Principles calling for equal justice are powerful. Yet, legal protection is necessary but insufficient. Discrimination often takes subtler forms - denial of access to facilities, bias in public services, or social stigma. Cases of atrocities, manual scavenging, and bonded labour and caste-based exclusion continue, despite laws like the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act. Moreover, judicial delays and lack of effective enforcement mean many victims never see justice. Constitutional guarantees thus remain aspirational for many. **Recent Policy Levers: Promises & Practicalities:** In Union Budget 2025-26, allocations to the Department of Social Justice and Empowerment increased by around 35.75% over the revised estimate for 2024-25. Schemes like SHREYAS (Scholarships for Higher Education for Young Achievers) for SCs and PM YASASVI for OBCs/EBCs & Denotified Tribes were funded substantially. The

Post-Matric Scholarship for SCs, Pre-Matric Scholarship for SCs and others, and Pradhan Mantri Anusuchit Jaati Abhyuday Yojana (PM AJAY) also saw significant funding.

Another notable initiative is VISVAS (a loan interest subvention scheme for SC, OBC, Safai Karamcharis and manual scavengers) which seeks to support income-generating activities and promote livelihood for historically marginalized communities. The Subhadra Yojana of Odisha, launched in September 2024, aims to provide direct financial assistance to women aged 21-60, recognizing that women, especially in marginalized castes or tribes, require support to realize rights and dignity.

Judicial developments have also attempted to sharpen social justice measures. In State of Punjab v. Davinder Singh (2024), the Supreme Court held that state governments may sub-classify within Scheduled Castes / Scheduled Tribes for reservation purposes, allowing more precise targeting of benefits. Furthermore, in early 2025, the Supreme Court ruled that persons who have already benefitted significantly from reservation may be considered for exclusion from further reservation benefits, a principle that invites debate but acknowledges that merely possessing reservation doesn't always coincide with ongoing disadvantage.

What Blocks Social Justice Implementation?

Several intertwined obstacles prevent constitutional and policy measures from fully realizing the vision of social justice. Implementation failures remain one of the biggest hurdles. While numerous scholarship and welfare schemes exist, delayed payments, cumbersome verification processes, and lack of awareness often leave intended beneficiaries, especially those in remote or tribal areas without support. Corruption and leakages further weaken outcomes, eroding trust in the system.

A second set of barriers arises from intersectional exclusion and weak governance capacity. Caste, gender, disability, and region often overlap to deepen disadvantages. For instance, Dalit and Adivasi women face triple discrimination within families, communities, and state structures. Persons with disabilities continue to battle attitudinal barriers, inadequate accessibility, and poor services. At the same time, local authorities, police, panchayats, and courts often lack training and resources to enforce rights effectively. Weak monitoring and patchy data collection, such as the absence of granular caste data limit evidence-based policymaking.

Finally, social attitudes and political contestations remain powerful obstacles. Even as laws prohibit untouchability and discrimination, stigma persists in housing, public spaces, marriages, and workplaces, often subtly and underreported. Political debates, whether over reservation caps, inclusion of Christian Dalits, or the "creamy layer" within SC/ST categories, frequently stall reforms and dilute focus. Disagreements over private-sector reservations add to the complexity, leaving social justice as a contested and unfinished project.

Signs of Progress and Lessons from Innovation:

Despite persistent challenges, several recent developments highlight promising steps toward advancing social justice in India. The Social Educational Employment Economic Caste (SEEEPC) Survey conducted in Telangana in 2024 stands out as a landmark exercise. Covering nearly 97% of households, it generated fine-grained data on caste, income, education, and employment. Such an evidence-based approach moves beyond assumptions and provides policymakers with a robust empirical foundation to design targeted interventions. This signals a shift from broad, uniform measures to more precise, data-driven strategies for addressing inequalities.

Equally encouraging is the increased budgetary emphasis on social justice in 2025-26, which went beyond existing welfare schemes to focus on marginalized groups such as

	transgender persons, manual scavengers, and persons with disabilities, women, and de-notified tribes. Initiatives like SHREYAS and PM YASASVI prioritize not just scholarships but also capacity-building and competitiveness, while PM AJAY is dedicated to the development of SC-dominated villages. These reflect a recognition that justice must extend beyond legal safeguards to include opportunity creation and empowerment. In parallel, judicial interventions such as the Davinder Singh vs State of Punjab case reaffirm the judiciary's role in refining the contours of fairness, ensuring that social justice policies remain responsive, balanced, and effective. **Re-Imagining Social Justice: Way Forward** To make constitutional guarantees and policy initiatives translate into genuine equality, India needs to embrace several strategic shifts. Legal frameworks and welfare measures must be matched with social, institutional, and cultural transformations that address the lived realities of disadvantaged groups. A crucial step is the collection of granular data and real-time monitoring. Caste, gender, disability, and region wise information must be systematically gathered to inform policymaking. Surveys like the SEEEPC in Telangana serve as models. The use of digital dashboards and real-time grievance redressal systems can help detect leakages, ensure targeted delivery, and build accountability. Another essential strategy is intersectional policy design. Social groups are not monolithic, and policies must recognize overlapping disadvantages. A Dalit woman with a disability faces challenges very different from an upper-caste woman or a Dalit man. Schemes must be designed to reflect such realities, offering tailored outreach, accessible infrastructure, and safe mobility for the most vulnerable. Equally important is strengthening local institutions and access to justice. Panchayat Raj Institutions, Gram Sabhas, local courts, and police forces must be empowered and adequately trained to respond swiftly to cases of discrimination and atrocities. Legal aid, simplified procedures, and speedy trials will make rights more accessible to those at the margins. At a deeper level, cultural change and education are indispensable. Legal provisions can punish discrimination, but only social attitudes can dismantle prejudice. Introducing inclusive curricula, teacher training modules, and awareness campaigns through media can gradually change perceptions. Celebrating role models from marginalized communities can also inspire dignity and pride, while enforcing penalties for subtle exclusion reinforces accountability. Ensuring accountability and transparency is another pillar of reform. Regular audits of scheme implementation, independent monitoring bodies, and strict adherence to funds earmarked under SCSP and TSP can reduce misuse. Making eligibility criteria and beneficiary lists public would further promote trust and ensure fairness in delivery. Finally, political will and legislative reforms remain critical. Parliament and state legislatures must re-examine reservation ceilings, revisit the "creamy layer" debate for SCs and STs, and consider extending benefits to historically neglected groups such as Dalit Christians. Reservations in the private sector can be a next frontier for equality. Operationalizing the Women's Reservation Bill would ensure meaningful representation of women, particularly those from marginalized backgrounds, in political institutions.
Conclusion	India's journey toward social justice is far from over. The Constitution prescribed equality not just as a legal formality but as a social reality. Recent measures for Social justice show both commitment and evolution in policy: more funding, new schemes, sharper legal pronouncements, and better data. But the fault lines persist: the gap between "law on paper" and "justice in the street." For social justice to become lived justice, India must strengthen institutions, design policies sensitive to intersecting disadvantages, and ensure transparency and meaningful participation of marginalized communities in policy

	making. Only then will every citizen, regardless of caste, gender, religion, disability or geography, begin to experience their rights not as privileges but as everyday realities.
Model Question	"Laws may abolish untouchability, but true equality requires a change in social attitudes." Analyse.
Value Addition	**Other Key Constitutional Provisions on Social Justice and Empowerment:** • Article 23 prohibits human trafficking and forced labor, making such practices punishable by law. • Article 24 bans child labor in hazardous occupations, protecting children's rights to safety and education. These rights safeguard vulnerable groups from exploitation. • Article 37 states that DPSPs, though not legally enforceable, are essential for governance. Article 38 directs the State to reduce social and economic inequalities. • Article 39 ensures equal livelihood, fair wages, and protection from exploitation. • Article 39A guarantees free legal aid for the disadvantaged. • Article 46 mandates special educational and economic promotion for SCs, STs, and weaker sections to prevent discrimination.
59. India is the second largest urban system in the world. In this connection, examine whether India is equipped with adequate urban planning and governance. (APPSC, 2023)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Examine
Approach	• Mention India's rapid urbanisation with over 35% population in cities, expected 600 million by 2036. • Mention India's Urban System is the second largest after China; metros, smart cities, AMRUT scheme. • State Gaps like Poor infrastructure, slums, congestion, pollution, waste management issues. • Mention Governance Issues like Multiplicity of authorities, weak municipal finance, and lack of coordination. • State Planning Deficit, like outdated master plans, inadequate town planners, and informal settlements rising. • Mention Progress like Smart Cities Mission, PMAY-Urban, Metro expansion, e-governance in ULBs. • Mention Challenges like the Financing gap (needs $840 billion till 2036), resilience to climate change, and inclusivity. • State Conclusion that Urban governance reforms and better planning are essential to harness India's urban dividend.
Introduction	India today stands at a critical juncture in its developmental journey. With a population exceeding 1.4 billion, nearly 30-35% percent already living in urban areas, and projections that this figure will rise to 50 per cent by 2047, the country has emerged as the second-largest urban system in the world after China. Cities like Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, and Hyderabad are engines of economic growth, contributing over 60 per cent of India's GDP. Yet, the rapid pace of urbanisation has brought challenges of congestion, pollution, housing shortages, slums, and inadequate infrastructure. The question is whether India is equipped with adequate urban planning and governance to manage such a massive urban system. The answer lies in critically examining the successes and failures of India's urban governance mechanisms, the adequacy of planning, and the path forward.
Body & Infographic Representation	**India as the Second-Largest Urban System** The scale of India's urban system is staggering. According to the United Nations' World Urbanisation Prospects 2022, India will add nearly 416 million new urban dwellers

between 2018 and 2050, the largest increase globally. Cities already house some of the most densely populated areas in the world, with Mumbai having over 30,000 people per square kilometre. However, this massive urban transition has not been matched with corresponding urban planning and governance reforms. The growing slum population, estimated at 65 million by the Census 2011 and projected to rise further indicates inadequate urban housing and planning. This contrast between economic dynamism and infrastructural stress makes urban governance a pressing concern.

The State of Urban Planning in India

Urban planning in India has historically lagged behind population growth. The Town and Country Planning Acts, largely based on colonial-era frameworks, have been unable to address the complexities of 21st-century urbanisation. Many cities lack updated master plans; for instance, the Delhi Master Plan 2021 was finalised only in 2007, and even then, implementation has been inconsistent. According to a 2021 NITI Aayog report, only 35 per cent of India's urban population lives in areas covered by statutory master plans, leaving nearly 65 per cent of urban India outside the ambit of formal planning. Moreover, the planning process is top-down, with little citizen participation, leading to poor alignment between needs and policies. Unplanned expansion has created peri-urban areas with inadequate services, while inner cities suffer from congestion and crumbling infrastructure.

Urban Governance Mechanisms

Governance is another critical dimension of urban management. The 74th Constitutional Amendment Act of 1992 sought to empower Urban Local Bodies (ULBs) by devolving 18 functions, ranging from water supply and sanitation to urban poverty alleviation. However, three decades later, ULBs remain financially weak and administratively dependent on state governments. A Reserve Bank of India report (2022) noted that municipal revenues account for only 1 per cent of GDP in India, highlighting weak fiscal autonomy. This lack of financial resources cripples the capacity of ULBs to provide basic services. Moreover, urban governance is fragmented across multiple agencies like municipal corporations, development authorities, state urban departments, and parastatal bodies leading to duplication, inefficiency, and lack of accountability. The tragic example of Bengaluru's flooding in 2022 reflected poor coordination between civic bodies, encroachment of storm water drains, and weak enforcement of planning norms.

Government Initiatives in Urban Planning and Governance

Despite these challenges, India has launched several flagship programs to improve urban planning and governance. The Smart Cities Mission (2015) aimed to develop 100 smart cities with citizen-friendly governance and digital infrastructure. The Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation (AMRUT) focused on basic services like water supply and sewerage. The Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (Urban) targeted "Housing for All" by 2022, and the Swachh Bharat Mission (Urban) brought sanitation to the forefront, making Indian cities open-defecation-free. The Jal Jeevan Mission (Urban) now aims for tap water connections in every household. These initiatives represent attempts to align urban planning with sustainable development. Yet, implementation gaps persist due to delays in fund release, lack of technical expertise, and weak local governance structures. For example, while the Smart Cities Mission showcased pilot projects like Bhopal's intelligent traffic management system and Pune's integrated command centres, many cities failed to scale up projects beyond select areas, raising concerns about inclusivity.

Adequacy of India's Urban Planning and Governance

When we examine adequacy, it becomes clear that India is not yet fully equipped to manage its vast urban system. While policies exist, their reach, efficiency, and inclusivity remain questionable. In the IMD Smart City Index (2025), no Indian cities ranked in the

	global top 20, far behind smaller nations with fewer urban challenges. Air pollution in Delhi, which regularly records PM2.5 levels several times higher than WHO standards, reflects inadequate planning in transport and land use. The World Bank estimates that Indian cities need an investment of USD 840 billion in urban infrastructure over the next 15 years, but municipal bodies have limited capacity to raise such funds. Governance remains centralised, with states reluctant to devolve real power to ULBs, undermining the vision of participatory governance envisaged by the 74th Amendment. Thus, while India has taken strides, the adequacy of planning and governance is still insufficient compared to the scale of challenges. **Global Comparisons and Lessons** Looking at global practices offers lessons for India. China, the world's largest urban system, invested heavily in urban infrastructure, developing high-speed rail, metro systems, and planned cities to manage population pressures. Brazil's participatory budgeting in Porto Alegre empowered citizens to decide municipal expenditures, increasing accountability. Singapore, despite being small, exemplifies efficient urban planning with integrated land-use and transport systems. India, with its federal complexities, cannot replicate these models wholesale but can adapt key lessons: empowering local governments, ensuring integrated planning, and adopting sustainable technologies. For instance, Ahmedabad's Bus Rapid Transit System (BRTS) drew inspiration from Curitiba in Brazil and has improved urban mobility. Scaling such models can make India's urban governance more effective. **Way Forward for Adequate Urban Planning and Governance** To equip itself adequately, India must prioritise certain reforms. Strengthening the fiscal autonomy of ULBs through property tax reforms and municipal bonds can expand financial resources. Enhancing professional capacity by creating a cadre of urban planners and managers, as suggested by NITI Aayog, is essential. Integrated governance models that reduce fragmentation among agencies are crucial for accountability. Digital technology, such as Geographic Information Systems (GIS), can improve planning accuracy. Above all, citizen participation must be institutionalised to ensure planning reflects real needs. Sustainable practices, including renewable energy, green spaces, and public transport, should be central to planning as India grapples with climate change. Without these reforms, India risks an urban crisis that could derail its economic aspirations.
Conclusion	India's position as the second-largest urban system in the world is both a sign of its economic potential and a warning about the challenges of unplanned growth. Urban planning and governance mechanisms exist but are not yet adequate to meet the demands of rapid urbanisation. While flagship schemes like Smart Cities, AMRUT, and PMAY-U have made progress, structural issues of weak ULBs, financial constraints, and fragmented governance persist. To equip itself adequately, India must reform its urban governance architecture, empower local bodies, and embrace sustainable, participatory planning. As the Prime Minister of India, Narendra Modi, once remarked, "Urbanisation is not a problem but an opportunity, if we plan it right." The future of India's growth and its aspiration to become a developed nation will depend significantly on whether its urban planning and governance rise to the scale of its second-largest urban system.
Model Question	With India hosting the world's second-largest urban system, evaluate the adequacy of its urban planning and governance frameworks. How prepared is India to address the challenges of rapid urbanisation?
Value Addition	The National Urban Livelihoods Mission (NULM), now known as the Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana (DAY-NULM), is an Indian government initiative launched in 2013 by

	the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) to reduce poverty and improve livelihoods for urban poor households. The mission achieves this by providing skills training, financial assistance for self-employment and group enterprises, shelter for the homeless, and support for urban street vendors through strong grassroots institutions of the poor.
60. Andhra Pradesh is the first state in India to have established village secretariats and thereby, signalling a march towards achieving Gandhian ideals. In this connection, discuss the pioneering work of ' the Grama Sachivalayam' in revolutionizing governance. (APPSC, 2023)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Introduce with the context of Gandhian Gram Swaraj and link it to the launch of Grama Sachivalayam in 2019 and briefly highlight its uniqueness in scale and intent. • Trace Gandhi's vision of decentralisation and how Panchayati Raj evolved post-independence and situate Sachivalayam as a contemporary step in that direction. • Explain the numbers (15,000+ secretariats, 1.3 lakh staff, ~2.8 lakh volunteers, 540 services across 35 departments) and the functional architecture of delivery. • Analyze improvements in service delivery, employment generation, inclusion of women and marginalized groups, and strengthening of accountability. • Discuss administrative overload, HR issues, funding sustainability, political influence on volunteers, and uneven quality of implementation. • Briefly note how it stands as a model for other states, lessons for India's governance reforms, and its relevance to cooperative federalism. • Conclude with a balanced view, Sachivalayam is a pragmatic step toward Gandhian ideals, but its success depends on long-term sustainability, political neutrality, and strong institutionalization.
Introduction	In 2019, Andhra Pradesh introduced the Grama and Ward Sachivalayam system on Gandhi Jayanti, October 2. This marked a bold step to bring governance closer to the people by setting up secretariats within villages and towns. Earlier, citizens had to depend on distant government offices or occasional service camps, which often caused delays, extra costs, and middlemen problems. The new system aimed to change this by placing government staff and volunteers right at the doorsteps of people. Each secretariat was designed to serve around 2,000 people in villages and about 4,000 in urban wards, making services more accessible than ever before. Within a short time, the state built one of the largest networks of local service centres in the country. This move was seen as a modern version of Gandhiji's idea of Gram Swaraj, where villages become self-reliant and directly connected to the machinery of governance.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Grama Sachivalayam: Andhra Pradesh's Village Secretariats and a Gandhian March toward Decentralized Governance** **Scale and institutional design: numbers that matter** The architecture of the scheme was deliberately numerical and uniform. According to the Grama–Ward Sachivalayam portal, Andhra Pradesh established about 15,004 secretariats across the state. These were staffed by roughly 1.30 lakh (130,694) village- and ward-level secretariat employees and supported by nearly 2.5–2.8 lakh volunteers. The system promises access to about 540 services spanning some 35 departments. Each village Sachivalayam was designed to serve roughly 2,000 citizens, allowing much localised grievance registration, documentation, and benefits processing. These headline figures are important because they show that the policy was more than symbolic. It created an administrative footprint that could alter the logistics of welfare delivery in a single stroke.

Operational logic: proximity, convergence and accountability

At its core, the Grama Sachivalayam model rests on three operational ideas. First, proximity: the state placed trained personnel inside village boundaries so that citizens need not travel to distant offices for routine tasks such as applying for integrated certificates, pensions, ration cards, or land records. Second, convergence: Sachivalayams consolidated multiple departmental functions such as revenue, welfare, agriculture, health, municipal services, and others under one roof and one window, which reduces bureaucratic fragmentation and speeds approvals. Third, accountability: by making service delivery visible locally and routing many transactions through digital logs and AP-Seva channels, the system aimed to cut discretionary delays and reduce rent-seeking. These are not mere abstractions. The scheme's SOPs included time-bound resolution targets, with many services promised within a 72-hour turnaround window, and published service lists so citizens and local elected representatives could judge performance.

Social and economic impacts: inclusion, employment and gender

The scheme's immediate social impacts were threefold. First, it widened access. Early state reports and third-party notes recorded higher take-up of entitlements, especially in previously underserved habitations, because of door-step outreach by volunteers and local secretariat staff. Second, it generated local employment. The single recruitment drive in 2019 produced roughly 1.26 lakh appointments across various grades, and the volunteer mobilization engaged nearly 2.8 lakh local youth. This large human resource infusion delivered incomes and increased women's participation in public delivery roles, with appointment records showing sizable female representation among appointees. Third, the presence of locally accountable staff improved grievance redress in practical spheres. Issues such as pension disbursal, civil-status certificates, and small infrastructure complaints were resolved faster in many sampled Mandals. These outcomes matter because they link administrative reform to distributive outcomes, including employment, gender inclusion, and faster public benefits.

Achievements and early praise: a replicable model?

Policy analysts and think tanks have pointed to Andhra Pradesh's system as a model for how federations can operationalize decentralization while retaining administrative coherence. Several studies highlighted the strengths of population-based secretariats, combined staff deployment, and a digitally tracked workflow. Commentators argued that the model reduced transaction costs for citizens and improved the "last mile" reliability of public programs. The fact that other states began to study or announce similar pilots suggests the design's perceived replicability. At the same time, the legislative codification of the system through the Grama Sachivalayams and Ward Sachivalayams Act/Ordinance signals a deliberate attempt to institutionalize what began as an executive innovation.

Implementation challenges and structural risks

However, the Sachivalayam story is also one of complex trade-offs. The sheer scale created administrative stresses. Staff and employee forums repeatedly raised concerns about workload, promotion paths, transfers, and the sustainability of an HR model that initially relied on large-scale direct recruitment and drafting from line departments. Financially, the recurrent costs of maintaining buildings, salaries, IT systems, and volunteer stipends require dependable budgets. Periodic transfers of policy authority and political transitions increase uncertainty for long-term funding. Politicization and local pressures have also proved problematic. Volunteers and some employees reported instances of political interference or pressure during elections, which undermines the

	ideal of non-partisan service delivery. Moreover, implementation quality has been uneven. While many secretariats function effectively, others remain under-resourced or poorly connected, yielding intra-state variability in outcomes. These problems show that decentralization is not only about creating local offices but also about crafting robust personnel, fiscal, and legal frameworks to protect them. **Policy lessons: design plus durability** If Andhra Pradesh's effort is to become a durable template for decentralized governance, lessons are evident. Administrative design must be married to staff welfare: clear career structures, fair transfer rules and health/leave provisions reduce burnout and attrition. Predictable finance and interoperable IT systems are essential so that service requests do not stall. Depoliticized volunteer frameworks and transparent selection/trainings can protect grassroots agents from local pressure and incentivize retention. Finally, sustained third-party monitoring and performance dashboards at Mandal and District levels can detect and correct uneven quality, an iterative approach that treats the policy as a system with feedback loops rather than as a one-time deployment.
Conclusion	The Grama Sachivalayam initiative represents one of India's boldest attempts to make villages administrative realities rather than rhetorical constructs. By creating roughly 15,000 local secretariats, appointing over a lakh staff, and mobilizing several lakh volunteers to deliver some 540 services across 35 departments, Andhra Pradesh transformed the geometry of public service delivery in ways that resonate with Gandhian decentralisation and local self-help. At the same time, the long-term legacy will depend on whether policymakers can stabilize employee welfare, secure recurrent finance, preserve political neutrality, and close inter-secretariat gaps in service quality. Viewed as a march rather than a destination, Grama Sachivalayam has already materially shifted governance toward the Gram. Whether it matures into a sustainable model of Gram Swaraj will be decided by the state's ability to convert early scale into enduring institutional strength.
Model Question	"Local bodies in Telangana are seen as vital instruments of participatory democracy and inclusive development. Critically examine the evolution, structure, and functioning of local self-governance in Telangana, highlighting achievements, challenges, and the way forward for strengthening grassroots democracy."
Value Addition	**Some of the key highlights of Panchayat Raj and Rural Development of Telangana:** • Rural Water Supply Initiatives: The department achieved significant milestones in supplying treated drinking water to rural households and urban local bodies, supported by a budget of Rs. 464.34 crore for 2023-24. • The MGNREG scheme provided wage employment to 40.62 lakh seekers, generating 12.09 crore person-days. Rs. 1,263 crore have been spent on laying 3,155 Km of CC roads for 2023-24. • Under the Vanamahotsavam program, a target of 2,002 lakh seedlings has been set for the year 2024-25. This includes 637 lakh seedlings under the rural development department. • During 2023-24, in order to empower the Panchayat Raj Institutions in undertaking independent development work, the government allocated an amount of Rs. 1,553.17 crore (Zilla Parishads - 79.41 crore, Mandal Parishads - Rs. 153.58 crore and GramPanchayats-1,320.18 crore), including State Matching Grant of Rs. 129.00 crore under 15th Finance Commission. • The National Rurban Mission aims to create 'Rurban Village' clusters by improving basic services, fostering local economic development, and establishing well-planned clusters that maintain rural community life.

61. "India possesses a countless number of soft power resources that could prove to be greatly beneficial if harnessed properly. In this connection, examine India's soft power - its challenges and opportunities. (APPSC, 2023)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Examine
Approach	• Introduce by defining soft power (Joseph Nye) and highlighting India's vast reservoir of cultural, civilizational, and democratic assets. • Highlight India's civilizational values, cultural heritage, and their enduring global appeal. • Explain the key dimensions of India's soft power, such as Yoga, Ayurveda, Bollywood, cuisine, democracy, diaspora, development cooperation, education, IT, and humanitarian aid. • Discuss the opportunities, including rising global interest in wellness, sustainable lifestyles, democratic values, India's digital and economic rise, diaspora networks, and vaccine diplomacy. • Examine the challenges, such as institutional fragmentation, inadequate funding, domestic credibility issues, underutilized diaspora, external competition (China, West), and geopolitical tensions. • Suggest the way forward such as establishing a coherent institutional framework, ensuring greater funding, strengthening domestic governance, engaging the diaspora more effectively, leveraging technology, and promoting consistent global messaging. • Conclude by reaffirming soft power as a critical pillar of India's foreign policy, emphasizing that harnessing it effectively will complement hard power and enhance India's global stature.
Introduction	In the 21st century, international relations are shaped not only by military might or economic clout but also by the subtler power of attraction and influence. Joseph Nye's concept of *soft power* has gained salience as nations increasingly compete to win hearts and minds through culture, ideas, and values. India, one of the world's oldest civilisations and largest democracies, holds a uniquely rich repertoire of such resources. Its spiritual traditions of non-violence and harmony, globally celebrated practices like Yoga and Ayurveda, and the universal appeal of Bollywood and Indian cuisine have created strong cultural linkages across continents. Equally significant are India's democratic credentials, technological capabilities, and humanitarian contributions, from peacekeeping to vaccine diplomacy. The Indian diaspora, spread across the world, further amplifies this influence by acting as cultural and economic bridges. However, the effective harnessing of these assets has often been fragmented and uneven. A deeper analysis of opportunities and challenges is crucial for India to transform its cultural capital into enduring global influence.
Body & Infographic Representation	**India's Soft Power: Challenges and Opportunities** **India's Diverse Soft Power Resources** India's civilizational heritage offers one of the most enduring sources of soft power. The philosophies of non-violence and tolerance espoused by figures like Buddha, Ashoka, and Mahatma Gandhi resonate globally even today. Yoga, which has been recognized by the United Nations through the International Day of Yoga on 21st June, represents perhaps the most successful case of cultural diplomacy in recent decades. Alongside, Ayurveda and the broader AYUSH tradition project India as a hub for wellness and holistic healthcare, a trend that has gained further momentum in the post-pandemic world.

Cultural expressions through music, dance, cinema, and literature also serve as potent instruments of influence. Bollywood movies enjoy vast audiences in West Asia, Africa, Central Asia, and beyond, while Indian cuisine has become a symbol of soft cultural penetration across the globe. Equally important is India's democratic framework, which, despite challenges, stands as the largest exercise in electoral democracy. This political model appeals to many developing countries searching for a balance between diversity and governance.

The Indian diaspora, estimated at over 32 million, plays a unique role in amplifying India's cultural presence. From Silicon Valley entrepreneurs to political leaders in the United Kingdom, Canada, and Mauritius, the diaspora strengthens India's image as a global community. In addition, India's role in humanitarian relief, development partnerships, peacekeeping, and global health initiatives, from its contributions to UN peacekeeping forces to its "Vaccine Maitri" programme during COVID-19 has given it a reputation as a responsible and compassionate power.

Soft Power in Indian Foreign Policy

Soft power has increasingly been woven into India's diplomacy. Successive governments have used cultural outreach, people-to-people exchanges, and development assistance as instruments of foreign policy. The establishment of Indian Cultural Centres abroad, the promotion of Nalanda University as a hub of Asian civilizational revival, and the creation of digital platforms to showcase Indian culture reflect this approach. Soft power has also been deployed strategically: for instance, Buddhist diplomacy strengthens ties with Southeast Asia, while educational scholarships and Lines of Credit enhance goodwill in Africa.

Equally, India has sought to present itself as a "voice of the Global South," a narrative that resonates among developing countries. By championing climate justice, technology transfer, and equitable global governance, India attempts to couple moral authority with diplomatic activism. At multilateral forums such as the G20, BRICS, or the UN, soft power complements hard power in shaping global perceptions of India as both a civilizational state and a modern economy.

Challenges to India's Soft Power Projection

India may possess abundant soft power resources, but several internal and external challenges limit their effective utilization. A primary concern is institutional fragmentation. Multiple agencies, including the Ministry of External Affairs, Ministry of Culture, Ministry of AYUSH, and the Indian Council for Cultural Relations operate in silos, often without clear coordination. This lack of coherence weakens strategy and dilutes impact. Closely linked to this is the issue of inadequate funding. Unlike China's Confucius Institutes or the UK's British Council, India invests relatively modestly in cultural diplomacy, restricting the global spread of cultural centres, scholarships, and outreach programmes.

Domestic credibility is another serious hurdle. Incidents of communal tensions, restrictions on press freedom, or allegations of democratic backsliding erode India's image as a pluralistic and tolerant society. Since soft power rests on moral authority and perception, internal inconsistencies between ideals and practice weaken India's narrative abroad. Similarly, the diaspora, though vast and influential, remains underutilized due to the absence of structured mechanisms for systematic engagement in cultural diplomacy or public policy initiatives.

External challenges are equally pressing. India faces stiff competition in a crowded field where other powers, particularly China, deploy aggressive investment and cultural strategies to gain influence. Geopolitical disputes, whether with Pakistan or along the

	Line of Actual Control with China, also tend to overshadow India's cultural diplomacy by projecting an image centered on security concerns. Moreover, rising international expectations demand consistency in upholding values like minority rights and democratic freedoms. Without aligning domestic conduct with global standards, India risks reputational costs that undermine its soft power appeal. **Opportunities for the Future:** India stands at a critical juncture where it can translate its immense cultural and civilizational wealth into tangible diplomatic influence. A foremost opportunity lies in framing a comprehensive national soft power strategy. Such a policy should map India's assets, identify priority sectors like AYUSH, education, culture, digital media, and diaspora engagement, and define measurable outcomes. Institutional clarity is equally important, with well-defined roles for the ICCR, MEA, and the Ministries of AYUSH and Tourism, supported by a coordination mechanism as suggested by policy experts. Expanding cultural diplomacy infrastructure is another priority. More Indian Cultural Centres and AYUSH centres abroad, strategically located in Latin America, Africa, the Middle East, and East Asia, can serve as one-stop hubs showcasing yoga, Ayurveda, cuisine, arts, and languages like Hindi and Sanskrit. In the digital age, media and online diplomacy are powerful tools. Indian films, music, and cultural narratives can be amplified through global OTT platforms and social media storytelling. India's development and health diplomacy offers a strong comparative advantage. Initiatives like "Vaccine Maitri" have already demonstrated goodwill. By supplying affordable medicines, green technologies, IT solutions, and infrastructure assistance, India can position itself as a development partner distinct from debt-driven models of aid. Harnessing the potential of the Indian diaspora is another opportunity. Beyond remittances, the diaspora can serve as cultural ambassadors through festivals, community centres, and academic collaborations, strengthening India's global cultural footprint. Finally, soft power depends on domestic credibility. A commitment to pluralism, transparency, human development, and inclusive governance will enhance the authenticity of India's democratic model. By aligning its cultural heritage with modern innovation and values, India can build a durable and respected soft power presence in the global order. **Way Forward** To consolidate gains, India must move beyond ad-hoc initiatives towards institutionalized planning. Strengthening the ICCR, increasing cultural diplomacy budgets, and creating mechanisms to evaluate the impact of soft power initiatives are crucial. Certifications in Yoga and Ayurveda can help standardize quality and protect authenticity. Partnerships with local institutions abroad, such as universities and cultural centers, will ensure that India's cultural diplomacy is contextually relevant. Equally important is aligning soft power with strategic goals. India should use its cultural influence to complement hard power initiatives in trade, technology, and security. For instance, educational scholarships to African students can accompany investment projects, while Buddhist tourism circuits can strengthen ties with East and Southeast Asia. In this way, soft power can act as both a bridge of goodwill and a multiplier of strategic partnerships.
Conclusion	India is uniquely positioned to shape the global order through the strength of its soft power. Few nations can combine the civilizational depth of the Vedas, Upanishads, Buddhism, and Gandhian philosophy with the modern appeal of Bollywood, democracy, digital innovation, and scientific progress. Yet, potential alone does not guarantee influence. Without institutional coordination, adequate investment, and credible

	domestic practices, India's vast reservoir of soft power risks being underutilised. The ethos of *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* (the world is one family), *Ahimsa* (non-violence), and *Sarva Dharma Sambhava* (respect for all religions) provide timeless values that can guide India's engagement with the world. If India builds on these traditions with a coherent strategy, expanded cultural and digital outreach, and genuine adherence to pluralism, it can project itself not only as an economic or geopolitical actor but also as a moral and cultural leader. By doing so, India can shape global narratives rooted in trust, attraction, and mutual respect.
Model Question	"India's intangible cultural heritage, from oral traditions and performing arts to rituals, festivals, and traditional knowledge systems - embodies the civilizational ethos of unity in diversity. Discuss the significance of safeguarding this heritage for cultural identity, social cohesion, and global recognition. Also, analyse the challenges in preservation and suggest measures to strengthen India's cultural diplomacy through intangible heritage."
Value Addition	**India @ Global Soft Power Index 2025:** • In the Global Soft Power Index 2025 released by brand Finance**,** India is ranked 30th globally, with a score of 49.8 out of 100. This is a slight decline from its previous position, but India continues to perform well in areas like future growth potential (3rd), arts and entertainment (6th), Space exploration (8th) and 18th in scientific advancement, India reaffirms its leadership in technology and innovation. • India ranks 28th for diplomatic influence and leaps 20 spots in global assistance, highlighting its expanding global role. • The report highlights India's resilience in its financial system and domestic demand, as well as its strong cultural influence and advancements in science and space exploration, despite facing economic headwinds and challenges in governance. • The United States maintains its position at the top of the ranking with an all-time highest Global Soft Power Index score of 79.5 out of 100.
62. Ek Bharat Shrestha Bharat is the call to forge national integration and the spirit of collective consciousness. Examine whether India has succeeded in rising above the forces of communal prejudice. (APPSC, 2023)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Examine
Approach	• Begin with the constitutional vision of unity in diversity. • Explain the idea of "Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat" and its objectives. • Provide historical examples of communal harmony and integration (e.g., the Independence movement). • Examine cases of communal violence and prejudice (Godhra, Delhi riots). • Highlight institutional safeguards: secularism, the judiciary, and the minority's commission. • Assess government programs fostering cultural integration (student exchange, tourism circuits). • Critically analyze persisting challenges: politics of polarization, hate speech, misinformation. • Conclude with a way forward: education, inclusive policies, and collective consciousness.
Introduction	India has long been celebrated for its civilizational ethos of "unity in diversity". The framers of the Constitution envisioned the Republic as a secular, pluralist, and inclusive nation. The Government's flagship initiative, Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat launched in 2015, reflects this vision by fostering cultural exchange, linguistic harmony, and collective consciousness across states. Yet, the persistence of communal prejudice,

	polarization, and identity-based politics raises questions about whether India has fully succeeded in rising above these forces. As Dr. B.R. Ambedkar once cautioned, "Democracy in India is only a top-dressing on an Indian soil which is essentially undemocratic." It is necessary to examine India's progress and challenges in forging national integration in the face of communalism, drawing from historical, social, and contemporary contexts.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Constitutional Vision of Unity and Secularism** The Constitution of India embeds secularism, equality, and fraternity as fundamental principles. Article 25 guarantees freedom of religion, while Articles 29 and 30 protect the cultural and educational rights of minorities. The Preamble explicitly speaks of "fraternity assuring the dignity of the individual and the unity and integrity of the Nation." Judicial interpretations, such as those in the S.R. Bommai vs. Union of India (1994) case, reinforced secularism as a fundamental feature of the Constitution. These constitutional safeguards aim to ensure that communal identities do not overshadow the collective national identity. **Historical Foundations of Integration** India's national integration is rooted in shared struggles. The freedom movement, under the leadership of Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru, emphasized the importance of communal harmony. Gandhi's slogan of "Hindu-Muslim unity" was central to the anti-colonial struggle. Nationalist Leaders represented the spirit of integration, reminding Indians that "we cannot win freedom unless Hindus and Muslims are united." Despite the Partition of 1947 leaving deep scars of communal violence, post-Independence India sought to rebuild itself on secular democratic lines. The linguistic reorganization of states in 1956 and later initiatives like the National Integration Council (1961) reflected the political commitment to unity amidst diversity. **Contemporary Initiatives for Unity: Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat** The Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat initiative pairs states and union territories for cultural exchange, promoting mutual understanding of heritage, cuisine, festivals, and languages. For instance, Andhra Pradesh is paired with Punjab, facilitating student exchange programs, joint tourism campaigns, and folk art festivals. Such initiatives build inter-regional awareness, fostering what sociologist Benedict Anderson termed "imagined communities." Similarly, campaigns like Unity Run, National Youth Festival, and Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav strengthen collective identity beyond religious or linguistic lines. **Success Stories in Rising Above Prejudice** India has displayed resilience in rising above communal divisions on many occasions. The 2014 declaration by the WHO that India is polio-free reflects how collective health missions can transcend social barriers. During natural disasters like the 2004 Tsunami or the Kerala floods of 2018, communities united beyond religious lines in relief work, showcasing the strength of solidarity. Electoral politics, too, occasionally witnesses cross-community mobilization, such as the Bihar coalition in 2015, where caste and religious divides were bridged against a larger ideological narrative. Popular culture, Bollywood, and cricket further cement this unity; the celebration of Sachin Tendulkar's centuries or A.R. Rahman's music is unifying across communities. **Persistent Challenges of Communal Prejudice** Despite these successes, communal prejudice continues to challenge India's unity. India witnessed an alarming 84 per cent rise in communal violence in the year 2024, according to a report by the Centre for the Study of Society and Secularism (CSSS). Episodes like the Muzaffarnagar riots (2013), Delhi riots (2020), and sporadic lynching linked to cow

	vigilantism highlight how communal violence undermines the social fabric. Misinformation and hate speech on social media amplify prejudices, making communal mobilization easier. Electoral politics often witness the exploitation of religious sentiments, evident in debates around temple-mosque disputes such as Ayodhya or Gyanvapi. **Socio-Economic Dimensions of Prejudice** Communal prejudice is not only cultural but also socio-economic. The Sachar Committee Report (2006) revealed that Muslims lag in literacy, employment, and access to public services, creating alienation. Dalits and Adivasis also face intersectional discrimination when combined with their religious identity. Unemployment and economic inequality further fuel resentment, with communal narratives sometimes being used to distract from structural issues. UNESCO's 2019 report on education highlighted that socially excluded groups continue to face barriers in access to quality schooling, affecting long-term integration. **The Role of Institutions and Civil Society** Institutions like the judiciary, Election Commission, and National Human Rights Commission play critical roles in addressing communal prejudice. Landmark judgments like the Ayodhya verdict (2019), though controversial, were largely accepted peacefully, showing institutional resilience. Civil society initiatives, be it Khudai Khidmatgar groups reviving Gandhi's spirit, or NGOs promoting interfaith dialogue, strengthen grassroots harmony. Media, literature, and academic spaces also shape narratives of inclusivity, though concerns of bias and sensationalism remain. **Global Comparisons and Lessons** Globally, multi-religious societies face similar challenges. Sri Lanka's ethnic conflict, the rise of Islamophobia in the West, and sectarian divisions in the Middle East illustrate how communalism threatens stability. India, however, stands out for sustaining democratic governance despite these pressures. The Pew Research Centre's 2021 report found that 84% of Indians value religious tolerance, even as many prefer segregation in neighbourhoods and marriages. This duality reflects progress but also persistent undercurrents of prejudice. **Way Forward: Strengthening National Integration:** To rise fully above communal prejudice, India must adopt a multi-pronged approach. Education should emphasize constitutional values, the history of composite culture, and ethical citizenship. Schemes like Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat need deeper penetration into rural areas and schools. Political accountability must ensure that hate speech and communal violence are dealt with firmly; NCRB data should be used proactively to identify vulnerable zones. Economic development must address inequality across communities, ensuring that the benefits of schemes like PM Awas Yojana or Skill India reach minorities. Digital literacy campaigns can counter online misinformation. "We are all children of the same Motherland," and realizing this requires both institutional commitment and citizen participation.
Conclusion	India's journey toward Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat is one of both achievement and struggle. While constitutional safeguards, cultural exchange programs, and people's resilience have fostered unity, communal prejudice remains a recurring challenge, often inflamed by politics, inequality, and misinformation. Yet, the overarching narrative is one of hope. India has repeatedly demonstrated the ability to rise above communal divides, drawing upon its civilizational ethos of tolerance and inclusivity. To fully realize the spirit of collective consciousness, the nation must strengthen institutions, empower citizens with inclusive development, and promote a culture of empathy. In doing so, India can move closer to the ideal of a truly integrated, prejudice-free Shreshtha Bharat.

Model Question	"Indian secularism is not an absence of religion in state affairs, but equal respect for all faiths." Critically examine the challenges of communal harmony in contemporary India.
Value Addition	The Muzaffarnagar riots were a series of communal clashes that broke out in August–September 2013 in Muzaffarnagar and Shamli districts of western Uttar Pradesh, between members of the Jat community (predominantly Hindu) and Muslims. The violence was sparked after an incident on 27 August 2013 in Kawal village, where a dispute involving the harassment of a girl led to the killing of two Jat boys and a Muslim youth. The situation escalated after inflammatory speeches at a "Mahapanchayat" (community meeting) and the circulation of a fake video on social media that spread hatred.
63. Should there be Reservation for Women in Politics? (APPSC, 2020)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Should
Approach	• Introduce with India's paradox, a vibrant democracy with poor gender representation. Cite latest data (13.6% women in 18th Lok Sabha) • Trace women's political journey from the freedom movement to constitutional guarantees (Articles 14, 15, 16, 39(a)). Mention past legislative attempts like the 108th Amendment Bill (1996–2010) and the 2023 Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam. • Discuss representation deficit, systemic barriers, and corrective justice arguments. Substantiate with studies (ADR, Chattopadhyay & Duflo, UN Women, etc.) showing women's impact on governance and inclusion. • Integrate examples from Panchayati Raj in India and international cases like Rwanda and Nepal to establish how quotas enhance representation and development outcomes. • Present opposing views such as proxy representation, meritocracy concerns, distortion of electoral process and logically counter them with data and long-term evidence of women's leadership effectiveness. • Suggest framework such as one-third quota, sub-quotas for SC/ST women, constituency rotation, capacity-building, financial support, and periodic review (sunset clause). • Conclude by emphasizing that women's reservation is essential for democratic legitimacy, social transformation, and inclusive governance. Reaffirm it as a constitutional necessity and a moral imperative for equality.
Introduction	India, the world's largest democracy, has long aspired to uphold the ideal of equal participation and representation of all its citizens. Yet, despite women constituting nearly half of the country's population, their representation in legislative institutions remains disproportionately low. In the 18th Lok Sabha (2024), women accounted for only 13.6% of Members of Parliament—far below both the global average and the one-third benchmark often discussed in policy and academic circles. This persistent gender imbalance in political representation raises a fundamental question central to the health of Indian democracy: Should India introduce statutory reservation for women in politics to ensure fair and equitable representation? The debate over women's reservation goes beyond mere numbers; it reflects the struggle for justice, equality, and inclusiveness in the nation's democratic processes. This essay explores the historical background, the need for reservation, empirical and global evidence, counterarguments, and implementation challenges before concluding with a balanced perspective on the way forward.

Body & Infographic Representation	**Historical Background** Women have been active participants in Indian politics since the days of the national movement. Leaders such as Sarojini Naidu, Annie Besant, and Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay played significant roles in the freedom struggle, symbolizing leadership in a deeply patriarchal society. The Constitution of India enshrined the principles of equality and non-discrimination through Articles 14, 15, and 16, ensuring equal access to opportunities. Moreover, Article 39(a) directs the State to ensure equal right to livelihood and participation in public life for both men and women. However, post-independence, the representation of women in politics remained disappointingly low. From 5% in the first Lok Sabha (1952) to 13.6% in 2024, the progress has been painfully slow. A major breakthrough came with the 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments in 1992, which mandated one-third reservation for women in Panchayati Raj Institutions and Urban Local Bodies. These reforms transformed the political landscape at the grassroots, demonstrating that reservation could empower women to become effective leaders. Yet, despite this success, similar measures at the state and national levels have faced political hurdles. The Women's Reservation Bill (108th Constitutional Amendment), first introduced in 1996, sought to reserve one-third of seats in Parliament and state legislatures for women. Although it was passed by the Rajya Sabha in 2010, it lapsed without Lok Sabha approval. More recently, the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam (2023) reintroduced this long-pending reform, promising 33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies, to be implemented after the completion of the next census and delimitation exercise. This step marks a significant, albeit delayed, move toward inclusive political representation. **The Need for Women's Reservation** India's persistent representation deficit highlights deep structural barriers that prevent women from participating equally in politics. Despite forming half the electorate, women are often marginalized during ticket distribution by political parties. Reports from the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR, 2024) show that women candidates receive only about 10–12% of party tickets. Moreover, entrenched social norms, financial constraints, and lack of institutional support continue to discourage women from entering electoral politics. Without affirmative action, achieving gender parity could take decades, undermining the credibility of India's democratic system. Reservation is also an instrument of corrective justice, designed not to offer privilege but to remedy historical and structural exclusion. As Dr. B.R. Ambedkar emphasized, political empowerment is the foundation of social empowerment. Ensuring women's representation compels political parties to nominate women in winnable constituencies, thereby dismantling entrenched patriarchal structures within party hierarchies. Empirical studies further reveal the policy and governance benefits of having more women in decision-making roles. The well-known study by Chattopadhyay and Duflo (2004) on panchayat reservations demonstrated that women leaders tend to prioritize developmental issues such as sanitation, drinking water, and education, these areas often neglected by male leaders. Subsequent research by Beaman et al. (2012) found that long-term exposure to female leaders reduces gender bias among voters and raises aspirations among young girls. Similarly, reports by UN Women (2024) and the World Bank (2023) have affirmed that women's participation leads to more inclusive, transparent, and welfare-oriented governance. The global experience also validates the transformative power of quotas. Countries such as Rwanda, where women constitute over 61% of Parliament, and Nepal, with over 30%

women legislators, have demonstrated that reservation systems can rapidly bridge the gender gap. According to the Inter-Parliamentary Union, nations that have adopted gender quotas have, on average, 10–15% higher representation of women in national legislatures than those without such measures. For India, which seeks to project itself as a global model of democracy, implementing women's reservation would strengthen its moral authority and international standing.

Evidence from India's Grassroots Experience

The introduction of one-third reservation for women in local governance under the 73rd and 74th Amendments provides a compelling precedent. Today, India has over 14 lakh women representatives in Panchayati Raj Institutions—the largest number of elected women in the world. Studies by the Ministry of Panchayati Raj and NITI Aayog highlight that women leaders in local bodies have improved the delivery of public goods, reduced corruption, and enhanced accountability. Their presence has also shifted governance priorities toward social welfare, health, and education.

Beyond administrative gains, these reforms have triggered a broader social transformation. Exposure to women leaders has increased community acceptance of female authority and created a new generation of politically aware women. Many of these grassroots leaders have subsequently contested and won higher offices, proving that reservations can serve as stepping stones for sustained political empowerment.

Counterarguments and Rebuttals

Despite strong empirical support, some critics oppose women's reservation, arguing that it leads to tokenism or proxy representation, where women act as fronts for male relatives. While such instances were observed in the early years of panchayat reservations, subsequent research by NCAER (2023) and PRIA (2021) shows that over time, as women gained training and experience, they began exercising real authority and decision-making power. Education, exposure, and capacity-building have gradually reduced the proxy effect.

Another criticism is that reservations undermine meritocracy. However, merit cannot function in the absence of equal opportunity. Systemic barriers prevent capable women from entering politics in the first place. Once elected, women have shown governance outcomes equal to or better than their male counterparts, as highlighted by the UNDP India Report (2023).

Opponents also fear that reservations may distort the electoral process by unfairly displacing male candidates. Yet, as seen in the case of caste-based or local body reservations, affirmative action is temporary and corrective, not permanent. Once equitable representation is achieved, the policy can be reviewed and phased out.

Some suggest that instead of statutory reservation, parties should adopt voluntary quotas or offer financial incentives for women candidates. While valuable, such measures have proven inadequate in practice. Data from the Election Commission of India reveal that political parties have not significantly increased women's nominations despite repeated calls for gender inclusion. Therefore, without legal compulsion, voluntary approaches are unlikely to deliver substantial change.

Designing an Effective Implementation Mechanism

For women's reservation to be effective and sustainable, it must be thoughtfully designed. The Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam proposes reserving one-third of seats for women, with a provision for sub-quotas for SC/ST women to ensure that benefits reach marginalized groups. The rotation of constituencies across elections would prevent labeling certain areas as "women-only," while maintaining geographical diversity. Additionally, capacity-building programs, financial support, and political training

	workshops—spearheaded by institutions like the National Commission for Women (NCW) and the Ministry of Women and Child Development—can strengthen the leadership potential of elected women. A sunset clause with periodic review every fifteen years can help assess the progress and relevance of the reservation over time. **Broader Implications** Reservation for women in politics carries far-reaching implications for India's democracy. It would enhance democratic legitimacy by ensuring that legislative bodies genuinely reflect the diversity of society. It would catalyze social transformation, challenging patriarchal norms and inspiring greater political participation among women and young girls. Furthermore, increasing women's presence in decision-making processes could shift policy priorities toward welfare, education, healthcare, and family well-being, resulting in more inclusive and responsive governance. On the global stage, India's commitment to women's political empowerment would strengthen its reputation as a progressive democracy that upholds gender equality as a constitutional and moral imperative.
Conclusion	The chronic under-representation of women in Indian legislatures represents both a democratic deficit and a developmental challenge. Reservation for women in politics is not about tokenism or symbolic inclusion; it is about fulfilling the constitutional promise of equality, deepening democracy, and broadening the spectrum of governance. The success of reservations in local bodies, coupled with compelling global evidence, demonstrates that quotas are the most effective mechanism to accelerate gender parity in political institutions. While concerns of proxy politics and meritocracy remain valid, they can be addressed through thoughtful policy design, training, and monitoring. "Women's reservation is not a matter of charity, but of justice and democracy's completion." Therefore, statutory reservation for women in legislatures is not only desirable but also indispensable for realizing the vision of a truly representative democracy envisioned in the Constitution of India.
Model Question	Analyze the challenges and benefits of implementing a 33% reservation for women in Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies.
Value Addition	**Highlights of the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam**: • Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam seeks to reserve one-third of all seats for women in the Lok Sabha and the state legislative assemblies. The allocation of reserved seats shall be determined by such authority as prescribed by Parliament. • One-third of the total number of seats reserved for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes shall be reserved for women of those groups in the Lok Sabha and the legislative assemblies. • Reserved seats may be allotted by rotation to different constituencies in the state or union territory. • Reservation of seats for women shall cease to exist 15 years after the commencement of this Amendment Act. • The implementation of the Women's Reservation Bill is contingent on specific steps. As outlined, the reservation is set to be enforced following the publication of a new census and the completion of the delimitation exercise.
64. Chinese Aggression and India: A Strategic Response (APPSC, 2020)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Approach	• Introduce by outlining the historical India–China relationship, mentioning cooperation and conflict, and highlight the evolving security challenge posed by Chinese assertiveness along the LAC.

	• Discuss key dimensions such as military assertiveness, cartographic expansion, and economic/technological influence in India's neighbourhood and domestic market. • Explain India's enhanced force posture, infrastructure development (roads, tunnels, bridges), and modernization of armed forces with strategic acquisitions and indigenous capabilities. • Cover bilateral talks (Corps Commander-level meetings), multilateral balancing (Quad, BRICS, SCO), and international messaging at forums like the UN and G20. • Highlight Economic and Technological Measures such as app bans, FDI scrutiny, supply chain diversification, and promotion of self-reliance in critical sectors. • Discuss strengths (multi-domain strategy, strategic partnerships, public/political consensus) and challenges (economic dependence, unresolved friction points, operational costs). • Conclude by summarizing India's approach as denial, deterrence, and diplomacy; stress sustaining strategy, reducing technological dependence, and preserving sovereignty and regional stability.
Introduction	The India–China relationship has long been marked by a combination of cooperation and contestation. Historically, the two countries have engaged in trade, cultural exchanges, and regional diplomacy while simultaneously grappling with a complex boundary dispute along the Line of Actual Control (LAC). Since the 1962 war, both nations have established a series of confidence-building mechanisms aimed at maintaining "peace and tranquility" along the border. These include agreements on troop conduct, communication channels, and mechanisms for resolving minor incidents. However, events over the past decade have exposed the limits of these agreements. The 2017 Doklam standoff and the 2020 confrontation in eastern Ladakh highlighted that China's incremental and assertive strategies could bypass conventional diplomatic mechanisms. Beijing's use of "salami slicing" tactics, rapid infrastructure construction, and aggressive patrolling has transformed the boundary dispute from a latent political issue into an active security challenge for India. The Galwan Valley clash of June 2020, which led to casualties on both sides for the first time in 45 years, served as a critical turning point in India's China policy. In response, India adopted a multi-pronged strategy that combines enhanced military preparedness, diplomatic engagement, economic countermeasures, and strategic partnerships with like-minded nations.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Nature of Chinese Aggression:** China's increasing assertiveness along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) has become a major security concern for India. The People's Liberation Army (PLA) has stepped up patrols, deployed additional troops, and constructed military infrastructure near disputed areas. Confrontations at Pangong Tso, Galwan, and Depsang between 2020 and 2021 reflect China's deliberate attempt to alter the status quo and consolidate tactical control. Satellite imagery and independent assessments reveal new roads, bridges, and permanent military habitats, enhancing China's mobility and rapid troop deployment in high-altitude regions. These actions indicate a strategy of gradual encroachment and coercive posturing, framed under the guise of "peaceful coexistence." China has also employed "cartographic expansion" as a diplomatic and psychological tool. Official Chinese maps often depict Arunachal Pradesh as "South Tibet" and claim large portions of Ladakh. The 2023 release of such maps triggered strong diplomatic protests from India, as these symbolic assertions undermine confidence-building measures and erode mutual trust established through prior agreements. Beyond military and cartographic measures, China uses economic and technological influence to expand its strategic reach in India's neighbourhood. Through the Belt and

Road Initiative (BRI), China has strengthened ties with Pakistan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, and the Maldives, reshaping regional connectivity and power dynamics. Domestically, Chinese technology firms had gained a strong foothold in India's digital ecosystem before restrictions in 2020, highlighting the challenges of technological dependence and the need for India to balance openness with national security.

India's Strategic Response: Military and Security Measures

In response to the 2020 Galwan Valley clash, India restructured its military posture to prioritize the northern borders. The Indian Army redeployed additional formations, artillery units, and air assets to the Ladakh sector, enhancing its capacity to deter and respond to PLA provocations. Complementing this, the Indian Air Force (IAF) stationed Rafale fighter jets at Ambala and Hashimara, strengthening aerial deterrence and ensuring operational dominance over key Himalayan sectors.

Recognizing the logistical advantage held by China, India accelerated the development of border infrastructure. The Border Roads Organisation (BRO) undertook an extensive expansion drive, constructing all-weather roads, high-altitude bridges, and strategic tunnels such as the Atal Tunnel and the Sela Tunnel. Between 2020 and 2023, capital outlay for border infrastructure was significantly increased, reflecting a long-term commitment to mobility, supply efficiency, and year-round access to forward areas.

India has also focused on modernizing its armed forces through a combination of indigenous development and selective foreign acquisitions. The procurement of the S-400 air defence system from Russia, UAVs from Israel and the US, and indigenous platforms under the *Atmanirbhar Bharat Abhiyan* demonstrates this hybrid approach. Defence budget allocations reflect this priority, with capital expenditure rising by 13% in 2023–24, signaling India's resolve to maintain credible, sustainable deterrence capabilities along its northern frontier.

India's Strategic Response: Diplomatic Engagement

India has relied on bilateral mechanisms to manage border tensions with China, particularly after the 2020 Ladakh crisis. Since then, both sides have held over 20 rounds of Corps Commander-level talks based on the 1993 and 1996 confidence-building agreements. While disengagement was achieved at friction points such as Pangong Tso and Gogra, key areas like Depsang and Demchok remain unresolved, highlighting the limits of dialogue amid continued PLA forward deployments. Nevertheless, these talks reflect India's commitment to diplomacy alongside robust military readiness.

In addition to bilateral engagement, India has pursued multilateral balancing to counter Chinese assertiveness. The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) with the US, Japan, and Australia has become pivotal for maritime security and technology cooperation in the Indo-Pacific. Simultaneously, India maintains strategic ties with Russia and participates in BRICS and the SCO, reflecting a multi-alignment approach. At global forums like the UN and G20, India emphasizes sovereignty and territorial integrity, defending its interests without over-internationalizing the dispute.

India's Strategic Response: Economic and Technological Measures:

India has implemented significant economic and technological measures to counter Chinese influence and protect national sovereignty. In 2020, the government banned over 200 Chinese mobile applications, including TikTok and WeChat, under Section 69A of the IT Act, citing threats to data security and privacy. This curtailed China's soft-power presence in India's vast digital market. Simultaneously, through Press Note 3 (April 2020), India mandated prior government approval for foreign direct investment (FDI) from countries sharing a land border, tightening scrutiny on Chinese investments during the COVID-19 pandemic. Several proposals remain under review, reflecting a cautious approach to economic engagement.

	India has also promoted supply chain diversification by advancing self-reliance in strategic sectors such as semiconductors, electronics, and defence manufacturing. Schemes like the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) attract domestic and non-Chinese foreign investors, reducing long-term economic dependence on Beijing. At the normative and legal level, India has consistently reminded China of its obligations under the 1993 and 1996 border agreements, emphasizing that PLA incursions violate these accords. Domestic measures like app bans and FDI screening under FEMA and FIPB rules, along with advocacy of UNCLOS principles in Indo-Pacific dialogues, reinforce India's rule-based, legally grounded strategic posture. **Evaluation of India's Response** India's response to Chinese aggression demonstrates a comprehensive strategy integrating military, diplomatic, and economic measures. Unlike in 1962, India now combines enhanced military readiness, rapid infrastructure development, and assertive economic actions to deter potential provocations. Strategic partnerships, particularly through the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) with the US, Japan, and Australia, have expanded India's strategic options and strengthened its influence in the Indo-Pacific. Combined with domestic defence modernization and coherent policy-making, these steps reflect a more confident and capable India. Equally important is the strong public and political consensus that emerged after the 2020 Galwan Valley clash. National unity has enabled the government to adopt a firm stance, reinforcing self-reliance and resilience across multiple fronts. Broad support for a hardline approach has legitimized economic restrictions and long-term security measures. However, challenges persist. Despite curbs and diversification, economic dependence on China remains high, with bilateral trade exceeding USD 118 billion in 2023. Military tensions continue at friction points like Depsang and Demchok, while sustaining high-altitude deployments and infrastructure in fragile zones imposes fiscal and environmental costs. India's strategy, though mature, requires balancing operational sustainability with long-term economic and security objectives.
Conclusion	Chinese aggression along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) represents a long-term strategic challenge rather than an isolated occurrence. India's response has been resilient and multi-dimensional, combining reinforced military posture, accelerated border infrastructure development, legal and economic safeguards, and strengthened strategic partnerships, all while maintaining open channels of communication with China. The core of India's approach lies in a calibrated blend of denial, preventing PLA advances, deterrence through capability-building and international alignments, and diplomacy via bilateral and multilateral engagement. Moving forward, the challenge for India will be to sustain this comprehensive strategy while managing economic costs, reducing technological dependence on China, and preserving domestic political consensus. By maintaining this balanced and adaptive posture, India can safeguard its sovereignty, uphold regional stability, and strengthen its strategic autonomy in the face of evolving Chinese assertiveness.
Model Question	India's approach to China has evolved from engagement to strategic competition. Analyze
Value Addition	**Key takeaways from the SCO Summit 2025:** • Agreements were signed between SCO member states on the SCO Anti-Drug Centre and on the Universal Centre for Countering Challenges and Threats to the Security of SCO Member States • SCO issued a joint declaration by strongly condemned the terrorist attack in Pahalgam on April 22.

	• SCO Dialogue Partner Status to Lao People's Democratic Republic • City of Cholpon-Ata in Kyrgyzstan designated "Tourist and Cultural Capital of the SCO" for 2025–2026. • India Proposed Civilisation Dialogue Forum to enhance people-to-people ties in the SCO, which would provide a global platform for the countries to share ancient civilisation, culture, traditions, and literature. • Chinese President proposed Global Governance Initiative for a more just and equitable global governance system and advancing toward a community with a shared future for humanity.

65. There is a global resurgence of nationalism or right-wing. Discuss its implications for democracy and the neo-liberal economic policies. (APPSC, 2017)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Open with the rise of nationalism in the US, India, Europe, and Brazil. • Explain how nationalism can strengthen identity and self-reliance. • Mention its risks: Majoritarianism, xenophobia, and weakening pluralism. • Mention that Neo-liberalism faces backlash through protectionism and anti-globalisation. • State Examples like Brexit, US–China trade war, Atmanirbhar Bharat. • Mention the Positive side, like revival of local industries and cultural pride. • Mention the Negative side, like erosion of democratic institutions and multilateralism. • Conclude with the need to balance nationalism with democratic values and global cooperation.
Introduction	The early twenty-first century has witnessed a global resurgence of nationalism and right-wing politics, challenging the liberal consensus that had dominated since the end of the Cold War. This trend, visible in diverse contexts such as the election of Donald Trump in the United States, Brexit in the United Kingdom, the rise of far-right parties in Europe, and the assertion of strong nationalist policies in countries like India, Brazil, and Turkey, signals a shift in both political and economic paradigms. While nationalism can strengthen cultural identity and state sovereignty, its rise raises critical questions about the future of democracy, pluralism, and neo-liberal economic policies that have underpinned globalisation for the past three decades. The implications of this resurgence are complex, carrying both opportunities and risks.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The Rise of Nationalism and Right-Wing Politics** Nationalism, broadly defined as loyalty to one's nation above global or supranational structures, has taken different forms across the globe. In Europe, anti-immigration sentiments and dissatisfaction with the European Union have fuelled the rise of right-wing populist parties like the National Rally in France, Alternative for Germany (AfD), and Law and Justice Party in Poland. In the United States, Trump's "America First" doctrine rejected multilateralism in favour of protectionism and stricter immigration controls. In India, the rise of right-wing politics has been marked by the Bharatiya Janata Party's emphasis on cultural nationalism, combined with developmental and welfare politics. This trend is driven by globalisation-induced inequalities, job insecurities, migration crises, and the perception that liberal elites have failed to protect ordinary citizens' interests. According to the Pew Research Centre (2020), trust in global institutions has declined sharply in many democracies, coinciding with the rise of nationalist and right-wing movements. **Implications for Democracy**

The resurgence of nationalism has profound implications for democracy, both positive and negative. On the positive side, nationalism often mobilises citizens around shared cultural or historical narratives, strengthening political participation. Leaders like Viktor Orban in Hungary and Narendra Modi in India have drawn legitimacy by appealing to national pride and identity, enabling strong mandates. However, critics argue that right-wing nationalism often undermines core democratic values of pluralism, tolerance, and dissent. Populist nationalism often centralises power in charismatic leaders, weakening institutional checks and balances. In extreme cases, it risks sliding into authoritarianism under the guise of majority rule. Thus, while nationalism may energise democracies, its exclusionary tendencies pose serious challenges to democratic health.

Implications for Neo-Liberal Economic Policies

The resurgence of nationalism also challenges neo-liberal economic policies, which emphasise free markets, globalisation, and minimal state intervention. The 1990s and early 2000s witnessed unprecedented global integration. Data from the World Bank shows a trade-to-GDP ratio of around 20% in the mid-1990s, and the ratio stood at approximately 25.3% in 2022. However, the backlash against globalisation has fuelled protectionist and inward-looking policies. Brexit represented a rejection of supranational economic integration, while the United States under Trump imposed tariffs on Chinese goods, igniting a trade war that disrupted global supply chains. Similarly, India's emphasis on "Atmanirbhar Bharat" (self-reliant India) reflects a shift toward economic nationalism. While such measures can promote domestic industries and reduce dependence on external shocks, they also undermine the principles of neo-liberalism that have driven global growth. The IMF has noted that rising protectionism can negatively impact global GDP by hindering trade and increasing costs. Hence, the rise of nationalism is reshaping economic policies away from liberal globalisation toward selective state-led interventions.

Nationalism, Populism, and Social Polarisation

One of the defining features of right-wing nationalism is its reliance on populist rhetoric. By positioning themselves as defenders of the "real people" against elites, right-wing leaders often polarise societies along ethnic, religious, or cultural lines. The refugee crisis in Europe, which saw over one million asylum seekers arrive in 2015, fuelled xenophobia and far-right mobilisation. In India, debates around citizenship, religious identity, and cultural heritage have sharpened political divisions. Social media has amplified these divides, spreading nationalist narratives but also misinformation. While populism may enhance political mobilisation, it can erode social cohesion and threaten democratic consensus-building. Democracies risk devolving into "illiberal democracies" when populism overrides constitutional safeguards.

Counter-Arguments: Positive Dimensions of Nationalism

It is important to recognise that nationalism is not inherently anti-democratic or anti-globalisation. In many developing countries, nationalism has been a force of liberation and self-assertion. India's independence movement, Africa's anti-colonial struggles, and Latin America's push for autonomy were all driven by nationalist sentiments. In contemporary times, nationalism has encouraged self-reliance in critical sectors such as defence, energy, and technology. The COVID-19 pandemic underscored the importance of national resilience, as countries prioritised domestic vaccine production and supply chain security. In this sense, economic nationalism may correct some of the excesses of neo-liberal globalisation, which left many vulnerable to global shocks. As Dani Rodrik argues, "Hyper-globalisation is neither feasible nor desirable; nations must retain policy space for domestic priorities." Thus, nationalism can coexist with democracy if it emphasises inclusive development and cooperative global engagement.

	Case Studies of Divergent Experiences Different countries illustrate the varied consequences of nationalism. In Hungary, Orbán's brand of "illiberal democracy" has weakened judicial independence and media freedoms, raising concerns in the European Union. In contrast, in Japan under Shinzo Abe, economic nationalism in the form of "Abenomics" sought to revive growth while maintaining democratic institutions. Brazil under Jair Bolsonaro combined nationalist rhetoric with disregard for environmental protections, leading to massive deforestation in the Amazon, raising global concerns. In India, nationalism has driven ambitious policies like Make in India and Digital India, but critics warn of rising majoritarianism. These divergent experiences suggest that the impact of nationalism depends on how it is harnessed, whether to strengthen inclusive governance or to entrench exclusionary politics. **The Future of Democracy and Globalisation in a Nationalist Era** The global resurgence of nationalism compels a rethinking of both democracy and neo-liberalism. Democracies must adapt by addressing the economic insecurities and identity anxieties that fuel right-wing populism, without compromising pluralism and freedoms. Similarly, globalisation must evolve into a more equitable model that reduces inequality between and within nations. Multilateral institutions like the WTO, IMF, and UN need reform to accommodate legitimate national aspirations while preserving global cooperation. A balanced approach, where nationalism strengthens sovereignty without undermining democratic values or international collaboration, appears to be the path forward.
Conclusion	The resurgence of nationalism and right-wing politics is one of the defining trends of our times, reshaping the contours of democracy and economic globalization. While nationalism can empower citizens, foster self-reliance, and correct some of the imbalances of neo-liberalism, its excesses can weaken democratic institutions, fuel authoritarianism, and disrupt global economic integration. As John Stuart Mill observed, "The worth of a state in the long run is the worth of the individuals composing it." Ultimately, the challenge for the global community is to harness nationalism in ways that deepen democracy rather than hollow it, and to reform globalization so that it serves the interests of all, not just a privileged few. The task is not to reject nationalism or neo-liberalism outright, but to seek a constructive balance that protects democratic ideals and promotes inclusive, sustainable development in a rapidly changing world.
Model Question	Analyse the impact of the contemporary rise of right-wing nationalism on democratic values and the trajectory of neo-liberal globalisation.
Value Addition	Xenophobia is the fear, hatred, or dislike of people, customs, or ideas that are perceived as foreign or strange, leading to hostility and prejudice against those from different cultures or nations. It's a learned behaviour that can be fuelled by stereotypes, socioeconomic factors, and the perception of a conflict between an "in-group" and an "out-group". Xenophobia manifests in various ways, from prejudiced comments and exclusionary behaviour to discrimination and even violence against foreigners or immigrants.

66. The Constitution of India provides protection to life and liberty of a citizen. At the same time, growing events of terrorism, naxalism and mob violence, underscore the need for stringent laws for control. Discuss the measures to be taken for striking a balance between both. (APPSC, 2017).	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Start with Article 21, guaranteeing the right to life and liberty as a constitutional safeguard.

	• Note growing threats from terrorism, naxalism, and mob lynching, weakening internal security. • Mention stringent laws like UAPA, NSA, and AFSPA framed to address these threats. • Highlight risks of misuse of such laws leading to human rights violations. • Stress the importance of judicial oversight and parliamentary accountability. • Suggest the use of modern technology and intelligence-based policing. • Cite examples like Supreme Court rulings ensuring balance between liberty and security. • Conclude by advocating harmony between rights protection and effective law enforcement.
Introduction	The Constitution of India, described by Granville Austin as a "seamless web of rights and responsibilities," places the protection of life and personal liberty at its core through Article 21. This provision, often called the "heart of fundamental rights," has been expansively interpreted by the Supreme Court to include rights to dignity, privacy, livelihood, and speedy trial. However, in recent decades, the rise of terrorism, naxalism, and mob violence has posed formidable threats to internal security and public order. These violent phenomena challenge the state to act decisively while simultaneously testing the limits of constitutional liberties. The central dilemma is how to ensure stringent measures for security without undermining democratic freedoms.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Constitutional Safeguards for Life and Liberty** The Indian Constitution recognizes fundamental rights as inalienable to human dignity. Article 21 guarantees that no person shall be deprived of life or personal liberty except according to procedure established by law. The Supreme Court, in Maneka Gandhi v. Union of India (1978), expanded this to mean that such procedures must be just, fair, and reasonable. Rights to legal aid, speedy trial, and protection from arbitrary arrests have been derived from this interpretation. Furthermore, Articles 19 and 22 provide freedoms of speech, association, and safeguards against preventive detention, ensuring that state power is not exercised arbitrarily. These guarantees provide the bedrock for balancing individual rights with collective security needs. **Rising Threats from Terrorism, Naxalism, and Mob Violence** The scale of internal security challenges in India makes this balance extremely complex. Terrorism, particularly cross-border militancy in Jammu and Kashmir, has claimed thousands of lives over the past three decades. Naxalism, once described by former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh as "the single biggest internal security challenge," continues to affect states like Between 2001 and 2024, the strife-torn Bastar region in Chhattisgarh has recorded 1,623 civilians of the 1,851 were murdered by Maoists often fuelled by communal tensions and misinformation on social media, have emerged as another pressing threat. Reports by IndiaSpend noted over 100 incidents of cow-related mob violence since 2015, raising questions about law enforcement and the protection of minorities. These rising threats necessitate strong legal measures but also caution against overreach. **Stringent Security Laws and Their Rationale** In response to these threats, India has enacted several stringent security laws. The Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), amended in 2019, empowers the government to designate individuals as terrorists, freeze assets, and extend detention without charge. The National Security Act (NSA) authorizes preventive detention for up to twelve months to maintain public order. The Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act (AFSPA) gives sweeping powers to security forces in disturbed areas like Jammu and Kashmir and parts of the Northeast. While these laws are designed to equip the state

against extraordinary threats, they have often been criticized for misuse and violation of human rights. For instance, the National Crime Records Bureau (2020) reported that only about 21.1% percent of UAPA cases ended in conviction, suggesting prolonged detentions without adequate proof. Thus, the rationale for stringent laws is strong, but their implementation raises concerns of proportionality and accountability.

Judicial Oversight and Human Rights Concerns

The judiciary has consistently played a balancing role in reconciling liberty with security. In Kartar Singh v. State of Punjab (1994), the Supreme Court upheld the Terrorist and Disruptive Activities (Prevention) Act (TADA) but emphasized safeguards against arbitrary arrests. Similarly, in the case of DK Basu v. State of West Bengal (1997), the Court laid down detailed guidelines to prevent custodial torture, affirming that security cannot come at the cost of human dignity. More recently, in PUCL v. Union of India (1997), the Court struck down telephone tapping without proper authorization, reinforcing the right to privacy. These judgments reflect the judiciary's attempt to ensure that the fight against terror and violence is conducted within constitutional boundaries. Yet, delays in trials, under trial detentions, and allegations of custodial excesses indicate that human rights concerns remain unresolved.

Need for Intelligence-Led and Technology-Driven Policing

One of the critical measures for balancing rights and security is reducing dependence on blanket, draconian laws by strengthening intelligence and technology-driven policing. Post-26/11 Mumbai terror attacks, India established the National Investigation Agency (NIA), which has successfully investigated cases like the Pulwama attack of 2019. The Crime and Criminal Tracking Network and Systems (CCTNS) and the National Intelligence Grid (NATGRID) aim to integrate databases for better tracking of suspects. Use of artificial intelligence to monitor social media misinformation and drones for surveillance in Maoist areas are examples of technological interventions that can minimize collateral violations of rights. The goal is to make counter-terror operations more precise and less intrusive, thereby protecting both security and liberty.

Community Participation and De-Radicalization

Long-term solutions to extremism and violence cannot rely solely on coercive laws. Community participation, dialogue, and de-radicalization programs are essential. Initiatives in states like Kerala and Maharashtra have engaged families, teachers, and local leaders to counter extremist propaganda among youth. Rehabilitation packages for surrendered Maoists in Chhattisgarh and Andhra Pradesh, providing vocational training and financial support, have shown success in reducing violence. Similarly, civil society interventions to counter mob violence through awareness campaigns, inter-faith dialogues, and digital literacy programs highlight non-legal ways to safeguard both liberty and security. These measures embody the principle that social harmony cannot be legislated by coercion alone but must be built on trust and inclusion.

Balancing Security with Democratic Accountability

For stringent laws to coexist with liberty, democratic accountability must be embedded in their implementation. Parliamentary oversight committees, independent human rights commissions, and free press act as watchdogs against abuse of power. Strengthening the role of institutions like the National Human Rights Commission and empowering state-level commissions can enhance transparency. Fast-track courts for terrorism and mob violence cases can ensure speedy justice, upholding both victims' rights and the accused persons' rights to trial. Data-driven policing, combined with ethical training of security forces, can reduce arbitrariness. The core principle of UDHR, "Human rights are not luxuries for the few but necessities for the many." This reflects the need to balance the collective right to security with individual freedoms.

	Comparative and Global Lessons India's dilemma is not unique. Democracies worldwide grapple with balancing liberty and security. Post-9/11, the United States enacted the Patriot Act, granting sweeping surveillance powers, but faced backlash over privacy violations, leading to reforms through the USA Freedom Act of 2015. The UK's counter-terrorism policies emphasize community engagement alongside legal enforcement. Learning from such global experiences, India must refine its legal and institutional mechanisms to ensure that counter-terror strategies do not erode democratic foundations. These lessons suggest that while extraordinary threats demand extraordinary responses, the essence of democracy lies in measured and accountable actions.
Conclusion	The Constitution of India, by protecting life and liberty, sets the foundation for a democratic society based on justice, equality, and dignity. Yet, terrorism, naxalism, and mob violence demand stringent countermeasures to safeguard national security. The challenge is to avoid the pendulum swinging excessively toward coercion, which risks eroding freedoms, or excessive leniency, which undermines security. Striking a balance requires judicial oversight, technology-driven precision, community-based interventions, and robust democratic accountability. As Mahatma Gandhi once remarked, "Freedom is not worth having if it does not include the freedom to make mistakes." The Indian state must therefore ensure that in protecting its citizens from violent threats, it does not strip them of the very liberties that make India a democracy. True security lies not only in defeating terrorism or violence but also in upholding the constitutional promise of liberty and justice for all.
Model Question	"The Indian Constitution guarantees the right to life and personal liberty as a fundamental right. However, the increasing threats of terrorism, naxalism, and mob violence highlight the demand for stringent laws to ensure internal security. Critically examine how..3… India can strike a balance between protecting individual freedoms and maintaining national security."
Value Addition	NATGRID, the National Intelligence Grid, is India's centralized, secure database designed to assist intelligence and law enforcement agencies in counter-terrorism and economic crime investigations by linking and providing access to data from various government databases. It collects and collates diverse information, including banking, travel, vehicle registration, and immigration records, to provide a comprehensive intelligence picture for authorized central agencies and state police forces. Conceived after the 2008 Mumbai terror attacks, NATGRID became an office under the Ministry of Home Affairs in 2010 and began operations in late 2020.

67. Discuss the progress in recent Indian efforts in evolving a joint counter terrorism strategy with different allies? What is the implication of the current violence in the Kashmir Valley on these efforts? (APPSC, 2016)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Discuss, What
Approach	• Start with India's vulnerability to terrorism and cross-border threats. • Mention bilateral collaborations with the USA, Israel, EU, and SCO on counter-terrorism. • Highlight India's advocacy at the UN for the Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism. • Cite joint exercises and intelligence-sharing initiatives (e.g., Malabar). • Note progress in cyber security, border management, and financial monitoring of terror. • Analyze the negative impact on India's global credibility.

	• Highlight Pakistan's role in fuelling insurgency, complicating international cooperation. • Conclude that India needs a balanced approach, firm security + human rights sensitivity.
Introduction	Terrorism has emerged as one of the gravest threats to international peace and security in the 21st century, transcending borders and undermining national sovereignty, economic growth, and social stability. India, being one of the worst-affected nations, has been battling multiple forms of terrorism, ranging from cross-border militancy in Jammu and Kashmir, left-wing extremism in central India, to radicalization-based urban terrorism. According to the Global Terrorism Index 2023, India ranked 13^{th,} indicating that it is one of the countries most impacted by terrorism. This reality has compelled New Delhi to forge joint counter-terrorism strategies with allies at bilateral, regional, and multilateral levels. At the same time, the persistence of violence in Kashmir continues to pose serious challenges, both in terms of practical security measures and in shaping India's global image.
Body & Infographic Representation	**India's Vulnerability to Terrorism** India's geopolitical position and diverse socio-political landscape make it particularly vulnerable to terrorism. With a 3,323 km border with Pakistan, 3,488 km with China, and porous boundaries with Nepal, Myanmar, and Bangladesh, India faces complex cross-border challenges. In addition, cyber terrorism, radicalization through social media, and funding via Hawala networks have added layers of complexity. These vulnerabilities necessitate cooperative counter-terrorism strategies that go beyond India's borders. **Bilateral Collaborations in Counter-Terrorism** One of the key pillars of India's counter-terrorism efforts has been deepening bilateral cooperation with strategic allies. India and the United States, for example, have institutionalized cooperation through the Counter-Terrorism Joint Working Group set up in 2000. The U.S. designation of Hizbul Mujahideen's leader, Syed Salahuddin, as a global terrorist in 2017 was a diplomatic success for India. Intelligence sharing, joint training, and homeland security dialogues have expanded since the 2008 Mumbai terror attacks, which killed 166 people, including foreign nationals. Similarly, Israel has emerged as a crucial partner, offering expertise in border management, drone surveillance, and cyber defense. Indo-Israel cooperation has grown significantly since the 1990s, with defense trade crossing USD 10 billion in recent years. With Russia, India maintains counter-terrorism cooperation under both bilateral frameworks and the Russia-India-China (RIC) dialogue, particularly in areas of intelligence and anti-radicalization strategies. **Multilateral and Regional Frameworks** India recognizes that terrorism cannot be tackled in isolation, which makes multilateral platforms central to its strategy. At the United Nations, India has been at the forefront of advocating for the Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism (CCIT) since 1996, aiming to create a universal legal definition of terrorism. Though yet to be adopted, India's persistence underscores its commitment to a rule-based global response. Regionally, India has strengthened cooperation within the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO), particularly through the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) that facilitates intelligence sharing and capacity building among members. BIMSTEC has also been used as a platform to isolate Pakistan, focusing instead on South and Southeast Asian counter-terror cooperation. At the Financial Action Task Force (FATF), India played a key role in placing Pakistan on the "grey list" for failing to curb terror financing, significantly restricting resources for extremist outfits. **Technological and Cyber Security Collaborations**

	The evolving face of terrorism, increasingly shaped by technology, has pushed India to forge alliances in cyber security and counter-radicalization. India and the European Union have held dialogues on cyber terrorism and online radicalization. With the United Kingdom, the 2015 Defence and International Security Partnership expanded joint efforts in monitoring terror financing through digital platforms. India has also joined global forums like the Global Counter-Terrorism Forum (GCTF) to integrate best practices. Domestically, initiatives like NATGRID (National Intelligence Grid) and CCTNS (Crime and Criminal Tracking Network System) are being strengthened with international technological collaborations. **The Role of Defence and Security Exercises** Military exercises with allies have become another dimension of counter-terrorism. Exercises like "Yudh Abhyas" with the U.S., "Indra" with Russia, and "Ajeya Warrior" with the UK all include counter-insurgency and counter-terrorism modules. The Malabar naval exercise, though focused on maritime security, indirectly enhances counter-terrorism preparedness by securing sea lanes against potential trafficking of arms or terror financing. These exercises not only improve operational readiness but also symbolize India's growing strategic alignments. **Implications of Kashmir Violence on Counter-Terrorism Collaborations** While India has made notable progress in internationalizing its counter-terrorism stance, the continuing violence in Kashmir poses both practical and diplomatic challenges. On the ground, frequent militant attacks disrupt stability and drain resources. For example, the Pulwama attack of 2019, which killed 40 CRPF personnel, escalated tensions with Pakistan, leading to the Balakot airstrikes. Diplomatically, insurgency in Kashmir provides adversaries like Pakistan a platform to portray the issue as one of human rights rather than terrorism. The Office of the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) reports on alleged human rights abuses in Kashmir have been used to question India's narrative, despite New Delhi's emphasis that Kashmir violence is externally sponsored. This complicates India's effort to build consensus at global platforms, especially among countries sensitive to human rights concerns. **Balancing Security and Human Rights in Kashmir** The implication of Kashmir violence is not merely external but also internal in terms of governance legitimacy. Excessive reliance on laws like the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act (AFSPA) and internet shutdowns invite criticism of democratic backsliding. While such measures may yield short-term security, they risk alienating the local population, which in turn undermines counter-radicalization strategies. Scholars argue that "a strategy overly dependent on coercion is counterproductive in Kashmir." This suggests that India's international credibility in counter-terrorism efforts will improve only if democratic principles and human rights sensitivities are balanced with security imperatives. **Global Perceptions and Strategic Costs** India's image as the world's largest democracy is both an asset and a responsibility. Strategic partners like the European Union often link security cooperation with human rights. Any perception of heavy-handedness in Kashmir risks slowing progress in counter-terrorism collaborations. For instance, certain European Parliament discussions have highlighted Kashmir while considering cooperation agreements. Thus, Kashmir violence is not just a domestic law-and-order issue but also a diplomatic variable that can impact India's ability to secure deeper counter-terrorism alliances.
Conclusion	India's efforts to evolve joint counter-terrorism strategies with allies have achieved substantial progress through bilateral partnerships, multilateral platforms, technological

	collaborations, and defense exercises. These have enhanced intelligence sharing, restricted terror financing, and strengthened operational readiness. However, the persistence of violence in Kashmir remains a critical challenge, both for domestic stability and international credibility. A holistic approach that combines firm counter-terror measures with dialogue, development, and democratic accountability is essential. It is once said, "Humanity will ultimately win the war against terrorism, not weapons alone." For India, this means that security must walk hand in hand with justice and inclusivity, ensuring that its counter-terrorism strategy commands both domestic legitimacy and international respect.
Model Question	"India has been actively engaging with global and regional allies to evolve a joint counter-terrorism strategy through bilateral, multilateral, and UN-level initiatives. Discuss the progress made in these efforts and examine how the ongoing violence in the Kashmir Valley impacts India's counter-terrorism collaborations."
Value Addition	RIC Troika was first conceptualised by former Russian PM Yevgeny Primakov in the 1990s, a time when Russia was trying to find its place on the global stage following the collapse of the USSR. It was institutionalised in the early 2000s, holding over 20 ministerial-level consultations since its inception. It seeks to counter Western dominance by leveraging the economic, military, and demographic heft of three populous, resource-rich nations. The grouping signals a shift from a unipolar world dominated by the West to a multipolar order where Eurasian trade corridors and local currencies challenge the supremacy of the US dollar. The grouping became largely inactive following the India-China Galwan border confrontation in 2020.
68. What is the present situation of Dalits in India? Despite numerous developmental schemes and stringent laws for protection, why there is no substantial progress at the ground level? (APPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	What, Why
Approach	• Begin with the historical oppression of Dalits and constitutional safeguards like Articles 17, 46. • Mention progress in literacy, political representation, and reservations. • Highlight the persistence of caste-based atrocities and social exclusion. • Quote NCRB data showing rising crimes against Dalits despite legal safeguards. • Analyze reasons: social prejudice, weak enforcement, corruption, and ineffective schemes. • Note regional variations in Dalit empowerment across India. • Suggest empowerment through education, land reforms, and grassroots mobilization. • Conclude by stressing social transformation along with legal protection.
Introduction	The Indian Constitution envisions a society free from discrimination, ensuring dignity, equality, and justice for all citizens. Dalits, historically oppressed under the caste system, have been provided with constitutional safeguards, affirmative action policies, and special welfare schemes to uplift their socio-economic status. Articles 17, 46, and legislations such as the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, were meant to guarantee both protection and empowerment. Despite these measures, the reality at the grassroots presents a grim picture. Dalits continue to face violence, exclusion, and marginalization in many parts of the country. The paradox of progressive legislation coexisting with entrenched social prejudice raises the critical question: why has substantial progress remained elusive despite decades of state intervention?

Body & Infographic Representation	**Constitutional and Legal Safeguards for Dalits** The framers of the Constitution made social justice a cornerstone of India's democracy. Article 17 abolished untouchability, while Article 46 directed the state to promote the educational and economic interests of the Scheduled Castes and protect them from social injustice. Reservations in education, employment, and legislatures provided political representation and opportunities for social mobility. Laws such as the Protection of Civil Rights Act (1955) and the SC/ST Prevention of Atrocities Act (1989, amended in 2015 and 2018) criminalized caste-based discrimination and violence. Institutions like the National Commission for Scheduled Castes were created to monitor safeguards. On paper, these measures created a robust legal framework, but translating them into social realities has been uneven and incomplete. **Present Socio-Economic Situation of Dalits** While there has been visible progress in Dalit literacy rates, political representation, and the emergence of a Dalit middle class, inequalities remain stark. The Periodic Labour Force Survey (2021–22) shows higher unemployment among Dalits compared to upper castes. Landlessness continues to be widespread; only around 9 percent of Dalit households own cultivable land, making them dependent on wage labour. In rural India, Dalits are disproportionately employed in low-paying, unorganized sector jobs. The poverty rate among Scheduled Castes is nearly 32 percent, compared to 16 percent for upper castes, according to the India Human Development Survey. These statistics highlight how Dalits remain structurally disadvantaged despite welfare programs. **Violence and Discrimination Against Dalits** One of the most alarming aspects of the present Dalit situation is the persistence of caste-based violence. The National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) reported 51,656 cases of atrocities against Scheduled Castes in 2022, a 13 percent increase compared to 2020. States like Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Madhya Pradesh consistently report high numbers of cases. The 2016 Una flogging incident in Gujarat, where Dalits were publicly beaten for skinning a dead cow, or the 2020 Hathras gang rape case, illustrate the severity of caste violence that continues to haunt Indian society. Structural discrimination is also evident in access to housing, education, and health care. Dalit children in some schools are still made to sit separately, and reports by the National Dalit Watch show instances of discrimination in disaster relief and public services. **Political Empowerment and Representation** Dalits have achieved greater political visibility in post-independence India. Reservation in legislatures has ensured Dalit participation in decision-making processes. Leaders such as B.R. Ambedkar, Kanshi Ram, and Mayawati have significantly shaped Dalit consciousness and political mobilization. Yet, political empowerment has not always translated into social empowerment. Many Dalit representatives face co-option by mainstream parties, limiting their capacity to advance transformative agendas. Moreover, Dalit women, despite reservations, face triple marginalization of caste, gender, and class, making their political presence less impactful. **Educational and Economic Challenges** Education has long been seen as the ladder of social mobility for Dalits. While reservations have opened avenues, dropout rates among Dalit students remain disproportionately high. According to the All India Survey on Higher Education (2021–22), Dalit enrolment in higher education is 15.3 percent, close to their population share, but quality gaps and discrimination persist. Reports of caste bias among faculty and students discourage sustained progress. Economically, Dalits continue to remain at the bottom of the pyramid. They are overrepresented in sanitation work, manual scavenging,

	and hazardous occupations. The Socio-Economic and Caste Census (2011) revealed that over 56 percent of Dalit households depend on casual labour, compared to 25 percent among other groups. This economic vulnerability reinforces cycles of poverty and exclusion. **Reasons for Lack of Substantial Ground-Level Progress** Several factors explain the limited transformation in Dalit lives despite legal and developmental interventions. First, deep-rooted social prejudice remains intact in rural and semi-urban areas, where 70 percent of Dalits reside. The hierarchical caste order continues to dictate social interactions, marriages, and access to resources. Second, poor implementation of schemes leads to leakages and corruption, preventing benefits from reaching the most marginalized. For instance, scholarship schemes for Dalit students often face delays and underfunding. Third, Dalits face systemic exclusion in the labour market, with discrimination in hiring and wage disparities still reported. Fourth, regional disparities exacerbate the issue like states in southern India show better Dalit empowerment compared to northern states, where feudal structures remain rigid. Lastly, violence and intimidation discourage Dalits from asserting their rights, perpetuating silence and fear. **Voices from the Ground and Social Movements** Grassroots movements have played an important role in mobilizing Dalit communities. The Dalit Panthers in the 1970s, inspired by Ambedkar and global Black rights movements, gave voice to the oppressed. More recently, movements led by young leaders like Jignesh Mevani in Gujarat highlight the continued relevance of Dalit mobilization against caste atrocities. Civil society groups like the National Campaign on Dalit Human Rights document violations and push for accountability. Yet, these efforts often face resistance from dominant caste groups and sometimes from the state itself, revealing the entrenched nature of caste-based inequality. **Way Forward for Dalit Empowerment** Substantial progress in Dalit empowerment requires a multi-pronged approach. Education and skill development must be prioritized with a focus on quality and inclusivity. Land reforms and economic redistribution are essential to break cycles of poverty and dependence. Strict enforcement of laws like the SC/ST Prevention of Atrocities Act, combined with fast-track courts, can deter violence. Social campaigns to dismantle caste prejudice, similar to mass literacy or health campaigns, are crucial for attitudinal change. Political mobilization must be strengthened with genuine representation rather than tokenism. As B.R. Ambedkar warned, "Caste is not merely a division of labour, it is a division of labourers," highlighting that real transformation requires structural changes in the economy, polity, and society.
Conclusion	The situation of Dalits in contemporary India is marked by both progress and persistent challenges. Legal and constitutional measures have succeeded in creating opportunities for education, representation, and employment, but the promise of equality remains unrealized at the grassroots. Rising atrocities, entrenched prejudice, and economic marginalization demonstrate that legal protection alone cannot dismantle centuries of social exclusion. Substantial progress demands not only effective policy implementation but also societal transformation. The path forward lies in combining law, empowerment, and social reform, ensuring that India's democratic ideals are not hollow promises but lived realities for its most marginalized citizens.
Model Question	"Despite constitutional safeguards, protective legislations, and welfare schemes, Dalits in India continue to face discrimination and marginalization. Analyze the present socio-economic situation of Dalits and discuss why there has been limited progress at the ground level despite developmental and protective measures."

Value Addition	The National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC) is a constitutional body in India, established under Article 338 of the Indian Constitution, to protect, promote, and oversee the welfare and socio-economic development of the Scheduled Castes (SCs). Its key functions include investigating issues related to SC safeguards, inquiring into complaints of rights deprivation, advising on socio-economic planning, and submitting annual reports with recommendations to the President. The commission comprises a Chairperson, a Vice-Chairperson, and three other members
69. "Sedition laws have no place in a democracy" – Comment on the above sentence, in the context of the recent conflicts in our country? (APPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Comment
Approach	• Introduce with context such as the colonial origin of sedition law, Gandhi's criticism of it, or its replacement under the BNS 2023. • Provide historical background by tracing the origin of sedition in colonial India, its continued presence after independence, and the reasons why independent India chose to retain it. • Discuss constitutional provisions, particularly Article 19(1)(a) and Article 19(2), to explain how sedition interacts with freedom of speech. • Examine judicial interventions, including key cases such as Kedar Nath Singh, Shreya Singhal, and the 2022 Supreme Court suspension, which have narrowed the scope of sedition. • Illustrate with balanced examples from recent conflicts, including the anti-CAA protests, the Disha Ravi case, the JNU controversy, and developments in Jammu and Kashmir. • Critically evaluate both perspectives: Against sedition and in support. • Suggest reforms such as narrowing the legal definition, judicial oversight, relying on existing security laws, and training enforcement agencies to distinguish dissent from disorder. • Conclude with a balanced note emphasizing that democracy must protect dissent while also safeguarding sovereignty, and argue for reform rather than outright rejection of sedition-like provisions.
Introduction	The debate over sedition laws in India has resurfaced in recent years, particularly after the government replaced the colonial-era Indian Penal Code with the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) 2023. While the infamous Section 124A of the IPC has been formally repealed, its essence continues under new provisions criminalizing speech or acts that threaten India's sovereignty, unity, and integrity. This has reignited long-standing questions about whether sedition has any legitimate place in a democracy. Critics see it as a colonial relic suppressing dissent, while the state argues it remains essential to safeguard unity in a diverse and conflict-prone nation. To understand this debate, it is necessary to explore the law's historical roots, democratic implications, judicial interventions, recent conflicts.
Body & Infographic Representation	**"Sedition Laws Have No Place in a Democracy" – Indian Perspective:** **Historical Legacy of Sedition Law** The sedition law was introduced in 1870 by the British colonial state to suppress nationalist voices. It was used against prominent leaders such as Bal Gangadhar Tilak and Mahatma Gandhi, who famously described it as the "prince among the political sections of the IPC designed to suppress the liberty of the citizen." At the time, the law served as a blunt instrument to curb freedom movements that questioned colonial authority.

Surprisingly, after independence, the law was retained. Indian lawmakers argued that in a newly partitioned country facing secessionist pressures and linguistic agitations, the state needed tools to preserve national integrity. Thus, while its origins were colonial, its persistence in independent India reflected anxieties about nation-building and internal security. This dual legacy has always complicated its democratic legitimacy.

Sedition and Democratic Ideals

Freedom of speech and expression, guaranteed under Article 19(1)(a) of the Constitution, is central to democracy. At the same time, Article 19(2) allows "reasonable restrictions" on this freedom in the interests of sovereignty, public order, and security of the state. Sedition sits at the crossroads of these provisions, often sparking contestation over what is "reasonable."

Critics argue that sedition extends far beyond reasonable restriction, as it criminalizes even peaceful dissent and non-violent criticism of government policy. This creates a chilling effect, discouraging citizens, academics, and journalists from speaking freely. On the other hand, governments have argued that in a diverse society with deep religious, ethnic, and regional divides, speech that appears harmless may sometimes escalate into communal disharmony or separatist propaganda. For the state, sedition provisions act as a preventive measure to preserve national unity.

The tension between liberty and security lies at the heart of this debate. Democracy thrives on dissent, but it also demands safeguards against speech that destabilizes the polity.

Judicial Interpretation and Safeguards

The judiciary has repeatedly intervened to limit the scope of sedition. In the landmark Kedar Nath Singh vs State of Bihar (1962) case, the Supreme Court upheld the constitutionality of Section 124A but restricted its application to speech that incites violence or public disorder. This ruling became the foundation for balancing freedom of expression with state security.

Subsequent judgments reinforced this position. In Shreya Singhal vs Union of India (2015), the Court emphasized that mere criticism or advocacy, without incitement to violence, cannot be criminalized. More recently, in May 2022, the Supreme Court effectively suspended the use of sedition by directing governments not to register cases under Section 124A until the law is re-examined. This unprecedented move acknowledged growing concerns about misuse while recognizing the state's security concerns.

Thus, while sedition remains in India's legal framework, judicial safeguards have sought to prevent its abuse and ensure that only speech linked to violence or disorder comes under its ambit.

Recent Conflicts Illustrating the Debate

The controversy around sedition in India is best understood through recent conflicts. During the anti-CAA and NRC protests, many students and activists were booked under sedition for raising slogans and organizing demonstrations. Civil society viewed these cases as examples of criminalizing democratic protest, while the government maintained that provocative speech carried the potential to spark communal tensions.

The arrest of climate activist Disha Ravi in 2021, linked to her alleged role in preparing a "toolkit" in support of the farmers' agitation, also drew widespread attention. For critics, this was a clear instance of state overreach into peaceful activism. Authorities, however, argued that the matter involved concerns of sovereignty because of possible foreign interference in domestic protests.

Universities such as Jawaharlal Nehru University have also witnessed sedition cases, with students accused of raising anti-national slogans. Opponents of such actions

described them as attempts to curb academic freedom, whereas the state defended its position by insisting that firm measures were necessary to protect national integrity. In Jammu and Kashmir, sedition and similar provisions have often been invoked to counter separatist narratives or political expressions that diverge from the official line. Human rights groups interpret this trend as evidence of shrinking civic space. At the same time, governments argue that the region's long history of militancy makes such measures unavoidable.

Even prominent intellectuals, including Arundhati Roy, have faced the threat of sedition-related charges for controversial speeches and writings. Supporters believe that intellectual debate is vital for the health of democracy. Officials counter this by asserting that free expression must always remain within the boundaries of sovereignty and public order. These episodes demonstrate the dual character of sedition in India. To critics it functions as a weapon against dissent, while governments continue to regard it as a shield necessary for unity and order.

The Case Against Sedition Laws

Those calling for abolition emphasize that sedition is a colonial relic incompatible with independent India's democratic ethos. They argue that its sweeping language enables misuse, producing a chilling effect on journalists, students, and civil society. Data from the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) shows that most sedition cases end in acquittal, raising concerns that the law is deployed more for political intimidation than genuine threats. Critics also point out that India already has targeted laws such as the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and anti-terror statutes, which can address violent or secessionist activities without criminalizing dissenting thought.

The Case for Retaining Sedition-like Provisions

On the other side, governments argue that India's unique social fabric makes sedition-like laws indispensable. The country's history of insurgencies in the Northeast, Punjab, and Kashmir illustrates the dangers of divisive propaganda. In the age of social media, provocative speech can spread instantly, mobilizing unrest or deepening communal divisions. The state also stresses that sovereignty is increasingly vulnerable to global misinformation campaigns, making strong deterrents necessary. Supporters of retention highlight that the judiciary has already narrowed sedition's interpretation to incitement of violence. Thus, the problem lies less in the law itself than in its misuse by lower-level enforcement, which can be addressed through safeguards rather than repeal.

Comparative Perspective

Globally, the trajectory of sedition laws is mixed. Countries such as the United Kingdom and New Zealand have repealed sedition, declaring it inconsistent with free expression. In contrast, states like Singapore and Malaysia continue to enforce sedition provisions, citing the need to preserve harmony in multicultural societies. India's dilemma reflects this divide: should it follow mature democracies that rely on narrower hate-speech and security laws, or retain a version of sedition suited to its specific vulnerabilities?

The Way Forward

The way forward may lie in reform rather than repeal. India could consider replacing sedition with a narrowly defined provision that explicitly targets speech inciting violence or secession, removing vague terms like "disaffection." Judicial oversight could be mandated before registering cases, ensuring frivolous complaints do not translate into harassment. Training police and prosecutors to distinguish between dissent and disorder would further minimize misuse. Strengthening the use of targeted laws like UAPA against genuine threats, while leaving peaceful dissent outside the ambit of criminal law, would balance liberty with security.

Conclusion	The sedition debate in India embodies the central democratic tension between liberty and security. While freedom of expression is the lifeblood of democracy, no state can ignore the risks posed by incitement to violence, separatist propaganda, or foreign interference. Recent controversies reveal how sedition laws can be misapplied against peaceful dissent, yet they also highlight the state's anxiety about maintaining unity in a diverse society. India's future lies not in clinging to colonial legacies, nor in abandoning safeguards altogether, but in crafting a modern legal framework that protects both democracy and sovereignty. A strong democracy is one that safeguards dissent while ensuring it does not slip into disorder. By striking this delicate balance, India can move closer to the democratic ideals enshrined in its Constitution.
Model Question	"Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita seeks to modernise Indian criminal law, but its success depends on judicial safeguards and enforcement." Analyse the potential strengths and challenges of the BNS framework.
Value Addition	**The Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 (BNS):** • The Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 (BNS) was passed on December 25, 2023, replacing the old Indian Penal Code, 1860 (IPC) as India's new criminal law. • Along with it, two other new laws, the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and the Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, came into effect from July 1, 2024, as notified by the Ministry of Home Affairs. • Reason for the change: The IPC was a leftover from the British colonial era and contained many outdated provisions. It did not fully reflect modern ideas about rights, social justice, equality, and inclusion. The new laws aim to provide a more contemporary, citizen-focused, and rights-based legal framework suitable for a modern democratic India.

70. Explain "BREXIT"? Discuss its likely impact on the governance, politics and economy of the European Union? (APPSC, 2016)

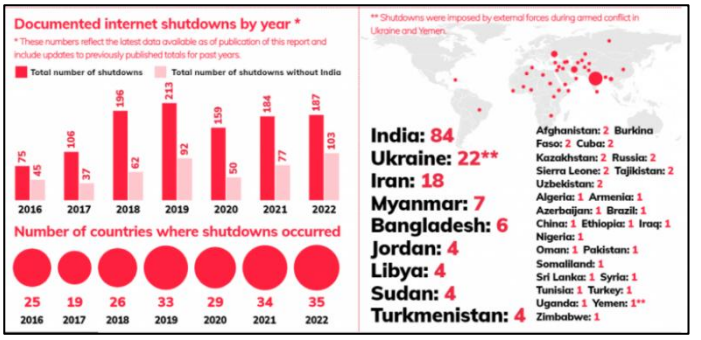
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Explain
Approach	• Start with defining BREXIT: Britain's exit from the European Union after the 2016 referendum. • Explain reasons behind BREXIT, like sovereignty, immigration, the Eurozone crisis, and EU bureaucracy. • Mention Governance impact, such as weakening of the EU's integration project and challenges to supranational decision-making. • State Politics, such as the rise of nationalism and Euroscepticism in member countries; EU's internal cohesion at risk. • Stress Economic aspects like impact on trade, labour mobility, financial markets, and budget contributions. • Explain the EU losing London as a global financial hub; negotiations on free trade and tariffs. • State Social consequences like migration issues, rights of EU citizens in the UK and vice versa. • Conclude with future outlook on EU reforms, stronger unity drive, and search for stability.
Introduction	The term "BREXIT" refers to the withdrawal of the United Kingdom (UK) from the European Union (EU), following a historic referendum held in June 2016, where 51.9% of the British electorate voted in favour of leaving. The decision marked the first time a member country chose to exit the EU, shaking the foundations of European integration, which had been built over decades. BREXIT became a symbolic turning point in global

	politics, highlighting the growing tension between supranational governance and national sovereignty. Its significance extends far beyond Britain, as the European Union itself now faces profound challenges in governance, politics, and the economy. It was famously remarked that "BREXIT is not just about Britain leaving the EU; it is about the EU facing itself."
Body & Infographic Representation	**BREXIT and the Governance of the European Union** Governance in the European Union has always been a delicate balancing act between the interests of sovereign states and the authority of supranational institutions like the European Commission, European Council, and European Parliament. BREXIT disrupted this balance in several ways. Firstly, the UK was one of the strongest proponents of liberal economic policies, supporting deregulation and opposing deeper political integration. Its departure has shifted the balance of power within the EU towards countries like Germany and France, which advocate stronger fiscal discipline and deeper integration. The decision also raised questions about the future of EU governance structures. With the UK leaving, the EU lost one of its most influential voices in foreign policy and security, which complicates decision-making in areas such as NATO coordination, sanctions against Russia, and relations with China. Moreover, BREXIT triggered debates over the democratic deficit within EU governance. Eurosceptic movements across Europe have argued that the Union's bureaucratic institutions lack accountability, and BREXIT has reinforced these concerns. A practical governance issue has been the handling of regulatory frameworks. Britain was a hub for financial services, and its departure forced the EU to reform regulations regarding capital markets, banking supervision, and financial transactions. The European Securities and Markets Authority (ESMA) in Paris has assumed greater responsibilities post-BREXIT. Thus, EU governance now faces the dual challenge of managing without Britain's institutional contribution while preventing similar exits by other members. **BREXIT and the Politics of the European Union** Politically, BREXIT has been a shockwave across the continent. It symbolised the rise of nationalist and populist movements that challenge the very idea of European integration. Right-wing parties in countries such as France, Italy, Hungary, and Poland have drawn inspiration from BREXIT to question the EU's legitimacy. This has heightened the risk of fragmentation in the Union. At the same time, BREXIT has also triggered a counter-trend of greater political cohesion among the remaining member states. In the face of the UK's exit, countries such as Germany, France, and the Netherlands have rallied to protect the integrity of the EU. The negotiation of the Withdrawal Agreement and the subsequent Trade and Cooperation Agreement (2020) demonstrated the EU's ability to present a unified political front. However, challenges remain. The Northern Ireland Protocol, a by-product of BREXIT, has created political turbulence not only in the UK but also within the EU, as it affects Ireland, an EU member state. The protocol's controversy over customs checks has strained relations between Brussels and London. Additionally, BREXIT has weakened the EU's global political clout. Without Britain, which is a permanent member of the UN Security Council and a nuclear power, the EU's strategic voice on global security is somewhat diminished. BREXIT also had an impact on the European Parliament. The redistribution of seats after the UK's departure gave more representation to smaller countries, slightly altering the parliamentary dynamics. Yet, the absence of British Members of European Parliament

	(MEPs), who often acted as a counterbalance to federalist forces, has tilted politics more towards centralisation. Thus, politically, BREXIT has both weakened and consolidated the EU, revealing deep contradictions within its political structure. **BREXIT and the Economy of the European Union** The economic impact of BREXIT on the European Union is multifaceted and long-term in nature. Before BREXIT, the UK was the second-largest economy in the EU, contributing significantly to the EU budget and functioning as one of the largest financial hubs in the world. Its exit has had repercussions on trade, investment, and labour mobility. On trade, the EU-UK relationship has been fundamentally altered. The EU lost a significant export market and supply-chain partner. Sectors like automobiles, agriculture, and pharmaceuticals have faced adjustment challenges. European businesses dependent on London's financial services sector, known as the "City of London", had to relocate parts of their operations to cities like Frankfurt, Dublin, and Paris. Investment has also been impacted. The UK was a preferred entry point for American and Asian companies into the EU's single market. With BREXIT, this role has diminished, causing a partial redirection of foreign direct investment (FDI) into mainland Europe. Reuters estimated in 2019 that around €1.2 trillion worth of banking assets moved from the UK to the EU post-BREXIT. The labour market has been affected by the end of free movement between the UK and EU. Millions of EU citizens who worked in Britain lost automatic rights, and similarly, British citizens in the EU faced restrictions. This created challenges for sectors like healthcare, construction, and education, which heavily relied on migrant labour. From a macroeconomic perspective, the EU also faced budgetary consequences. This compelled the EU to reform its budgetary allocations and explore alternative revenue mechanisms, such as the EU Green Tax and digital services tax. The pandemic and the Ukraine war further complicated economic relations. BREXIT reduced the EU's ability to act collectively on certain trade and supply chain matters, although the crisis also highlighted the EU's capacity for resilience. Nevertheless, the long-term economic consequences of BREXIT are likely to include slower trade growth, increased regulatory divergence, and the weakening of Europe's global competitiveness. BREXIT was more than just Britain's exit from the European Union; it was a stress test for the very idea of regional integration. Its implications for EU governance, politics, and economy are profound and long-lasting. On governance, it has weakened the liberal bloc and forced the EU to restructure institutional decision-making. Politically, it has inspired nationalist movements but also fostered greater unity among the remaining members. Economically, it has disrupted trade, investment, labour mobility, and budgetary stability, while also opening new opportunities for deeper integration among the EU-27.
Conclusion	The future trajectory of the European Union will depend on how it manages the BREXIT legacy. If the Union can reform its governance structures to be more transparent and democratic, assert political unity in the face of rising nationalism, and adapt its economy to post-BREXIT realities, it may emerge stronger. "The European Union is more than just a market; it is a community of destiny." BREXIT has challenged this destiny, but it has also created the possibility for renewal and reinvention of the European project.
Model Question	What do you understand by "BREXIT"? Critically analyse its implications for the institutional framework, political integration, and economic stability of the European Union.
Value Addition	On 24 December 2020, negotiators for the EU and the UK reached a deal on the two parties' new relationship. The EU and the UK have set out the terms of this deal in three agreements:

	• The Trade and Cooperation Agreement • The Information Security Agreement • The Nuclear Cooperation Agreement. On 1 January 2021, the rules set out in these agreements will come into force.
71. Write a critical essay on the violation of human rights. What measures do you suggest to protect human rights in times of crisis? (TGPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Write, What
Approach	• Define human rights as universal, inalienable rights ensuring dignity and equality. • Mention global context: UDHR 1948, Indian Constitution Part III (Fundamental Rights). • Highlight violations: custodial torture, communal violence, terrorism, child labour, and women's exploitation. • Use examples: Nirbhaya case, custodial deaths (NHRC reports), Refugee crises. • Discuss systemic failures: weak enforcement, delayed justice, and political misuse. • Suggest reforms: stronger NHRC/SHRCs, police reforms, fast-track courts, human rights education. • Mention the role of civil society, media, and international cooperation in protection. • Conclude with Ambedkar's vision of "constitutional morality" for safeguarding rights.
Introduction	Human rights are the basic, inherent, and inalienable rights of every individual, irrespective of nationality, religion, caste, gender, or social status. They are indispensable for a dignified life and are guaranteed globally by instruments such as the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR, 1948) and nationally through constitutional provisions like Part III of the Indian Constitution. However, despite this moral and legal framework, violations of human rights remain widespread, often intensifying during times of crisis such as wars, terrorism, natural disasters, and internal conflicts. In India and across the world, human rights violations manifest in forms ranging from custodial torture and gender violence to suppression of dissent and denial of basic freedoms. As Nelson Mandela rightly stated, "To deny people their human rights is to challenge their very humanity." Thus, critically examining these violations and exploring measures to protect human rights during crises is essential for ensuring justice and equality.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Understanding Human Rights and Their Framework** Human rights encompass civil, political, social, economic, and cultural dimensions. The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights and the International Covenant on Economic, Social, and Cultural Rights (ICESCR, 1966) provide binding obligations for states. In India, the Constitution enshrines fundamental rights under Articles 12–35, while Directive Principles of State Policy lay down the foundation for socio-economic justice. Further, institutions such as the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC), State Human Rights Commissions, and the judiciary act as watchdogs to enforce these rights. Despite such robust frameworks, violations remain persistent, particularly in times of stress when state power often collides with individual liberty. **Dimensions of Human Rights Violations** Human rights violations occur in multiple forms. Custodial torture and extra-judicial killings have been a recurring concern. The Annual Report on Torture 2019 said 1,606 of the deaths happened in judicial custody and 125 in police custody. Cases like the custodial death of Jayaraj and Bennix in Tamil Nadu (2020) highlight how abuse of power by law enforcement undermines basic rights.

Discrimination and violence against marginalized communities also reflect deep-rooted inequalities. Dalits, tribals, religious minorities, and women often bear the brunt of systemic injustice. Crimes against Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes have shown an upward trend, with NCRB data (2021) recording over 50,000 such cases annually. Violence against women, ranging from domestic abuse to workplace harassment, also represents a severe human rights challenge.



Freedom of speech and expression, the bedrock of democracy, is another area under strain. Arbitrary internet shutdowns like India recorded 84 shutdowns in 2022, the highest in the world, to restrict not only freedom of expression but also the right to education, health, and livelihood. Civil society activists and journalists often face intimidation under restrictive laws, undermining the right to dissent.

Human Rights in Times of Crisis

Crises such as terrorism, communal violence, pandemics, and natural disasters often magnify human rights challenges. The fight against terrorism sometimes justifies stringent laws that compromise individual freedoms. For instance, the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) has been criticized for misuse, with low conviction rates but high numbers of arrests, raising concerns about arbitrary detention.

During communal riots and ethnic conflicts, human rights are often the first casualty. The 2002 Gujarat riots, the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, and more recent episodes of communal violence in Delhi (2020) underscore the vulnerability of minorities during crises. Similarly, insurgency-hit regions like Kashmir and parts of the North-East have witnessed prolonged curfews, disappearances, and restrictions, testing the balance between security and liberty.

The COVID-19 pandemic illustrated how health emergencies can lead to large-scale rights violations. Millions of migrant workers were stranded without food, shelter, or transport, exposing the fragility of social security systems. Lockdowns, while necessary for public health, also led to the denial of livelihoods, education, and access to healthcare for vulnerable groups. Globally, refugee crises caused by conflicts in Syria, Afghanistan, and Ukraine highlight how wars and political instability strip people of their fundamental rights to life, dignity, and shelter.

Institutional and Structural Weaknesses

Persistent human rights violations stem from structural and institutional weaknesses. Police systems remain overburdened, undertrained, and often lack accountability mechanisms. According to the National Judicial Data Grid 2025, the pendency of cases in the Supreme court is 88,417, denying victims timely justice. Human rights commissions, though significant, are often toothless due to limited powers, political interference, and inadequate resources. Furthermore, socio-economic disparities perpetuate inequality, making marginalized communities more vulnerable to violations. Lack of awareness about rights among citizens further aggravates the situation.

The Role of Judiciary and Civil Society

	The judiciary has often acted as a guardian of human rights. In landmark cases such as Kesavananda Bharati v. State of Kerala (1973), the Supreme Court upheld the primacy of fundamental rights, while in Maneka Gandhi v. Union of India (1978), it expanded the interpretation of the right to life and liberty under Article 21. Public Interest Litigations (PILs) have enabled marginalized groups to seek justice. Civil society organizations, activists, and media also play a crucial role in exposing violations and mobilizing public opinion. The Right to Information Act (2005) has empowered citizens to hold authorities accountable. However, shrinking civic space and restrictions on NGOs under regulations such as the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) raise concerns about the ability of civil society to function independently. **Measures to Protect Human Rights in Times of Crisis** Strengthening human rights protection requires a multi-dimensional approach. First, robust legal safeguards must be reinforced. Laws dealing with terrorism and emergencies should be balanced with strong judicial oversight to prevent misuse. Second, institutions like NHRC and SHRCs must be given greater autonomy, financial independence, and enforcement powers. Police and judicial reforms are critical. Training law enforcement personnel in human rights, installing CCTV cameras in police stations, and fast-tracking sensitive cases can curb custodial violence. Legal aid services and human rights awareness campaigns must reach vulnerable communities. During crises, social protection systems must be strengthened. The COVID-19 pandemic highlighted the need for universal healthcare, portable ration systems, and direct cash transfers to safeguard the rights of the poor. Technology can play a role in improving transparency and service delivery, but it must be implemented without infringing on privacy rights. International cooperation also matters. India, as a signatory to UN conventions, must align domestic practices with global human rights standards. Engaging with organizations such as Amnesty International and the UNHRC can improve accountability.
Conclusion	Human rights are the cornerstone of democracy and justice. Yet, their violation, whether through state overreach, social discrimination, or neglect during crises, remains a global challenge. In India, while the Constitution and institutions provide a strong framework, implementation gaps, weak accountability, and structural inequalities perpetuate violations. Protecting human rights in times of crisis requires a fine balance between security and liberty, coupled with strong institutions, an active civil society, and a vigilant judiciary. Ensuring human rights are safeguarded even in the most testing circumstances is the true measure of a just society.
Model Question	Protection of civil liberties and fundamental freedoms becomes most vulnerable during emergencies and internal conflicts. Critically analyze this statement and suggest mechanisms to strengthen human rights safeguards.
Value Addition	**National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB)** • It was established in 1986 to act as a repository of information on crime and criminals. • It comes under the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), Government of India. • It was set up based on the recommendations of the Tandon Committee, the National Police Commission (1977-1981), and the Task Force of the Home Ministry. • It is responsible for collecting and analysing crime data as well as serving as a repository of such information to aid investigators in tracing crimes and criminals. • Headquarters: New Delhi

	• In 2009, the NCRB was entrusted with the responsibility of monitoring, coordination, and implementing the Crime and Criminal Tracking Network and System (CCTNS) project. This project connects about 15,000 police stations and 6,000 high offices in the country. • In 2017, the NCRB launched the National Digital Police Portal, which allows police officers to look for a criminal or suspect on the CCTNS database and gives citizens with services such as online complaint filing, etc. • The Bureau has also been entrusted to maintain the National Database of Sexual Offenders (NDSO) and share it with the States/UTs on a regular basis.
72. Write an essay on 'War on Terror' in the light of 9/11. (TGPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Write
Approach	• Introduce with the real-life impact of 9/11 attacks, their symbolism, and how they marked a turning point in global security. • Discuss how the U.S. and its allies launched the War on Terror, interventions in Afghanistan and Iraq, NATO's role, and how counter-terror strategies evolved worldwide. • Indian Experience of Terrorism – Examine major terrorist incidents in India (Parliament 2001, Mumbai 2008, Pulwama 2019, and Pahalgam 2025), highlighting state-sponsored cross-border terrorism and India's counter-terror strategies. • Analyze UN Security Council resolutions (1373, 1540), UN Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, and FATF measures. Include India's advocacy for the Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism (CCIT). • Evaluate successes such as elimination of terror leaders and choking finances, alongside criticisms like prolonged wars, civilian casualties, and rise of ISIS. Link lessons for India. • Suggest a holistic approach: universal definition of terrorism, multilateral cooperation, technology-driven counter-measures, socio-economic inclusion, and India's leadership role. • Conclude by stressing that war on terror is a long-term global struggle requiring both hard and soft power.
Introduction	On September 11, 2001, the world witnessed a watershed moment in the history of terrorism. Four hijacked passenger planes were turned into weapons of mass destruction. Two aircraft struck the Twin Towers of the World Trade Center in New York, one hit the Pentagon, and another crashed in Pennsylvania after passengers resisted the hijackers. Nearly 3,000 lives were lost in the single deadliest terrorist act in modern times. For many, the chilling collapse of the Twin Towers symbolized the vulnerability of even the most powerful nation. The aftermath led to the declaration of a "War on Terror," reshaping security doctrines, foreign policy, and domestic politics across the world. For India, already scarred by decades of militancy in Punjab and insurgency in Jammu & Kashmir, the global attention on terrorism after 9/11 brought both challenges and opportunities. The country that had long warned of the dangers of cross-border terrorism found its voice amplified on the world stage.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The Global Response: Declaring the War on Terror** In the immediate aftermath of 9/11, U.S. President George W. Bush announced a "Global War on Terror," targeting not just perpetrators but also states that harbored or supported terrorist groups. Afghanistan, under the Taliban regime, became the first battleground. Operation Enduring Freedom launched in October 2001 ousted the Taliban within weeks, though the insurgency would persist for decades. Soon, the campaign extended beyond

Afghanistan. The 2003 invasion of Iraq, justified on the grounds of alleged weapons of mass destruction and links to terrorism, remains controversial. NATO invoked Article 5 (collective defense) for the first time, while states across the globe tightened counter-terrorism laws, enhanced intelligence cooperation, and choked terror financing networks. However, military-centric approaches brought mixed outcomes. While key leaders such as Osama bin Laden were neutralized, extremist networks evolved, leading to new threats like ISIS.

Terrorism in India: Parallel Struggles

Long before 9/11, India had faced the scourge of terrorism, and its experiences illustrate that terrorism is not a new phenomenon but an enduring challenge with regional and global implications. In December 2001, just three months after 9/11, Lashkar-e-Taiba and Jaish-e-Mohammed terrorists stormed the Indian Parliament, killing security personnel and bringing India and Pakistan to the brink of war. In 2008, the Mumbai attacks marked another watershed moment, where ten militants trained in Pakistan unleashed carnage in the city, killing 166 people, including foreigners. The attacks, executed with precision and live media coverage, mirrored al-Qaeda–style urban terror.

The following decade saw further assaults on Indian sovereignty and security. In 2016, the Pathankot airbase and Uri army camp were targeted by cross-border terrorists, prompting India's surgical strikes across the Line of Control, a significant doctrinal shift in its counter-terrorism strategy. In February 2019, a suicide bomber in Pulwama killed 40 CRPF personnel, leading to the Balakot airstrikes and heightened Indo-Pak tensions. Even more recently, the 2025 Pahalgam attack in Jammu & Kashmir, where militants targeted pilgrims and security forces, underlined the persistence of terror despite two decades of global counter-terror campaigns. These incidents demonstrate that terrorism in India is not only a domestic security issue but also a manifestation of state-sponsored networks, particularly emanating from across the border.

UN and Global Resolutions on Terrorism

The War on Terror catalyzed global institutions, particularly the United Nations, to adopt binding frameworks against terrorism. The United Nations Security Council Resolution 1373, passed just weeks after 9/11, made it mandatory for states to criminalize terrorism financing, deny safe havens, and enhance intelligence cooperation. Resolution 1540 in 2004 further expanded this framework by focusing on preventing terrorists from acquiring weapons of mass destruction. To oversee these developments, the UN established the Counter-Terrorism Committee (CTC) to monitor implementation and assist states in capacity building.

In 2006, the UN adopted the Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, which provided a holistic approach, combining security measures with efforts to address root causes such as poverty and political exclusion. Beyond the UN, bodies like the Financial Action Task Force (FATF) gained prominence in the post-9/11 world by creating strict anti–money laundering and counter-terror financing standards. FATF's grey-listing of countries such as Pakistan demonstrated how economic pressure could be used to curb terror financing. India, meanwhile, has consistently pushed for the Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism (CCIT), seeking a universally accepted definition of terrorism to eliminate the excuse of "good" versus "bad" terrorists, though disagreements among member states have stalled its adoption.

Achievements and Shortcomings of the War on Terror

The War on Terror yielded important achievements. Terrorist financing networks were disrupted, al-Qaeda was considerably weakened, and many terror plots were foiled through intelligence sharing. The killing of Osama bin Laden in 2011 symbolized a

	milestone victory. Yet, the campaign faced several shortcomings. Prolonged wars in Afghanistan and Iraq led to enormous human and financial costs, with hundreds of thousands of civilians killed and trillions of dollars expended. The power vacuum created by the Iraq invasion gave rise to ISIS, which expanded the terror threat globally. In addition, counter-terror measures such as the USA PATRIOT Act triggered concerns over surveillance, profiling, and human rights abuses. Thus, while terrorism was checked in some respects, new manifestations emerged, proving the limits of force-based solutions. **India's Response and Lessons Learned** India drew significant lessons from the global War on Terror while tailoring them to its own context. Institutional strengthening was prioritized after the 2008 Mumbai attacks, leading to the creation of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) for specialized counter-terror investigations. A more proactive security doctrine was adopted with surgical strikes in 2016 and the Balakot airstrikes in 2019, reflecting India's willingness to take deterrent measures beyond defensive postures. On the diplomatic front, India actively engaged with FATF, SCO, BRICS, and UN forums, pushing for collective action against terrorism and highlighting the dangers of state sponsorship. Technology and cyber surveillance became essential components of counter-terrorism, given the rise of online radicalization, drone infiltration, and crypto-based terror financing. At the same time, India recognized the importance of community outreach, developmental programs, and socio-economic measures in conflict-prone regions like Kashmir to reduce alienation and recruitment by extremist groups. **The Way Forward: Towards Comprehensive Security** Two decades after 9/11, the central lesson is that terrorism cannot be defeated solely through military might. A future-oriented strategy requires a balance of hard power, diplomacy, and socio-economic measures. The adoption of the Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism is necessary to eliminate the double standards where some groups are labeled "freedom fighters." Stronger multilateralism through the UN, regional organizations, and FATF is crucial to choke terror financing and enforce accountability. Technology must be harnessed to counter online radicalization and cyber propaganda. Addressing root causes such as political grievances, poverty, and lack of governance remains equally important for long-term stability. For India, with its dual experience of being both a victim and a proactive responder, the role in shaping global counter-terrorism norms becomes even more significant.
Conclusion	The War on Terror, triggered by the tragic events of 9/11, remains an ongoing struggle. It underscored that terrorism is a borderless menace requiring collective vigilance. While it achieved tactical victories, the persistence of attacks from Baghdad to Mumbai, Kabul to Pulwama, and Pahalgam shows that terrorism has merely evolved rather than disappeared. For India, the lessons are sharper: terrorism is not an abstract global issue but a lived reality. From the Parliament attack in 2001 to Pulwama in 2019 and Pahalgam in 2025, India's journey highlights both resilience and the need for stronger international solidarity. Ultimately, the war on terror must go beyond guns and drones, it must also win over hearts and minds, uphold justice, and strengthen the foundations of peace.
Model Question	"In the wake of recent global conflicts, do international institutions like the UN, NATO, and BRICS still remain effective instruments of collective security? Critically analyze."
Value Addition	**Some of the Major Developments in the UNSC on Counter-Terrorism since the 1990s:** • **UNSC Resolution 731 (1992):** Focused on international condemnation of the bombing of Pan Am Flight 103; elimination of international terrorism, and urged Libya to cooperate in the investigation.

	• **UNSC Resolution 1267 (1999):** Imposition of sanctions on Taliban, including an arms embargo and freezing of assets. Establishment of 1267 'Taliban committee' for monitoring implementation. • **UNSC Resolution 1373 (2001):** Adopted under Chapter VII post 9/11 attacks. Mandated states to criminalize terrorist financing, freeze terrorist assets, and deny safe haven to terrorists. Established the Counter-Terrorism Committee (CTC). • **UNSC Resolution 2341 (2017):** Called upon states to address the risk to and protect critical infrastructure from terrorist attacks. • **UNSC Resolution 2462 (2019):** Focused on Terrorist Financing, underscored the central role of the UNSC, and urged states to implement Financial Action Task Force (FATF) recommendations.

73. Write a critical essay on the existing laws/policies against sexual harassment of women at the workplace. (TGPSC, 2016)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Write
Approach	• Introduce issue: gender equality, workplace dignity, link to Articles 14, 15, 21. • Mention landmark case: Vishaka v. State of Rajasthan (1997) guidelines. • Discuss Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition, Redressal) Act, 2013. • Highlight gaps: poor implementation, lack of awareness, stigma, and underreporting. • Cite statistics: NCRB data on workplace harassment cases. • Suggest measures: gender-sensitisation training, independent Internal Complaints Committees (ICC), strict penalties. • Stress corporate responsibility, women's empowerment, and legal literacy. • Conclude that safe workplaces ensure inclusive growth and women's participation in the economy.
Introduction	The workplace is not merely a site of employment but also an arena where human dignity, equality, and security must be guaranteed. For women in particular, the right to work in safe environments is essential for realizing constitutional ideals of equality under Articles 14, 15, and 21. Sexual harassment at the workplace, however, continues to be a pervasive problem, undermining both women's participation in the workforce and their human rights. Recognizing the seriousness of the issue, India has enacted specific laws and policies, most notably the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act of 2013. Yet, despite progressive legal measures, the ground reality reflects significant gaps in implementation, awareness, and institutional accountability. A critical analysis of these frameworks highlights both achievements and limitations in ensuring gender justice at the workplace.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Historical and Legal Evolution of laws/policies against sexual harassment of women at work places** The recognition of sexual harassment as a violation of women's rights in India can be traced to the landmark case of Vishaka v. State of Rajasthan (1997). In this judgment, the Supreme Court defined sexual harassment as a violation of the right to life and dignity under Article 21 and issued the Vishaka Guidelines, which mandated employers to establish mechanisms for complaint redressal. These guidelines, inspired by the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW), laid the foundation for subsequent legislation. The enactment of the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace Act, 2013, was a watershed moment. It codified the Vishaka guidelines into law and broadened the definition of workplace to include both organized and unorganized sectors, private

enterprises, educational institutions, hospitals, and even households employing domestic workers. The Act mandates the creation of Internal Complaints Committees (ICCs) in organizations with more than ten employees and Local Complaints Committees (LCCs) at the district level for unorganized sectors. This legal evolution reflects India's gradual but important recognition of workplace harassment as not only a moral and social wrong but also a legal offense.

Provisions of the Sexual Harassment Act, 2013

The Act provides a comprehensive framework for prevention, prohibition, and redressal. Sexual harassment is broadly defined to include unwelcome physical contact, demands for sexual favours, sexually coloured remarks, showing pornography, and any other unwelcome conduct of a sexual nature. Employers are required to adopt a zero-tolerance policy, disseminate awareness, and sensitize employees through training. ICCs, with a mandatory woman presiding officer and an external NGO representative, are designed to ensure impartial investigations. The Act also prescribes penalties for non-compliance, including fines and cancellation of business licenses. Furthermore, it provides safeguards against victimization and retaliation, protecting complainants during and after the process.

Challenges in Implementation of the Act

Despite the progressive nature of the law, its enforcement faces critical hurdles. One of the foremost issues is the lack of awareness. A survey by the Indian Bar Association (2017) revealed that nearly 70% of women who experienced harassment at the workplace did not report it due to fear of stigma, retaliation, or lack of trust in institutional mechanisms. In many organizations, particularly in the unorganized sector which employs over 90% of women workers, ICCs are either absent or dysfunctional.

Moreover, social stigma and patriarchal attitudes often silence victims. Women fear being labelled as troublemakers or facing career setbacks. In some cases, ICCs are dominated by senior management, leading to bias and intimidation. The case of former Chief Justice Ranjan Gogoi facing allegations of sexual harassment in 2019 and the subsequent institutional handling raised serious questions about impartiality, transparency, and the effectiveness of redressal mechanisms, even in the highest judicial body of the country.

Another limitation lies in the Act's weak enforcement mechanism. While it prescribes penalties for non-compliance, monitoring remains inadequate. Many states lack updated data on the formation of ICCs or the functioning of LCCs. A 2021 report by the Ministry of Women and Child Development acknowledged widespread non-implementation of the Act, especially in small organizations, educational institutions, and rural areas.

Statistical Evidence of the Problem

The gravity of workplace harassment is evident from data trends. In India, over 400 cases of sexual harassment are reported annually. These numbers reflect only the tip of the iceberg, as underreporting remains rampant. The #MeToo movement in India (2018) further revealed the widespread and systemic nature of harassment across sectors, including media, cinema, academia, and corporate industries.

Constitutional and International Dimensions

From a constitutional perspective, sexual harassment violates Articles 14, 15, and 21, which guarantee equality, non-discrimination, and the right to life with dignity. The Supreme Court, in Apparel Export Promotion Council v. A.K. Chopra (1999), upheld that even an attempt to outrage a woman's modesty at the workplace constitutes harassment. Internationally, India is bound by CEDAW, which obligates states to eliminate discrimination against women in all forms, including the workplace. The

	International Labour Organization's Convention No. 190 (2019) on Violence and Harassment, though not yet ratified by India, sets global standards for inclusive workplace safety. These frameworks emphasize that workplace harassment is not just an individual grievance but a systemic violation of human rights and labour rights. **The Role of Institutions and Civil Society** Institutions such as the NHRC, NCW (National Commission for Women), and women's rights groups play an active role in raising awareness and pressuring governments and organizations to ensure compliance. The NCW frequently issues notices to organizations failing to establish ICCs. Civil society movements, especially #MeToo, have broken the silence surrounding workplace harassment and forced public discourse. However, backlash, trolling, and victim-blaming still reflect societal reluctance to confront entrenched patriarchal structures. **Suggestions for Strengthening the Framework** Strengthening workplace safety requires a multi-pronged strategy. First, strict monitoring and audits of ICCs and LCCs must be institutionalized, with penalties for non-compliance rigorously enforced. Second, awareness campaigns and gender-sensitization programs should be integrated into workplace culture to break the silence around harassment. Third, legal reforms are necessary to ensure time-bound investigations, protection for whistle-blowers, and safeguards against misuse while prioritizing victim protection. Fourth, expanding the coverage of the law to include gig workers, freelancers, and online workspaces has become urgent in the digital era. Technology, while empowering, has also facilitated cyber harassment that often spills into professional domains. Corporate accountability must also be emphasized. Companies should move beyond token compliance to genuine cultural transformation, promoting inclusive and safe environments. Regular training, anonymous reporting mechanisms, and transparency in redressal outcomes can build trust among employees. Finally, social transformation is indispensable. Patriarchal norms that normalize harassment must be challenged through education, community engagement, and representation of women in leadership positions.
Conclusion	The existence of laws and policies against sexual harassment at the workplace represents a significant advancement in India's pursuit of gender justice. However, the gap between legislation and reality remains stark, with underreporting, weak enforcement, and societal stigma continuing to silence victims. In the Vishaka judgment, the Supreme Court (SC) held that "Gender equality includes protection from sexual harassment and the right to work with dignity, which is a universally recognized basic human right." For this vision to materialize, laws must be backed by strong institutions, genuine corporate commitment, and societal change. Only then can workplaces truly become spaces of dignity, equality, and empowerment for women, thereby unlocking the full potential of India's workforce and democracy.
Model Question	Gender justice in professional spaces requires more than legislation. It demands institutional accountability and cultural change. Evaluate the effectiveness of existing frameworks in ensuring workplace dignity for women.
Value Addition	The Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW) is a landmark international human rights treaty adopted by the UN in 1979 that obligates countries to end discrimination against women and girls in all aspects of life, including politics, economics, and society. Often called the "international bill of rights for women," it requires signatory countries to eliminate discriminatory laws and practices, implement policies to achieve equality, and often includes an optional protocol allowing for individual complaints of violations.

74. What does the Indian National Policy for Senior Citizens 2011 reveal about the changing Indian society? Elaborate. (TGPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	What, Elaborate
Approach	• Introduction with demographic data on India's ageing population or an anecdote reflecting the struggles of elderly in modern India. Contrast traditional reverence for elders in joint families with today's challenges of nuclear households, urban migration, and neglect. • Explain why the 2011 policy replaced the 1999 version—rising life expectancy, feminization of ageing, urbanization, and weakening family support systems. • Highlight how the policy reveals shifts: erosion of joint families, growing state responsibility, changing aspirations of seniors (demand for independence and participation), and vulnerabilities of elderly women. • Discuss provisions of National Policy for Senior Citizens 2011 for healthcare, housing, social security, protection from abuse, and promoting productive ageing—showing a rights-based and inclusive vision. • Link policy with current schemes: NPHCE, IGNOAPS, Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana, Atal Vayo Abhyuday Yojana, Elderline, etc., showcasing operationalization. • Assess gaps in implementation, insufficient pension coverage, healthcare inadequacies, and need for gender-sensitive, tech-enabled, and community-driven approaches. • Suggest integrated elderly care, stronger legal protections, digital literacy, private sector role, and sensitization for intergenerational solidarity. • Conclude by affirming that dignity and care for the elderly is both a reflection and a test of India's evolving social fabric.
Introduction	In Indian tradition, the elderly have always been held in reverence, forming the custodians of wisdom and family values within intergenerational households. Care for the aged was once seen as both a duty and an honor, rooted deeply in cultural and religious ethos. Yet, the last few decades have witnessed a rapid transformation in social structures, lifestyles, and aspirations. Urbanization, migration, and globalization have weakened the bonds of the joint family system, leaving many senior citizens vulnerable to neglect, loneliness, and insecurity. Against this backdrop, the Indian National Policy for Senior Citizens (NPSC) 2011 was framed, replacing the earlier 1999 policy. More than a welfare blueprint, it reflects the changing realities of Indian society and its evolving approach to ageing.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Indian National Policy for Senior Citizens 2011: A Mirror of Changing Indian Society** **Demographic Transition and Policy Rationale:** India is undergoing a demographic shift characterized by a steady rise in its elderly population. The 2011 Census reported 104 million people above the age of 60 (8.6% of the population), a figure projected to cross 19% by 2050. Improved healthcare and life expectancy, while positive indicators of development, also create unprecedented challenges—healthcare demands, social security, housing, and psychological well-being. The NPSC 2011 was conceived to meet these challenges by providing a holistic framework ensuring dignity, security, and active participation for senior citizens. **What the Policy Reveals about Changing Indian Society** The National Policy for Senior Citizens (2011) reveals several deep transformations within India's social fabric. One of the most significant changes is the decline of the joint family system. Once the backbone of elder care, the joint family has steadily given way to nuclear households. As a result, elderly parents increasingly face neglect or

abandonment, compelling the state to step in as a new caretaker through institutional and policy measures. Another major factor shaping this policy is the impact of urbanization and migration. With younger generations moving to cities or abroad in pursuit of education and employment, ageing parents are often left behind in small towns and villages. Recognizing this, the policy emphasizes institutional forms of care such as day-care centers, assisted living facilities, and old-age homes, reflecting the shift from family-based to community- and state-supported care.

The policy also highlights the changing aspirations of the elderly. Unlike earlier generations, who often accepted dependence as a natural part of old age, today's seniors increasingly seek independence, financial security, and opportunities for active ageing. Acknowledging this change, the policy incorporates provisions for skill-building, employment, and avenues for productive engagement, thereby encouraging senior citizens to continue contributing to society.

Another important dimension is the feminization of ageing. Since women generally outlive men, a larger proportion of elderly women face widowhood, economic hardship, and social vulnerability. The policy responds to this pressing reality with gender-sensitive measures designed to address the specific challenges faced by elderly women, ensuring dignity and protection.

Finally, the policy reflects a significant shift in the role of the state. Traditionally, the family bore the primary responsibility for the care of the elderly. However, with weakening family structures, this responsibility is now increasingly shared among the state, civil society, and the private sector. This indicates the emergence of a redefined social contract where elder care is seen as a collective responsibility rather than a purely familial one.

Salient Features of NPSC 2011

The NPSC 2011 envisions an inclusive and rights-based framework for senior citizens. It calls for affordable healthcare, with geriatric facilities at primary health centers, specialized wards at district hospitals, and insurance coverage for the elderly. It emphasizes income security, proposing expanded pensions, tax incentives, and continued employment opportunities.

The policy also addresses housing, encouraging old-age homes, assisted living, and community-based care models. A significant thrust is on protection against abuse and exploitation, calling for strict implementation of the *Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act (2007)*. Beyond material needs, the policy promotes lifelong learning, social engagement, and productive ageing, redefining old age as a phase of active contribution to society rather than passive dependence.

Present Initiatives for Senior Citizens

Building on the NPSC 2011, several initiatives have been introduced. The *Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act (2007)* mandates family support and empowers tribunals to enforce it. The National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly (NPHCE) establishes geriatric clinics, specialized hospital wards, and regional geriatric centers.

For financial support, the Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS) provides direct assistance, supplemented by schemes like the Senior Citizens Savings Scheme and Varishtha Pension Bima Yojana. The Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana provides free assistive devices to weaker sections, while Digital Literacy for Senior Citizens bridges the technology divide. The Elderline (14567) helpline offers immediate assistance, and the Atal Vayo Abhyuday Yojana (AVYAY) funds day-care centers and old-age homes.

	Collectively, these initiatives represent a paradigm shift: senior citizens are now seen not merely as dependents but as active stakeholders in development. **The Silver Economy: Turning Ageing into Opportunity** A critical dimension of India's response to ageing lies in the silver economy—a framework that views the elderly as contributors to economic growth and not just recipients of welfare. With an expanding elderly population, opportunities are emerging in healthcare services, financial products, housing solutions, travel, wellness, and digital platforms tailored for seniors. The silver economy emphasizes productive ageing, encouraging seniors to re-engage in the workforce, share skills, and participate in entrepreneurship. This approach aligns with NPSC 2011's vision of independence and active participation. By tapping into the purchasing power and knowledge capital of senior citizens, India can convert demographic challenges into economic opportunities, creating a win-win model for both elderly well-being and national development. **Broader Social Implications** The NPSC 2011 and associated initiatives highlight how Indian society is adapting to modern realities. The ageing of the population underscores the dual challenge of honoring traditional respect for elders while developing institutional mechanisms to meet new demands. The policy also challenges ageist stereotypes, showcasing old age as a stage of productivity, wisdom, and contribution rather than dependency. Furthermore, it raises questions of intergenerational equity, how to allocate resources fairly between a youthful population driving the economy and an elderly population requiring care. The silver economy offers a bridge, ensuring seniors contribute while also being cared for. **Way Forward** As India transitions into an ageing society, more needs to be done. Implementation gaps persist, with many elderly deprived of pensions, healthcare, or safe shelter. A stronger integrated care model is required, combining health, housing, and social security. Technology-driven solutions like telemedicine, digital health records, and social platforms to combat loneliness should be expanded. Legal protections against elder abuse must be tightened, while policies must remain gender-sensitive, addressing the unique challenges faced by elderly women. Civil society and the private sector should be incentivized to innovate services in the silver economy, from retirement homes to financial products. Above all, sensitization of younger generations is critical to ensure intergenerational solidarity, reviving the ethos of respect while adapting to modern needs.
Conclusion	The Indian National Policy for Senior Citizens 2011 is more than a welfare policy—it is a mirror of the changing Indian society. It reveals the weakening of family-based support, the rise of state intervention, the aspirations of a new generation of seniors, and the feminization of ageing. At the same time, it frames old age as a space of opportunity, where dignity, participation, and contribution are central. By linking elderly welfare with the silver economy, India demonstrates that its development story is not only about its youthful demographic dividend but also about its ageing population. Ultimately, how a society treats its elderly is a litmus test of its moral compass. For India, ensuring dignity, security, and empowerment for senior citizens will define not just its cultural resilience but also the inclusivity of its progress in the 21st century.
Model Question	"India has a large young population and is said to have the chance to benefit from a demographic dividend. What are the benefits and problems that come with this situation? Suggest how government policies can help turn this potential into real and inclusive growth for the country."

Value Addition	**India's Demographic Dividend:** • India's 'demographic dividend' has long been touted as a key driver of the nation's future growth. With more than 800 million people below the age of 35, the country boasts of having one of the largest youth populations anywhere. This demographic 'asset', however, is increasingly under threat of becoming a 'liability', as the gap between education and real-world skills, and degrees and employability widens. If this gap is not addressed, India's demographic dividend could morph into a demographic time bomb — a paradox at scale. Over the past decade, data show that 40%-50% of engineering graduates from Indian universities have not been placed in jobs, highlighting the worrying gap between academic education and industry requirements. More and more youngsters are going to college or university, yet employers report increasing difficulty in finding talent with the right skills. Belatedly, educators are acknowledging the problem, with 61% of higher education leaders today agreeing that curricula are not aligned with rapidly changing job market needs.
75. The civil society has to play an active role, when institutions of democracy have not served the people of India as well as they were expected to."- Discuss the statement in the context of the struggle for Jan Lokpal Bill. (APPSC, 2012)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Introduce with the idea of democratic institutions Parliament, Executive, Judiciary, and media as pillars ensuring accountability and representation, but note how corruption and inefficiency weakened public trust. • Define civil society as citizens' organized expression NGOs, social movements, and activists serving as a watchdog and pressure group when formal institutions falter. • Explain the context of the Jan Lokpal Movement (2011) emerging from public frustration over corruption scandals and perceived institutional apathy. • Describe how Anna Hazare and India Against Corruption (IAC) mobilized mass participation, media attention, and moral pressure for an independent anti-corruption ombudsman. • Analyse how the movement showcased democratic awakening citizens reclaiming political accountability through peaceful protest and public discourse. • Critically evaluate limitations over-dependence on moral appeal, lack of political strategy, and the gradual dilution of the Lokpal Act post-enactment. • Conclude by emphasizing that civil society complements, not replaces, democratic institutions—its role is to strengthen transparency, ethics, and responsiveness through constructive engagement and sustained vigilance.
Introduction	Democracy thrives not only on strong institutions but also on an active, aware, and participative citizenry. India's Constitution established several democratic institutions—Parliament, Judiciary, Executive, Election Commission, and others—intended to ensure justice, equality, and accountability. However, when these institutions falter due to corruption, inefficiency, or political manipulation, the role of civil society becomes crucial in safeguarding democratic values. The Jan Lokpal movement, one of the most significant civil society uprisings in post-independence India, epitomized this corrective function. It symbolized people's frustration with institutional inaction against corruption and reflected the awakening of participatory democracy.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Understanding Civil Society and Democratic Institutions:** Civil society refers to the collective body of citizens and organizations outside the government who voluntarily work to protect public interests and uphold accountability.

It includes NGOs, pressure groups, media, academia, activists, and socially conscious individuals.

"Democratic institutions", on the other hand, are the pillars that enable democracy to function-ensuring representation, rule of law, and transparency. In India, despite having a robust institutional framework, many such bodies have often failed to meet people's expectations due to institutional inertia, politicization, and lack of transparency. When this gap widens, civil society acts as the moral conscience of the state, voicing the people's demands and mobilizing collective action.

Institutional Failures and the Rise of Corruption:

In the early 2000s, India witnessed widespread corruption scandals—the 2G spectrum scam, Commonwealth Games scam, and Coalgate, among others. Public trust in institutions eroded as investigative agencies were seen as politically influenced, Parliament was often disrupted, and bureaucratic accountability weakened. The Constitutional and statutory bodies, designed to protect citizens, appeared ineffective. The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) was often termed a "caged parrot," and the Central Vigilance Commission (CVC) lacked prosecuting powers. Even though the Right to Information Act (2005) empowered citizens, the systemic corruption remained deeply entrenched.

In this context of institutional underperformance, civil society emerged as a corrective force representing the anger, moral outrage, and hope of millions who believed that democracy could only be redeemed by citizen participation.

The Genesis of the Jan Lokpal Movement:

The demand for an independent anti-corruption ombudsman—the Lokpal—was not new. The first draft of the Lokpal Bill was introduced in Parliament in 1968, but successive governments failed to pass it. Between 1968 and 2010, the Bill was introduced eight times and lapsed each time.

By 2010, civil society's patience ran out. Under the leadership of Anna Hazare, a veteran Gandhian activist, along with Arvind Kejriwal, Kiran Bedi, Prashant Bhushan, and others, the India Against Corruption (IAC) movement was launched. It aimed to pressure the government into passing a strong, independent Lokpal Bill that could investigate and prosecute corruption without political interference.

The Jan Lokpal Movement and Civil Society in Action:

The movement began in April 2011 when Anna Hazare undertook a hunger strike at Delhi's Jantar Mantar, demanding the adoption of a "Jan Lokpal Bill" a citizen's version of the government's proposed Lokpal Bill. Within days, the movement transformed into a mass citizen uprising, with millions joining protests across cities, towns, and villages.

Social media played a crucial role, mobilizing youth, students, and professionals. The movement cut across class, caste, and regional divides, resonating with citizens frustrated by everyday corruption and declining trust in governance. It marked the revival of Gandhian methods of peaceful protest and moral persuasion in a modern digital age.

The civil society leaders insisted that the proposed Jan Lokpal should have the authority to investigate corruption cases against even the highest offices including the Prime Minister—within defined time limits, and with autonomy from government control.

Impact and Outcomes of the Movement:

The Jan Lokpal movement was a turning point in India's democratic evolution. It rekindled public faith in non-violent civic activism and forced the political class to acknowledge people's demand for accountability.

As a result of sustained pressure, the Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act was passed in December 2013. Though not identical to the Jan Lokpal draft, it established a statutory anti-corruption authority with powers to investigate public functionaries.

	However, the implementation faced hurdles delay in appointments, bureaucratic resistance, and limited autonomy. It took until 2019 for the first Lokpal to be appointed. Despite its limitations, the movement succeeded in making corruption a national debate and in awakening a generation of civic-conscious youth. The movement also transformed India's political landscape. Many activists, like Arvind Kejriwal, entered formal politics, leading to the formation of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) an example of how civil society action can evolve into institutional political participation. **Civil Society as a Corrective to Institutional Failure:** The Jan Lokpal movement demonstrated how civil society can: Mobilize public opinion to hold institutions accountable, Fill gaps left by political and bureaucratic systems, strengthen participatory democracy by engaging citizens directly in governance, and revive moral discourse in politics by appealing to ethics, transparency, and justice. It reaffirmed that democracy is not merely about periodic elections, but about continuous engagement between the state and society. When institutions become complacent or compromised, civil society ensures that the spirit of the Constitution justice, liberty, equality, and fraternity is upheld in practice. **Criticisms and Challenges:** While the movement achieved significant mobilization, critics pointed out certain concerns. Some argued that excessive civil society pressure risked undermining institutional legitimacy or promoting populism over deliberation. Others noted that the movement lacked organizational structure and failed to sustain long-term engagement after the Bill's passage. Moreover, civil society movements must balance activism with responsibility ensuring protests remain within democratic norms and do not bypass established institutions entirely. Constructive dialogue and institutional reform, rather than confrontation, ensure sustainable change. To sustain democratic integrity, India needs responsive institutions and responsible citizens. Civil society must focus on capacity building, awareness, and collaboration with state mechanisms to create systemic change rather than episodic protest.
Conclusion	The Jan Lokpal movement stands as a testament to the power of civil society in revitalizing democracy. When institutions falter, it is the collective conscience of citizens that preserves the essence of governance. The movement not only demanded legal reform but also inspired a moral awakening, reminding India that democracy is not self-sustaining it must be constantly nurtured through vigilance, participation, and ethical commitment. Civil society, therefore, is not an alternative to institutions but their moral compass ensuring that the voices of the people remain the heart of Indian democracy.
Model Question	"In recent years, civil society movements have emerged as the conscience keepers of Indian democracy. Critically examine the role of civil society in ensuring accountability and transparency when formal institutions of governance fall short of public expectations."
Value Addition	**Key Provisions of the Lokpal and Lokayukta Act, 2013** • Selection Committee: Chaired by the Prime Minister, includes Speaker of Lok Sabha, Leader of Opposition, Chief Justice of India (or nominee), and an eminent jurist appointed by the President. • Jurisdiction: Covers the Prime Minister, Union Ministers, MPs, and government employees in Groups A, B, C, and D. Includes foreign donations above Rs.10 lakh under FCRA. • Composition: One Chairperson and up to eight members; 50% must be judicial members. Half of all members represent SC/ST/OBC/minorities/women.

	• Superintendence: Can direct investigative agencies, including the CBI, in cases referred by the Lokpal. • Lokayukta: States must establish Lokayukta institutions within 365 days of the Act. • Eligibility: Chairperson or members cannot be MPs/MLAs; minimum age 45; Chairperson can be a former CJI, Supreme Court judge, or eminent person. **Amendment (2016):** • Leader of the largest opposition party can join the selection committee if no recognized Leader of Opposition exists. • Modifies Section 44: public officials report assets and liabilities as per government guidelines, removing the original 30-day requirement.
76. Write an essay on decentralised democracy and empowerment of weaker sections, in the light of recent developments in Panchayati Raj system in Andhra Pradesh. (APPSC, 2012)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Write
Approach	• Define decentralised democracy, rooted in the 73rd Constitutional Amendment (1992), ensuring people's participation at the grassroots. • Mention constitutional vision of self-governance (Article 243) and Ambedkar's ideal of "voice to the voiceless." • Trace evolution in Andhra Pradesh from N.T. Rama Rao's Mandal system to digital governance under e-Panchayats. • Explain empowerment of weaker sections like SC/ST/Women reservation (33%→50%), direct fund devolution, social audit mechanisms. • Cite recent initiatives such as Navaratnalu-Padhakam, Grama Sachivalayam, and Andhra Pradesh Panchayat Raj Act, 2020, enhancing inclusion. • Assess how decentralisation improved service delivery, but note challenges — elite capture, fiscal dependence, bureaucratic dominance. • Quote CAG/APSRD data showing a rise in women sarpanch representation and local welfare delivery outcomes. • End with a vision like deepening democratic roots requires financial autonomy, capacity-building, and genuine participation of weaker sections.
Introduction	Decentralised democracy lies at the heart of India's constitutional vision, envisaged by the framers as a means to ensure political participation, social justice, and inclusive development at the grassroots. The 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act of 1992 institutionalised Panchayati Raj as a three-tier system of rural self-governance, mandating the creation of Gram Panchayats, Mandal Parishads, and Zilla Parishads. This landmark reform aimed to transform India's democracy from representative to participatory by transferring power, functions, and funds to local bodies. In the state of Andhra Pradesh, decentralised democracy has evolved dynamically, with continuous efforts to integrate technology, empower weaker sections, and improve service delivery. The state's recent initiatives, such as Grama Sachivalayam, Navaratnalu-Padhakam, and amendments to the Andhra Pradesh Panchayat Raj Act, 2020, mark a renewed phase in the empowerment of the poor, women, and marginalised communities through strengthened local governance mechanisms.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Historical Evolution of Decentralised Democracy in Andhra Pradesh** The idea of decentralised democracy in Andhra Pradesh has deep roots dating back to the Community Development Programme (1952) and the Panchayati Raj experiment of 1959 under Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru. However, it was N.T. Rama Rao's reforms in the 1980s restructured local governance by introducing Mandal-level institutions for

better administrative efficiency. With the 73rd Amendment, Andhra Pradesh became one of the pioneer states to enact conformity legislation in 1994, establishing a vibrant three-tier structure of local bodies. Over the years, successive governments have focused on empowering panchayats through fiscal transfers, reservation policies, and capacity-building programmes.

By 2021, Andhra Pradesh had 12,842 Gram Panchayats, 685 Mandal Parishads, and 13 Zilla Parishads, collectively representing the voices of 70.53% of its rural population. These institutions have become vital platforms for participatory planning, especially in implementing poverty alleviation and welfare schemes such as MGNREGS, PMAY-Gramin, and Swachh Bharat Mission. The essence of decentralised democracy, as envisioned by Mahatma Gandhi's concept of Gram Swaraj, finds tangible expression in Andhra Pradesh's efforts to bring governance closer to people's doorsteps.

Institutional Framework for Empowerment of Weaker Sections

Empowerment of weaker sections, including Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs), Backwards Classes (BCs), minorities, and women, has been a central objective of decentralised democracy. The 73rd Amendment mandated proportional representation through constitutional reservations: Article 243D provides for not less than one-third reservation for women and proportionate reservation for SCs and STs in Panchayati Raj institutions (PRIs). Andhra Pradesh went a step further, enhancing women's representation to 50%, thereby positioning itself among the leading states promoting gender-inclusive governance. Moreover, reservations for SCs and STs are implemented based on demographic ratios, ensuring that leadership opportunities reach marginalised social groups. The state's Scheduled Areas Governance (PESA Act, 1996) further strengthens tribal self-rule in agency areas by granting Gram Sabhas decisive powers in managing natural resources and welfare projects. This has enabled tribal communities in districts like Visakhapatnam and Parvathipuram-Manyam to exercise greater control over their socio-economic development.

Recent Developments in the Panchayati Raj System in Andhra Pradesh

The recent decade has witnessed transformative innovations in the Panchayati Raj system of Andhra Pradesh, aligning decentralised governance with the digital era and inclusive growth models. A major reform was the creation of Grama/Ward Sachivalayams (Village Secretariats) in 2019, a unique governance model providing services across departments at the village level through secretariats staffed with trained local youth. This initiative reduced bureaucratic distance, enhanced transparency, and ensured time-bound service delivery. The Village Volunteers System serves as an interface between citizens and the government, ensuring equitable access to welfare benefits, particularly for weaker sections.

Another significant step was the implementation of the Andhra Pradesh Panchayat Raj Act, 2020, which emphasised performance-based grants, digital records, and accountability mechanisms. The state's Navaratnalu welfare framework further reinforced decentralised decision-making, prioritising schemes like Amma Vodi (education support for mothers), YSR Pension Kanuka (social security for the elderly and disabled), and YSR Cheyutha (economic empowerment of women from marginalised communities). These programmes, implemented through Gram Sabhas, demonstrate how decentralised democracy can directly improve the lives of weaker sections.

Fiscal Decentralisation and Local Governance

Fiscal devolution is the backbone of effective decentralisation. In compliance with the 14th and 15th Finance Commission recommendations, Andhra Pradesh has progressively increased grants to Panchayati Raj institutions. Furthermore, the

	integration of e-Panchayat and digital accounting systems has enhanced transparency in fund utilisation, reducing leakages and promoting citizen oversight. This fiscal empowerment has enabled Gram Panchayats to implement projects like water harvesting, sanitation drives, and social housing with greater accountability and local relevance. **Impact on Social Empowerment and Inclusion** Decentralised democracy has had a transformative effect on social empowerment in Andhra Pradesh. Women representatives, especially from marginalised backgrounds, have emerged as catalysts for change in local governance. Similarly, SC and ST Panchayat leaders have leveraged their positions to ensure fair implementation of welfare schemes like SC/ST Sub-Plan allocations and land distribution programmes. The establishment of Social Audit Units under the Panchayat Raj framework has also strengthened participatory accountability, allowing weaker sections to question irregularities in local governance. The empowerment of weaker sections through participatory audits and grievance redressal platforms has enhanced both their voice and bargaining power in local democracy. **Challenges in Deepening Decentralised Democracy** Despite substantial progress, challenges persist in realising the full potential of decentralised democracy in Andhra Pradesh. Local bodies often suffer from fiscal dependency on the state government and lack adequate administrative autonomy. Bureaucratic dominance and political interference sometimes undermine the authority of elected representatives, particularly women and members of weaker sections. Elite capture and factionalism in rural areas continue to distort the participatory character of Gram Sabhas. Moreover, capacity gaps among Panchayat functionaries limit effective planning and monitoring. This calls for continuous skill enhancement, awareness building, and greater involvement of civil society organisations in strengthening democratic capacities at the grassroots. **The Way Forward: Deepening Grassroots Empowerment** For decentralised democracy to translate into genuine empowerment of weaker sections, policy focus must shift towards functional devolution, capacity building, and digital inclusivity. Strengthening Gram Sabhas as deliberative platforms for participatory decision-making and integrating real-time monitoring tools like Smart Panchayat Portals can further enhance accountability. Ensuring regular fiscal transfers, promoting women's leadership training, and institutionalising local planning units are essential to sustain the democratic vibrancy of PRIs. The proposed District Planning Committees under Article 243ZD must be made operational to integrate local plans into district and state development strategies, bridging the gap between bottom-up aspirations and top-down policy frameworks.
Conclusion	Decentralised democracy in Andhra Pradesh stands as a robust experiment in translating constitutional ideals into tangible social transformation. Through sustained political will, institutional reforms, and innovative service delivery mechanisms, the Panchayati Raj system has become a vehicle of empowerment for the weaker sections. As Dr B.R. Ambedkar envisioned, "Political democracy must be accompanied by social and economic democracy." Andhra Pradesh's evolving Panchayat framework exemplifies this synthesis by placing power and resources in the hands of the marginalised. Yet, the journey toward complete empowerment demands deeper fiscal autonomy, capacity enhancement, and unwavering commitment to participatory governance. The state's experience reaffirms that true democracy does not reside

	merely in elections but in every citizen's active voice in shaping their own destiny through the village republics of India.
Model Question	Discuss the role of grassroots governance in promoting social justice and inclusive development with special reference to Andhra Pradesh.
Value Addition	The 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act of 1992 added Part IX to the Constitution, "The Panchayats", and also added the Eleventh Schedule, which consists of the 29 functional items of the panchayats. Part IX of the Constitution contains Articles 243 to 243 O. The Amendment Act provides shape to Article 40 of the Constitution (directive principles of state policy), which directs the state to organise the village panchayats and provide them powers and authority so that they can function as self-government. With the Act, Panchayati Raj systems come under the purview of the justiciable part of the Constitution and mandate states to adopt the system. Further, the election process in the Panchayati Raj institutions will be held independently of the state government's will. The Act has two parts: compulsory and voluntary. Compulsory provisions must be added to state laws, which include the creation of the new Panchayati Raj systems. Voluntary provisions, on the other hand, are the discretion of the state government. The Act is a very significant step in creating democratic institutions at the grassroots level in the country. The Act has transformed the representative democracy into a participatory democracy.
77. Examine the causes and consequences of the emerging sub regionalism and demand for smaller states in India. (APPSC, 2012)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Examine
Approach	• Begin by defining sub-regionalism as regional assertion within states based on cultural, economic, or administrative grievances. • Mention how post-independence India saw periodic demands for smaller states — from linguistic reorganisation (1956) to Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, Uttarakhand (2000), and Telangana (2014). • Explain how uneven political representation and neglect by dominant state leadership fuel sub-regional identity politics. • Highlight economic disparities like uneven development, resource distribution, and lack of investment in backward sub-regions. • Note the role of distinct historical, linguistic, or tribal identities seeking recognition and autonomy (e.g., Gorkhaland, Bodoland). • Point to administrative inefficiency and difficulty in governance of large states as a rationale for creating smaller, manageable units. • Discuss positive impacts of better governance, regional equity, identity satisfaction, and negative ones like inter-regional rivalry, resource conflicts, and political instability. • Conclude that sub-regionalism reflects India's diversity and democracy; managing it through balanced federalism and inclusive development is vital.
Introduction	India's political landscape has been profoundly shaped by its regional diversities. The evolution from linguistic states in the 1950s to recent demands for smaller states reflects a dynamic process of democratisation, development, and identity assertion. Sub-regionalism refers to the assertion of distinct political, cultural, or economic identities within a larger state, often resulting in demands for administrative autonomy or separate statehood. Far from being a threat to national unity, sub-regionalism in India largely represents the democratic articulation of local aspirations within the federal framework. However, it also exposes deep-seated inequalities and governance gaps that

	persist within large states. The demand for smaller states, such as Telangana (2014), Gorkhaland, Bodoland, Vidarbha, and Bundelkhand, exemplifies these emerging trends in India's sub-regional politics.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Historical Background and Context of Sub-regionalism** The roots of sub-regionalism in India can be traced to the linguistic reorganisation of states in 1956, following the movement for Andhra State after Potti Sriramulu's martyrdom. The States Reorganisation Commission (SRC) recognised that linguistic and cultural homogeneity could promote administrative efficiency and harmony. However, over time, new forms of regional inequalities emerged within the states themselves. The creation of new states in 2000, such as Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, and Uttarakhand and later Telangana in 2014, marked a shift from linguistic to developmental and identity-based demands. The reconfiguration of internal boundaries of states has therefore become a recurring response to sub-regional grievances rooted in uneven development and political neglect. **Political Causes of Emerging Sub-Regionalism** Politically, sub-regionalism arises from the centralisation of power within states and the perceived domination of one region or community over others. In many large states, political representation and leadership are concentrated in particular sub-regions, marginalising others. For instance, in united Andhra Pradesh, Telangana leaders accused the coastal elites of political and bureaucratic dominance, leading to regional alienation. Similarly, the demand for Vidarbha in Maharashtra stems from the Marathwada region's exclusion from political power and public investment. Political scientist Paul Brass noted that sub-regionalism often represents the "politics of recognition and representation", a demand not just for resources but also for voice and visibility. The rise of regional parties like the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS), Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM), and Bodoland People's Front (BPF) demonstrates how sub-regional aspirations have found organised political expression within India's democratic framework. **Economic and Developmental Causes of Sub-Regionalism** The most compelling cause of sub-regionalism is economic disparity within states. Unequal distribution of resources, uneven infrastructure, and neglect in public investment have created a sense of relative deprivation among backward regions. According to the Planning Commission's Regional Imbalance Report (2008), more than 40% of inter-district disparities exist within states, not between states. The Telangana Movement provides a classic example. Despite contributing nearly 60% of united Andhra Pradesh's revenue, Telangana received less than 30% of the budgetary expenditure for irrigation and infrastructure. Similarly, Jharkhand, rich in minerals and forests, remained impoverished due to resource exploitation without local development benefits. This mismatch between resource contribution and developmental outcomes fuels sub-regional identity politics and demands for separate states as instruments of equitable governance. **Socio-Cultural and Identity Factors for the Rise of Sub-Regionalism** Beyond economics, sub-regionalism in India is deeply intertwined with cultural identity and historical memory. Many sub-regions possess distinct linguistic, tribal, or historical traditions that feel overshadowed within larger state identities. The Bodoland movement in Assam and the Gorkhaland agitation in West Bengal reflect the assertion of cultural distinctiveness and the quest for political recognition. Similarly, tribal groups in Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh mobilised around the idea of self-determination and cultural preservation, which mainstream state politics had long ignored.

Sociologist Andre Beteille observed that "India's unity survives not by erasing diversity but by institutionalising it." Sub-regionalism, therefore, is not merely a separatist impulse but a search for inclusive representation of distinct socio-cultural identities within the constitutional framework.

Administrative and Governance Factors Influencing Sub-Regionalism

Administrative inefficiency in large states often aggravates sub-regional discontent. As states expand in population and area, governance becomes centralised, bureaucratic, and less responsive to local needs. Smaller states are seen as more administratively manageable, allowing closer state-citizen engagement. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission (2008) also emphasised that smaller states can improve governance efficiency if backed by adequate institutional and fiscal capacity.

Empirical evidence from states created in 2000 supports this view. According to NITI Aayog's State Performance Index (2020), Chhattisgarh and Uttarakhand recorded better growth rates and human development indicators than their parent states. However, the outcomes are mixed. Jharkhand continues to lag due to governance deficits, proving that mere bifurcation without robust institutions cannot ensure equitable development.

Consequences of Emerging Sub-Regionalism and Smaller States

The consequences of sub-regionalism are twofold. They are positive and negative. On the positive side, it enhances democratic participation by empowering marginalised regions and improving representation. New states often witness increased political accountability and developmental focus. For example, post-bifurcation Telangana achieved an average GSDP growth rate of 12.7% (2014–2023), driven by targeted irrigation schemes like Mission Kakatiya and welfare programs such as Rythu Bandhu. Smaller states also allow better administrative coordination and resource planning.

On the negative side, sub-regionalism can sometimes encourage competitive populism, inter-regional rivalry, and resource conflicts. Disputes over water sharing between Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, or boundary tensions between Jharkhand and Bihar, illustrate such outcomes. Moreover, frequent demands for new states, such as Harit Pradesh, Bundelkhand, and Vidarbha, can strain the federal structure and divert attention from institutional solutions to regional imbalances. The proliferation of new states without fiscal and administrative preparedness could also burden the exchequer and fragment political stability.

Sub-Regionalism and Indian Federalism

India's federalism has proved remarkably resilient in accommodating sub-regional aspirations. The Article 3 of the Constitution empowers Parliament to create new states, reflecting the framers' pragmatic approach to territorial flexibility. Unlike secessionist movements, sub-regionalism operates within the constitutional and democratic framework, reinforcing rather than undermining national unity. As former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh remarked during the creation of Telangana, "The demand for smaller states is an expression of India's maturity as a democracy, not its weakness."

Yet, managing sub-regionalism requires balancing identity-based politics with cooperative federalism. The Inter-State Council, NITI Aayog, and Finance Commissions must play proactive roles in addressing intra-state disparities through transparent devolution of resources and equitable development planning.

Case Studies and Empirical Reflections

The experience of Chhattisgarh illustrates how smaller states can harness administrative autonomy for targeted development, particularly in rural electrification and tribal welfare. Conversely, Jharkhand's instability (with more than 11 governments in 22 years) reveals the challenges of governance fragility in resource-rich yet politically

	fragmented regions. Telangana's success in achieving rapid economic growth contrasts with continued movements in Gorkhaland and Bodoland, where partial autonomy through councils has not fully resolved grievances. These case studies underline that while smaller states may address administrative challenges, they cannot substitute for inclusive governance and equitable resource distribution. **Way Forward** The way forward lies not in unchecked proliferation of new states but in institutionalizing mechanisms of regional equity within existing federal structures. The central and state governments must prioritise intra-state development planning, decentralise fiscal powers, and strengthen District Planning Committees (Article 243ZD) for localised governance. Establishing a Permanent Second States Reorganisation Commission, as suggested by scholars, can provide a systematic, evidence-based framework to evaluate genuine sub-regional demands. The focus should shift from territorial reorganisation to fiscal federalism, participatory governance, and inclusive growth that neutralise the roots of sub-regional alienation.
Conclusion	The emergence of sub-regionalism and the demand for smaller states in India reflect both the vibrancy and the vulnerabilities of its federal democracy. While sub-regional aspirations expose uneven development and governance deficits, they also testify to the strength of India's constitutional system that allows peaceful negotiation of such demands. The challenge lies in transforming sub-regional identity politics into instruments of equitable development and cooperative federalism. India's unity, as Jawaharlal Nehru envisioned, must rest not on uniformity but on the "federalisation of diversity." Hence, the creation of smaller states should not be viewed as fragmentation but as part of a continuous democratic process, ensuring that every region, however small, finds its rightful place in the nation's developmental journey.
Model Question	Discuss the factors leading to sub-regional movements and the growing demand for smaller states in India.
Value Addition	**Secessionism:** It is a form of regionalism that involves militant and fundamentalist groups advocating a separation from India based on ethnicity or any other factor. Isac Muivah's National Socialist Council of Nagaland (NSCN-IM), the Islamic fundamentalist groups in J&K, United Liberation Front of Asom (ULFA) in Assam are examples of such an extreme dimension of regionalism.
78. Assess the power of courts to intervene in executive policy in the context of judicial activism of recent days. (APPSC, 2012)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Assess
Approach	• Begin by defining judicial activism and contrasting it with judicial restraint — cite Justice Bhagwati's activism during the post-Emergency period. • Explain the constitutional basis of Articles 32, 226, and 142 empowering courts to ensure justice even against executive inaction. • Trace the evolution of Kesavananda Bharati (1973), Maneka Gandhi (1978), and the PIL era, expanding judicial reach into governance. • Discuss modern activism like environmental orders, the 2G spectrum case, coal allocation, and COVID-19 vaccine pricing interventions. • Assess limits such as separation of powers (Articles 50 and 122) and critique of overreach (e.g., striking down NJAC Act, policy interference). • Balance between accountability and over-judicialization, like courts act as "sentinels on the qui vive," not policy makers. • Refer to the Pegasus case, farm laws, demonetisation review, and climate-related suo motu actions.

	• Conclude that courts' intervention must protect constitutional morality without substituting executive wisdom, and ensure checks without paralysis.
Introduction	The relationship between the judiciary and the executive has always been a defining feature of constitutional governance in India. The Constitution envisages a clear separation of powers among the three organs, viz., the legislature, executive, and judiciary, each acting as a check on the others. However, in recent decades, the judiciary's role has significantly expanded through the instrument of judicial activism, wherein courts have stepped beyond mere interpretation of law to shape executive policy, enforce constitutional mandates, and protect fundamental rights. This expansion has sparked debate over whether such activism ensures accountability or disturbs institutional balance. In the context of recent judicial interventions, the assessment of the courts' power to influence executive policy becomes vital to understanding the evolving dynamics of Indian democracy.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Constitutional Basis of Judicial Intervention** The Constitution of India provides a strong foundation for judicial intervention in executive actions. Articles 32 and 226 empower the Supreme Court and High Courts, respectively, to issue writs for the enforcement of fundamental rights. Article 142 authorises the Supreme Court to pass any decree necessary for complete justice in a matter. Through these provisions, the judiciary assumes not only a corrective but also a supervisory role over executive functioning. The concept of judicial review, enshrined in the Constitution, gives courts the authority to examine the constitutionality of executive and legislative actions. As early as A.K. Gopalan v. State of Madras (1950) and later in Maneka Gandhi v. Union of India (1978), the judiciary affirmed its power to ensure that executive policies conform to the principles of fairness, reasonableness, and due process. **Evolution of Judicial Activism in India** The rise of judicial activism in India is closely tied to the socio-political context of the post-Emergency period. The judiciary, having faced criticism for its passivity during the Emergency (1975–77), redefined its role in protecting citizens' rights. Under the leadership of justices such as P.N. Bhagwati and V.R. Krishna Iyer, the courts embraced Public Interest Litigation (PIL) as a tool to democratize access to justice. Landmark judgments like Hussainara Khatoon (1979), which led to the release of thousands of under trial prisoners, and Vishaka v. State of Rajasthan (1997), which laid down guidelines on sexual harassment at workplaces, reflected the judiciary's proactive stance in addressing policy gaps. Judicial activism evolved into a mechanism to hold the executive accountable when it failed to act or acted arbitrarily. **Judicial Activism and Executive Policy: The Expanding Frontiers** Over time, the judiciary's interventions have expanded from the realm of individual rights to areas traditionally considered executive prerogatives, such as environmental protection, economic policy, and governance reforms. The MC Mehta cases on pollution control and the Ganga cleaning directives showcase the courts' sustained engagement with executive implementation failures. In Union of India v. Association for Democratic Reforms (2002), the Supreme Court directed the Election Commission to mandate disclosure of candidates' criminal records, directly influencing electoral policy. Similarly, the 2G Spectrum case (2012) and the Coal Block Allocation case (2014) witnessed judicial annulment of government decisions on grounds of arbitrariness and lack of transparency, reinforcing the court's role as guardian of public resources. During the COVID-19 pandemic, the Supreme Court and several High Courts actively scrutinised executive responses concerning migrant workers, oxygen supply, and

vaccine distribution. The Supreme Court's suo motu case on oxygen management (2021) exemplified how the judiciary's intervention can act as a moral and administrative compass during crises. While critics viewed such actions as encroachment into policy domains, supporters hailed them as necessary correctives in the face of executive inertia.

Recent Trends of Judicial Activism

Judicial activism in recent years has taken diverse forms, often reflecting contemporary governance challenges. The judiciary has intervened in issues ranging from environmental sustainability to digital privacy. The Puttaswamy judgment (2017), which recognised the right to privacy as a fundamental right, reshaped the policy landscape for data protection and surveillance. In Subramanian Swamy v. Union of India (2016), the court upheld criminal defamation laws, balancing free speech with social order, a classic example of judicial balancing in policy interpretation.

The Pegasus spyware case (2021) marked another assertive phase, where the Supreme Court ordered an independent probe into allegations of unauthorised surveillance, thereby compelling the executive to ensure transparency in matters of national security. Similarly, the court's interventions in the Delhi Government vs. Lt. Governor (2018 & 2023) cases clarified the boundaries of administrative power in the National Capital Territory, underlining federal and constitutional propriety. These instances highlight how courts, through activism, have redefined the contours of executive discretion in governance.

Criticism of Judicial Activism and the Doctrine of Separation of Powers

Despite its achievements, judicial activism has faced criticism for blurring the line between judicial review and judicial overreach. The Constitution's Article 50 implicitly endorses the separation of the judiciary from the executive, ensuring institutional independence. Excessive intervention by courts into policy-making is often seen as undermining democratic accountability, as judges are unelected and lack the technical expertise of administrators. Former Chief Justice A.M. Ahmadi once cautioned that "the judiciary must not become a super-legislature or super-executive."

Critics often cite examples such as the ban on firecrackers, judicial directives on BCCI administration, or the striking down of the National Judicial Appointments Commission (NJAC) Act (2015), as instances of judicial overreach. The NJAC judgment, while protecting judicial independence, also raised concerns about insulating the judiciary from public accountability. Former Chief Justice M.N. Venkatachaliah observed that judicial activism should not evolve into "judicial adventurism," as it risks eroding institutional trust and disrupting the equilibrium envisaged by the Constitution.

Judicial Accountability and Institutional Balance

Judicial activism, though rooted in constitutional morality, must operate within the limits of judicial accountability. The judiciary's legitimacy stems from public confidence and adherence to constitutional boundaries. Empirical evidence shows that excessive judicial interventions can delay administrative actions. For instance, a 2022 study by the Centre for Policy Research highlighted that nearly 65% of PILs filed in the Supreme Court pertained to governance matters, often straining judicial resources. Furthermore, the Law Commission of India (272nd Report) emphasised the need for self-restraint and prioritisation of systemic reforms over case-specific activism.

The judiciary's power is at its best when it reinforces, rather than replaces, executive responsibility. The Ayodhya judgment (2019), for instance, demonstrated how judicial prudence could deliver closure to a politically sensitive issue while respecting executive implementation. Similarly, in the demonetisation review case (2023), the court upheld

	the government's economic decision while reaffirming the principles of proportionality and procedural transparency, signalling a mature equilibrium between activism and restraint.
Conclusion	The power of courts to intervene in executive policy remains one of the most potent expressions of constitutional justice in India. Judicial activism has, over time, emerged as a necessary instrument to uphold citizens' rights, ensure administrative accountability, and fill policy vacuums. Yet, the strength of judicial authority lies in its judicious use — one that respects institutional boundaries and democratic ethos. As Justice D.Y. Chandrachud remarked, "Judicial activism is not about governance by judges, but about ensuring that governance remains within the limits of law." The future of India's constitutional democracy thus depends on a balanced, principled activism that acts as a constitutional compass, guiding the executive rather than governing in its place.
Model Question	Critically examine the scope and limits of judicial review in maintaining the balance between the executive and the judiciary in contemporary India.
Value Addition	When Judicial Activism goes overboard and becomes Judicial Adventurism, it is referred to as Judicial Overreach. In simpler terms, it is when the judiciary starts interfering with the proper functioning of the legislative or executive organs of the government. Judicial Overreach is undesirable in a democracy as it breaches the principle of separation of powers. In view of this criticism, the judiciary has argued that it has only stepped in when the legislature or the executive has failed in its own functions.
79. Democratic decentralization or Panchayati Raj aims at making democracy real by bringing the millions into the functioning of their representative government at the lowest level. However, parallel bodies at various levels diluted its aims and functions. Discuss with illustrations from Andhra Pradesh. (APPSC, 2011)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Introduce with the idea of democratic decentralization as envisaged by the 73rd Amendment and the Andhra Pradesh Panchayat Raj Act, 1994. Define its objective of making democracy participatory at the grassroots. • Briefly mention the three-tier PRI structure, Gram Sabha, and the principle of devolution of "3Fs" (Funds, Functions, and Functionaries). • Define what parallel bodies are (DRDAs, watershed committees, line departments, donor-driven committees) and why they emerged in Andhra Pradesh. • Discuss how parallel bodies weakened Panchayats through functional overlap, financial disempowerment, weakening of Gram Sabhas, and bureaucratic dominance. • Use examples like DRDA in MGNREGS, SHG federations, watershed committees, and line department control in education/health. • Highlight how this led to weakened autonomy of Panchayats, reduced citizen participation, and inefficiencies in local governance. • Conclude with reforms (SVAMITVA, AP Panchayat Raj Amendment 2024, e-Gram Swaraj), policy lessons, and recommendations for strengthening Panchayats by curbing parallelism.
Introduction	Democratic decentralization through the Panchayati Raj system is one of the most far-reaching reforms in post-independence India. By devolving power to elected bodies at the village, intermediate, and district levels, the Constitution sought to make governance participatory and accessible to millions of citizens. The 73rd Constitutional Amendment of 1992 institutionalized this process by mandating a three-tier structure, reserving seats

	for women and marginalized groups, and assigning 29 subjects under the Eleventh Schedule to Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs). The Andhra Pradesh Panchayat Raj Act, 1994 operationalized these provisions at the state level. However, in the erstwhile Andhra Pradesh, as in many other states, the rise of parallel bodies such as district agencies, donor-driven committees, and line-department structures, diluted the constitutional aims of Panchayati Raj. Instead of empowering Gram Sabhas and elected Panchayats, these entities often took over functions, funds, and decision-making authority.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Democratic Decentralization and Dilution by Parallel Bodies: Lessons from Erstwhile Andhra Pradesh** **Constitutional and Legal Background** The 73rd Amendment was celebrated as a milestone because it provided constitutional status to local self-governments. Andhra Pradesh enacted its Panchayat Raj Act in 1994, creating Gram Panchayats, Mandal Parishads, and Zilla Parishads. These were expected to prepare and implement plans for economic development and social justice. However, state practices diverged from constitutional ideals. Large portions of rural development, irrigation, health, and education continued to be managed by departmental hierarchies or special-purpose vehicles. Reports from the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) (2019–2022) highlighted persistent issues in the flow of funds to Panchayats and weak control over transferred functions. This reflected the coexistence of formal PRIs and informal parallel bodies, which undermined decentralization in practice. **Emergence of Parallel Bodies in Andhra Pradesh** The rise of parallel bodies in Andhra Pradesh stemmed from administrative and political preferences. District Rural Development Agencies (DRDAs) became the nodal agencies for flagship programmes like poverty alleviation and wage employment. Donor-supported projects such as watershed development and World Bank-assisted programmes created local committees outside the Panchayat framework. Similarly, Self-Help Group (SHG) federations under the Development of Women and Children in Rural Areas (DWCRA) scheme grew into powerful financial institutions managing substantial credit flows independently of Panchayats. Health, education, and irrigation services remained firmly within line-department control, with teachers, doctors, and engineers reporting to state-level officials rather than local elected bodies. The rationale offered was efficiency and accountability, but the unintended effect was the sidelining of PRIs. **Dilution of Panchayati Raj Functions** The existence of parallel agencies diluted the functions of PRIs in multiple ways. First, there was erosion of functional clarity. Though subjects such as drinking water, sanitation, and minor irrigation were constitutionally assigned to Panchayats, their implementation was handled by departmental engineers or special project units. Gram Panchayats thus had little role in planning or prioritizing works. Second, there was financial disempowerment. Major rural development funds were routed through DRDAs or mission-mode projects, while Panchayats received irregular and inadequate grants. For instance, a 2021 report in *The Hindu* noted that Panchayats in Andhra Pradesh had pending dues under central finance commission allocations, even as parallel bodies controlled substantial project budgets. Third, there was weakening of Gram Sabhas. Programme committees often held separate consultations, bypassing Gram Sabhas, which reduced community participation and accountability. **Illustrations from the Andhra Pradesh Experience** Concrete examples highlight the dilution of democratic decentralization. DRDAs in Andhra Pradesh implemented the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment

Guarantee Scheme (MGNREGS) for years, with Panchayats often reduced to wage distribution roles, while planning and execution remained in DRDA hands. Similarly, watershed committees created under donor-driven programmes functioned independently of Gram Panchayats, often deciding on beneficiary selection and fund allocation. In the case of self-help groups, while they significantly empowered rural women, their federations often received direct funds from the state government, bypassing Panchayat institutions.

The education and health sectors reflected another dimension of parallelism. Despite constitutional assignment, Panchayats had little say in the deployment of teachers or health staff. For example, the Andhra Pradesh Health Audit Report (2020) pointed out that Gram Panchayats were not consulted in planning for primary health centres, which continued to be controlled by state-level health departments. These illustrations show that, despite legal provisions, the administrative reality left Panchayats with limited authority.

Consequences for Local Democracy

The cumulative effect of these developments was the weakening of local self-government. Panchayats were unable to act as autonomous planning and decision-making bodies. Elected representatives, especially at the village and mandal levels, often found themselves sidelined by bureaucrats managing centrally sponsored schemes. The Gram Sabha, envisaged as the fulcrum of participatory democracy, lost credibility when people realized that major programmes were controlled by external agencies. The CAG observed that weak financial transfers and dependence on departmental staff had prevented Panchayats from functioning as envisaged in the Constitution. Over time, this reduced citizen engagement and accountability, while fragmenting rural governance across multiple institutions.

Recent Developments and Reforms

Despite challenges, recent years have seen attempts to strengthen Panchayati Raj both nationally and in Andhra Pradesh. At the Union level, the Ministry of Panchayati Raj has promoted digital tools such as the e-Gram Swaraj portal for transparency and planning, and the SVAMITVA scheme, which uses drone technology for mapping property to enhance Panchayat revenues. These initiatives aim to reduce financial dependence on parallel bodies by expanding the revenue base of Panchayats.

In Andhra Pradesh, the Panchayat Raj (Amendment) Bill, 2024 sought to update the 1994 legislation, including removing restrictive norms like the two-child rule for contesting local elections, thereby expanding political participation. The state has also experimented with real-time governance systems for monitoring Panchayat-level works. However, reports continue to highlight resource gaps, pending financial transfers, and the persistence of parallel agencies in key sectors. Thus, while reforms mark progress, the structural issue of parallelism remains unresolved.

The Way Forward

The Andhra Pradesh experience points to key policy lessons. First, there is an urgent need to complete the devolution of funds, functions, and functionaries in both letter and spirit. Legal provisions must be matched by budgetary commitments and local administrative control. Second, parallel bodies should be rationalized. Specialist agencies may be retained for technical expertise, but they should function under the oversight of Panchayats and Gram Sabhas, not as substitutes. Third, strengthening Gram Sabhas through mandatory participatory planning is crucial to re-establish local accountability. Fourth, capacity building and staffing at the Panchayat level are essential. Unless Panchayats have trained personnel and technical support,

	administrative elites will continue to justify bypassing them. Finally, there must be transparency in devolution. The introduction of a state-level Devolution Index, akin to NITI Aayog's rankings, could ensure greater public scrutiny of progress.
Conclusion	Panchayati Raj was envisioned as the foundation of grassroots democracy, empowering ordinary citizens to shape development and governance. Yet in Andhra Pradesh, as elsewhere, the rise of parallel bodies such as district agencies, line departments, and donor-driven committees has diluted this vision. While these arrangements were often justified in the name of efficiency, they undermined autonomy, weakened Gram Sabhas, and fragmented accountability. Recent reforms, from SVAMITVA to amendments in state legislation, offer hope for revival, but the persistence of parallel structures continues to challenge the spirit of democratic decentralization. For Panchayati Raj to fulfil its constitutional promise, elected local bodies must become the real custodians of development, rather than peripheral actors overshadowed by unelected agencies. Only then can democracy truly become "real" for millions of rural citizens in Andhra Pradesh and across India.
Model Question	"The Telangana Panchayati Raj system, envisioned through the Telangana Panchayat Raj Act, 2018, seeks to empower Gram Panchayats and strengthen local self-governance. However, challenges such as inadequate devolution of funds, parallel administrative structures, and capacity gaps have limited its effectiveness."
Value Addition	**Telangana Government Approves 42% BC Quota in Local Bodies, Total Reservation Rises to 67%:** • On September 26, 2025, the Telangana government issued a Government Order (GO No. 9) mandating a 42% reservation for Backward Classes (BCs) in upcoming local body elections. This move increased the total reservation in local bodies to 67%, with 42% for BCs, 15% for SCs, and 10% for STs exceeding the 50% cap conventionally upheld by the Supreme Court. • The government order was issued based on the findings of a dedicated BC commission, headed by B Venkateshwara Rao, a retired IAS officer. This commission's recommendations, in turn, were based on data from the Socio-Economic, Educational, Employment, Political, and Caste (SEEEPC) survey, which found that BCs constitute over 56% of Telangana's population but are underrepresented in local governance.

80. Analyse reasons for the decreasing proportion of female population in India and suggest solutions to contain this trend. (APPSC, 2008)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Analyse
Approach	• Introduce with a real-life scenario or statistic (Example: Haryana's skewed sex ratio, families using "miracle remedies") to highlight the issue. Introduce the broader problem of declining female population and its significance for society. • Discuss deep-rooted issues such as son preference, gender-based discrimination, female foeticide, infanticide, and limited access to education. • Examine low female labor force participation, economic dependence, wage inequality, and lack of property/financial ownership among women. • Analyze gender-based violence, inadequate maternal and reproductive healthcare, malnutrition, and gaps in law enforcement (NCRB data) that affect female well-being. • Outline existing efforts like gender-focused budgeting, health campaigns (Swasthya Nari, Sashakt Parivar), education and skill development schemes, and awareness programs to improve women's status.

	• Suggest holistic measures: stronger law enforcement, gender-sensitive education, economic empowerment, improved healthcare access, and community engagement. • Conclude by emphasizing the need for sustained action to restore gender balance.
Introduction	In the bustling streets of Haryana, a state long grappling with a skewed sex ratio, families sometimes resort to unscientific "miracle remedies," claiming they can ensure the birth of a male child. Such practices, ranging from herbal concoctions to ritualistic interventions, not only endanger the health of expectant mothers but also highlight deep-seated societal biases favoring sons over daughters. This phenomenon is not confined to Haryana alone; several northern and western states exhibit similar trends, reflecting centuries-old patriarchal norms that equate male children with family lineage, economic security, and social status. According to NFHS-5, the sex ratio in India stood at 1,020 males for every 1,000 females, revealing a persistent male bias. This demographic imbalance has far-reaching consequences, affecting marriage patterns, social stability, workforce composition, and the nation's overall development trajectory.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Reasons for the decreasing proportion of female population in India:** **Socio-Cultural Underpinnings: The Weight of Tradition** A major reason for the declining female population is the deep-rooted preference for sons, particularly in northern and western states such as Haryana, Punjab, and Uttar Pradesh. Cultural norms often view male children as carriers of family lineage and providers of economic security, while daughters are sometimes perceived as an economic burden due to dowry practices. This preference manifests in harmful practices such as sex-selective abortions, female foeticide, and neglect of girl children. NFHS-5 data also highlights regional disparities in sex ratios at birth, indicating that despite legislative measures like the Pre-Conception and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (PCPNDT) Act, son preference continues to influence family planning decisions. Limited access to education further compounds these socio-cultural biases. Girls in rural and marginalized communities often face barriers to schooling due to early marriage, household responsibilities, and safety concerns. While female literacy rates have improved over the decades, gaps persist, particularly in states with pronounced patriarchal norms. Without education, girls are less likely to be empowered to make decisions regarding their health, marriage, and careers, perpetuating cycles of dependency and inequality. **Economic Dimensions: Inequality and Dependence:** Economic factors play a crucial role in reinforcing the gender imbalance. India's female labor force participation remains low, standing at just 32.8% in 2024, compared to 77.1% for men. This disparity reflects systemic barriers such as wage inequality, lack of childcare facilities, and societal expectations that confine women to domestic roles. Many women remain economically dependent on male family members, limiting their bargaining power within households and reducing their perceived value. The Economic Survey 2024 further emphasizes that women's ownership of land and property remains low, and their participation in formal financial institutions is limited. Economic dependence intersects with social norms to create a vicious cycle. Families with constrained resources may prioritize investment in sons' education and careers over daughters, reinforcing the perception of males as the primary economic contributors. This combination of economic and social pressures directly contributes to the skewed female population. **Health and Safety Concerns: Vulnerabilities that Persist**

	Women in India continue to face significant health risks and vulnerabilities that exacerbate demographic disparities. Gender-based violence, including domestic abuse, sexual harassment, and trafficking, remains widespread. NFHS-5 data reports that a notable proportion of women have experienced physical or sexual violence, negatively affecting their health and well-being. Inadequate healthcare services, especially in rural areas, further compound these risks. Maternal mortality, malnutrition, and lack of access to reproductive health facilities remain pressing concerns, disproportionately affecting female survival rates. While legal frameworks exist to protect women, enforcement is often inconsistent. The National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) indicates a high incidence of crimes against women, highlighting gaps between legislation and practical implementation. Weak enforcement not only jeopardizes women's safety but also perpetuates societal attitudes that undervalue female lives. **Government Initiatives: Efforts to Restore Balance** Recognizing these challenges, the government of India has launched several initiatives aimed at improving the status of women. The Union Budget 2025-26 allocated ₹4.49 lakh crore for women's welfare, marking a significant increase from the previous year. Programs such as "Swasthya Nari, Sashakt Parivar" focus on providing comprehensive health screenings, addressing issues like anemia, hypertension, and cancer among women. In parallel, schemes promoting girls' education, skill development, and financial literacy aim to empower women and reduce gender gaps across socio-economic strata. Public awareness campaigns have also gained momentum, targeting harmful practices like female foeticide and early marriage. By combining financial incentives with community engagement, these programs attempt to alter long-standing cultural perceptions and emphasize the value of the girl child. **Towards a Holistic Solution: Education, Empowerment, and Engagement** Addressing the declining female population requires a multidimensional strategy. Strengthening the legal framework and ensuring stricter enforcement of laws against gender-based discrimination and violence can create a safer environment for women. Incorporating gender-sensitive curricula in schools and community-based awareness programs can challenge societal biases and foster respect for women from a young age. Economic empowerment is equally critical. Ensuring women's access to credit, property rights, and employment opportunities, alongside creating safe and flexible work environments, can enhance their financial independence and societal standing. Healthcare access must also be expanded, particularly in rural areas, through affordable maternal and reproductive health services and targeted awareness campaigns. Finally, community engagement, including the active involvement of men and boys in promoting gender equality, is essential to transform social attitudes and sustain long-term change.
Conclusion	The declining proportion of females in India is a complex issue influenced by socio-cultural, economic, and health factors. Although NFHS-5 reported 1,020 females per 1,000 males in 2021, regional disparities remain stark. States like Haryana, Punjab, and Delhi continue to show skewed sex ratios, with Ghaziabad recording just 853 girls per 1,000 boys in mid-2025. Deep-rooted son preference, combined with illegal sex-selective practices, exacerbates this imbalance, threatening social stability, demographic health, and equitable development. Addressing this challenge aligns with SDG 5, which aims to achieve gender equality and empower women and girls. Strategies include strengthening legal protections, promoting girls' education and skill development, improving maternal healthcare, and raising community awareness to shift societal attitudes. Together, these measures can

	foster an inclusive society where every girl is valued and contributes meaningfully to India's development.
Model Question	"Despite significant progress in education, health, and workforce participation, gender disparities persist in India. Critically examine the challenges to achieving gender parity across social, economic, and political spheres. Suggest measures to promote equality and empower women in line with national and global frameworks such as SDG 5."
Value Addition	**Global Gender Gap Report 2025:** • The Global Gender Gap Index releases by World Economic Forum measures gender parity across four key dimensions: Economic Participation and Opportunity, Educational Attainment, Health and Survival, and Political Empowerment. • India has ranked 131 out of 148 countries in the World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Report 2025, slipping two places from its position last year. • With a parity score of just 64.1%, India is among the lowest-ranked countries in South Asia, according to the report released on Thursday (June 12, 2025). India ranked 129 last year. • Iceland leads the rankings for the 16th year running, followed by Finland, Norway, the United Kingdom and New Zealand. • Yet full parity remains 123 years away at current rates, according to the report.
81. Discuss the working of Panchayati Raj in Andhra Pradesh with a focus on devolution of powers to local bodies. (APPSC, 2008)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Socio- Political Issues
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Introduce with the constitutional foundation of Panchayati Raj under the 73rd Amendment, highlighting its aim of democratic decentralization. Briefly mention Andhra Pradesh's early adoption and institutional framework. • Explain the evolution of Panchayati Raj in India through key committees (Balwant Rai Mehta, Ashok Mehta, L.M. Singhvi) and link these to Andhra Pradesh's 1994 Act establishing the three-tier system. • Describe the organizational framework: Gram Panchayats, Mandal Parishads, and Zilla Parishads, with emphasis on representation, Gram Sabha participation, etc. • Analyze the 3Fs: Functions, Finances, and Functionaries to evaluate how far real devolution has taken place in AP. Include examples like PM-SVAMITVA, Village/Ward Secretariats. • Critically assess successes (e-governance, financial transparency, capacity building) and persistent challenges (fiscal dependence, weak Gram Sabhas, dual control of staff). • Conclude with reform-oriented suggestions such as stronger SFC implementation, participatory planning, and integration of new governance mechanisms, reinforcing democratic decentralization as the core objective.
Introduction	Grassroots democracy in India is rooted in the vision of Mahatma Gandhi's Gram Swaraj — "true democracy cannot be worked by twenty men sitting at the centre. It has to be worked from below by the people of every village." The 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1992 transformed this idea into a constitutional reality by institutionalizing Panchayati Raj as the third tier of government. Andhra Pradesh (AP) was among the pioneering states in adopting Panchayati Raj institutions (PRIs) and enacted the Andhra Pradesh Panchayat Raj Act, 1994. While the constitutional framework mandates devolution of functions, finances, and functionaries, the real question is the extent to which these powers are actually transferred to local bodies. This essay examines the

	working of PRIs in Andhra Pradesh with special emphasis on devolution of powers, supported by committee recommendations, government reports, and recent examples.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Working of Panchayati Raj in Andhra Pradesh: Focus on Devolution of Powers** **Historical and Legal Framework** The Panchayati Raj system in Andhra Pradesh finds its constitutional basis in Part IX of the Indian Constitution (Articles 243–243O) and the Eleventh Schedule, which lists 29 subjects to be devolved to local governments. Andhra Pradesh operationalized these provisions through the Andhra Pradesh Panchayat Raj Act, 1994, establishing a three-tier structure comprising Gram Panchayats at the village level, Mandal Praja Parishads at the intermediate level, and Zilla Praja Parishads at the district level. The system's evolution can be traced back to landmark committee recommendations. The Balwant Rai Mehta Committee (1957), in its pioneering report, emphasized that "development cannot progress without democratic decentralisation," leading to the creation of a three-tier framework that continues to guide Andhra Pradesh's model. Later, the Ashok Mehta Committee (1978) described Panchayats as "the most viable and operationally relevant unit of planning and development." These foundational ideas continue to shape the state's decentralized governance structure, ensuring local participation in planning and execution. **Structure and Scale of Local Bodies** Andhra Pradesh has built an extensive Panchayati Raj network, comprising over 13,300 Gram Panchayats across 26 districts. Each Panchayat is led by an elected Sarpanch, with constitutionally mandated reservations for women (33%), and for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and OBC communities. The Gram Sabha, an assembly of all registered voters in the village, serves as a participatory platform for approving development plans, budgets, and local priorities, reinforcing the spirit of grassroots democracy. As the L.M. Singhvi Committee (1986) aptly described, Panchayats are "the embodiment of direct democracy." This sentiment is visible in Andhra Pradesh's institutional design, which aims to promote inclusive governance and citizen involvement in local decision-making. **Devolution of Functions** The Eleventh Schedule empowers states to devolve 29 subjects to local governments, and Andhra Pradesh has accordingly distributed responsibilities among its three tiers. Gram Panchayats handle essential civic functions such as sanitation, drinking water, rural housing, and maintenance of primary schools and health sub-centres. Mandal Praja Parishads focus on agricultural extension, minor irrigation, and mandal-level planning, while Zilla Praja Parishads are tasked with district-level planning, coordination, and implementation of large-scale rural infrastructure projects. However, this functional devolution remains incomplete in practice. Many line departments retain administrative control over key sectors, limiting Panchayat autonomy. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission (ARC, 2008) observed that "the real empowerment of Panchayats is curtailed by the reluctance of state governments to part with powers and resources." Andhra Pradesh's experience mirrors this national trend, where devolution on paper often fails to translate into effective control at the local level. **Devolution of Finances** Financial devolution forms the backbone of functional empowerment. Andhra Pradesh's Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) receive resources from both the Central Finance Commission (CFC) and the State Finance Commission (SFC). The 14th Finance

Commission allocated ₹8,654 crore to the state's rural local bodies for the period 2015–20, while the 15th Finance Commission continued this pattern, linking grants to outcomes in water and sanitation service delivery.

At the state level, successive SFCs have recommended formula-based transfers from state revenues to local bodies. However, reviews by the CAG and the SFCs indicate that such transfers have been partial and delayed, limiting financial predictability and autonomy. Gram Panchayats also mobilize own-source revenues through property tax, water cess, and market fees. The PM-SVAMITVA scheme has further expanded the tax base by mapping land parcels using drones and GIS technology, thereby strengthening local fiscal capacity. Yet, as the Ashok Mehta Committee cautioned, "without adequate financial resources, Panchayats can only be paper tigers," highlighting the continued need for fiscal empowerment.

Devolution of Functionaries

True decentralization also requires administrative devolution, the transfer of functionaries. In Andhra Pradesh, this remains an unfinished task, with many staff members functioning under dual control of line departments and local bodies. This has weakened institutional accountability at the Panchayat level.

In recent years, the state has undertaken innovative reforms to bridge this gap. The Village/Ward Secretariats and Volunteer System, introduced in 2019, has brought governance closer to citizens by delivering services directly at the doorstep. Additionally, the construction of over 4,600 Gram Panchayat Bhawans has improved office infrastructure and administrative efficiency. However, critics argue that such parallel structures risk overshadowing elected Panchayats, echoing the 2nd ARC's warning that "creating parallel institutions weakens the authority of elected bodies and defeats the spirit of the 73rd Amendment."

Performance, Achievements, and Gaps

The Panchayati Raj system in Andhra Pradesh has achieved significant progress in transparency, service delivery, and digital governance. Platforms like eGramSwaraj and PRIASoft have enhanced financial reporting and accountability. The implementation of SVAMITVA has reduced land disputes and increased local revenues, while around 70% of Gram Panchayats now have functional office buildings, as per the Ministry of Panchayati Raj (2023).

Nevertheless, several challenges persist. Most Panchayats continue to exhibit fiscal dependence on state and central transfers, limiting their functional autonomy. Gram Sabhas, though mandated, often remain symbolic due to low participation. Moreover, capacity deficits, particularly the shortage of trained personnel for planning, budgeting, and technical implementation, continue to hamper effective decentralized governance. As the Balwant Rai Mehta Committee once cautioned, without genuine decentralisation, Panchayats risk becoming "mere agencies of state administration rather than institutions of self-government."

Way Forward

For the Panchayati Raj system in Andhra Pradesh to function as a truly empowered grassroots governance mechanism, several reforms are essential. The full implementation of SFC recommendations would ensure predictable and equitable fiscal transfers. Systematic capacity building of elected representatives and staff through training and digital literacy is crucial for improving governance outcomes. Expanding own-source revenue generation through digital property records and rational user charges can enhance fiscal independence.

Equally important is the need to revitalize Gram Sabhas as genuine forums for participatory planning and social audit. Finally, integrating the volunteer and secretariat

	systems with elected Panchayats, rather than allowing them to function in parallel, would reinforce institutional legitimacy. As the Second Administrative Reforms Commission rightly emphasized, "For democracy to be meaningful to the people, empowerment of local governments is the only way forward." Andhra Pradesh's progress thus depends on deepening this devolution in both letter and spirit.
Conclusion	The Panchayati Raj system in Andhra Pradesh stands as a constitutional and democratic innovation to realize grassroots empowerment. While Andhra Pradesh has a robust legal framework and large-scale institutional presence, the devolution of powers remains incomplete. Functions are devolved on paper, finances are partially dependent, and functionaries remain under state control. Yet, positive steps include Finance Commission grants, SVAMITVA property mapping, digital governance, and GP infrastructure, signal a gradual strengthening of PRIs. In essence, for Panchayats in Andhra Pradesh to evolve from "agencies of delivery" to "engines of self-governance," the state must ensure genuine transfer of the 3Fs, revitalize Gram Sabhas, and harmonize parallel administrative innovations with elected institutions. Only then will the spirit of Gandhian *Gram Swaraj* and the 73rd Amendment find true realization in Andhra Pradesh.
Model Question	"Discuss the significance of the 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendment Acts in deepening democratic decentralization in India. Critically analyze their implementation and the extent to which they have empowered local self-governments in rural and urban areas.
Value Addition	**State Finance Commission:** • Article 243-I of the Constitution of India lays down that the Governor of state shall, as soon as may be within one year from the commencement of the Constitution (seventy third amendment) Act, 1992, and thereafter at the expiration of every fifth year, constitute a Finance Commission to review the financial position of the Panchayats and make recommendations to the Governor. • Similarly, Article 243-Y of the Constitution has a provision for the municipalities. Article 243-I and 243-Y have a provision that the State Finance Commission shall recommend the principles governing the distribution between the state and the panchayats and the municipalities of the net proceeds of the taxes, duties, tolls and fees leviable by the State, which may be divided between them. The Commission shall also recommend about the grants to the Panchayats and Municipalities from the Consolidated Fund of the State and measures to improve the financial position of these local bodies.

(v) Cultural and Historical Aspects

82. Illustrate the role of aniconic symbols in the representation of Gautam Buddha in Sunga arts and relate its influence to the development of Buddhist art in later periods (TGPSC, 2024)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Cultural and Historical aspects
Keyword	Illustrate
Approach	• Begin with the transition from Mauryan to Sunga art (2nd century BCE) and the emergence of symbolic Buddhism. • Explain that Buddha was represented through symbols, not human form, due to early religious restraint. • Mention the Bodhi tree (enlightenment), wheel (Dharmachakra), footprints, empty throne, and stupa. • Cite Bharhut and Sanchi reliefs showing narrative scenes without Buddha's image. • Emphasise spiritual abstraction and emphasis on symbolism over realism. • Explain how Sunga art bridged Hinayana's aniconism and later Gandhara–Mathura anthropomorphic art.

	• Show how later schools adopted both symbolic and human representations harmoniously. • Conclude that Sunga aniconic art laid the philosophical and artistic foundation for mature Buddhist iconography.
Introduction	The evolution of Buddhist art in India reflects a profound shift from symbolic representation to iconic manifestation, mirroring changes in religious thought, devotional practice, and artistic convention. During the Sunga period (2nd century BCE–1st century BCE), the image of Gautama Buddha was expressed not through anthropomorphic depictions but through aniconic symbols that conveyed his spiritual essence and historical life events. This artistic idiom emerged from a deep sense of reverence for the Buddha's transcendence, an understanding that the Enlightened One could not be confined to a physical form. The Sunga art, flourishing after the Mauryan Empire's decline, thus became a seminal phase in the evolution of early Buddhist imagery, setting the aesthetic and philosophical foundations for later developments in the Gandhara, Mathura, and Amaravati schools of Buddhist art.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Context of Sunga Art and its Religious Milieu** The Sunga dynasty (c. 185–73 BCE) succeeded the Mauryas, inheriting an empire where Brahmanical revivalism and Buddhist patronage coexisted. While the Mauryan art under Ashoka emphasised imperial grandeur and universal Dharma through polished monolithic pillars and inscriptions, the Sunga art localised and humanised these expressions. It was during this time that monumental stupas such as Bharhut, Sanchi, and Bodhgaya underwent artistic embellishment, becoming vibrant narrative canvases for Buddhist themes. Unlike the earlier simplicity of Ashokan monuments, Sunga art reflected intricate carvings, regional idioms, and symbolic storytelling. The Buddhist artists, influenced by Theravada orthodoxy, refrained from portraying the Buddha in human form. Instead, they used aniconic symbols that encapsulated his spiritual presence and life episodes, aligning with the philosophical view that the Buddha had transcended physical existence after attaining Parinirvana. **The Role of Aniconic Symbols in Sunga Art** The aniconic phase of Buddhist art was characterised by symbolic motifs representing the Buddha's life and teachings without showing his physical image. These symbols became the language through which devotees and artists communicated the sacred. Among the most recurrent were the empty throne, the Bodhi tree, Dharma Chakra, footprints (Buddhapada), stupas, and the wheel of law. The empty throne symbolised the Buddha's presence during significant events like his enlightenment at Bodh Gaya or his first sermon at Sarnath. It indicated that while the physical Buddha was absent, his spiritual authority and Dharma endured eternally. Similarly, the Bodhi tree, under which Siddhartha attained enlightenment, became a recurrent motif in Bharhut and Sanchi reliefs, signifying enlightenment and divine awakening. The Dharma Chakra (Wheel of Law) represented the turning of the wheel of Dharma, first set in motion at Sarnath. In the Bharhut stupa railings, a wheel flanked by deer stands for the Dharmachakra Pravartana, the first sermon delivered by the Buddha. The Buddhapada or footprints carved with auspicious symbols such as the lotus, swastika, and wheel conveyed the Buddha's divine journey upon earth, suggesting his continued guidance to followers despite his physical absence. The stupa, as an architectural and symbolic form, encapsulated the Buddha's presence as a reliquary and spiritual centre, representing his enlightenment, teaching, and final liberation.

Artistic Features and Aesthetic Expression of Sunga Artists

The Sunga artists excelled in relief sculpture, using red sandstone and local materials to craft intricate scenes filled with narrative vitality. The railings and gateways of Bharhut Stupa are adorned with detailed panels illustrating Jataka tales and episodes from the Buddha's life, where the master himself is indicated only by symbols amidst human and celestial figures. For example, in the Mahabhinishkramana (Great Departure), the horse Kanthaka is shown leaving the palace with an empty saddle, attended by celestial beings, a masterful way of implying the Buddha's departure without portraying him directly.

The female yakshis and tree spirits (shalabhanjikas) carved on the railings represent the continuity of folk and fertility motifs within Buddhist architecture, illustrating the synthesis of popular and religious art. The Sunga sculptors imbued these reliefs with rhythmic movement, detailed ornamentation, and expressive gestures, revealing an early maturity in Indian narrative art.

Philosophical Underpinnings of Aniconism in Buddhist art

Aniconism in Sunga Buddhist art was not merely an artistic limitation but a theological choice grounded in early Buddhist doctrine. According to the Hinayana or Theravada school, reverence was directed toward the Dharma and Sangha, not the deified image of the Buddha. The Mahaparinibbana Sutta of the Digha Nikaya suggests that the Buddha discouraged image worship, emphasising mindfulness of his teachings over corporeal representation. This ideological restraint fostered a symbolic visual culture, ensuring that art served as a vehicle for contemplation rather than idolatry.

Moreover, these symbols invited interpretative engagement, a meditative process in which devotees could internalise the meanings of enlightenment, compassion, and detachment. Thus, the aniconic art of the Sunga period acted as a spiritual pedagogy, merging aesthetics with metaphysics.

Influence of Sunga Art on Later Buddhist Art

The legacy of Sunga aniconism profoundly shaped the trajectory of Buddhist art in subsequent centuries. When the Kushan Empire patronised Buddhism from the 1st century CE onward, the Gandhara and Mathura schools began to depict the Buddha in human form, influenced respectively by Greco-Roman naturalism and indigenous Indian stylisation. Yet, even within these iconic traditions, the symbolic motifs of the Sunga period persisted as secondary emblems, the Dharma Chakra behind the Buddha's head, the Bodhi tree in background reliefs, or the lion throne beneath him.

At Amaravati and Nagarjunakonda, flourishing under the Satavahanas and Ikshvakus, the synthesis reached its zenith. The reliefs combined anthropomorphic Buddhas with Sunga-derived symbols, integrating narrative dynamism with devotional accessibility. For instance, in Amaravati's great stupa panels, while the Buddha appears in human form, the Bodhi tree and empty throne motifs still mark earlier traditions. Thus, Sunga symbolism provided the visual grammar for later Buddhist iconography across South and Southeast Asia.

Regional and Global Resonance of Sunga Art

The symbolic idiom that began in Sunga art eventually spread along the Buddhist trade routes across Central and Southeast Asia. In regions such as Sri Lanka, Myanmar, and Thailand, early Buddhist relics and monuments bore aniconic symbols before adopting anthropomorphic images, showing direct influence from Indian prototypes. This diffusion underscores the cultural universality of symbols; an empty throne or a wheel could transcend language and geography, communicating the Dharma to diverse audiences.

Empirical and Archaeological Evidence regarding Sunga Art

	Archaeological findings from Bharhut, Sanchi, and Bodhgaya provide empirical evidence of this artistic phase. The Bharhut railings, now housed in the Indian Museum, Kolkata, carry inscriptions in Brahmi script identifying donors, merchants, monks, and laywomen attesting to widespread social participation in religious art. This democratisation of art also fostered the proliferation of Buddhist imagery. The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) records show that stupas constructed or renovated during the Sunga period increased across central India, indicating a significant expansion of the Buddhist cultural landscape. These data corroborate the vibrancy of aniconic art as both a devotional and socio-economic phenomenon.
Conclusion	In conclusion, the role of aniconic symbols in the representation of Gautama Buddha in Sunga art was both profound and transformative. Rooted in doctrinal purity and aesthetic innovation, these symbols transcended the material world to evoke the Buddha's spiritual presence. The Sunga artists, by transforming abstract theological ideas into visual metaphors, created a language of faith that would endure across centuries. Their artistic idiom laid the foundation for the transition from the symbolic to the iconic, influencing not only the Gandhara and Mathura schools but also shaping Buddhist visual culture across Asia. As E. B. Havell remarked, "The Indian artist sought not to portray the transient, but to reveal the eternal." The Sunga aniconic tradition thus remains a timeless testimony to how art can embody philosophy, communicate transcendence, and serve as a bridge between the human and the divine.
Model Question	Discuss how the aniconic phase of Buddhist art during the Sunga period reflected early religious ideology and aesthetic sensibilities.
Value Addition	**Bharhut Stupa:** • It was discovered by Alexander Cunningham. • Originally it was built by Ashoka but enlarged and renovated during the Shunga period in the mid-2nd century BC. • It is situated in the Satna district of Madhya Pradesh. • Red stone was used to make the railings. • It represents the beginning of a Buddhist narrative relief and decoration tradition for holy structures. • E.g. Queen Mayadevi's dreams and depiction of Ruru Jataka
83. The Role of the Youth in Preserving India's Cultural Heritage. (APPSC, 2020)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Cultural and Historical aspects
Approach	• Introduce with a real-life example, story, or quote that highlights the connection between youth and heritage. • Explain tangible and intangible heritage, and why preservation matters for identity and nation-building. • Discuss the Youth demographic strength, creativity, and ability to reinterpret tradition through technology, innovation, and activism. • Integrate government initiatives and institutional support by mentioning schemes like CHYLP, fellowships, SPIC MACAY, Zonal Cultural Centres, and UNESCO youth forums. • Provide contemporary illustrations, include youth-led heritage walks, digital archiving projects, craft revival startups, and community participation examples. • Critically Analyse challenges such as lack of awareness, commercialization, bureaucratic hurdles, and generational disconnect. • Conclude by stressing on education, technology integration, recognition, and policy participation, ending with a visionary note on youth as stewards of cultural democracy.

Introduction	On a winter morning in Varanasi, a group of college students gathered at the ghats before sunrise. Though some had travelled from Delhi, Chennai, and Bengaluru, they carried cameras, sketchpads, and notebooks, participating in a heritage walk organized by young volunteers under the "My City, My Heritage" initiative. As they listened to an elderly boatman recount the legend of the Ganga aarti, recorded folk songs sung on the steps, and sketched the outlines of centuries-old temples, it became clear that cultural heritage is not confined to textbooks or museums. It is alive, thriving in daily practices, stories, and spaces. Across India, youth are increasingly taking the lead in documenting and preserving this legacy. From SPIC MACAY concerts in schools and universities to digital archiving on social media and government programs like the Cultural Heritage Youth Leadership Programme (CHYLP), young people are emerging as active guardians of India's cultural wealth. In a rapidly changing world, their role is indispensable.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The Role of the Youth in Preserving India's Cultural Heritage** **Cultural Heritage as a Living Identity** India's cultural heritage is vast, diverse, and layered by comprising tangible assets such as monuments, forts, manuscripts, and handicrafts as well as intangible traditions such as oral epics, folk songs, dance forms, and culinary practices. Heritage is the sum total of traditions, monuments, objects, and culture inherited from past generations. For India, a country rooted in civilizational continuity, heritage is not a static artifact but a dynamic part of daily identity and social life. Young people, by sheer demographic strength, over 65% of India's population is below the age of 35, form the backbone of this living identity. Their relationship with heritage will determine whether it is nurtured, reinterpreted, or neglected in the decades to come. **The Unique Role of Youth in Preservation** The youth occupy a unique position at the crossroads of tradition and modernity. Unlike older generations, which primarily receive and transmit heritage, today's youth interpret it and make it relevant to contemporary life. Their creativity, openness, and technological skills allow them to democratize access to cultural heritage through social media, digital platforms, and virtual tools. They innovate in conservation using 3D modelling, crowdsourced archiving, and digital mapping, while also bridging generational gaps by learning from elders and adapting traditional knowledge to modern contexts. Moreover, they mobilize peers through campus clubs, awareness campaigns, and cultural movements, expanding the reach of heritage beyond academic or elite circles. Examples of such efforts are evident across India. Youth-led initiatives like "India Lost and Found" on Instagram have engaged thousands in rediscovering neglected monuments, while students in cities like Delhi, Jaipur, and Hyderabad organize heritage walks that foster awareness and a sense of ownership. These efforts demonstrate that when youth engage actively, heritage transforms from a passive relic into a living, participatory conversation. **Government Initiatives Supporting Youth Engagement** Recognizing the potential of youth, the Indian government has launched several initiatives to encourage their participation in cultural preservation. The Cultural Heritage Youth Leadership Programme (CHYLP), under the Ministry of Culture, raises awareness among children, particularly from underprivileged backgrounds, by taking them to museums, monuments, and heritage sites. The government also supports young artists through schemes like the Scholarship to Young Artistes in Different Cultural Fields and the Junior Fellowship Scheme, enabling them to continue training in traditional art forms. The establishment of Zonal Cultural Centres (ZCCs) has created platforms for youth engagement. Through programs such as the Rashtriya Sanskriti Mahotsavs, ZCCs bring

together folk performers, craftspeople, and students, allowing young people to experience cultural traditions firsthand. At the international level, the World Heritage Young Professionals Forum 2024, hosted by UNESCO in collaboration with India, brought together youth from across the globe, including young Indians, to discuss sustainable heritage practices. The Know India Programme (KIP) by the Ministry of External Affairs further connects Indian-origin youth abroad with their ancestral culture.

Youth in Action: Contemporary Illustrations

Beyond government schemes, youth themselves have demonstrated innovation in heritage preservation. SPIC MACAY has, for decades, promoted classical and folk arts in schools and colleges through voluntary student engagement. In cities like Jaipur, Hyderabad, and Lucknow, student collectives organize heritage walks that interpret the histories of old neighbourhoods, temples, and bazaars. Young designers and entrepreneurs are reviving dying crafts by linking them to modern markets. Events like Sewa Parv 2025 saw students participating in workshops with folk artists, while digital campaigns such as "Save Our Crafts" and college projects documenting oral histories highlight youth-led preservation of living traditions. In museums, interns and volunteers assist in cataloguing and guiding visitors, bridging institutions and communities and making heritage accessible and participatory.

Challenges in Youth Participation

Despite these positive trends, several challenges remain. A significant portion of urban youth continues to remain unaware of or disconnected from local cultural traditions, often preferring globalized or commercial entertainment forms. Financial and infrastructural constraints restrict the ability of young enthusiasts to sustain long-term projects, while bureaucratic hurdles in accessing heritage sites and permissions can discourage grassroots work. Heritage is also frequently perceived as elitist, associated with scholars, tourists, or wealthy patrons, which alienates common youth from active participation. Furthermore, urbanization and migration have weakened the transmission of local traditions, dialects, and crafts from one generation to the next. Unless these challenges are systematically addressed, youth engagement in heritage risks becoming sporadic rather than sustained.

Enablers for Deeper Youth Engagement

To strengthen youth involvement, heritage education must be mainstreamed in schools and colleges. While NCERT and NIOS already include cultural chapters, the approach should become more experiential through field visits, oral history projects, and heritage clubs. Technology offers another pathway: the use of augmented reality, virtual tours, gamified apps, and social media campaigns can make heritage attractive and engaging for young audiences. Communities and youth must work together, with elders mentoring students while youth document traditions digitally. Incentives in the form of awards, fellowships, and recognition at cultural festivals will further motivate young contributors. Decentralized participation through Panchayats and municipal cultural boards could institutionalize youth voices in heritage governance. By embedding youth directly into policy frameworks and decision-making bodies, India can transform cultural preservation into a democratic and participatory exercise.

Youth as Stewards of Cultural Democracy

Heritage is not merely about monuments or museums, it is about collective identity. Youth, by becoming stewards of this identity, help democratize heritage beyond narrow definitions. They can ensure inclusivity by amplifying marginalized traditions, regional dialects, and folk practices that are often ignored by mainstream narratives. In doing so, they promote not just preservation but also cultural justice. The act of preservation

	becomes not a backward-looking activity but a forward-looking, transformative project where youth reinterpret the past for the needs of the present and the aspirations of the future.
Conclusion	**Carrying the Torch Forward:** Rabindranath Tagore once wrote that every child carries the message that God is not yet discouraged of man. This idea of renewal applies equally to heritage. India's cultural wealth, from the Rig Vedas to Nagaland's folk songs, from the Ajanta caves to Kutch crafts, is a torch passed through generations, and today's youth are its next bearers. Their role goes beyond preservation, they must reinterpret, innovate, and transmit it in ways that resonate with contemporary society. Initiatives like CHYLP, ZCC festivals, SPIC MACAY, and global platforms such as the UNESCO Young Professionals Forum provide guidance, but the real impact depends on the imagination, creativity, and dedication of young people themselves. The story of students at the ghats of Varanasi exemplifies this spirit: by engaging directly with heritage, they transform it into living memory. In a rapidly changing India, youth participation is both a responsibility and an opportunity, ensuring that the essence of India's cultural legacy thrives for future generations.
Model Question	"With climate change, biodiversity loss, and pollution emerging as defining challenges of the 21st century, the role of youth has become central in shaping sustainable futures. From grassroots movements to global climate strikes, young people are redefining environmental activism and policy debates."
Value Addition	**Cultural Heritage Youth Leadership Programme (CHYLP):** • CHYLP envisaged enriching awareness of Indian culture and heritage amongst the youth in order to promote, understand and develop fondness for India's rich cultural heritage, with a view to develop appropriate leadership qualities amongst youth. • The focus of the programme was to be on less privileged children residing in backward areas by interacting with them in vernacular languages for their better understanding. Intermittently programme was given to Centre for Cultural Resources and Training (CCRT), an autonomous organization working under the purview of Ministry of Culture. CCRT organized workshops for the scheme. • However, to accelerate the process, Museum Division of this Ministry arranged visits of children of unprivileged section of society to museums so that these children may get an opportunity to gain the knowledge relating to the Indian History and Culture and Science.
84. Discuss the emergence of various cultural forms as tools of social mobilization in the Telangana statehood movement. (TGPSC, 2016)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Cultural and Historical aspects
Keyword	Discuss
Approach	• Introduce with the Telangana statehood movement, its historical roots, and the significance of cultural identity in mobilizing support. • Provide context about Telangana's socio-political and cultural marginalization within Andhra Pradesh to explain why cultural assertion became a rallying point. • Highlight the role of traditional art forms like Bathukamma, Oggu Katha, and Lambadi dance in uniting people and conveying political messages. • Discuss the use of Oggu Katha, Burrakatha, and street plays to narrate struggles, raise awareness, and foster collective identity. • Explain how flags, graffiti, posters, and other visual symbols reinforced the movement's messages and created emotional appeal. • Include how youth, student groups, and organizations like Telangana Jagruthi contributed to cultural mobilization and activism.

	• Conclude by showing how cultural forms went beyond expression to become effective tools of social and political mobilization during the movement.
Introduction	The Telangana statehood movement, culminating in the creation of Telangana as India's 29th state on June 2, 2014, was far more than a political struggle, it represented a profound assertion of regional identity, cultural heritage, and social pride. While political leaders and activists played critical roles in steering the movement, the widespread engagement and creativity of the youth proved decisive in shaping its trajectory. Young people across urban and rural areas actively participated in rallies, demonstrations, and cultural events, harnessing folk music, dance, theatre, visual arts, and other cultural expressions to mobilize communities and reinforce a sense of shared identity. Their involvement not only amplified the political message but also rooted it in Telangana's cultural ethos. This essay explores how various cultural forms became instruments of social mobilization, examining key events, symbolic expressions, and the broader impact of youth-led cultural engagement in realizing the demand for statehood.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Historical Context and Cultural Identity** The demand for a separate Telangana state has deep historical roots, tracing back to the post-independence era. The region's distinct linguistic, cultural, and economic identity often felt marginalized within the larger Andhra Pradesh state. The Telangana Rebellion (1946–1951) against feudal landlords and the subsequent integration into Andhra Pradesh without adequate safeguards for regional autonomy laid the groundwork for future movements. Over the decades, cultural identity became a rallying point for those advocating for a separate state, with folk traditions, local narratives, and regional symbols serving both as emblems and tools of resistance. The collective consciousness of the people was shaped not only by political grievances but also by a shared understanding of Telangana's distinct heritage, which became the moral and cultural backbone of the movement. **Cultural Forms as Instruments of Mobilization** Folk music and dance played a vital role in expressing Telangana's identity and mobilizing public support. Traditional art forms such as Bathukamma, Oggu Katha, and Lambadi dance symbolized the region's rich cultural heritage. During protests, rallies, and public gatherings, participants performed songs and dances that narrated local stories and struggles, transforming public spaces into vibrant arenas of cultural assertion. The revival of Bathukamma celebrations, especially during festivals, became a powerful emblem of unity and resistance, with women leading these events, blending cultural pride with political solidarity and reinforcing grassroots engagement. Theatre and street performances, particularly Oggu Katha and Burrakatha, effectively conveyed the movement's messages to both rural and urban audiences. These performances dramatized the challenges faced by Telangana's people, highlighting economic disparity, cultural neglect, and political marginalization. The emotive power of storytelling fostered a shared sense of identity, bridging generational divides and inspiring active community participation in the statehood struggle. Visual arts and symbolism further enhanced the movement's resonance. The pink flag adopted by the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS), featuring a white map of Telangana on a pink background, became a potent symbol of regional pride. Graffiti, posters, and banners with local motifs reinforced these messages visually, transforming public spaces into arenas of civic engagement and asserting Telangana's cultural and political identity. **Telangana Jagruthi and the Cultural Revival** Telangana Jagruthi, founded by K Kavitha in 2006, played a pivotal role in promoting cultural awareness and preserving regional identity during the statehood movement. The organization focused on reviving traditional festivals, arts, and crafts, thereby instilling a

	sense of pride and belonging among the people of Telangana. Through programs and events organized across villages and cities, Telangana Jagruthi enabled youth to engage directly with their heritage, fostering community participation and cultural consciousness. The organization's emphasis on education, cultural immersion, and grassroots mobilization reinforced the link between heritage and political activism, making cultural revival an inseparable component of the movement. **Role of Folk Singers and Writers** Folk singers and writers were instrumental in voicing the aspirations and grievances of Telangana's populace. Artists such as Gaddar (Gummadi Vittal Rao), Guda Anjaiah and others became cultural icons whose songs, poetry, and performances highlighted social injustice, economic neglect, and political marginalization. Their art resonated with rural and urban audiences alike, creating an emotional connection that went beyond political rhetoric. Writers and poets chronicled the historical struggles of the region, contributing to a literary tradition that reinforced Telangana's unique identity. Through their works, folk artists and writers mobilized the masses, offering cultural narratives that complemented the movement's political strategies. **Youth and Digital Media** The youth played a transformative role in the Telangana statehood movement, not only through physical participation but also by leveraging digital platforms to amplify their voices. Social media became a critical arena for mobilization, with campaigns, hashtags, and online petitions reaching audiences across India and abroad. Youth-led initiatives on platforms like Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube disseminated information, organized events, and countered misinformation. Student organizations, such as the Telangana Students Federation (TSF), orchestrated flash mobs, digital awareness drives, and campaigns that connected rural and urban populations, making digital activism a powerful complement to traditional cultural forms. These efforts facilitated a wider understanding of the movement and encouraged national and international engagement. **Institutional Support and Cultural Promotion** Institutional initiatives were essential in sustaining the movement's cultural momentum. The establishment of the Telangana State Cultural Council provided formal platforms for the preservation and promotion of folk arts, crafts, and festivals. Government recognition of Bathukamma as the state festival symbolized both cultural pride and political acknowledgment. Educational institutions also played a significant role, incorporating Telangana's history, language, and culture into their curricula and organizing cultural festivals to showcase traditional arts. These initiatives offered youth avenues to actively participate in heritage preservation, further intertwining culture with political activism. **Challenges and Criticisms** Despite the successes of cultural mobilization, the use of cultural forms in the Telangana movement was not without challenges. The politicization of cultural festivals, such as Bathukamma, occasionally drew criticism for potentially overshadowing their traditional significance. Additionally, some argued that an excessive focus on cultural identity might divert attention from pressing socio-economic issues in the newly formed state. Critics emphasized the importance of balancing cultural assertion with inclusive governance and sustainable development, ensuring that heritage promotion complemented rather than replaced substantive policy action.
Conclusion	The Telangana statehood movement demonstrates how cultural forms can transcend traditional boundaries to become powerful instruments of social mobilization. Through

	folk music, dance, theatre, visual arts, and digital media, the people of Telangana articulated their identity, highlighted regional challenges, and mobilized support for statehood. Organizations like Telangana Jagruthi, along with folk singers and writers, nurtured a cultural renaissance that strengthened the movement's emotional and social appeal. The active participation of youth, coupled with institutional support, ensured that the struggle became a fusion of politics and culture. The formation of Telangana on June 2, 2014, marked the culmination of decades of activism, and today, the state continues to thrive culturally, socially, and economically, celebrating its heritage while pursuing progressive governance and development.
Model Question	"Discuss the journey of Telangana since its formation in 2014, emphasizing the state's achievements in governance, economic growth, education, and cultural preservation. How have these developments impacted the lives of its people?"
Value Addition	**Telangana History & Culture:** **Legacy of Dynasties and Cultural Heritage:** • Telangana, India's youngest state, was formed on June 2, 2014, after its separation from Andhra Pradesh. The region has a rich history dating back to the Satavahanas, Kakatiyas, and Qutb Shahis, who left remarkable architectural and cultural legacies. Hyderabad, the capital, showcases a blend of Persian, Mughal, and Telugu influences, evident in landmarks like Charminar and Golconda Fort. The state's culture thrives through vibrant festivals like Bathukamma and Bonalu, celebrating its deep-rooted traditions. Telangana's heritage is also reflected in its unique cuisine, arts, and handlooms, such as Pochampally Ikat and Gadwal sarees. **Festivals and Traditions:** • Vibrant festivals like Bathukamma celebrate womanhood with floral arrangements and folk songs. Bonalu, dedicated to Goddess Mahakali, showcases Telangana's spiritual essence. Sammakka Saralamma Jatara is one of India's biggest tribal festivals. Ugadi marks the Telugu New Year with cultural festivities. Traditional art forms like Perini Sivathandavam and Oggu Katha reflect Telangana's deep-rooted traditions.
(vi) Issues related to Civic Awareness	
85. Obesity is a silent pandemic undermining India's public health gains. (APPSC, 2025)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Issues related to Civic Awareness
Approach	• Introduce obesity as a growing public health concern in urban and rural India. • Provide statistics showing rising obesity prevalence across age groups. • Explain health consequences: diabetes, cardiovascular diseases, and reduced productivity. • Identify contributing factors like sedentary lifestyle, processed food, and Urbanisation. • Discuss the economic and social burden on the healthcare system. • Mention government initiatives such as the Fit India Movement and the National Nutrition Mission. • Suggest preventive measures like awareness, healthy diet, physical activity, and school programs. • Conclude that addressing obesity is crucial to sustain India's public health gains.
Introduction	Obesity has emerged as a silent pandemic in India, quietly undermining decades of public health gains achieved through interventions against communicable diseases, malnutrition, and maternal-child health issues. Traditionally, India grappled with undernutrition and infectious diseases, but rapid urbanisation, sedentary lifestyles, and nutritional transition have given rise to a new health crisis. According to NFHS-5 (2019–

	21), about 24% of women and 23% of men aged 15–49 are overweight or obese. The World Health Organisation (WHO) classifies obesity as a global epidemic, linking it to chronic non-communicable diseases such as type 2 diabetes, hypertension, cardiovascular disorders, and certain cancers. In a country already burdened with a dual health challenge of undernutrition and overnutrition, obesity represents a hidden threat that erodes both individual health and broader public health achievements. Unlike infectious diseases that attract immediate attention, obesity develops silently over the years, making early detection and prevention critical for sustaining India's health gains.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Epidemiological Trends and Demographics of obesity** Obesity in India exhibits significant demographic variation, influenced by socio-economic status, urbanisation, and lifestyle patterns. Urban populations display higher prevalence due to sedentary jobs, motorised transport, and exposure to high-calorie processed foods. NFHS-5 data reveal that in metropolitan cities such as Delhi, Mumbai, and Bengaluru, nearly one-fourth of adults are overweight or obese. Moreover, childhood obesity is rising alarmingly; a 2020 study in the 'Indian Journal of Paediatrics' reported that 14% of school-going children in urban India were overweight or obese. The coexistence of childhood obesity alongside childhood undernutrition highlights India's complex "double burden of malnutrition," posing serious long-term threats to health systems and economic productivity. **Health and Socioeconomic Consequences related to obesity** Obesity undermines public health by increasing the risk of chronic diseases and healthcare expenditures. Studies show that obese individuals have a 3–5 times higher risk of developing type 2 diabetes, hypertension, and heart disease. The economic burden is staggering; A projection published in early 2025 by 'The Times of India' cited estimates that India's obesity burden could swell to ₹6.7 lakh crore per year by 2030, accounting for hospitalisations, medications, and productivity loss. Socially, obesity contributes to stigma, low self-esteem, and reduced workforce participation. Empirical evidence from the International Journal of Obesity indicates that children with obesity often experience academic challenges and social exclusion, further compounding long-term health inequities. Thus, the silent progression of obesity threatens not only individual well-being but also undermines public health infrastructure, eroding previous gains in life expectancy, maternal-child health, and disease prevention. **Contributing Factors for obesity** Multiple interlinked factors contribute to the obesity pandemic in India. Urbanisation has transformed dietary patterns, leading to increased consumption of energy-dense, nutrient-poor processed foods, sugary beverages, and fast foods. Sedentary lifestyles, driven by office work, digital entertainment, and reduced physical activity in urban settings, exacerbate the problem. Cultural factors also play a role; traditional high-calorie diets combined with reduced physical exertion in middle-class households contribute to weight gain. Additionally, socio-economic transitions, including rising disposable incomes and globalisation of food chains, have increased access to unhealthy foods even in semi-urban areas. A 2021 study in BMC Public Health highlighted that genetic predisposition interacts with lifestyle factors, creating population subgroups highly susceptible to obesity and metabolic disorders. **Government Initiatives and Policy Responses** Recognising the growing threat, the Government of India has introduced several initiatives to combat obesity and promote healthy lifestyles. The National Programme for Prevention and Control of Cancer, Diabetes, Cardiovascular Diseases and Stroke (NPCDCS) focus on early screening, awareness campaigns, and lifestyle interventions.

	The Fit India Movement, launched in 2019, encourages physical activity, sports participation, and healthy dietary practices among citizens. School-based programs under the Rashtriya Bal Swasthya Karyakram (RBSK) promote monitoring of children's BMI and nutrition counselling. Additionally, public health campaigns emphasise reducing sugar intake, promoting traditional diets rich in fibre, and increasing physical activity. Despite these efforts, implementation remains fragmented, and urban-rural disparities persist, highlighting the need for a coordinated, multi-sectoral response to prevent obesity from undermining public health gains. **Preventive Measures and Community Engagement** Addressing obesity requires both individual and systemic interventions. Health education campaigns targeting schools, workplaces, and communities can promote awareness of healthy diets, regular exercise, and lifestyle modifications. Evidence from Kerala's "Nourish Kerala" program shows that community-driven initiatives integrating yoga, traditional diets, and physical activity reduced obesity prevalence among schoolchildren by 8% over five years. Workplace wellness programs, regulation of junk food advertising, and taxation of sugar-sweetened beverages are additional measures with proven effectiveness globally. Furthermore, urban planning promoting walkable neighbourhoods, public parks, and cycling infrastructure can reduce sedentary behaviours. Prevention-focused strategies are particularly important because treatment of obesity-related conditions imposes a substantial economic and health burden on the public health system. **Global Comparisons and Lessons for India** Globally, countries such as the USA, Mexico, and the UK have experienced similar obesity epidemics and offer lessons for India. Mexico's taxation on sugar-sweetened beverages led to a 7.6% reduction in consumption over two years, demonstrating the effectiveness of fiscal measures. The USA's school nutrition programs and community exercise initiatives have contributed to stabilising childhood obesity rates. India can adapt these strategies within its socio-cultural context, emphasising culturally acceptable diets, affordable access to healthy foods, and community engagement. International evidence underscores that obesity control requires multi-dimensional interventions combining policy, education, urban planning, and healthcare infrastructure.
Conclusion	Obesity, as a silent pandemic, poses a formidable challenge to India's public health achievements, threatening to reverse gains made in combating malnutrition, infectious diseases, and maternal-child health. With rising prevalence across age groups, urban-rural disparities, and increasing childhood obesity, it is evident that urgent action is required. Multifaceted strategies involving government policy, community engagement, lifestyle modification, and public awareness are essential to address the crisis. Empirical evidence from India and abroad shows that early intervention, education, and systemic measures can significantly reduce the burden of obesity. To safeguard India's public health gains and ensure sustainable health outcomes, combating obesity must become a national priority, integrating preventive, curative, and policy-driven approaches. As stated, "Obesity is preventable and controllable if addressed early and collectively," emphasising the need for immediate and coordinated action in India.
Model Question	"Fiscal policy is an underused tool in India's fight against obesity."
Value Addition	Body Mass Index (BMI), previously known as the Quetelet index, is a simple way to check if an adult has a healthy weight. It is calculated by dividing a person's weight in kilograms by their height in meters squared (kg/m²). To find BMI, take a person's weight (kg) and divide it by their height (m) squared. A normal BMI falls between 18.5 and 24.9, based on the World Health Organisation (WHO) guidelines.

86. With advent of new technologies every year the need for human touch keeps descending. New technologies have surely made life easier, but is this taking us away from our basic necessities to maintain personal - physical relations without fellow human beings? (APPSC, 2011)

Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Issues related to Civic Awareness
Approach	• Introduction with a real-life example illustrating the paradox between technological convenience and emotional isolation. • Explain how rapid technological advancements impact human touch and interpersonal relationships. • Discuss recent innovations (2024–25) in AI, telemedicine, online learning, and remote work that influence social interaction. • Analyze evidence on loneliness, mental health, and changing social behavior due to digital dependence. • Highlight examples where technology augments rather than replaces human connection (education, healthcare). • Suggest strategies and policies to preserve empathy, physical connection, and dignity amid digital growth. • Conclude with a balanced perspective emphasizing intentional use of technology to enhance, not erode, human relationships.
Introduction	In early 2024, a viral story emerged of an elderly woman in Bengaluru who relied on a home-assistant robot for companionship. While the device reminded her to take medicines and played her favorite music, she confessed that what she missed most was "a real conversation, a warm hug." This simple yet profound sentiment reflects a growing paradox of our times, as technology becomes smarter and more efficient, human relationships often grow more distant. With the advent of artificial intelligence, social media, telemedicine, and virtual learning, our lives have undoubtedly become easier and more connected. Yet, beneath this digital convenience lies a deeper question: are we gradually losing the human touch such as the empathy, warmth, and physical connection that have always been the foundation of our shared humanity?
Body & Infographic Representation	**Has technology eroded the human touch?** **Technology's many faces: convenience, reach and substitution** Technology has expanded human capabilities in clear and measurable ways. Digital infrastructure and the growth of India's digital economy have raised access to services, information and commerce, contributing to national GDP and widening inclusion in previously underserved areas. Government programmes and private platforms have pushed telemedicine, online education, digital justice tools and AI-powered public services into everyday life, particularly since the pandemic accelerated adoption. These developments demonstrate that technology often substitutes for distance, time and scarcity of human experts rather than deliberately replacing social bonds. **Developments in 2024–25 that matter for human relations** Recent years have seen several trendlines that directly affect interpersonal contact. First, remote work and hybrid workplaces have become widespread; Various Surveys document falling engagement among remote workers relative to on-site staff, illustrating a potential weakening of workplace social capital. Second, telemedicine and digital health (eSanjeevani and local telehealth centres) expanded aggressively, improving access but changing the texture of doctor–patient interactions from in-person to screen-mediated encounters. Third, generative AI and conversational agents moved into everyday use (legal help, counseling prototypes and automated customer service), enabling many tasks that previously required face-to-face effort. Fourth, social robots and proposals for robot-assisted eldercare and childcare have gained attention in

research and media, raising normative questions about emotional substitution. These concrete developments show technology's dual character: it reduces friction and increases reach while altering contexts where human contact traditionally happens.

Evidence on social impact: loneliness, engagement and mental health

A growing research literature links technology use with mixed effects on loneliness, mental health and social integration. While digital connectivity can reduce isolation for many, by connecting dispersed families or enabling telecare, heavy reliance on mediated communication correlates with increased loneliness and poorer mental health outcomes for some groups. Social isolation (objective lack of social contact) and loneliness (subjective feeling of being alone) are distinct; evidence suggests that digital interactions may alleviate isolation but not always the subjective depth of companionship that face-to-face interaction delivers. Public-health and psychological studies emphasize that long-term reductions in embodied social contact have measurable negative consequences for both mental and physical health.

Where technology augments rather than replaces humane contact

Not all technological change displaces human touch. In education, NCERT and other Indian institutions have promoted digital modules and guidelines (PRAGYATA, curricular updates) to supplement classroom learning, often with the explicit aim of preserving teacher-student relationships while widening access. Open schooling (NIOS) and blended learning have enabled learners excluded from conventional schooling to remain connected to mentors and peers. Similarly, telemedicine initiatives are increasingly designed as hybrid systems: triage and follow-up are remote, while serious diagnostics and therapeutics still demand physical encounters. In many caregiving contexts, technology functions as a force-multiplier, enabling scarce human caregivers to reach more people rather than substituting for emotional presence.

Risks of over-reliance: commodification and attenuation of empathy

Despite augmentative uses, certain trends risk commodifying human interaction. Automated customer-service agents, AI "companions", and algorithm-driven social feeds can optimize engagement metrics without cultivating empathy, accountability or deep understanding. Workplace data show falling engagement among remote staff, suggesting that routine social rituals (casual conversations, spontaneous problem-solving, physical proximity) play a role in motivation and belonging, aspects technology alone struggles to replicate. Moreover, when caregiving is delegated to robots or fully virtual interfaces, the subtleties of touch, tone, and shared presence that support emotional resilience can be attenuated. These risks do not mean technology is inherently dehumanizing; rather, the design incentives and institutional choices around deployment determine outcomes.

Policy and educational responses: safeguarding human connection

Recognizing these tradeoffs, public bodies and educators in India and globally have begun to emphasize hybrid approaches and digital literacy that include ethical and social skills. NCERT modules and national guidelines for digital education stress critical thinking about media and the social uses of technology, aiming to prepare students to use digital tools without becoming socially numbed. Public health and telemedicine policies increasingly recommend blended-care pathways, data privacy protections and community outreach to mitigate the isolating effects of purely digital care. At the organisational level, on-site or hybrid work policies that prioritize structured social interaction (team check-ins, mentorship and 'watercooler' time) are gaining traction to protect engagement.

Practical measures to restore and preserve human touch

	To restore and preserve the human touch in an increasingly digital world, several practical measures can be implemented. Firstly, designing for hybridity is essential, systems must combine digital convenience with regular in-person interactions. For instance, blended schooling models and telemedicine services complemented by periodic physical consultations can ensure that the warmth of personal connection is not lost amid technological efficiency. Secondly, it is important to build "presence" into digital interfaces by training professionals to communicate with empathy and attentiveness in online environments. Longer video consultations, active listening, and explicit emotional check-ins can humanize virtual interactions, making them more compassionate and effective. Equally significant is the effort to preserve unstructured social time in both physical and virtual spaces. Institutions and organizations should protect informal interactions such as casual conversations, mentorship sessions, or virtual coffee breaks, opportunities that nurture creativity, trust, and belonging. Moreover, digital literacy and emotional education must become integral components of school curricula. Teaching children how to balance screen time, cultivate empathy, and build offline friendships will help them grow into socially grounded individuals despite technological ubiquity. Finally, policymakers should focus on regulating technology to uphold dignity, ensuring that automation is used to relieve drudgery and repetitive tasks rather than replacing roles requiring empathy, care, and human connection. Together, these measures encourage a future where technology enhances human flourishing without displacing the authentic relationships that define our shared humanity.
Conclusion	In the present day, technology continues to redefine every sphere of human life, from remote work and AI-assisted learning to telemedicine and digital governance. Recent developments such as India's eSanjeevani telehealth expansion, the National Digital Education Mission, and the rise of AI companions highlight both the potential and the pitfalls of digital transformation. While these tools improve accessibility and efficiency, over-reliance risks weakening face-to-face bonds, empathy, and community engagement. The way forward lies in intentional integration, designing hybrid systems that blend virtual efficiency with personal interaction, strengthening digital ethics education, and regulating automation to protect human dignity. By prioritizing empathy, inclusion, and accountability, technology can evolve as a means to deepen, not diminish, our shared humanity and collective well-being.
Model Question	"Artificial Intelligence (AI) models such as ChatGPT, Perplexity AI, and Copilot are increasingly being integrated into classrooms, research, and assessment systems. Critically examine their influence on the Indian education system. Suggest measures to ensure that AI integration enhances critical thinking, inclusivity, and human creativity rather than undermining them."
Value Addition	**The Impact of Digital Technologies:** • Digital technologies have advanced more rapidly than any innovation in our history – reaching around 50% of the developing world's population in only two decades and transforming societies. • In the health sector, for instance, AI-enabled frontier technologies are helping to save lives, diagnose diseases and extend life expectancy. In education, virtual learning environments and distance learning have opened up programmes to students who would otherwise be excluded. • Public services are also becoming more accessible and accountable through blockchain-powered systems, and less bureaucratically burdensome as a result of AI assistance. Big data can also support more responsive and accurate policies and programmes.

	• However, those yet to be connected remain cut off from the benefits of this new era and remain further behind. Many of the people left behind are women, the elderly, persons with disabilities or from ethnic or linguistic minorities, indigenous groups and residents of poor or remote areas. • For example, globally, the proportion of women using the internet is 12% lower than that of men. While this gap narrowed in most regions between 2013 and 2017, it widened in the least developed countries from 30 per cent to 33 per cent.
(vii) Reflective Topics	
87. Motivation may be understood as the set of forces that cause people to behave in certain ways. Elucidate the above statement and describe the importance of motivation and the need for a motivated employee in any organisation. (TGPSC, 2024)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Reflective Topics
Keyword	Elucidate
Approach	• Define motivation as internal and external forces driving human behaviour towards goal achievement (e.g., Robbins' definition). • Explain that motivation directs, energises, and sustains employee actions. • Interpret the "set of forces" as psychological, social, and organisational factors influencing behaviour. • Mention motivational theories like Maslow's hierarchy, Herzberg's two-factor, or McGregor's Theory X & Y to show conceptual clarity. • Highlight how motivation enhances productivity, creativity, job satisfaction, and goal alignment. • Explain that motivated employees reduce absenteeism, improve teamwork, and foster organisational growth. • Cite examples like ISRO scientists' intrinsic motivation or corporate incentive systems improving performance. • Conclude that motivation is the psychological engine of organisational success, essential for efficiency and innovation.
Introduction	Motivation is one of the most vital psychological forces that governs human behaviour, especially in organisational contexts where performance and productivity depend not only on technical skills but also on inner drive. The statement, "Motivation may be understood as the set of forces that cause people to behave in certain ways," reflects the idea that motivation is the invisible energy that directs, sustains, and regulates human actions toward achieving specific goals. In the realm of management and public administration, motivation is not merely an abstract concept but a decisive factor determining the efficiency of human resources. As Stephen Robbins defines, "Motivation is the willingness to exert high levels of effort toward organisational goals, conditioned by the effort's ability to satisfy some individual need." Thus, the role of motivation is central to bridging the gap between potential and performance.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Understanding the Concept of Motivation** Motivation is derived from the Latin word "movere", meaning "to move." It represents the psychological process that initiates, guides, and maintains goal-oriented behaviour. Within organisations, it encompasses both intrinsic and extrinsic factors that influence employee performance. Intrinsic motivation arises from internal satisfaction, such as recognition, self-growth, or the joy of achievement, whereas extrinsic motivation is driven by external rewards like salary, promotions, or incentives. Motivation is, therefore, a composite of needs, goals, attitudes, and environmental influences that together determine how people behave in a given setting.

In the organisational framework, motivation is dynamic rather than static; it changes with situations, time, and the individual's aspirations. The renowned psychologist Abraham Maslow, in his Hierarchy of Needs Theory, arranged human needs in five ascending levels. They are physiological, safety, social, esteem, and self-actualisation, suggesting that once lower needs are satisfied, and higher needs emerge as motivators. Similarly, Frederick Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory distinguished between hygiene factors (salary, work conditions, supervision) and motivators (achievement, recognition, responsibility), asserting that true satisfaction comes from motivators, not merely the removal of dissatisfaction. These theories underline that motivation is not a one-dimensional force but a complex psychological mechanism that explains why employees behave differently under similar circumstances.

Elucidating the Statement

The statement that motivation is a "set of forces that cause people to behave in certain ways" implies that human behaviour at work is neither random nor purely mechanical but a response to various internal and external stimuli. These "forces" may include biological drives, emotional impulses, social aspirations, and organisational conditions. In a corporate or administrative context, this means that employees work efficiently not simply because they must, but because they are moved to do so by factors that align personal satisfaction with institutional goals.

For instance, when a civil servant dedicates long hours to implementing welfare schemes effectively, it is not merely due to bureaucratic duty but due to intrinsic motivation, a sense of public service, recognition, or commitment to social transformation. Conversely, when employees feel disengaged, underappreciated, or unfairly treated, their motivation declines, resulting in absenteeism, reduced productivity, or resistance to organisational change. Therefore, the behavioural outcomes within an organisation, diligence, creativity, loyalty, or indifference, are reflections of motivational forces operating within individuals.

The Importance of Motivation in an Organisation

Motivation forms the foundation of organisational success. It acts as the catalyst that converts individual capacity into purposeful performance. A motivated workforce not only achieves higher productivity but also fosters innovation, cooperation, and resilience in the face of challenges. In today's competitive and knowledge-driven economy, where human capital is the prime asset, motivation has become a strategic necessity.

Empirical evidence supports this view. According to a Gallup Global Workplace Report (2023), organisations with highly motivated employees report 21% higher profitability and 17% greater productivity than those with disengaged staff. Similarly, a McKinsey & Company survey found that employees who feel recognised are five times more likely to stay longer with their organisation, highlighting the motivational power of non-monetary appreciation. In the Indian context, companies such as Infosys and the Tata Group have institutionalised motivational practices, including skill development, transparent appraisals, and employee wellness initiatives, to sustain morale and loyalty.

Moreover, motivation enhances job satisfaction, which is directly linked to reduced turnover and better mental health. In public organisations, such as government departments, a motivated officer displays higher accountability, commitment, and ethical performance. For example, the success of the Swachh Bharat Mission and Digital India campaigns depended largely on the motivation of district-level officers and local staff who transformed policy into action through enthusiasm and ownership.

The Need for a Motivated Employee in Any Organisation

A motivated employee is the cornerstone of any effective organisation. The complexity of modern workplaces is driven by technology, competition, and stakeholder expectations, which demand employees who are not just skilled but also inspired. Motivation nurtures creativity and innovation, enabling workers to propose new solutions, adapt to change, and exceed set standards. In contrast, lack of motivation leads to what organisational psychologists term "presenteeism", being physically present but mentally disengaged.

From a managerial perspective, motivated employees require less supervision, display higher self-discipline, and align personal ambitions with organisational missions. For instance, in public sector enterprises, motivated employees can reduce inefficiencies and improve service delivery, aligning with citizen-centric governance. Similarly, in private firms, motivation boosts customer satisfaction and organisational reputation.

In the age of automation and artificial intelligence, where repetitive tasks are increasingly mechanised, motivation is what differentiates human contribution through empathy, innovation, and judgment. In service sectors such as healthcare, education, and administration, motivation determines the quality of human interaction and social outcomes. The World Economic Forum (2023) observed that "soft skills" such as emotional intelligence, resilience, and motivation are among the top future competencies needed to sustain employability in the Fourth Industrial Revolution.

Theoretical and Practical Dimensions of Motivation

Motivation operates both as a psychological construct and as a managerial tool. Theoretically, it explains human behaviour in terms of need fulfilment, reinforcement, and expectancy. Vroom's Expectancy Theory, for instance, posits that motivation depends on three variables like expectancy (belief that effort leads to performance), instrumentality (belief that performance leads to reward), and valence (value of reward). Practically, managers translate these insights into performance-linked incentives, participatory decision-making, recognition systems, and supportive work environments. Public administration theorists such as Chester Barnard and Douglas McGregor emphasised motivation as the essence of organisational effectiveness. McGregor's Theory X and Theory Y proposed two contrasting views of human nature: while Theory X assumes workers are inherently lazy and need control, Theory Y sees them as self-motivated and creative if given autonomy. Modern management increasingly adopts Theory Y, creating environments that encourage initiative and self-direction.

Challenges in Maintaining Motivation

Despite its importance, sustaining motivation in organisations poses several challenges. Bureaucratic rigidity, lack of recognition, inequitable rewards, and poor leadership can demoralise employees. In the public sector, red tape and limited career mobility often dampen enthusiasm. Similarly, in private firms, excessive workload, job insecurity, and a mismatch between personal goals and organisational vision can lead to burnout. Therefore, leadership plays a critical role in creating a culture of trust, fairness, and purpose, which are the psychological roots of motivation.

Contemporary Relevance of Motivation

In the post-pandemic era, motivation has assumed renewed significance. Remote work, digital fatigue, and organisational restructuring have redefined what motivates employees. Modern workplaces are increasingly focusing on purpose-driven motivation, aligning employees' personal values with social and environmental goals. Companies like Google and Infosys have pioneered initiatives such as flexible work models, mental health support, and community engagement programs that sustain long-term motivation beyond monetary incentives.

	For government employees, the challenge is to blend administrative motivation with ethical commitment. Civil servants motivated by ideals of integrity and service delivery play a transformative role in inclusive governance. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission (2008) recommended performance-based incentives and citizen feedback systems to boost motivation in public administration, a reform still pertinent today.
Conclusion	In conclusion, motivation is the driving force that determines why individuals act, how intensely they act, and how long they sustain their efforts. It represents the set of psychological and social forces that channel human behaviour toward organisational objectives. The importance of motivation lies in its capacity to convert potential into performance, skill into service, and duty into dedication. A motivated employee is not merely a productive worker but a catalyst of organisational excellence, creativity, and ethical growth. As management thinker Peter Drucker observed, "The task of management is to make people capable of joint performance, to make their strengths effective and their weaknesses irrelevant." This capability can only be realised through motivation is the invisible thread that connects human aspiration to organisational achievement and transforms collective effort into enduring success.
Model Question	Explain how motivation acts as a driving force influencing human behaviour within organisations. Discuss its significance in enhancing employee performance and organisational effectiveness.
Value Addition	**Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory**: It suggests that certain factors (motivators) lead to job satisfaction and motivation (e.g., achievement, recognition), while others (hygiene factors) prevent dissatisfaction but don't necessarily motivate (e.g., salary, working conditions).
88. Beauty is truth, truth is beauty. (APPSC, 2023)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Reflective Topics
Approach	• Introduce with Keats' poetic context and interpret the quote as a philosophical union of aesthetics and ethics. • Explain the interdependence of truth and beauty, showing how each gives meaning to the other. • Integrate perspectives from Plato, Indian thought (Satyam, Shivam, Sundaram), and Kant to establish universality. • Illustrate through art, literature, science, and ethics how truth manifests as beauty and vice versa. • Establish contemporary relevance by Linking with modern issues such as consumerism, post-truth society, environmental ethics, and governance. • Conclude by reaffirming Keats's message as a timeless moral and aesthetic compass for human life.
Introduction	John Keats, the Romantic poet, concluded his timeless poem Ode on a Grecian Urn with the profound lines: "Beauty is truth, truth beauty,- that is all / Ye know on earth, and all ye need to know." This succinct expression captures a deep philosophical insight, that beauty and truth are not two separate entities but rather two sides of the same reality. What is truly beautiful must be true, and what is genuinely true carries an intrinsic beauty. These words transcend the boundaries of art and poetry, offering reflections that reach into philosophy, science, morality, and human existence itself. In an era of superficial appearances and post-truth narratives, this quote reminds humanity of the harmony between appearance and essence, aesthetics and ethics, feeling and reason.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The Meaning and Essence of the Quote** At its core, the quote proposes that truth and beauty are deeply intertwined, forming an inseparable unity that defines the highest form of human experience. Beauty appeals to

the heart and senses; truth appeals to the mind and moral conscience. Keats's insight lies in uniting the two: a thing of beauty is enduring only when it expresses a deeper truth, and truth becomes compelling and transformative when expressed beautifully. This synthesis bridges the emotional and the intellectual, showing that aesthetic pleasure and moral virtue are not opposites but harmonious companions in the quest for understanding life and the universe.

Philosophical Interpretations

Philosophers across time have attempted to explore the relationship between truth and beauty. Plato, in his theory of forms, viewed beauty as a visible reflection of truth and goodness. For him, the contemplation of beauty elevates the soul toward the ultimate reality, the Form of the Good. In Indian philosophy too, this unity finds expression in the triad Satyam, Shivam, Sundaram - truth, godliness, and beauty, suggesting that the beautiful and the truthful are divine attributes of the same cosmic order. Even Immanuel Kant, in his Critique of Judgment, viewed beauty as the harmonious correspondence between the mind and nature, implying that beauty reflects a deeper rational order, a form of truth experienced through perception. Across civilizations and centuries, thinkers have recognized that the perception of beauty often leads to the realization of truth.

Beauty as a Pathway to Truth

Beauty often serves as a bridge that leads the human spirit toward truth. A work of art, a musical composition, or a scene in nature might not reveal facts, yet it evokes emotional and moral truths about human experience, suffering, and transcendence. When one gazes at the serene symmetry of a flower, the grandeur of a sunset, or the vastness of the night sky, one senses an underlying order, a harmony that reflects the laws of nature and the beauty of existence itself. Scientists too have acknowledged that their pursuit of knowledge is often guided by an aesthetic intuition. The elegance of Einstein's equations or the symmetry of DNA's double helix suggests that beauty is a signpost of truth. Thus, beauty is not an escape from reality but a mode of perceiving its hidden coherence and meaning.

Truth as the Foundation of Beauty

Conversely, truth lends authenticity and depth to beauty. In a world overwhelmed by superficial appearances, artificial glamour, and digital manipulation, beauty that is divorced from truth becomes hollow and deceptive. The glow of genuine beauty lies in honesty, integrity, and naturalness. A person's moral integrity and inner kindness are far more beautiful than any cosmetic enhancement. Similarly, an artwork or a poem endures not because of ornamental charm but because it captures emotional or moral truth. The Ajanta paintings, the sculptures of Khajuraho, or Gandhi's simple life of truth and non-violence all exemplify how truth imbues beauty with lasting resonance. Without truth, beauty degenerates into illusion; with truth, it becomes eternal.

Truth and Beauty in Art and Literature

Art and literature are perhaps the most visible realms where truth and beauty coexist. Great works of art have survived not because they were visually pleasing alone, but because they revealed something profoundly true about the human condition. Shakespeare's tragedies portray the beauty of human emotion while revealing the truths of ambition, love, and moral frailty. Leonardo da Vinci's Mona Lisa captivates us not merely through technique but through its enigmatic expression, a truth about the mystery of human emotion. Rabindranath Tagore's poetry weaves divine truth and lyrical beauty into one seamless thread, reminding us that life's ultimate beauty lies in spiritual realization. When art becomes propaganda, divorced from truth, it loses its soul. When art serves truth, it achieves immortality.

	Moral and Ethical Dimensions The unity of beauty and truth also has profound moral implications. A truthful life is a beautiful life. An honest person radiates an inner beauty that no external adornment can match. In contrast, falsehood and deceit, however attractively presented, eventually reveal ugliness. At the societal level, a just and transparent system possesses moral beauty. The Constitution of India, with its emphasis on equality and justice, represents a beautiful embodiment of truth in social form. When governance upholds truth and integrity, it reflects an aesthetic order of harmony and trust. Beauty without truth leads to hypocrisy and corruption; truth without beauty becomes rigid and harsh. The ethical ideal lies in integrating both, sincerity in principle and grace in conduct. **Scientific and Rational Dimensions** Even in science, truth and beauty converge in surprising ways. Scientists often describe theories as beautiful when they display simplicity, symmetry, and coherence. The most successful scientific laws, Newton's laws of motion, Einstein's theory of relativity, and Schrödinger's equation, are admired for their elegance as much as their explanatory power. This aesthetic instinct drives scientific discovery, showing that the human mind recognizes beauty as a reflection of universal truth. The beauty of a mathematical proof or a scientific model lies in its truthful representation of nature's order. Thus, science and art, reason and imagination, are united by the same human longing to perceive the beautiful truth of existence. **Relevance in the Contemporary World** In the modern age, Keats's insight carries renewed urgency. We live in a world of curated realities, consumerism, and misinformation. The digital era promotes instant beauty, edited images, viral trends, and visual perfection, but often at the cost of authenticity. Similarly, truth itself is under siege in a climate of fake news and post-truth politics. To reclaim the harmony of beauty and truth is to rediscover authenticity. In education, it calls for nurturing not only intellect but also aesthetic and moral sensibility. In governance, it demands transparency and ethical conduct. In environmental ethics, it reminds us that the beauty of the earth can only be preserved through the truth of sustainable living. True progress, therefore, lies in harmonizing scientific truth with aesthetic and moral beauty. **Critiques and Reflections** While Keats's assertion is celebrated for its poetic idealism, not all thinkers have agreed with it unconditionally. Nietzsche argued that sometimes illusion is essential for life, that raw truth could be unbearable without the mask of beauty. Postmodern philosophers also question the universality of truth and beauty, suggesting that both are culturally constructed and subjective. Yet, even these critiques affirm the vitality of Keats's vision. The constant dialogue between illusion and truth, between subjective beauty and objective fact, sustains the evolution of human understanding. The tension itself becomes beautiful, revealing that truth and beauty are not static concepts but dynamic pursuits.
Conclusion	"Beauty is truth, truth is beauty" is not merely a poetic line but a timeless insight into the unity of existence. Keats teaches that life's highest fulfillment lies in reconciling the real and the ideal, the factual and the emotional, the rational and the aesthetic. To live truthfully is to live beautifully; to perceive beauty is to recognize truth. In a fragmented world torn between materialism and moral ambiguity, this thought offers a compass for individuals and societies alike. Whether in science, art, politics, or personal conduct, the harmony of truth and beauty forms the foundation of human civilization. Indeed, as Keats reminds us, that is "all we know on earth, and all we need to know."

Model Question	"Not everything that is faced can be changed, but nothing can be changed until it is faced."
Value Addition	The quote, **"Not everything that is faced can be changed, but nothing can be changed until it is faced,"** emphasizes the power of courage and awareness in confronting life's challenges. It reminds us that while some realities may resist transformation, meaningful progress begins only when we acknowledge and address them. In the Indian context, social reformers like Mahatma Gandhi, B.R. Ambedkar, and Periyar exemplified this truth by confronting injustice, discrimination, and inequality head-on. Whether it is corruption, gender bias, or environmental degradation, ignoring problems perpetuates them, while facing them sparks dialogue and change. Thus, the quote inspires individuals and societies to embrace moral responsibility, resilience, and action as the first steps toward lasting transformation.
89. Civic Sense and Public Spaces: An Urgent Need to Behave Responsibly (APPSC, 2020)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Reflective Topics
Approach	• Introduce with the idea of civic sense and link it to responsible citizenship and quality of public life in India. • Explain why civic sense is vital for democracy, urban governance, and social harmony. • Analyze causes of poor civic behavior - weak civic education, lack of accountability, and social apathy. • Discuss how civic irresponsibility affects public spaces, environment, governance, and collective dignity. • Emphasize education, participatory governance, enforcement, community ownership, and ethical leadership. • Conclude by reaffirming civic sense as a moral and constitutional duty essential for a clean, inclusive, and responsible India.
Introduction	The quality of a nation's civilization is often judged not by its economic progress alone, but by the civic behavior of its citizens in public spaces. Civic sense, the awareness of one's duties, rights, and responsibilities towards society forms the backbone of collective living. Public spaces, whether roads, parks, markets, railways, or offices, are reflections of this civic consciousness. Unfortunately, in India, the disregard for civic responsibility is visible everywhere, littered streets, reckless driving, vandalized property, and a general apathy toward public amenities. The growing urbanization and population pressures have made civic sense not just a matter of etiquette but a pressing national necessity. The call to behave responsibly in public spaces is, therefore, not a moral plea but a prerequisite for sustainable urban and social development.
Body & Infographic Representation	**Understanding Civic Sense and Its Significance** Civic sense refers to the behavioral norms that enable individuals to live harmoniously within society. It includes respect for laws, concern for public property, regard for others' rights, and sensitivity toward the environment. It is rooted in the values of empathy, discipline, and collective responsibility. In a democracy like India, where freedom is constitutionally guaranteed, civic sense ensures that individual liberty does not become social chaos. When citizens exercise their rights responsibly, by following traffic rules, maintaining cleanliness, conserving public resources, and respecting diversity, public spaces transform from contested zones into shared commons of dignity and order. Thus, civic sense is not a minor social courtesy; it is a civic virtue essential for democracy, development, and dignity. It determines how the state functions, how the economy thrives, and how society sustains its moral fabric. **Civic Deficit in India: A Cultural and Institutional Challenge**

India's civic deficit is paradoxical. While the country boasts of ancient traditions emphasizing discipline and respect for community life, modern civic behavior often reflects neglect and indifference. Streets are encroached upon, garbage is dumped indiscriminately, vehicles ignore lane discipline, and public utilities are often damaged without remorse. Such behavior erodes the very essence of public life.

Several factors contribute to this civic indiscipline**. First,** rapid urbanization has outpaced civic infrastructure and education, leading to overcrowded and poorly managed cities. Second, there exists a cultural dichotomy, while individuals maintain high standards of cleanliness and order in private spaces, they often disregard the same in public. Third, weak enforcement of municipal laws, inadequate civic education, and corruption have diluted accountability. Lastly, a lack of civic pride and community ownership over public property has fostered the notion that public space belongs to none.

The result is visible - chaotic traffic, overflowing drains, polluted rivers, and degraded urban landscapes that compromise not just aesthetics but public health and safety.

Public Spaces as Mirrors of Public Behavior

Public spaces are the physical embodiment of civic culture. They represent inclusivity, accessibility, and democratic participation. Parks, libraries, transport systems, and public offices are not just amenities, they are instruments of social cohesion. However, when these spaces are misused, neglected, or privatized through apathy, they lose their social function.

The condition of India's public spaces often mirrors civic irresponsibility. The defacement of historical monuments, littering in tourist sites, spitting in public, and the disregard for pedestrian rules symbolize a deeper moral disorder, the failure to perceive public spaces as shared assets. Ironically, Indians who maintain exemplary civic behavior abroad often disregard similar norms at home, revealing that the problem lies not in capability but in collective social conditioning.

Reviving civic behavior in public spaces requires changing this mindset, from one of indifference to one of stewardship. Citizens must recognize that clean, safe, and orderly public spaces are not the government's charity but a collective achievement.

Role of Governance and Civic Institutions

While individual responsibility is crucial, institutional mechanisms play an equally significant role in nurturing civic sense. Good governance must aim to create systems that make responsible behavior easy and convenient. Urban local bodies, mandated under the 74th Constitutional Amendment, hold the primary responsibility for maintaining civic infrastructure. However, their success depends on public cooperation and accountability mechanisms.

Initiatives such as the Swachh Bharat Mission, Smart Cities Mission, and AMRUT have attempted to integrate civic participation into urban governance. The success of Indore and Mysuru as clean cities demonstrates that behavioral transformation, when coupled with efficient municipal management, yields remarkable results. Moreover, the involvement of Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs), NGOs, and youth volunteers in cleanliness drives and waste segregation campaigns reflects the potential of participatory governance.

However, civic sense cannot be enforced through fines alone. Governance must combine infrastructure, enforcement, and education to create a culture of responsibility. A well-designed public dustbin or disciplined traffic system often educates more effectively than a thousand slogans.

Education and Socialization as Drivers of Civic Responsibility

	Civic sense is not innate; it must be cultivated through education and social learning. Schools and families are the primary incubators of civic values. Yet, civic education in India remains limited to theoretical civics textbooks rather than practical engagement. Children must be taught to value cleanliness, respect diversity, conserve resources, and participate in community welfare from an early age. Activities like school-led cleanliness drives, traffic awareness programs, and environmental projects can instill a sense of collective responsibility. Mass media and digital platforms also have a transformative role. Campaigns like "Do the Right Thing" or "My City, My Responsibility" can make civic behavior aspirational rather than obligatory. When responsible citizenship is celebrated in popular culture, it reinforces the idea that civility and patriotism are inseparable. **Environmental Dimension of Civic Behavior** Civic sense extends beyond social responsibility to environmental stewardship. Littering, plastic pollution, and encroachment of public lands are not only civic violations but ecological threats. The neglect of civic behavior contributes directly to environmental degradation, from the choking of drains during monsoons to the pollution of rivers like the Yamuna and Musi. The "Green Good Deeds" movement and local initiatives for waste segregation and composting demonstrate how environmental ethics and civic sense converge. When citizens treat the environment as a public space deserving respect, sustainability becomes a lived reality rather than a distant policy goal. **Ethical and Moral Perspective** At its core, civic sense is an ethical expression of respect - for law, for others, and for nature. Mahatma Gandhi's idea of Sarvodaya (welfare of all) and Swachhta (cleanliness) emphasized that true freedom is inseparable from self-discipline and public morality. Civic sense thus becomes an extension of moral duty (dharma). When citizens behave responsibly, they embody the constitutional values of equality, fraternity, and dignity. The morality of a society is measured not by how people behave in private, but by how they act when no one is watching, in public spaces shared by all. **The Way Forward** To strengthen civic responsibility in India, a multi-dimensional approach is essential. First, civic education must be institutionalized across all levels of schooling and community life. Second, civic laws, especially those relating to waste management, traffic, and vandalism, must be enforced strictly yet fairly. Third, public spaces should be designed to invite responsible behavior - well-lit, accessible, and inclusive. Fourth, citizens must be empowered through awareness campaigns and community-driven initiatives. Lastly, leaders must lead by example; when those in public office display civic discipline, it sets a powerful precedent. Building civic sense is not a one-time effort but a continuous social evolution. It requires patience, participation, and pride in collective ownership of shared spaces.
Conclusion	Civic sense and public spaces are inseparable reflections of a nation's moral and civic maturity. A society that treats its streets, monuments, and parks with care demonstrates respect for itself. India's journey toward a developed and inclusive nation cannot rest solely on economic growth or technological progress; it must rest equally on behavioral transformation. Civic sense transforms chaos into community, indifference into empathy, and apathy into action. The urgent need to behave responsibly in public spaces is, therefore, not merely a call for better manners, it is a call for a better nation. As citizens learn to see public spaces as shared homes, India will not only become cleaner and safer but also more humane, disciplined, and truly democratic.
Model Question	"The true measure of progress is not economic growth, but the growth of human character."

Value Addition	The quote, "The true measure of progress is not economic growth, but the growth of human character," reminds us that development must go beyond material prosperity to encompass moral, ethical, and social advancement. A nation's real strength lies not only in its GDP or infrastructure but in the integrity, compassion, and responsibility of its citizens. In the Indian context, leaders like Mahatma Gandhi and Swami Vivekananda emphasized that true progress is rooted in self-discipline, empathy, and service to others. Rapid industrialization or technological innovation loses meaning if society neglects justice, equality, and humanity. Therefore, sustainable progress must balance economic ambitions with the cultivation of values, ensuring that growth uplifts both livelihoods and the moral fabric of the nation.
90. My First Public Speaking Experience. (APPSC, 2020)	
Syllabus	Paper I: General Essay: Reflective Topics
Approach	• I will introduce how public speaking became my first act of courage and self-expression, shaping my identity and dream of winning the World Cup for India. • I recall my first speech - filled with fear, trembling, and the breakthrough moment that gave me confidence. • I realize how finding my voice became a source of empowerment in a country where expression means participation. • I connect that early confidence to leadership on the cricket field - learning to motivate, communicate, and stay calm under pressure. • I culminate with India's 2025 Women's World Cup victory under my captaincy, symbolizing the growth of that first courageous voice. • I conclude that public speaking taught me how courage transforms fear into strength, silence into purpose, and dreams into destiny.
Introduction	Public speaking has always been regarded as one of the most challenging yet transformative human experiences. To stand before an audience and communicate one's thoughts requires not only preparation but also courage, clarity, and authenticity. My first public speaking experience, though modest in its scale, became a turning point in my life. It shaped my confidence, gave me a voice, and instilled in me the leadership qualities that would later define my journey in Indian cricket. I am Harman Preet, and the shy schoolgirl who once trembled before a crowd would one day lift the 2025 Women's Cricket World Cup for India. That journey from stage fear to world glory began with a single speech.
Body & Infographic Representation	**The First Step into the Spotlight** I still remember the day vividly. I was in school, chosen to deliver a short speech on "Sportsmanship and Discipline" during the morning assembly. Until then, the idea of speaking to hundreds of students had never crossed my mind. I had practiced my lines for days, but the real challenge began the moment I stood before the microphone. My palms were sweating, my heart raced, and the sight of so many faces staring at me made me doubt myself. Yet, within that moment of hesitation lay a realization - fear was natural, but silence was not an option. I took a deep breath and began. My voice quivered at first, but as I spoke about what I loved most sports, I found rhythm and strength. That moment taught me a lesson that has stayed with me throughout life: courage is not the absence of fear but the triumph over it. Much like walking onto a cricket pitch to face the first delivery, the first step in public speaking is often the hardest, but it's also the most important. **Finding My Voice** As I continued speaking, the nervousness began to fade. I started to enjoy the sound of my own voice filling the air, not out of pride, but out of connection, with the audience and

with myself. The applause at the end wasn't just appreciation; it was liberation. I had found my voice, and with it, a new kind of confidence.

That small speech was more than a school exercise, it was a personal revelation. It showed me that true communication comes from sincerity, not perfection. This realization became a cornerstone of my cricketing journey as well. In the years that followed, whenever I faced challenging moments on or off the field, I reminded myself of that first speech. The courage to speak up then became the courage to lead later.

Public Speaking as Empowerment:

In India, public speaking holds a special significance beyond individual expression, it is a tool of empowerment. In a diverse and democratic country, the ability to communicate ideas confidently is essential for social participation, leadership, and reform. Unfortunately, many young Indians, especially girls, grow up hesitant to express themselves due to cultural conditioning, social expectations, or lack of encouragement.

For me, that first speaking experience symbolized freedom. It was a small act of defiance against self-doubt and a declaration that my voice mattered. In a nation where women's sports often struggle for recognition, it was an early assertion of identity. It made me believe that dreams, no matter how unconventional, deserve to be spoken aloud.

Public speaking, in this sense, becomes a democratic act. It teaches individuals to engage with ideas, express dissent, and inspire change. It also builds the confidence required for leadership in any field, whether in politics, education, or sports. Every young person who learns to speak confidently becomes a stronger citizen, capable of contributing to India's collective growth.

The Bridge Between Communication and Leadership

Public speaking and leadership share a deep connection. A leader who cannot communicate effectively struggles to inspire trust or convey vision. My first speech taught me not just to speak, but to connect and this ability became crucial in my cricketing journey.

As I rose through the ranks from local tournaments to the national team, communication became central to my role. Whether motivating teammates in tense matches or addressing media after victories and defeats, I realized that leadership is as much about emotional articulation as it is about strategy. When words are genuine, they unite people toward a common purpose.

My evolution as a captain was built on the same foundation that began in that school auditorium, the courage to express clearly, listen deeply, and lead compassionately. Public speaking, therefore, was not a skill I learned once; it was a discipline I continued to refine through every interaction, interview, and team meeting.

Overcoming Hesitation: Building Confidence Through Experience

Confidence, I learned, is not inherited, it is built, layer by layer, through experience. The more I spoke in public, the more comfortable I became with expressing my ideas. The same was true on the cricket field. Every inning strengthened my ability to face pressure, just as every speech strengthened my composure before an audience.

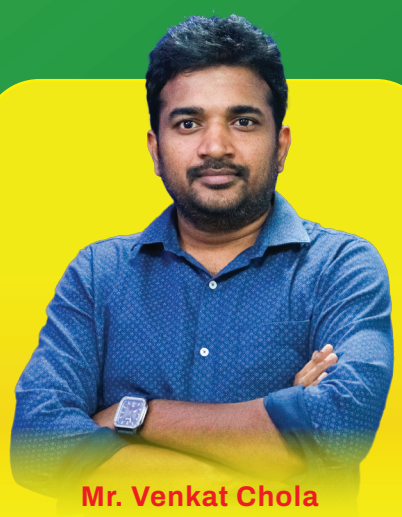
For many young Indians, especially in rural and semi-urban areas, the lack of exposure to public speaking limits self-confidence. Schools and community spaces must encourage debates, storytelling, and leadership activities so that children can overcome hesitation early. Such exposure not only nurtures self-expression but also prepares them for the challenges of professional and civic life.

	In my own life, this early experience proved invaluable. When I eventually addressed large press conferences or spoke to international audiences, I could still recall the nervous young girl who learned to steady her voice for the first time and smile at how far she had come. **Public Speaking as a Life Skill** Beyond leadership, public speaking enhances every dimension of life. It improves listening, empathy, and emotional intelligence. It teaches discipline in thought, precision in language, and respect for differing opinions. These are not just communication skills—they are life skills essential for both personal growth and societal harmony. For me, the ability to speak clearly and confidently helped in unexpected ways. It allowed me to advocate for women's cricket, mentor younger players, and express gratitude to fans. It gave me the courage to speak about the challenges women face in sports, not with resentment, but with hope. Every time I spoke publicly, I was reminded that words, when used wisely, have the power to change perceptions and inspire generations. **From the Stage to the World Stage** Years after that first speech, I stood on another stage, this time, not in a school, but at the D.Y. Patil Stadium of Mumbai, leading India in the final of the 2025 Women's Cricket World Cup. The journey from that trembling schoolgirl to a national captain had come full circle. When the final ball was bowled and India emerged victorious, emotions flooded back, not only of triumph, but of gratitude. As I lifted the trophy, I realized that the courage that carried me through that World Cup was born long before the tournament, it was born the day I dared to speak publicly for the first time. That small act of confidence had blossomed into a lifelong belief: when you find your voice, you find your strength. The applause that day on the field echoed the applause I once received in school, and I understood that victories, whether of words or of sport, are won through self-belief.
Conclusion	My first public speaking experience was not simply a childhood memory, it was the foundation of everything that followed. It taught me how to transform fear into strength, hesitation into confidence, and silence into expression. In a country like India, where communication and confidence are catalysts of empowerment, such experiences are vital for building responsible, expressive, and inspired citizens. As India celebrated its historic 2025 Women's World Cup victory, I looked back at the long journey and smiled. The real victory was not just on the scoreboard, it was in the journey from a nervous school speaker to the captain of a world champion team. Public speaking gave me my voice; cricket gave that voice a purpose. And together, they taught me that dreams become destiny only when we dare to express them aloud with conviction, courage, and an unbreakable belief in ourselves.
Model Question	"Clean politics begins with clean citizens."
Value Addition	The quote, *"Clean politics begins with clean citizens,"* highlights the deep connection between public morality and political integrity. A nation's governance reflects the values and conduct of its people; corrupt politics often thrives where citizens tolerate or participate in unethical practices. In India, where democracy grants citizens the power to elect and hold leaders accountable, civic responsibility becomes the foundation of clean governance. Leaders like Mahatma Gandhi envisioned politics as an instrument of service rooted in truth and ethics, achievable only when citizens uphold honesty, awareness, and active participation. True political reform, therefore, does not start in parliament but in the conscience of every individual who chooses integrity over indifference and accountability over apathy.

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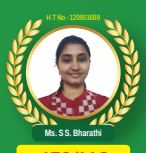
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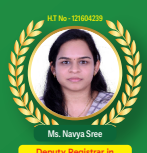
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